

PALGRAVE STUDIES IN EUROPEAN POLITICAL SOCIOLOGY

Power and Protest in Central and Eastern Europe

Edited by
Claudiu Crăciun · Henry P. Rammelt



Palgrave Studies in European Political Sociology

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Claudiu Crăciun · Henry P. Rammelt
Editors

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Contents

Contention, Democracy, and Capitalism. A View from Central and Eastern Europe 1
Claudiu Crăciun and Henry P. Rammelt

Country Cases

Albania—Duality of Democracy Through Power and Protest 27
Gilda Hoxha

Belarus—Civil Resistance and State Repression in an Autocracy 51
Olena Nikolayenko

Bulgaria—Protest Movements Transforming the Party System 81
Ivaylo Dinev and Dragomir Stoyanov

Czech Republic—From Apathy to Mass Mobilisations, 1989–2022 109
Kateřina Vráblíková

Georgia—Backstage Decisions, Frontstage Agenda, and the Return of Political Activism 137
Lia Tsuladze

Hungary—The Changing Roles of Civil Society and Social Movements Facing Autocratisation 161
Márton Gerő and Szabina Kerényi

North Macedonia—Two Sides of the Same Coin Pleading for Democratisation from Below 191
Ivan Stefanovski

Poland—Changing Patterns of Protest Mobilisation in a Polarised Society 217
Piotr Kocyba

Romania—Democratic Change and Protest Movements 247
Ruxandra Gubernat and Diana Mărgarit

Russia—Dynamics of Protest Activity in Putin's Regime 275
Radzhana Buyantueva

Ukraine—Power and Protest Interplay Amidst Geopolitics 301
Olga Zelinska

Conclusions

Resisting the Democratic Backlash: Social Movements in Central and Eastern Europe 329
Donatella della Porta

Socio-Economic Development, Class, and Protest 343
Maria Grasso and Ruxandra Gubernat

The Facets of Mobilisation. Why Is Liberal Civil Society Losing Momentum in Central and Eastern Europe? 359
Cristian Pîrvulescu

Power, Protest, and Possibilities in Central and Eastern Europe 371
David S. Meyer

Index 387

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List of Figures

Belarus—Civil Resistance and State Repression in an Autocracy

Fig. 1 Number of participants in street actions on Freedom Day in Minsk, 2006–2019 (*Source* The Human Rights Centre Viasna; *Radyio Svaboda*) 63
Fig. 2 Number of detainees on Freedom Day in Minsk (*Source* The Human Rights Centre Viasna) 64

List of Tables

Hungary—The Changing Roles of Civil Society and Social Movements Facing Autocratisation

Table 1 Conflict-oriented and depoliticised spheres of activity 172

Romania—Democratic Change and Protest Movements

Table 1 Outcomes of social movements (2011–2018) 262

Contention, Democracy, and Capitalism. A View from Central and Eastern Europe

Claudiu Crăciun and Henry P. Rammelt

Protests and social movements in Central and Eastern Europe (CEE), as in other geographical areas, are connected to political power in many ways. What sets the region apart is that protest is still linked with its foundational elements. Protests and social movements were historically connected to the assertion of national and state sovereignty, opposition to communist regimes, the building and maintaining of democratic polities, and geopolitical realignments (Beissinger, 2002; Ekiert et al., 2007; Ekiert & Kubik, 1999; Kaldor & Vejvoda, 1997). Current political developments, such as the emergence of populism and democratic backsliding, the pervasive influence of new media and technology, or the role of civil society, warrant the need for a comprehensive examination. Central and Eastern Europe's historical, political, and socio-economic trajectories offer a distinctive vantage point for examining such contemporary political dynamics.

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The volume fills this gap in our understanding of power configurations and their contestation by providing systematic evidence from a still under-researched region. This part of Europe experienced significant transformations over the past thirty years, leading to a 'post-transition' phase, whose diversity in outcomes defies any straightforward categorisation. In the volume, we do not focus on the initial process of the state, regime, and economic transformation but on a more recent period in which the constitutional framework, the regime, the party systems, and administrative reforms became institutionalised. From an economic point of view, the capitalist transformation is almost complete, with all its consequences—deindustrialisation/reindustrialisation, relative dependence on foreign capital, entering specific productive and value chains, development of the financial and service economy, increasing territorial disparities, and migration. The extent of transformation and interdependence between these variables made a compelling case to take a broader view on politics and its contentious dimension. Political power does not rest exclusively on party organisations, leaders, institutions, and bureaucracies. The majority of the contributions uncover networks of informality and influence, entrenched economic interests, clientelistic systems, transnational cooperation, and politicised media landscapes.

The focus on 'post-transition' does not ignore or obscure the major citizen mobilisations before and after the fall of communism. Instead, it infuses a new sense of historicity into analysing more recent events, some of which are easily overlooked or treated in isolation. We were interested in understanding which issues became more widely contested, how protests and movements emerged and were structured, and what were their aggregated effects on power structures. Ideally, the volume should have a chapter for each country in the region, even though its exact borders are subject to debate (see Berend, 2005). While not exhaustive, the case studies included are representative of the context and the typical set of challenges. All the countries became nominally democratic after 1990, but their democratic trajectories and quality varied significantly. Their economies transformed as part of a new global capitalist order, but there is no apparent convergence in model or performance. Most countries had to redefine state and national identities with different means and outcomes. The EU integration, an unavoidable prospect in the region, grouped the countries according to their membership perspective and status. We avoided clustering the case studies, as it would have meant opting for a single logic or framework. Instead, by presenting the

cases alphabetically, we highlighted their diversity, complexity, and the comparative potential.

The contributors to the volume chose their own theoretical and methodological tools. However, political opportunities, how social movements frame them, and the impact the former exerts over the latter seem highly relevant for studying the relationship between protest and power (Kitschelt, 1986; McAdam, 1999; Meyer & Minkoff, 2004). Multiple chapters, therefore, rely on political process theory and the political opportunity structures approach. As opportunities always need to be framed and perceived as such by social movements (Gamson & Meyer, 1996; McAdam et al., 1996; Snow et al., 1986), framing theory constitutes a second lens employed by many of the contributors. In terms of methodology, the chapters reflect the discussions in the field on methodological pluralism (della Porta, 2008a; 2024; Tarrow, 1995) and the possibilities for—or even the need for—employing a wide range of methods to understand better the multifaceted nature of the relationship of protest and power.

Collectively, the contributors have balanced the historical context, political structuring, and protest events. Protest events and movements are presented in two complementary logics: temporal and analytical. The temporal logic is more than simply presenting events in chronological order. The authors recognise the relevance and development of protests in time, acknowledging the argument that eventful protests trigger critical junctures, produce abrupt changes which develop contingently and become path-dependent (della Porta, 2020). Second, the authors group the protest events according to their agenda and grievances. Identifying a single issue or agenda that structures the major protest events is difficult. With various proportions and intensities, all significant protests and movements are about democratic transition and consolidation, electoral politics and institutions, nation and state-building, socio-economic policies and redistribution, corruption, and geopolitical orientation simultaneously. Not even the most localised and specific protests are about one issue. For example, municipal and environmental movements oppose parties, leaders, business practices, corruption, and community destruction, a point made already by Milan and Dolenec (2023) in the case of several Southeast European states. Yet, other issues are not politicised and contentious to the same extent and in a similar way, such as state and nation-building.

Power and Protest in CEE. Towards a Comparative Research Agenda

If new social movements emerged in Western Europe due to social change that affected power relations (Kriesi et al., 1995), social movements in CEE after the fall of communism regime were confronted with the challenges—and opportunities—of a triple transition—political, economic, and social (see Offe, 1991). Thus, it seems tantamount to developing integrated approaches considering the historical legacies, socio-economic structures, and power configurations created during the post-transition period (Ekiert, 2015; Ekiert & Kubik, 2017). We argue that these holistic approaches would benefit from bringing contention, social movements, and protest to the study of the post-communist transformations. At the same time, we acknowledge the region's divergent historical, political, and socio-economic trajectories. The internal differences between countries in the region further widened. Their development patterns further diversified and, hence, require nuanced analyses of the relationship between institutionalised politics and other societal actors—first and foremost social movements and civil society—through long-term studies of protest events, movements, civil society, and street politics. Therefore, the 'triple transition' led to diverse development paths that are increasingly challenging to be researched in a comparative framework. However, if we want to make any substantial claims on global and European democracy, capitalism, and socio-economic transformation, endeavours such as the present volume are indispensable.

The socio-economic underpinnings of protests represent a critical research avenue yet to be fully developed. While socio-economic factors are recognised as catalysts for protests (Gurr, 1970; Piven & Cloward, 1979; Skocpol, 1979), detailed studies linking economic conditions, inequality, and specific economic policies to the emergence and trajectory of protest movements are needed to get a clearer picture of the motivations behind and the success of social movements. The works of Bohle and Greskovits (2006, 2019, 2007) on neoliberalism and the studies on class-based inequalities (Grasso & Giugni, 2022; Grasso et al., 2019; Schlozman, Brady, & Verba, 2018) invite further exploration of how economic crises and policies influence protest strategies and outcomes. Recently, scholars of social movements and unconventional political participation have restarted arguing that the field should pay more attention to long-term socio-economic developments and, in

particular, to the effects of the way the economy is organised (neoliberal capitalism) on the field (della Porta, 2015; Gagyi, 2021a; Giugni & Grasso, 2019a; Grasso et al., 2019; Walder, 2009). Císař and Navrátil (2016) proposed a theoretical hybrid between political opportunity structures and models of capitalism and showed how in the case of the Czech Republic varieties of capitalism produce varieties of protest formation. Also, class-based discussions recently re-entered social movement studies (e.g. Bernhard & O'Neill, 2021; della Porta, 2022; Westheuser & della Porta, 2022), and some scholars from the region argue that class-based analyses and studies of socio-economic drivers for protest are even the more important for the study of Eastern Europe (Beissinger et al., 2014; Gagyi, 2021b; Gagyi, 2022; Slačálek, 2022). Dinev (2020) argues in his work on Bulgaria and Slovenia that class matters and that specific grievances such as unpaid salaries and dismissals reveal an important underlying anti-system contention against austerity measures and privatisation. However, systemic contradictions of capitalism and grievances related to socio-economic conditions are frequently overshadowed (or even obscured) by narratives that focus on 'irresponsible' or 'corrupt elites' rather than on structural conditions (Crăciun, 2017; Císař & Navrátil, 2016; Gubernat & Rammelt, 2021, 2023).

In this vein, reviving the study of social movements through the lens of inequality and socio-economic grievances (Bertuzzi et al., 2022), the volume advances the understanding of the relationship between protest and political power by analysing the socio-economic and historical drivers of protests. Notably, Vráblíková's (2025) chapter on the Czech Republic puts the socio-economic development caused by the regime change and socio-economic grievances at the heart of the analysis. The volume also includes other relevant and under-researched country cases to better understand the nexus between political and economic transition to capitalism, such as Albania (Hoxha, 2025) and Georgia (Tsuladze, 2025). The concluding chapter by Grasso & Gubernat (2025) situates these findings within the literature on inequalities and political participation.

The phenomenon of authoritarian drift and democratic backsliding, not only in some Central and Eastern European countries although in particular there, presents a significant area of concern and inquiry. This trend, underscored by the decline in public participation in the democratic process and a reversion to authoritarian practices, needs a more detailed analysis of how protests and civil society movements

challenge, resist, or sometimes inadvertently reinforce these developments. The limited usefulness, in hindsight, of the transition paradigm to explain the resurgence of authoritarianism, the non-successes of the democratisation process many countries encountered, never reaching the ideal-typical stage of consolidated democracies (e.g. Linz and Stepan's [1996] predictions on successful consolidation), further underlines the need for systematic conceptualisations relevant for Central and Eastern European countries. The illiberal turn in the politics of the region compels us to reconsider the relation between power and different societal stakeholders, notably social movements and civil society, being sensitive to socio-economic structuring, cultural influences, and geopolitical alignments. While much research on CEE illiberalism's forms, character, and origins has been achieved, many questions remain. Greskovits (2015) identified a need for more nuanced perspectives, notably on the role of civil society and social movements in the light of the resurgence of authoritarian practices and neoliberalism. However, few studies (e.g. Gerőcs & Gagyi, 2022) have attempted to analyse illiberal tendencies as a result of the neoliberal transition, or at least focused their attention on economic aspects of illiberalism. For example, studies on Hungarian civil society indicate a general need for comparative research on how activism can contribute to democratic resilience amid authoritarian tendencies or democratic backsliding (Gerő et al., 2023; Mikecz, 2020). While recently essential works in this regard have been published (della Porta, 2013; Fiket et al., 2024; Mikecz, 2023), few have focused on the actual impact of movements on power holders. The volume addresses this gap by providing in-depth analyses of the efforts of different democratic actors in challenging illiberal governance, the obstacles they face, and the impact they have—e.g. Stefanovski (2025) on North Macedonia, Buyantueva (2025) on Russia, and Nikolayenko (2025) on Belarus. By doing so, the volume offers a wealth of insights on how to sustain democratic practices, resist authoritarian tendencies, and ensure the resilience of democratic polities in the face of illiberal tendencies, not limited to CEE in their relevance. The concluding chapters by Pîrvulescu (2025) and della Porta (2025) look at the historical origins of illiberalism, but insist that civic activism, regardless of the regime type, has the potential to contribute to resisting the democratic backlash.

Further, the mutual reinforcement of authoritarianism and state repression in Central and Eastern Europe presents an opportunity to study

protest movements' adaptability and resilience within increasingly restrictive environments. The evolving tactics of state repression, notably policing strategies and tactics, as well as surveillance and the corresponding strategies adopted by protest movements (Elliott et al., 2022; Earl et al., 2022; Reynolds-Stenson & Earl, 2022) still require further research. These issues, deeply interwoven into the region's post-transition dynamics, require an investigation to unravel how protest movements navigate, challenge, and sometimes inadvertently reinforce patterns of populism, repression, and increasingly illiberal tendencies. The interplay between crises, such as the COVID-19 pandemic, the financial crisis of 2008, and the 'Refugee Crisis', and the surge of populism represents another critical area for exploration, given the gaps in scholarly understanding of crisis-induced populism (Kaldor & Selchow, 2015; Kriesi & Pappas, 2015; McMahon et al., 2024; Mudde, 2022; Vasiljevic et al., 2023). There is a compelling need to understand how these crises catalyse populist movements and enable autocratic-style rule. The strategies and effectiveness of protests in contexts where populist rhetoric and policies reshape public discourse, political engagement, policing and repression, and the very nature of democratic participation also warrant further investigation.

Another relevant and developing area of research is the study of state-mobilised movements, as suggested by Ekiert and colleagues (Ekiert et al., 2020; Ekiert & Perry, 2020). State mobilised protests and social movements are still, with few exceptions, understudied phenomena, if at all, limited to studies on Hungary and Poland, far from reflecting the diversity of state mobilisations in the region. Others have argued that the impact of socio-economic policies by illiberal governments, particularly their impact on civil society and social movements, requires further investigation (Bohle et al., 2022). Also, discussions on cultural factors (Kubik, 2023; Pospieszna & Vráblíková, 2022) and the contribution of social movements (Hellmeier & Bernhard, 2023) to the rise and consolidation of such regimes have only just begun. The analysis of state-mobilised movements is at the forefront of a number of chapters in this volume: Kocyba (2025) shows how political power can coopt or invent protest movements, Gerő and Kerényi (2025) and Buyantueva (2025) show the effect of state-sponsored civil society on protest movements and mass mobilisation. The volume also captures the temporal and tactical shifts in how states respond to protests and how movements adapt to and resist

these strategies. Gerő and Kerényi (2025), Stefanovski (2025), and Nikolayenko (2025) analyse social movements and civil society as democratic actors challenging and facing autocratic tendencies in Hungary, North Macedonia, and Belarus. Confronted with different obstacles created by the power holders—notably new legislation shrinking spaces for civil society and hampering the organisation of protest movements, repression, hostile and government-controlled media, counter mobilisations—civic actors were forced to adapt and innovate.

In the debates on democratic resilience, on possibilities to hampering or, at least, decelerating de-democratisation and authocratisation, much hope was once again put in civil society. Civil society played a key role, as did social movements, in the regime changes, as well as in the transition period. The two, therefore, can be considered similar actors, distinguished mainly by epistemological differences in researching them (della Porta, 2020). della Porta (2020) pleads, therefore, for more unified approaches in studying these actors' challenges to power and their collaborative ethos. While, for a long time, CEE was considered to be an example par excellence for weak civil society, as compared notably to the US and Western Europe, the aforementioned role civil society and social movements played throughout the past three decades is increasingly challenged (Bernhard, 2020; Baća, 2024; Jacobsson & Korolczuk, 2017; Jacobsson and Saxonberg, 2016). The Western dominance in the study of social movements and civil society has to be questioned (Ekiert & Kubik, 2017; Foa & Ekiert, 2017; Gagyi, 2021b; Heller & Schmidt, 2024), and that is precisely what the volume does. Almost all the chapters look at a multitude of relevant actors, NGOs, environmental, urban and municipalist movements, ad-hoc groups, trade unions, political parties, at their interactions, coalition building, and co-dependencies. Civil society seems more differentiated, resourceful, and experienced than in the early transition phase. However, its capacity to affect power at a more structural level is contingent and uncertain.

Geopolitical cleavages, such as the orientation towards the West (Europe and the European Union) or the East (Russia) and their connection to citizen mobilisation and protest, still need more systematic attention. Císař (2020) notes that internationalisation and the Europeanisation of social movements have left a deep imprint on CEE civil societies. While there is a consensus in the literature regarding the instrumental role of international organisations and non-profit and EU agencies in the early formation of civil society organisations, we are still

missing an overview of the recent street-level protests and movements in the region. It is also unclear how an attraction to the East, or, at least, to non-Western governance and societal models, impacts the activities, goals, and frames of non-institutionalised political actors. Recent research shows that Europe is increasingly politicised, a process driven by various actors with different ideological agendas. Still, the broader theme of European integration is often not the primary focus of protest activism (van Kessel & Fagan, 2022). This finding is based on an analysis of older and newer EU states. However, the volume shows that the EU-related developments are becoming more politicised and polarising, even triggering political violence in the countries seeking accession or a closer partnership. It also sheds light on the possible trajectories for Europeanisation from below in an 'enlarged' Europe (della Porta & Caiani, 2011). The return of geopolitics and its related contention are related to an assertive and aggressive Russia, which uses various tactics to advance its interests. The so-called refugee crisis was a first critical juncture, placing humanitarian and civil society actors on a defensive line, followed by the pandemic contention fuelled by extreme right and conspiratorial groups aligned with Russian interests. The 2022 invasion of Ukraine produced a rift which separated Russia-aligned authoritarian-conservative actors from the EU and global democratic countries and organisations. The volume provides long-due insights into how geopolitical cleavages shape street politics and the relation between protests and power alike. Buyantueva (2025), Dinev and Stoyanov (2025), Hoxha (2025), Nikolayenko (2025), Stefanovski (2025), Tsuladze (2025), and Zelinska (2025) provide in-depth research on the connections between West/East orientations and street mobilisations, and on how political cleavages shape politics in the region.

The discussions on the relationship between social movements and party politics (Bernhard et al., 2020; Piccio, 2016) pinpoint a significant gap in our grasp of these dynamics. It has been observed that party-sponsored protest reaches its highest level in Eastern Europe vi-a-vis other European regions, prompting questions regarding the relationship between the independence of civil society and the dominance of political parties in the political arena on the one hand, and delayed democratisation on the other (Borbáth & Hutter, 2021). Following Tarrow (2021), we see, therefore, a need for detailed studies that look at the cooptation and transformative potential of social movements within the political

sphere, particularly in CEE contexts where historical legacies and political developments differ markedly from the rest of Europe. The volume offers a wealth of insights on this connection in all the contributions, building on valuable work on both party politics and social movements. Social movements and protests can have a direct impact on the institutionalisation of the party system, or the lack of it, considered to be both inherent and potentially dangerous (see Casal Bértoa & Mair, 2012; Casal Bértoa, 2014). At the same time, party system institutionalisation, or party system closure, is associated with weaker democratic performance and quality (Casal Bértoa & Enyedi, 2021). Social movements and parties seem also a relevant factor in the disappearance and the establishment of new parties (see Haughton & Deegan-Krause, 2020). Social movements and protests are also connected to parties in regard to their main issue dimensions (Císař & Vráblíková, 2019). The Bulgarian (Dinev & Stoyanov, 2025) and Romanian (Gubernat & Mărgarit, 2025) cases show to the largest extent the potential impact of movements, from creating new political cleavages to new and viable party organisations. Similarly with Milan and Dolenec (2023) who argue that in the case of several Southeastern European states social movements created electoral platforms to increase democracy and serve as bulwarks against democratic erosion, most of the contributions acknowledge the instrumental role of party politics in supporting democracy. The volume offers a wealth of new insights in this regard, ranging from the mobilisation efforts of established political parties (see Kocyba, 2025) in this volume on Poland), the emergence of populist parties challenging ideals and practices of Western models of liberal democracy or supporting them (see Gubernat & Mărgarit [2025] in this volume on Romania), to protest-induced electoral stability and changes in the party system (see Dinev and Stoyanov [2025] in this volume on Bulgaria). Also, the analysis of the strange absence of new political formations (such as in the case of North Macedonia (see Stefanovski [2025] in this volume on North Macedonia) contributes to our understanding of when and how challenger parties appear and the party system is subject to change.

Relevant for understanding the connection of protest, movements, and parties, we note that elections-related contention is also still widespread throughout the region (see Bunce & Wolchik, 2010; Norris et al., 2015), further indicating an important link between the democratisation, democratic culture, and protest mobilisation. Elections set in motion all the

relevant forces and organisations in the society. In CEE, there are structural reasons for also triggering protests: there is little level-playing field between the competitors, parties can use public resources and public bureaucracies to influence the results, and the work or electoral institutions is routinely questioned on impartiality and transparency grounds. The elections-related protest and campaigns show how three-decade-long democratic practice does not necessarily result in better and more trusted electoral practices. Notably, the two case studies on the most autocratic regimes included in the volume show how important electoral contention is in the overall economy of mass mobilisation in Belarus (Nikolayenko, 2025) and Russia (Buyantueva, 2025).

The study of the effectiveness and outcomes of protest movements highlights significant research gaps that extend beyond the context of CEE (Giugni et al., 1999; Giugni & Bosi, 2012; Meyer, 2021; Bosi et al., 2016). These gaps underscore the need for a more systematic investigation into the strategies employed by protesters, their cultural impacts, interactions with institutional politics, and the tangible changes they affect within societies and political systems. There's a notable gap in understanding the effectiveness of various protest strategies and the concrete outcomes achieved by social movements in influencing policy, political discourse, and societal change. We still need a focused examination of how social movements shape collective identities, public discourse, and social norms and how they navigate the complex terrain between protest and institutional politics (della Porta & Zamponi, 2022; Giugni & Grasso, 2019b; Van Dyke & Taylor, 2018). Moreover, the reflection on the broad spectrum of social movements' outcomes, including unintended consequences (Jasper et al., 2022; Meyer, 2021; Rucht, 2023) or the challenges to established norms by movements that can result in long-term cultural change (Kaldor & Selchow, 2013), points to the need for further research. Another relevant element of this discussion relates to the institutionalisation of social movements either into movement parties or in sustainable forms of social and political organisation (della Porta et al., 2017; Fiket et al., 2024; Varvarousis et al., 2021). All the contributions advance our understanding of effectiveness and outcome of protest movements, feeding directly into the global research agenda.

Structure of the Volume

The volume provides insights into the effectiveness of protest strategies, their cultural and societal impact, and their interactions with institutional politics through long-term country case studies that unveil the mechanisms through which social movements shape and are shaped by broader political and social processes. The contributors were invited to reflect on changes that can be attributed to protests and movement, such as legislative reforms, stopping of infrastructural projects, resignations of political leaders, government and coalition crises, early elections, referendum outcomes, forming new parties and cleavages, and variation in electoral support for parties. The overall image, which might be surprising for many activists and protestors in the region, is that protest matters. Many of the contributors to this volume share della Porta's (2013, 2020) enthusiasm regarding the positive impact of social movements on politics. The socio-economic situation, the lack of trust in parties and representative institutions, and the still-fluid party systems and political cultures create a conducive environment for consequential protests and mobilisations. The contributors included several other dimensions in their accounts, such as time duration, intensity variations, socio-demographic structure, and territorial diffusion. As expected, most protest events are concentrated in the capitals and large cities and have some socio-demographic similarities. Yet, the most notable mobilisations, even though concentrated, were 'total' events in the sense that they involved the whole society and disrupted the functioning of the state institutions and policy-making. In other cases, there were remarkable solidarity protests in which citizens and activists from the capitals and large cities helped galvanise local support against specific policies and projects. At the same time, the chapters presented the groups and organisations driving the mobilisation, their network and resources, and their mobilisation channels. Given the nature of the protest events studied, one distinction became apparent, between organised civil society and loosely connected individuals and community groups. Many protests were ignited and driven not by formal organisations but by groups and communities of activists, similar to the networked movements in which Castells (2012) put his hope. The role of the formal organisation was essential, for example, in dealing with authorities by initiating or responding to legal actions or offering logistical resources, mainly between protest events. Most significant protest events developed their symbols and cultures through chants,

slogans and images, and connected with artists, songs, and festivals. Apart from their internal dynamic, protest events and movements evolved in relation to power structures and governmental institutions. Encounters with law-enforcement and discriminatory ways of protest policing can be foundational moments for social movements (della Porta, 2008b; della Porta & Reiter, 1998; Gamson et al., 1982). The chapters explore the relationships varying from confrontation and repression to recognition and collaboration.

Gilda Hoxha identifies two phases of mobilisation in Albania. One was top-down, in which new party actors and leaders channel or organise contention to secure political and electoral legitimacy. In the second, citizens and social groups became relatively autonomous and capable of opposing party actors, pushing issues that were either non-politicised or absent from party and governmental policies. Through protests, citizens and civil society groups put forward various socio-economic claims, opposing large infrastructure projects that endanger the environment and defending the fundamental rights of women and minorities. In Belarus, Olena Nikolayenko charts the transformation of mobilisation from a diverse agenda focused on the quality of elections, environmental protection, national identity, and socio-economic grievances to a widespread and non-violent resistance against authoritarianism, met with harsh repression by the regime. Ivaylo Dinev and Dragomir Stoyanov describe in their contribution on Bulgaria how protest movements became key political players by introducing new repertoires that influenced election campaigns, by joining political forces or turning into protest parties and movement parties, or by creating new cleavages between 'protest' and 'traditional' parties. In the Czech Republic, Kateřina Vráblíková explains how protest movements became deeply embedded in the economic and political transformations of the transition. From an initial pro-democratic mobilisation in the early 90s, the contention refocused on neoliberal capitalism, austerity, and its correlated political dimension of technocratic populism. Lia Tsuladze explores the Georgian case, in which the protests opposed large-scale environmental projects, anti-democratic elite choices, and the country's foreign policy course. As the methods of key governing actors became more repressive and harsh, including by attempting to restrict the functioning of civil society organisations, the contention became entrenched and set to keep the country on the path of EU integration. In Hungary, civic movements and civil society are analysed as having a social integration function. Márton Gerő and Szabina Kerényi observe

a change in political opportunity structures after 2010 and the multiplication of protest events, varying in size and duration, opposing the continuous autocratisation of the Orban regime. In North Macedonia, Ivan Stefanovski focuses on the coalition building between social movements and political parties, whose relations were structured around the bottom-up pressures for improving democracy and the rule of law, the contentious choices triggered by the country's name, its international recognition, and the path for European integration. In Poland, Piotr Kocyba identifies two types of mobilisation, progressive and regressive. The first one is a resistance against attacks on the rule of law and individual liberties pushed by national-conservative governing actors, for example, the women's protest on abortion, and the second is a countermobilisation from the conservative right involving parties and various social groups. In Romania, Ruxandra Gubernat and Diana Mărgarit show that starting with the anti-austerity protest in 2012, there were several subsequent waves of significant mobilisations, which were cumulative in terms of pressure on the political system and actors but had different social dynamics and narratives from one wave to another. In the case of Russia, Radzhana Buyantueva argues that contention is structured by the increased autocratisation of the regime. The fraudulent parliamentary elections in December 2011 prompted significant protest, which continued with the manifestation of support for Alexey Navalny as the leading opposition figure. The full-scale invasion that started in 2022 against neighbouring Ukraine triggered a wave of discontent, but the regime met it with militarisation and brutal policing, which significantly narrowed the room for expressing both political and civic discontent. In Ukraine, Zelinska highlights, one of the driving forces behind contention was the democratisation/nation-building/geopolitical orientation nexus, the central point of reference during the post-communist transition. The framing of mobilisation and protest as part of several 'revolutions' points out their structural and consequential role in politics. In the concluding chapters, Donatella della Porta reflects on the nature of contentious politics in the region and finds that autonomous forms of protests can represent more authentic and effective forms of mobilisation for democracy (della Porta [2025] in this volume). David S. Meyer (2025) reflects on mobilisation, contention, and political change and highlights the relevance of the country cases for a global analysis inspired by the political opportunity approach, in which state capacity and international institutions are key variables.

The volume is not meant to chart all the protests and movements in the region. Some other individual events and agendas should have been covered in the contributions. However, this doesn't mean they are irrelevant; on the contrary, they are. Aggregating protests and movements at country level and projecting cumulative effects on power leave their own blind spots, which we are sure will be of interest for a growing social movement's research community. The editors and the contributors have put forward comparative research agenda focused on the region as such, based on the solid research work done on the region, and in constant conversation with the global research on protests and movements. By better understanding these dynamics, policymakers, scholars, and activists can navigate with more ease and clarity the ever-present challenges for democracy in Central and Eastern Europe and beyond.

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Country Cases

Albania—Duality of Democracy Through Power and Protest

Gilda Hoxha

Following the regime change, after decades of political oppression under communist rule, a new political order of competitive pluralism and democracy emerged in Albania. In this chapter, we analyse activism and protest events in Albania from 2010 through 2022, exploring the interplay of institutionalised politics and various forms of civic engagement and organisation. Emphasising the relevance of social cleavages, resource mobilisation, and political opportunity structures for mobilisation, the chapter explains the impact of civic participation and activism on the democratic process and state institutions in Albania. Research on such topics is confronted with a number of issues such as the low degree of political participation and activism in Albania and the fact that scholarly attention was mainly focused on street protests. A significant amount of research is related to the '90s student movement and the collapse of the communist regime in Albania, while a few other studies focus on formal political participation such as youth quotas and gender equality, among

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others. The chapter fills these gaps in the academic perspective by looking at the interplay between protest and power in Albania. I will notably explain the relationship between the democratisation process and activism. To do so, I attempt to answer the following research questions: (1) What is the impact of activism and protest in decision-making in Albania? (2) What is the impact of the political regime on activism and protest?

In more detail, the chapter presents key protest events taking place after 2010. Firstly, I will look at top-down mobilisations, rallies, protests, and boycotts: protests and hunger strikes in 2010 organised by the Socialist Party of Albania (SPA), the events of 21 January 2011, and the protests and parliamentary boycott organised by the Democratic Party of Albania (DPA) between 2016 and 2018. Secondly, I present bottom-up mobilisations, protests, petitions, and cultural protest events related to broader socio-economic and political issues such as human rights, urban development, and environment, most of which took place between 2013 and 2016. The protest events are analysed according to three main dimensions: (1) a general theoretical approach that presents the socio-economic conditions of the time; (2) a descriptive background of the events and their relations to power structures; and (3) the impact of the protest agenda, patterns of participation, mobilisation channels, and outcomes. The events themselves are presented according to the main triggers of mobilisation as either top-down or bottom-up, and, following this logic, according to the different issue areas they can be located in. The methodological approach of this chapter is following ideas of methodological pluralism and mixed method designs, both characteristic for social movement studies (della Porta, 2014).

The chapter is organised in four main sections. Section "Understanding Democracy Democracy Through the Political Development of Albania" describes the historical context of protests and the democratisation process in Albania. Section "Power and Protest in Albania: A Top-Down Approach" presents the protest events of the political parties in Albania. These events reflect 'protest' as a tool for political power and are analysed through a top-down perspective. Section "Power and Protest in Albania: Bottom Up" focuses on civic engagement and how protest culture took shape in Albania. The last section concludes with an analysis of the current relationship between power and protest, taking into account current interactions between power and protest, and emphasising the role of resource mobilisation in facilitating civic engagement and activism.

Understanding Democracy Through the Political Development of Albania

Since declaring independence in 1912, Albania has undergone several changes of the political system that have brought consistent political instability that continues to impact democracy even today. As a result, Albania's current democratic system remains fragile.

Although civic participation and mobilisation have been a core part of the new democratic system, the relationship between social groups, civil society, and new power structures has been fraught and affected by economic shocks, such as the massive privatisation program or a series of pyramid financial schemes. Social groups and civil society view civic participation, including protests, as a way to connect politics to clear socio-economic concerns and advance the democratic gains of the transition. Political parties, on the other hand, view them as legitimising tools for their claim to power. The two competing forms of mobilisation, bottom-up and top-down, have defined the democratic transition, each being dominant in different phases. In the mid-90s, political parties possessed material resources such as money, media, logistics, and political activists. Since the alternative protest culture was weak, political parties used social groups' needs to strengthen their power via protest events and mass rallies. In the early 2000s, a new phase emerged, witnessing the rise of protests grounded in various agendas and interests that provided alternatives to top-down mobilisation.

The anti-communist revolt in Albania was significantly fuelled by socio-economic grievances voiced by students; dissatisfaction over dormitories' infrastructure, living conditions, and financial problems (Fevziu, 2012). The student protest got support from all over the country against the communist regime's control over its citizens' lives. In this process, students' demands shifted from their initial (and mainly student related) ones to more structural ones, demanding democracy and freedom. After the fall of communism, various social groups, such as former landowners, political prisoners, and factory workers, arose as actors who had the potential to mobilise and build a protest culture outside party politics. They realised, however, that the safest way to turn their grievances into policies was through newly formed political parties. The Labour Party of Albania (LPA), which transformed into SPA and DPA, formed a two-party system and effectively mobilised the energies and expectations of large parts of the electorate. DPA, the first opposition party established after 45 years,

positioned itself as an implicit vehicle to turn grievances formulated by students and other social groups into its party program and policies. As its popularity and support have grown, domestically and internationally, it has remained a key political actor during the democratic transition.

The difficulties of the economic transition hindered the attempts to establish a stable political and party system. In the first four years of democracy, Albania pursued social-political and economic transformation based on a macroeconomic stabilisation program, adapting to free market principles and embarking on a massive privatisation program (World Bank, 1994). Apart from the confusion brought by the new economic order, state weakness and predatory behaviour of some financial actors brought forth major crises. In the so-called pyramid schemes created between 1992 and 1996, funds and companies offered very high investment returns. Willing to increase their incomes and encouraged by the high payouts, many Albanians were drawn in, investing all they had, such as houses, land, and, in some cases, livestock (Jarvis, 2000). By late 1996, one of the biggest schemes collapsed, triggering a loss of public confidence and a cessation of new investments. Subsequent collapses of other schemes prompted the Bank of Albania to limit daily withdrawals from bank accounts to prevent companies from emptying their accounts. The crisis sparked serious social unrest and a breakdown of authority, with the government losing control over the military and police, leading to desertion and weapon theft from armouries. The government's inability to intervene or implement financial measures to curb the pyramid schemes showed the vulnerability of democratic politics in the absence of regulatory safeguards and enforcement. Consequently, the rule of law became one of the cornerstones of post-communist transition, together with socio-economic conditions, political order, and new social cleavages (Kajsiu, 2008).

Power and Protest in Albania: A Top-Down Approach

The early 2000s in Albania were relatively calm in terms of socio-political activity. The parliamentary election held in 2001 would secure SPA's second mandate to govern (KQZ, 2001). The election process was deemed quiet and regular, with no serious incident or concern reported. However, internal disputes within political party structures and a lack of transparency in leadership procedures, particularly within

SPA's leadership, pose a significant challenges to Albanian democracy and the newly elected government (TV Klan, 2001). These disagreements were temporarily resolved when the party chairman resigned only to be re-elected by the party assembly. Nevertheless, these leadership disagreements would resurface later in time.

The 2005 parliamentary elections brought DPA to power. Their platform focused on investment and infrastructure, exemplified by the construction of the *Rruga e Kombit*, Tirana-Pristina highway. The 2009 elections saw DPA return to government, this time in coalition with the Socialist Movement for Integration (SMI), established in 2004 as a response to the internal strife within the SPA party in the early 2000s. The 2009 parliamentary elections were the first ones to follow a new Electoral Code, having a strong proportional representation component, known *Proporz*, which led to problems similar to those encountered in mainly German-speaking countries. The OSCE/ODIHR Election Observation Mission Final Report would describe the effects of the electoral system as follows:

> …The particular implementation of this system, referred to as "*Dushk*" allowed large parties to maximise their gains by shifting proportional votes to smaller allies, without having to forfeit seats won in single members constituencies… (OSCE/ODIHR, 2009)

The '*Dushk' phenomenon* was one of the main reasons for the opposition coalition, led by SPA, to organise street protests once a week for a few months. The coalition's discourse centred mainly around allegations of corruption, the lack of financial transparency in infrastructure projects, public investments, clientelism, and inflation, etc. (Top-Channel, 2010). Despite their efforts, the weekly rallies were not successful for the opposition of that time. SPA continued to push for early parliamentary elections and reported irregularities to the Central Election Commission (CEC) for further investigation. Despite the opposition coalition's reservations, the CEC certified the election results.

Subsequently, the leadership of SPA decided to escalate the protests, by initiating a hunger strike in May 2010. Approximately 20 SPA PMs staged a hunger strike in Tirana's main boulevard, citing deteriorating sociopolitical conditions in Albania (Majko, 2010). The hunger strike ended after 20 days, when Sali Berisha (DPA), the incumbent prime minister, met with Edi Rama (SPA), the opposition leader, in Strasbourg for a

dinner brokered by European Union (EU) representatives in Albania. To this day, the details of their discussion are unclear, but it effectively ended the hunger strike and the associated protests. SPA's protest focused on political grievances, highlighting disagreement between the government and the opposition, concerning the quality of governance, financial transparency, public investments, and corruption. However, the SPA failed to effectively present these existing grievances as a public concern, as their focus was primarily on the parliamentary elections process and deputy seats, rather than on broader societal grievances.

Simultaneously, a hunger strike organised by former political prisoners from the communist era was underway—minimal media and public attention, no other support. One of the protesters self-immolated and passed away a few days later (Abrahams, 2015). Since the early '90s, political prisoners had been raising awareness for their rights, including moral compensation and financial indemnity. However, the two simultaneous hunger strikes failed to unite, nor did they manage to garner support from other social groups. This resulted in missed opportunities for SPA to expand their movement or recruit additional supporters beyond its electoral base.

Up until January 2011, Albania experienced a relatively calm period, with few protests and sporadically public speeches by political parties. It appeared that solutions to the existing grievances were being exclusively channelled through the official process, most notably through voting in parliamentary elections. However, after an investigative TV show on January 20 exposed a corruption scandal related to the *Rruga e Kombit* highway, reigniting street protests in the country. The following day, SPA quickly organised a mass protest, with participation extending beyond party affiliates. Public opinion was sensitive to such affairs due to memories of a past corruption case, exposed after an explosion of a weapons factory killing 28 people, including children, civilians, and factory employees.

The demonstration started in the afternoon of January 21 leaving from Skanderbeg Square and marching towards the prime minister's offices. The march was lawfully registered by SPA's bureau. Within three hours, protest tensions escalated, leading to confrontations between law enforcement and protesters, resulting in property damage and casualties. Stones, metal bars, and umbrellas were thrown at the police as the PM's office was attacked. The police responded with tear gas, rubber bullets, water cannons, and stun grenades. Smoke billowed from burning cars, some of

them police vehicles (Koleka, 2011). Republican Guard officers killed four protesters. The public discourse in media talk shows and newsrooms was largely unanimous: the demonstration resulted in material damage and casualties among the protestors, prompting calls for organisers to take responsibility for the events unfolding.

Despite the public outcry, political leaders had diminished the value of democracy by favouring their political interests over human rights. The court decision in September 2013 held some officials accountable for the deaths of protestors, although accountability remained contentious. The lawyer of one victim's family states: 'The Republic of Albania, and especially the Guard of the Republic, are responsible for the protestors' deaths, not only by Albanian legislation but also on the European Convention of Human Rights, since the 'force used' was not 'necessary' in shooting the protesters' (Cela, 2015). The events of 21 January 2011, stand as a sensitive and dark chapter in Albanian democracy. It underscores how political opportunity structures impact protests, and how repression can have a silencing effect. Violence and excessive use of force can be used to control society in order to gain control over those who try to raise concerns or impact the decision-making process through means other than elections. For Albanians, this episode of repression is ingrained in their collective memory.

The parliamentary election in June 2013 was pivotal, not only for national public opinion but also for representatives of the international community. Albania's aspirations towards EU accession were strongly intertwined with the election process, as the political environment had been tense since the 2009 parliamentary elections (OSCE/ODIHR, 2013). A few weeks before the election, the CEC faced membership changes that would impact the new government coalition. The changes were perceived as purely politically motivated, especially considering the questionable legal basis for the dismissals (Ligj. Nr.10019, 2008). The political environment remained polarised between DPA and SPA. Newer political parties, such as SMI, appeared to lack the trust of the electorate. The only viable path to securing a seat in the parliament was through coalitions with one of the two major political parties. Despite this, the 2013 parliamentary elections were generally considered successfully. SPA's success of gathering around 1 million votes seems to herald a new chapter for Albanian democracy. Sali Berisha (DPA), the historical leader of DPA, resigned from active politics. By 2015, as the local elections were approaching, the DPA, lead now by Lulzim Basha (DPA),

staged a rally aimed at ousting Rama's (SPA) government, accusing it of being responsible for corruption, and poverty, as well as for its misguided tax policies (Mejdini, 2015). December 8 was deliberately chosen as the date of the protest, coinciding with the anniversary of the first anti-communist protest in the early 1990s, evoking collective memories from the past. The protest initiated by Lulzim Basha (DPA) and the opposition appeared to be a way to motivate its supporters, especially given that pre-election polls were discouraging for DPA. The agenda for the 8th December protest was published before the event took place on the website of DPA. It began as a peaceful march from DPA's offices to the prime minister's office, with DPA's supporters invited to share their dissatisfaction and discuss daily problems on-stage. For DPA, groups such as farmers and small business owners, represented some of the failures of Edi Rama's governance.

By this time, Albania was experiencing a significant brain drain, with young people, specialists, and well-educated citizens emigrating to EU countries. To Lulzim Basha (PDA) and to DPA supporters, the patience of Albanians had come to an end. This marked the start of a serious protest wave, which would not cease until some very popular goals were achieved. Civil disobedience emerged as the tool, with a technocratic government seen as the solution (Koleka, 2015). The opposition protest and massive marches continued until 2017. As the next parliamentary election approached, the intensity of the protests escalated. For a period of three months, DPA organised a 24/7 protest using a large tent on the main boulevard in Tirana. Throughout this time, the opposition's goal was primarily focused on influencing the pre-election environment. The impact of these protests over nearly two years culminated in an agreement between the government and the opposition. Basha (DPA) and Rama (SPA) reached a deal whereby opposition parties would have their representatives included in a 'technical governance' arrangement, serving as temporary vice prime minister and ministers, in key areas including interior, health, education, finance, and justice, to ensure a democratic electoral process. This 'technical governance' was also to be included in the electoral management and monitoring process.

The parliamentary elections in 2017 unfolded relatively calmly despite the ongoing crisis and opposition rallies. Edi Rama (SPA) secured a single-party majority, while the opposition DPA, under the leadership of Lulzim Basha (DPA), suffered a loss in votes. SPA's former coalition partner, SMI previously led by Ilir Meta who, had since become

Albania's president, saw an increase in its seats to 4 from 19 compared to the previous elections and decided to join the opposition coalition (NDI, 2017). Although the opposition parties and their allies (as part of the technical government) were involved in the election management process, the results were contested and for alleged manipulation of the vote-counting, etc (Erebara, 2020). Consequently, the opposition coalition resumed street protest, demanding new parliamentary elections, and emphasising concern about Albania regressing to a one-party state or a totalitarian regime. These protests were followed by parliamentary session boycotts for over a year. For DPA and Lulzim Basha (DPA), these protests and boycotts were a reaction to what they perceived as a state emergency, fuelled by suspicion of vote-counting manipulation by SPA. The two main opposition parties, DPA and SMI, struggled to maintain a united front (Deutsche Welle, 2019). In 2019, their parliament members resigned, leaving the country without an official opposition. These new protest tactics adopted by the Albanian opposition were criticised by both domestic media and the international community, who advocated for a democratic resolution of the issues.

In 2021, Sali Berisha, the former leader of DPA, launched a campaign to regain leadership of the party. Berisha (DPA) had two options: to adhere to the party's statute and hold elections, or to initiate a series of protests against the current leadership of the party. Berisha decided to go for the latter due to two main reasons: (1) DPA had been experiencing electoral losses, including in its electoral bastions, since 2013; (2) Berisha (DPA) faced obstacles to his return to the party under Lulzim Basha's (DPA) leadership. Berisha's (DPA) supporters began protesting against Basha's (DPA) leadership, with some even aiming to forcefully take control of the party headquarters. As a result, since 2021, DPA has been represented by two factions: one led by Lulzim Basha (DPA) as per the party's legal structure and the other by Sali Berisha (DPA) and his supporters, an outcome following a party summit convened by Berisha. Meanwhile, SMIA suffered electoral losses and dwindling support, leading to a decrease in the number of their seats in parliament. In an attempt to revitalise itself, it revamped itself into a new political party, the Freedom Party of Albania (FPA), under the leadership of Ilir Meta (FPA) after his presidential mandate expired. These events, including protests, boycotts, leadership instability, and the reshaping of political parties, have led to disillusionment and loss of hope among their voters. In the two last elections, the opposition parties, such as DPA and FPA, have experienced a

considerable loss of voter support. In contrast, SPA has seen an increase in the municipalities they controlled, including traditional strongholds of DPA, such as Shkodra.

The old rhetoric of democracy and freedom, much needed in the '90s, is now a thing of the past (Kajsiu, 2008). Albania faces new challenges, such as the need to improve living standards, undertake juridical reforms, fulfil EU's membership criteria, and integrate into EU's structures. Power in numbers now is no longer sufficient to achieve protestors' goals if the grievances do not reflect the daily struggles of the population. Furthermore, the failure of the opposition's long-term rallies may be attributed to their reliance on outdated protest repertoire, an outdated political program, or outdated policies.

Power and Protest in Albania: Bottom Up

Social Justice

The establishment of Political Organization (PO) in 2011 marked the beginning of a new era of activism in Albania, distinct from the previous examples discussed above. Founded as a shared space for public discussions by young activists and university professors, PO's ideology is rooted in leftist principles, advocating for social justice, radical social transformation, equality, political participation, and freedom (teza11, 2011). Over the last 12 years, PO has been actively engaged in raising awareness, facilitating public discussion, and empowering people to reach their goals of social justice and socio-economic transformation. One significant aspect of PO's activism has been its contribution to the establishment of independent trade unions, such as chromium miners' union, United Miners' Union of Bulqiza (UMUB), the petrol refinery workers union, United Oil Workers Union, and the call-centre workers union Solidarity (Muci, 2022). Notably, PO emphasised its support for the miners and petrol refinery workers underscoring its early engagement in political movements in Albania. For analytical clarity and enhanced comprehension, specific protest events will be analysed in regard to PO's activism. PO is the first example of a socio-political movement in post-communist Albania. These protest events, supported by PO activists, are characterised by a shared socio-economic background, similar grievances, and often yielding comparable outcomes. The historical trajectory of miners' activism traces back to 2007, marked by a challenging journey fraught with difficulties.

Due to hard and hazardous working conditions prevalent in Bulqizë's mine, a series of fatal working accidents claimed the lives of more than 10 miners within two weeks. During this time, the miners lacked organisation and a specific agenda; rather, they spontaneously rallied together to march in honour of their lost colleagues. Despite the lack of formal organisation, a few benefits were obtained including salary bonuses. Around 2011–2012, the miners once again mobilised for the same reasons, starting a hunger strike, underground, in the confines of their working place. Through this, they were aiming to avoid any external influences until their demands were met (Agolli, 2011). Among the demands were investments in the mine's infrastructure, enhanced work safety measures, higher salaries, earlier retirement options, and access to paid medical services in case of accidents. These were to be safeguarded through a special law on the status of miners. While some of the demands were met initially, achieving a comprehensive safeguarded status remains an ongoing process. As of 2022, citizens from across the country have united to propose a project law in parliament specifically addressing the status of miners.

Education

The debate surrounding higher education reform in Albania traces back to 2011, when the discussion first emerged within university campuses. The main goals of this reform were enhancing credibility and the adoption of the Bologna system in Albania. Over the previous two decades, private institutes had been licensed to operate as universities, leading to a growing scepticism among academics and the public regarding the legitimacy of these institutions, being perceived as businesses rather than providers of quality education. During the electoral campaign of 2013, the government had stated that the higher education reform is a key priority, pledging to implement strict control over private universities, regulate fees, and ensure accreditation of academic processes in both public and private universities. Since then, professors, academics, and students have raised and voiced their concerns regarding the low level of transparency of such a reform.

On 6 December 2018, the Finance Department of the Faculty of Architecture and Urban Planning at the Polytechnic University of Tirana introduced a new fee requirement for students. This decision was part of a broader reform slated to be implemented in public universities

(state owned) by January 2020, seeking to standardise examinations and modules. In response, a coalition of students from the University of Tirana, supported by the Movement for the University (MU), decided to boycott classes and hold a protest at the Ministry of Education, Sports, and Youth. Within three days, the protest had increased to 10,000–15,000 students participating from all over Albania (Qorri, 2018). The protest continued for more than two months, primarily manifesting through boycotting university activities and students peacefully articulating their demands. These included the issuance of student id cards, reduced fees for public universities, improved infrastructure in dormitories, and better quality of teaching and research (Top-Channel, 2018). Student protests were categorically separate from political organisations, particularly opposition parties, political leadership, or any individual who had political connections and influence over public opinion. The protests, often compared with the student protest in the 90s, lasted for three weeks and marked a significant shift in protest culture, changing the perceptions within Albanian society regarding protesting and decision-making. During the protest, social media emerged as an effective mobilisation platform, allowing students to share their grievances and address them to the proper channels such as the government and the Ministry of Education (Hasa, 2019). Traditional media also covered the protests extensively as their intensity grew day by day. The student protest is a pivotal event in post-communist Albania for several reasons. It transcended the mere grievances of the moment to become a full-fledged social movement. It had a historical trajectory, with support from various social groups, but no politicians. In addition, social media and traditional media impacted the public perception of protest, emphasising that also alternative forms of participation, beyond elections and political party memberships, are needed in democracies (Rammelt, 2018). The student movement's outcomes are a testament to the power of the combination of the need for social change and citizens' activism, which ultimately led to social change and the cultivation of a protest culture. Additionally, amidst particular conditions such as COVID-19, other significant events unfolded. One such event occurred during the lockdown period December 2020 when a young man was shot dead by the police (ABCNews, 2020). Klodian Rasha, a 25-year-old, was walking near his house in the early morning of 8 December 2020, during curfew hours. Subsequent investigations revealed that the young man had no prior criminal record and protests erupted that lasted for 5 days, even

during curfew hours. The protestors expressed their sense of insecurity caused by repression and life-threatening situations during encounters with law enforcement. This incident ultimately shed light on the country's trajectory towards becoming a police-centric state rather than a democracy. Consequently, the Minister of Interior Affairs, Sandër Lleshi (SP), resigned from his position, and the police officer responsible for shooting the young boy was convicted and sentenced to ten years in prison.

The onset of the pandemic and the war in Ukraine only a few months later contributed to further aggravating the socio-economic situation, leading to price increases for countless products, particularly oil, gas, and petrol products. In response, a peaceful protest was organised, spurred by a status on Facebook stating '*I am tired of the prices, tomorrow I will protest, even if I am the only one*' posted by activist Adriatic Llapaj, who managed to gather thousands of Tirana's citizens. The protest centred around degrading living conditions and called for tax policies aimed at reducing prices for essential food products. Despite its simplicity, the protest was impactful, while brief and peaceful. As a result, a special tax force was established to monitor gas prices, marking a tangible outcome of the demonstration.

Urbanism

The National Theatre Building (NTB) was a project initiated by Giulio Berté in January 1938 and completed on 17 May 1939 (Hoxha, 2016). Initially, the building structure was proposed to be a multifunctional space, encompassing a theatre, pools, sports fields, and restaurants. With all these functions, the NTB boasted its own distinct architectural style, characterised by its symmetrical shape with two structures resembling towers, reflecting a post-futuristic design (ibid.). After World War II, Enver Hoxha's communist regime repurposed the building as the 'Special Court' for trials against the 'enemies of the people'. However, on 17 May 1945, the building was officially inaugurated as the National Theatre and served as a theatre to both national and international performers until 2020. Despite its historical significance, constant discussions calling for the demolition of the NTB have occurred since the early 2000s. Actors and artists argued against such plans, and no concrete actions towards the demolition were taken. In recent years, proposals for new territorial reforms and constructions emerged, including a government proposal to build a smaller theatre in the same area. Again, these territorial reforms faced resistance from artists, urbanists, and architects. Due

to its architectural significance, the NTB was included as one of the 14 most endangered places in Europe by Europa Nostra in December 2019 (Kryeziu, 2020). The proposal was met with disapproval and protests from the artistic community followed. For over two years, artists continued to protect the building by keeping watch around the clock in shifts, demonstrating their determination to preserve the NTB (Hoxha, 2022). However, despite the opposition and various institutional arrangements between Tirana's Municipality and the Government, a decision was made for the demolition of the building. On 17 May 2020, the 75th anniversary of the building, without prior announcement and disregarding the pandemic protocol and legal procedures, state police entered the building at 4.20 a.m., arresting the citizens inside and initiating the demolition process. The protest continued the next day, attempting to stop the demolition, and persisted even under the conditions of COVID-19 curfews and lockdown. Activism surrounding the NTB has a historical trajectory spanning approximately 12 years of resistance. The long-term activism evolved around the establishment of a social movement organisation Alliance for the Protection of the Theater (APT) a heterogeneous organisation primarily led by actors and artists. Among many challenges faced, the mobilisation was ultimately doomed to fail due to a lack of physical public space where protesters could gather, maintain the continuity of the protest, and attract others to join. Additionally, there was a pervasive discourse within the media, often framing activists as a small group of people who do not understand the necessity of urban modernisation and the city's development (Redaksia, 2020). Despite the resistance, protest, civic engagement, and public support, the building was ultimately demolished.

Similar modern territorial transformation projects, such as the area of the former main station, an artificial lake, '*5 Maj,' Unaza e re*', and the *Bërxullë* neighbourhood, spurred similar protests from 2019 to 2021. The main point of contention revolved around the financial compensation for owners, with government institutions offering considerably lower compensation than market value. Some protests lasted for months, while others were short-lived, occasionally involving confrontations with law enforcement, but mostly occurring without incident. Eventually, the protests came to an end as some activists were co-opted by political parties, and others were incentivised through financial means to cease their opposition (Top-Channel, 2018).

Environment

The environment plays a crucial role for Albanian citizens and environmental issues are very present in decision-making processes through political parties, notably the Green Party. The following events can be considered the inception of a new environmental movement. Firstly, in 2011, Law no. 1046, of 22/09/2011 '*Integrated management of solid waste*' (QBZ, 2011) aimed to ensure the protection of the environment and human health against pollution and damages resulting from solid waste. The law outlined objectives to enhance integrated waste management plans, stipulate general requirements, and provide guidelines for the managing various types of waste, including hazardous waste, specific waste, waste land-filling, waste burning, and waste import and export, along with technical standards (UNEP-LEAP, 2011). However, procedures for proposing and approving the law raised concerns among the citizens regarding the safety and health implications of waste management, given the absence of adequate infrastructure. Moreover, there were plans to import solid waste from other European countries, which further alarmed the public and activists, viewing these procedures and investments as a threat to the environment and the citizens alike. The law also lacked specificity regarding the kind of waste that could be imported, leading citizens to feel threatened by the potential import of medical waste or hazardous substances. Despite small and spontaneous protests organised before the vote on the law, they were unsuccessful in preventing its ratification. Subsequently, an 'Alliance against waste import' was formed by citizens and environmental NGOs, calling for a referendum. However, initiating such legislative action posed a significant challenge and could be very time-consuming. According to Law No. 9087 of 19 June 2003, which regulates citizen initiatives in the legislative process, particularly referendums, 50,000 endorsements from eligible voters are required to propose a referendum. The law outlines the legal steps to hold a referendum once the citizens have obtained the necessary endorsements, a process which could take more than two years. It passed, despite the activism and the referendum processes, which were underway for the entire time in which the parliament discussed and voted on the law. The SPA opposition promised to suspend the decision if they won the upcoming parliamentary elections. As institutions such as the CEC and the Constitutional Court examined the documents submitted by the citizens, SPA won the majority in the parliamentary

elections. By September 2013, Law No. 1046, dated 22 September 2011 was suspended, rendering the referendum unnecessary. The event sparked discussions among the public on referendums and how to improve or design new legislation on them, a discussion that continues to this day.

Syrian Chemical Weapons Proposal 2013

Albania was considered to become a potential destination for dismantled Syrian chemical weapons, leading to a five-day protest. The protests followed smaller gatherings in the centre of Elbasan and its nearby village *Mjekës*, where the facility to dismantle weapons was located. Several factors contributed to public opposition to the proposal. These included a lack of infrastructure and expertise for handling such processes, as well as memories from past incidents like the explosion at a cartridge factory in 2008. This event strongly impacted public opinion and stimulated a perception of the proposal as dangerous, potentially life threatening in the event of accidents, and environmentally unfriendly. In addition, Albania's emerging status as a tourist destination added to concerns (Geoghegan, 2013). As the protest continued, Prime Minister Edi Rama (SPA) engaged in discussions on the matter with international political leaders, but no decision was made by him or his government (Nichols & Deutsch, 2013). Protestors had flooded the main boulevard of Tirana, as well as the cities of Korçë, Elbasan, Shkodër, Lezhë, and Gjirokastër. In Durres, they managed to successfully block the main entrance to the country's main harbour. Beyond the initial protestors, additional groups gathered to join the rally, including hundreds of students, journalists, and civil society organisations. Never before had such spontaneous mass mobilisation happened. These events serve as the best examples of grassroots mobilisation and the initial stages of a social movement fitting the characteristics of a bottom-up mobilisation. Life and a safe environment are among Albanians' highest priorities, motivating them to mobilise and impact the decision-making process. Moreover, these events brought citizens from all over the country together in Tirana, marking a new pattern of collective behaviour and political culture. They also challenged the dominance of political parties, demonstrating that citizens can utilise non-conventional forms, such as protests, to assert their influence.

Valbona Valley

Albania boasts a diverse ecosystem, encompassing a long coastline, considerable mountains regions, rivers, and valleys. The socio-political transition and the economic development had, however, a very negative impact on the environment. Thus Valbona Valley, nestled in the Albanian Alps, has gotten attention from international tourists and media alike due to its wild nature and picturesque hiking trails. As a result, locals started investing in guesthouses, leading to a resurgence in village populations as attention grew from investors. However, a pressing problem faced by the locals and environmentalists was the emergence of hydropower investments threatening the valley's delicate ecosystem. For years, citizens, locals, environmentalists, and artists have joined forces to raise awareness and protect the region against these investments, using various forms of protest trying to impact decision-making processes. One new, innovative form involved organising festivals and art activities to raise awareness about the threats facing the valley. A jazz festival (ZA Fest) organised by local and international artists was held in the valley. The ZA festival, in particular, aimed to prevent hydropower investments. The festival is now a traditional event, continuing as a poignant reminder of the importance of nature and as a means of preventing further damage to the environment.

Vjosa Valley

The Vjosa River is considered the last wild river in Europe, possessing a wilderness made up of an enormous mosaic of diverse habitats from narrow gorges in the upper reaches to the wide braided river sections in the middle and a near-natural delta at the Adriatic Sea. The middle stretch alone comprises eight habitats of the highest conservation importance at the EU level (Balkan Rivers, 2022).

For years, this pristine river ecosystem has been threatened by dam projects that, if constructed, would destroy this natural landscape, flooding some parts of the valley while leaving others dry. In addition to the dam projects, the Vjosa Valley faces further environmental jeopardy due to an impending airport construction project. Environmentalists, activists, and citizens have been advocating for the proclamation of the Valley as a National Park. The timeline of the Vjosa's valley activism can be summarised including the following main events. In 2014, protests started as local mayors and valley locals held the first press conference,

calling on the government to reject the dam project and establish Vjosa Valley as a National Park. The Vjosa Valley awareness campaign went international, influencing the European Union Parliament to halt all dam plans. By 2019, the '#Hands off Vjosa' gained momentum on social media platforms, with support from notable figures such as Leonardo DiCaprio. Environmental organisations, such as Eco Albania, successfully sued the dam project in administrative court. A 'Hands off Vjosa' concert followed the year after in nearby towns, drawing attention to the cause. In 2020, one of the largest science petitions in global freshwater ecology called to halt dam projects in the Vjosa Valley. In 2021, over 20 Albanian environmental organisations, led by Eco Albania, submitted a detailed proposal to the Ministry of Tourism and Environment to classify the Vjosa Valley as a National Park. In 2022, the Albanian government declared the Vjosa Valley as a Nature Park instead of National Park. The legal status of Vjosa Valley as a Nature Park would not provide effective protection to the area or its tributaries against destruction. Efforts to proclaim Vjosa Valley as National Park are ongoing, even as construction for the airport proceeds. Despite the challenges, activists remain committed to preserving the ecological integrity of the Vjosa Valley and continue to advocate for its designation as a National Park.

Conclusion

Albanian activism throughout the past two decades has been steadily evolving and shaping a political culture of active citizens. Events analysed in this chapter show that resource mobilisation is essential for mass mobilisation and impactful on decision-making. It is also highly relevant when assessing the consequences of protests. Protests organised by political parties most often mobilise around historical and political conditions and articulate grievances along party-lines. Such protests are more effective in reaching their goals and are thus considered more successful than civic engagement. The partial success of these top-down mobilisation events can be explained through their privileged access to material resources, such as logistics, supporters, and money. On the other hand, the political system provides fewer options for bottom-up activism to impact decision-making. The Albanian political system most often uses the legal framework, legal prerogatives, and repressive policing to quell protests. A media system that is controlled by a few people and often

aligns with their owners' political parties, particular interests, and partisanship further burdens bottom-up mobilisations. However, in recent years, social media platforms have been used as effective communication channels and mobilisation tools by activists, partially circumventing the challenges posed by the unsympathetic mainstream media.

However, the oftentimes violent repression of protests and the lack of opportunities to influence decision-making, hence, the relatively unfavourable political opportunity structures, still provide ground for bottom-up mobilisations. When drawing on scholarship dedicated to the effects of protests and social movements, the Albanian case provides a number of very interesting inferences. The outcomes of bottom-up protests are mainly limited to effects of the protest on the protests themselves, on the protesters, and on subsequent social movements. Outcomes can, then, mainly be considered in terms of biographical impact of activism (McAdam, 1989), or in terms of unintended consequences of 'eventful protests' (della Porta, 2008). The oftentimes violent repression of protest provides opportunities for movements to construct efficient 'injustice frames' (Gamson et al., 1982).

The NTB exemplifies how gaps in the legal framework create opportunities for misleading legal interpretations and conflicting instructional agendas that may not align with the public interests or opinions. When Tirana's Townhall decided to demolish the NTB, the Constitutional Court had been facing a shortage of members due to legal reforms, making it impossible for the court to render a decision. Consequently, the legal procedures for the demolition could not be judged by the court.

I pinpointed a number of points of contention that managed to bring Albanians on the streets: inaccessible power structures, structural grievances, and contradictions between generally accepted values and actual political practices. Despite efforts to quell the protests, such as the oftentimes violent repression, means of social control meant to steer collective behaviour, broad parts of Albanian society showed tremendous resilience, and a democratic political culture emerged. Social movements often try to influence public opinion, not only regarding their claims and the social wrongs they identify but also regarding their own acceptability (Woodly, 2015). Correspondingly, another 'unintended' consequence of the protests can be identified in the gradual subtle change in public opinion, benefiting from the concentrated but polarised media landscape. A certain opening of the media towards protest-related topics and increased coverage of such topics, similar to cases in other countries of

the region (see Rammelt [2014] for Romania), can be observed. Consequently, the general perception regarding activism changes with every success story of social and political struggle, inspiring citizens to take a stand.

Yet, the political elite remains largely unchallenged in Albania. The country is a prime example of how closed and repressive systems stimulate protest and activism while limiting their effects on the system itself. To provoke sustainable change that extends beyond protest participants, political activists, and involved citizens, a variety of tools needs to be employed. Protest, legal support, legal struggle, social media activism, and awareness-raising campaigns are all crucial parts of a toolkit that is steadily developing. This toolkit has the potential to impact public opinion and, ultimately, to challenge the political elite's control over the discourse and their grip on power.

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Belarus—Civil Resistance and State Repression in an Autocracy

Olena Nikolayenko

Belarus under Aliaksandr Lukashenka has become known as "Europe's last dictatorship" (Korosteleva et al., 2023; Wilson, 2011).[1] Elected as the president in 1994, the former head of a state-owned farm (*sovkhoz*) concentrated all the power in his hands by building a massive coercive apparatus, maintaining a behemoth state sector, and inhibiting the development of opposition political parties, independent judiciary, non-state media, non-governmental organisations, private business, and independent trade unions (Bedford, 2017; Frear, 2018; Marples, 2009; Silitski, 2010). The 1996 referendum expanded the presidential powers and paved the way for the disbandment of the national parliament. In 2004, Lukashenka staged another referendum, abolishing the two-term presidential limits. The incumbent assumed his sixth consecutive term in

[1] Most names are transliterated from Belarusian into English, using the American Library association—Library of Congress (ALA-LC) Romanization Tables, https://www.loc.gov/catdir/cpso/romanization/belarusian.pdf.

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office in September 2020. The strongman systematically targeted alternative sources of power in an attempt to consolidate and extend his rule. Yet, there remained pockets of resistance to the current regime. Drawing on their prior involvement in various civic initiatives and non-political activities, Belarusians exhibited "a remarkable capacity for grassroots self-organisation" in 2020 (Astapova et al., 2022).

This chapter examines the interplay between civil resistance and state repression in contemporary Belarus. The concept of nonviolent resistance denotes "a method of struggle in which unarmed people confront an adversary by using collective action—including protests, demonstrations, strikes, and noncooperation—to build power and achieve political goals" (Chenoweth, 2020, p. 70). The chapter begins by describing political and socioeconomic conditions that affected contentious politics in the country. Next, the chapter scrutinises major cases of mass mobilisation against the regime between 2006 and 2022, with a focus on electoral malpractices, historical memory, environmental protection, and anti-war activism.

The chapter seeks to contribute to interdisciplinary scholarship on protests and repression by examining methods of civil resistance and state countermoves in one of the most repressive political regimes in contemporary Europe. Belarus under Lukashenka falls into the category of countries in which civil liberties and political rights are systematically violated. Nonetheless, civil resisters seek to employ a wide range of nonviolent methods to erode the strength of the regime. The chapter speaks to a key debate in contentious politics literature about the effectiveness of nonviolent resistance in bringing down an autocrat. Over the past three decades, Belarusians have shown unwavering commitment to nonviolent action (for an overview, see Bulgakau & Dynko, 2011). In particular, thousands of people participated in peaceful anti-government protests in the summer of 2020. Yet, mass mobilisation appeared to be an insufficient condition for the removal of the incumbent from office. Despite large-scale protests, the autocrat retained the loyalty of the coercive apparatus and remained in power. A cross-time analysis of state-society relations is important to enhance our understanding of today's struggles for democracy and national independence in the country.

Political Opportunity Structure

A major argument in contentious politics literature is that political opportunity structure, "consistent—but not necessarily formal or permanent—dimensions of the political struggle," affects the level of mass mobilisation (Tarrow, 1998, pp. 19–20). Scholars distinguish different elements of the political environment pertinent to contentious politics, including elite divisions, defections within the coercive apparatus, unity of opposition political parties, development of independent media, and support of influential allies (Meyer, 2007; Osa & Corduneanu-Huci, 2003). Consistent with the political opportunity perspective, security defections might increase the likelihood of social unrest in a hard autocracy. The KGB of Belarus, however, retained the Soviet-era methods of social control and remained loyal to the regime. Opinion polls conducted by the Independent Institute of Socio-Economic and Political Studies (IISEPS) also suggest that less than one-fifth of the voting-age population trusted opposition political parties. Only 18.9% of survey respondents in December 2007, as well as 15.8% of respondents in December 2013, reported trust in opposition political parties (IISEPS, 2007, p. 3; 2013, p. 11). Moreover, the degree of press freedom was dismally low throughout the period. Belarus was ranked 153rd out of 180 countries in 2019–2022, down from 151st in 2006, in the World Press Freedom Index compiled by the Reporters without Borders.[2] Taken as a whole, there were hostile conditions for mass mobilisation.

In addition to domestic factors, the international political opportunity structure had a profound impact on interactions between the incumbent government and challenger organisations. Specifically, policies pursued by the European Union (EU) and the Russian Federation affected the political climate in Belarus. On the one hand, the EU sought to stimulate democratic development in the East European country. On the other hand, the Russian government tried to sustain the authoritarian regime and deepen Belarus's economic dependence on Russia.

A wave of electoral revolutions marked by mass mobilisation against electoral malpractices, popular demands for regime change, and the use

[2] The World Press Freedom Index is calculated based on five indicators of the press freedom situation, assessing the political context, legal framework, economic context, sociocultural context, and journalists' safety. For details, visit the webpage of the Reporters without Borders, https://rsf.org/en/index-methodologie-2022?year=2022&data_type=general.

of nonviolent action swept across the post-communist region in the early 2000s (Bunce & Wolchik, 2011; Nikolayenko, 2017). The 2003 Rose Revolution caused the resignation of the incumbent President Eduard Shevardnadze and brought into power Mikheil Saakashvili, a reform-oriented, pro-European politician. Over the course of the 2004 Orange Revolution, Ukrainians set up an encampment on Independence Square in the capital city of Kyiv and demanded the overturn of the fraudulent election results, which culminated in a rerun of the second round of the presidential election and the electoral victory of Viktor Yushchenko, a former banker with pro-European views. Furthermore, post-election protests erupted in Azerbaijan and the Kyrgyz Republic in 2005. This wave of anti-regime mobilisation was a catalyst for the emergence of an encampment in the capital city of Minsk in the wake of the 2006 election. Concurrently, the Belarusian government drew lessons from prior electoral revolutions and took preemptive measures (Silitski, 2005). Specifically, state authorities expanded the use of information and communication technology to subvert mass mobilisation against the regime (Lysenko & Desouza, 2015).

The country underwent a period of limited liberalisation in the aftermath of the deteriorating Belarus-Russia relations and the 2008 financial crisis. The Russian government exerted pressure on Lukashenka by exploiting energy resources as an instrument of foreign policy. In 2007, the Russian state-owned gas company Gazprom raised the gas price for Belarus from $46.7 per 1,000 cubic metres to $100 (Maksymiuk, 2007). Initially, Gazprom gained a fifty-percent stake in Beltranshaz, Belarus's state-owned gas pipeline company. As a result of another deal signed in 2011, Gazprom acquired full ownership of Beltranshaz in exchange for the sale of gas at a discount price (*BBC*, 2011). Russia's ban on dairy products from Belarus also signified tensions in bilateral relations in the summer of 2009. In turn, Lukashenka tried to improve his relations with the EU and solicit financial resources from the West. In May 2009, Belarus participated in the Eastern Partnership Summit aimed at deepening political and economic ties among European countries. Under international pressure, several political prisoners, including Mikalai Dziadok, Artsiom Prakapenka, Yury Rubtsou, and Mikalai Statkevich, were released before the 2015 presidential election.

Following a streak of positive economic growth from 1996 to 2014, Belarus's economy sank into recession in 2015–2016. GDP growth

dropped from 7.8% in 2010 to −3.8% in 2015.[3] According to the official statistics, the unemployment rate rose from 0.5% in 2014 to 5.8% in 2016. The Life in Transition Surveys also registered a decline in life satisfaction in Belarus, down from 51% in 2010 to 41% in 2016 (de Haas, 2016, p. 80). Only twenty percent of the survey respondents reported that their households lived better in 2016 than four years earlier. Against this backdrop, Lukashenka performed a balancing act by negotiating financial assistance from the EU and the International Monetary Fund and securing a new aid package from the Moscow-based Eurasian Fund for Stabilization and Development (Shraibman, 2016a). Yet, the Belarusian government was reluctant to implement structural reforms.

The government's response to the COVID-19 pandemic delivered a heavy blow to the legitimacy of the current regime (Silvan & Kilybayeva, 2024). Lukashenka denied the hazardous effects of the coronavirus and did not introduce any lockdown measures in 2020. According to the official statistics, Belarus reportedly had one of the lowest death rates in Europe during the pandemic (Kirpich et al., 2022). In reality, however, the situation was far worse. Given the government's denial of a public health emergency, activists launched a crowdsourcing campaign ByCovid19 and raised €304,000 in three months to purchase personal protective equipment, oxygen tanks, and other medical equipment for local hospitals (Karáth, 2020). Furthermore, the level of trust in the government has considerably dropped. An online survey conducted by the Berlin-based Centre for East European and International Studies (ZOiS) found that more than half of 18–34-year-old Belarusians residing in the country's six largest cities disapproved of the president's decision not to implement the COVID-19 restrictions amid the pandemic (Krawatzek & Sasse, 2021). In addition, online polls released by such leading Belarusian media outlets as *Tut.by* and *Onliner.by* suggested that only three percent of their audience was going to vote for Lukashenka in the 2020 election (Wesolowsky, 2020).

Furthermore, the Russia-Ukraine war affected state-society relations in Belarus. In 2014, Lukashenka was reluctant to take a clear-cut position on Russia's annexation of Crimea to maintain relations with various stakeholders in the region (Shraibman, 2016b). However, following the 2020

[3] Data on Belarus's economy are retrieved from the *World Development Indicators* [database]. The World Bank, https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators.

presidential election, Lukashenka's space for political manoeuvring has considerably narrowed down. In the midst of the 2020 anti-government protests throughout Belarus, President of Russia Vladimir Putin pledged a $1.5 billion loan to the republic. "Russia is our elder brother," remarked Lukashenka during his meeting with Putin in Sochi. "If someone beyond the Western borders is itching [for a fight], we are ready at any moment" (Levchenko, 2020). Amid mass protests, Belarus hosted the Belarusian-Russian military drills named Slavic Brotherhood in September 2020 and the military drills organised by the Collective Security Treaty Organization under the code name Inviolable Brotherhood in October 2020 (*Belta*, 2020; Romashenko, 2020). In February 2022, Belarus became a launching pad for a Russian attack against Ukraine. Opinion polls conducted by the Chatham House in the summer of 2022 indicate that one-third of Belarus's urban population supported Russia's military operation in Ukraine (Chatham House, 2022a, p. 5). Moreover, given the heavy consumption of news from Belarusian and Russian state-controlled media sources, 41% of survey respondents in August 2022 agreed with the statement that the Russian troops were not using weapons against civilians in Ukraine (Chatham House, 2022a, p. 8). Survey results also show that consumption of news from state-controlled media was negatively associated with support for democracy and market economy (Chatham House, 2022b, p. 14). In contrast, those Belarusians who consumed news from such media sources as *Belsat*, *Euroradio*, *Nasha Niva*, and *Radyio Svaboda* reported less favourable views of Russian foreign policy. Specifically, many Belarusians disapproved of Russia's actions to coerce Belarus into further integration with the Russian Federation under the guise of a union state.

Post-election Protests in Belarus

Despite gross violations of democratic procedures, national elections are regularly held in Belarus. Over the past fifteen years, the presidential elections took place in March 2006, December 2010, October 2015, and August 2020. In addition to the incumbent, several candidates were placed on the ballot. According to the official results, however, Lukashenka reportedly won more than two-thirds of the popular vote. In March 2006, for example, the incumbent was re-elected with 82.6% of the vote, and his main opponent Aliaksandr Milinkevich received six percent of the vote. Likewise, Lukashenka allegedly garnered 79.6% of the popular vote in December 2010, while Andrei Sannikau, co-founder of the civic

organisation Charter 97, received 2.4%, and the Belarusian poet Uladzimir Nyaklyayew—1.7% (Organization for Security and Co-operation in Europe, 2011, p. 28). The official results of the 2020 presidential election appeared to be fraught with an astounding degree of electoral fraud (*Voice of Belarus*, 2020). In August 2020, the Central Election Commission of Belarus declared that Lukashenka was re-elected for the sixth consecutive term, with 80.1% of the popular vote, and Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya reportedly received only 10.1% of the vote. A high incidence of electoral malpractices ignited post-election protests.

Ploshcha-2006 was a hallmark of mass mobilisation against gross violations of democratic procedures during the 2006 presidential election. Between 20,000 and 30,000 people gathered on Kastrychnitskaya (October) Square on 19 March 2006 to protest against vote rigging and dispute Lukashenka's re-election for the third consecutive term (Viasna, 2006a, p. 4). Amid biting weather, civil resisters established an encampment, and hundreds of people stayed on the main square around the clock (Kudrytski, 2007; Navumau, 2016). The first four tents were set up on March 20. By March 23, thirty-four tents were installed on the square (Dubavets, 2006, p. 134). People chanted such slogans as "Long Live Belarus" (*Zhyve Belarus!*) and "We Believe! We Can! We Will Win!" (*Verym! Mozham! Peramozham!*). Another salient attribute of civil resistance was the banned white-red-white flag, which was adopted by the Belarusian Democratic Republic (*Belaruskaia Narodnaia Respublika*, BNR) in 1918 and regained its legal status in post-Soviet Belarus until the 1995 referendum, bringing back the Soviet-style symbols of statehood (*EuroBelarus*, 2016). Young people and in particular university students made up a sizable share of encampment inhabitants. The documentary film *Ploshcha* directed by Yury Khashchavatski, for example, highlighted the youth's participation in civil resistance.[4]

As a countermove, the police restricted citizens' access to the encampment. Minsk residents had difficulty delivering food and supplies to youthful protesters enduring subfreezing temperatures. Moreover, most people who exited the encampment were beaten and arrested in surrounding areas (Peuch, 2006). At dawn on March 24, the riot police stormed the encampment and terminated the occupation of urban space in the centre of the city. That day, over 327 protesters were taken to the

[4] A full version of the documentary *Ploshcha* is available for viewing on the YouTube channel *Belsat Doc* at: https://youtu.be/L97M6G8-Lhc?si=QS39ktLEdBXW1mMv.

Akrestsina detention centre (Viasna, 2006b). Overall, more than a thousand people were arrested for their participation in the 2006 post-election protests (Chavusau & Reviaka, 2007, p. 55). Targeting youth activists, the coercive apparatus deployed repressive measures against members of such youth organisations as Malady Front (Youth Front) and Bunt (Revolt) and the civic initiative Khopyts (Enough). Scores of students were expelled from universities and forced to leave the country. Some Belarusian youth moved to Vilnius, home to the European Humanities University which was shut down by the Belarusian government in 2004 and relocated to Lithuania (Dounaev, 2007). Other Belarusian students continued their education at Polish universities with the support of the newly established, Polish-funded Konstanty Kalinowski Scholarship Program (Pospieszna, 2014). Meanwhile, the former presidential contender Milinkevich announced the establishment of the social movement Za Svabodu (For Freedom).

On the night of 19 December 2010, thousands of people again turned out on Kastrychnitskaya Square to denounce vote rigging and state repression. As a preemptive measure, state authorities erected a large skating rink and blasted Russian pop music on the city's main square to contain the size of a protest rally and silence opposition politicians. In turn, protesters decided to march to Independence Square, where the main office of the Central Election Commission was located. According to some estimates, between 30,000 and 40,000 people gathered on the square, holding white-red-white flags and chanting such slogans as "Get Out!" (*Ukhadzi*) and "Long Live Belarus" (*Charter 97*, 2010). Some provocateurs tried to break into a government building (*Nasha Niva*, 2010). In response, the riot police deployed disproportionate force against protesters to clear the square. It was one of the most violent dispersals of protests in Belarus's recent history (*Belsat*, 2018). A survey of released detainees conducted by the Legal Transformation Center, a Belarusian non-governmental organisation, and the Independent Observation Mission, an international group of activists, documented that "most of the trials were held behind closed doors, without defence counsel, and lasted no longer than ten to fifteen minutes" (Human Rights Watch, 2011a). At least 725 people were sentenced to imprisonment for 10–15 days for participation in a public gathering and subjected to inhumane conditions and ill-treatment (Human Rights Watch, 2011b; Legal Transformation Center, 2011). Several opposition politicians and activists

were imprisoned for longer terms; some of them were released due to Western pressure by the time of the next election.

The presidential election held on 30 June 2015 concluded without mass anti-government protests. Most well-known opposition politicians and seasoned activists were denied a chance to run for the presidency. The political opposition called for a boycott of the national elections. Tatsiana Karatkevich, a member of the civic campaign Tell the Truth! (*Govori pravdu!*), was criticised for her decision to participate in the presidential race and, thus, bestow a modicum of legitimacy upon the electoral process (*Novy Chas*, 2015; *Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty*, 2015). The other two presidential candidates placed on the ballot congratulated Lukashenka on his electoral victory even before the Central Election Commission officially declared him a winner (Schreck, 2015).

Using a similar playbook, the Belarusian government drove any viable candidate out of the presidential race in 2020 (Amnesty International, 2020). Siarhei Tsikhanouski, a popular blogger and producer of the YouTube channel *Strana dlia zhizni* (Country for Life) was arrested two days prior to the government's announcement of the election date in May 2020. Mikalai Statkevich, a leader of the Belarusian Social Democratic Party (Hramada), was also arrested in May 2020 and later sentenced to fourteen years in prison. Similarly, Paval Seviarynets, a long-standing critic of Lukashenka's regime and a co-founder of the Belarusian Christian Democracy Party, was detained in June 2020 and subsequently sentenced to seven years in prison. Viktar Babaryka, a well-known banker, was arrested after his team collected a sufficient number of signatures for his registration as a presidential candidate. Valery Tsapkala, former director of a high-tech park, also declared his intent to run for the presidency, but he fled the country prior to his arrest and received a seventeen-year sentence in absentia. Despite a high level of state repression, three female political novices formed a united front against the strongman and drew large crowds on the campaign trail (Tsapkala et al., 2021). Maryia Kalesnikava, a member of Babaryka's election campaign team, and spouses of the two presidential hopefuls—Sviatlana Tsikhanouskaya and Veranika Tsapkala—sought to overcome the climate of fear and mobilise popular support for political change.

Some of the largest anti-government protests in contemporary Belarus were held in the aftermath of the 2020 presidential election (Bedford, 2021). According to various estimates, between 200,000 and 500,000 people joined the March for Freedom in Minsk on 16 August 2020

(*Charter 97*, 2020). Moreover, anti-government protests erupted in over one hundred localities throughout the country. Mateo (2022) finds that pre-existing social network ties were crucial to the anti-regime mobilisation in August 2020. Sociological research also indicates that people from different backgrounds, including IT sector employees, industrial workers, doctors, and university students, took to the streets to condemn police violence and demand political change (Bekus & Gabowitsch, 2021). Public outrage over electoral fraud and police brutality, along with the loss of fear, drew tens of thousands of people into a nonviolent struggle against the regime (Nikolayenko, 2022).

Women's marches were a highlight of civil resistance in Belarus (Gapova, 2023; Gaufman, 2021). For several weeks on Saturdays, women dressed in white or wrapped in white-red-white flags marched in downtown Minsk, carrying flowers, holding protest signs, and chanting slogans. On September 5, for example, approximately 5,000 women participated in a march, calling for an end to police brutality (Bellamy, 2020). On September 19, the number of participants dropped to 2,000 people, and the police arrested over 300 women, including 73-year-old retired geologist Nina Bahinskaya (*BBC*, 2020).

Another prominent feature of the 2020 mass mobilisation was the rise of the working class against the incumbent government. Workers demanded the annulment of the results of the fraudulent elections, the release of all the political prisoners and individuals arrested for their participation in peaceful post-election rallies, and the conduct of a transparent investigation into the cases of the excessive use of force by the police. On August 17, workers at the Minsk Wheeled Tractor Plant (*Minski zavod kolavykh tsiahachou*, MZKT) greeted Lukashenka with boos and the chant "Leave!" (Scollon, 2020). That day, nearly 10,000 workers from major Minsk enterprises, including the Minsk Tractor Works (*Minski traktarny zavod*, MTZ) and the Minsk Automobile Plant (*Minski autamabilny zavod*, MAZ), marched through the city to the main office of Belteleradiocompany and called for an end of state censorship on national television (*Radyio Svaboda*, 2020a). Across the country, workers signalled their disapproval of the incumbent government's performance. Of 16,000 employees at Belaruskali, one of the world's largest producers of potash fertilisers located in the city of Salihorsk, over 6,000 people put their signatures in support of a strike in August 2020 (Kotliar, 2020). Similarly, one-third (approximately 3,400 of 10,000 people) of workers at

the oil refinery Naftan and Polymir, a manufacturer of chemical products in Navapolatsk, voted in support of the protesters' demands (*Radyio Svaboda*, 2020c). Over 500 employees at Hrodna Azot, a producer of nitrogen compounds and fertilisers, declared their participation in a strike on August 19 (*Hrodna Life*, 2020). Furthermore, many workers withdrew their membership in state-controlled trade unions and joined independent trade unions in an attempt to resist the brutal regime and advocate for labour rights (Artiukh & Gorbach, 2020).

Faced with a staggering level of civil resistance, the strongman ordered a massive crackdown against regime opponents. More than 33,000 Belarusians were imprisoned for their participation in the election campaign and post-election protests from May to December 2020 (Viasna, 2021a). Hundreds of testimonies collected by human rights organisations demonstrate the systematic use of torture in detention centres (Human Rights Watch, 2020; International Committee for Investigation of Torture, 2023; Viasna, 2021a). Jailed protesters were subject to psychological intimidation, physical violence, and sexual violence (Belarus Women's Foundation, 2021; International Partnership for Human Rights and Truth Hounds, 2020). Many activists lost employment, and scores of students were expelled from universities (Danilovich, 2021). In addition, state authorities cracked down on the mass media, civic organisations, and trade unions. Independent trade unions, for example, were designated as "extremist organisations," and labour union activists were imprisoned (Amnesty International, 2021; Viasna, 2022e). Furthermore, following the replacement of Belarusian journalists with RT staff in August 2020, Russian political technologists assumed key positions at the Belarusian state-owned media company and bombarded the country with an avalanche of disinformation campaigns (*Radyio Svaboda*, 2020b).

A longitudinal examination of post-election protests demonstrates that the level of mass mobilisation against electoral malpractices varied over time. Public outrage over the quality of elections peaked when the incumbent's approval rating hit its lowest point and the magnitude of electoral fraud reached enormous proportions. The scale of police brutality against participants in peaceful post-election rallies further amplified mass discontent in 2020. Civil resisters experimented with a wide range of methods, including the occupation of urban space, protest rallies, marches, and strikes. In response, the coercive apparatus deployed a wide arsenal of

repressive methods to strangulate anti-regime mobilisation and safeguard the regime's survival.

Freedom Day

March 25, known as Freedom Day (*Dzen Voli*), marks a milestone in Belarusian history. On 25 March 1918, the Belarusian Democratic Republic declared national independence and adopted the white-red-white flag as a symbol of statehood. Public celebrations of this historical event were banned in the Soviet Union. Yet, given cracks in the communist regime and the conduct of partly free legislative elections in the spring of 1989, the Belarusian Popular Front (*Bielaruski Narodny Front Adradzhen'ne*, BNF) seized an opportunity to call for Belarus's independence. A few dozen university students who participated in a street action with pro-independence slogans were detained in March 1989 (Darafeichuk, 2023). The political conditions have dramatically changed with the dissolution of the Soviet Union. Though Freedom Day was not designated as an official state holiday, Belarusians could celebrate it without the threat of police violence in the early 1990s. In March 1993, Belarusian government officials and politicians, including the speaker of the Supreme Council Stanislau Shushkevich, attended a special ceremony, marking the seventy-fifth anniversary of BNR with a performance of Belarusian musicians and the audience's chants of "Long Live Belarus" (*Novy Chas*, 2018). Since the start of Lukashenka's rule, however, this date has become a rallying point for regime opponents and a pretext for preemptive arrests of civic activists. Opposition political parties and civic organisations annually organised protest rallies to challenge the entrenchment of authoritarianism, denounce a crackdown on Belarusian culture and language, and oppose the loss of Belarus's sovereignty within the framework of the Russia-Belarus Union.

As shown in Fig. 1, the number of participants in street actions held in Minsk ranged from 300 in 2011 to 10,000 people in 2006, with a record number of participants in 2018. In addition to the intensity of state repression, the format of celebrating Freedom Day might explain cross-time variation in the level of mass mobilisation. Usually, opposition political parties organised a march in downtown Minsk, concluding with a public rally. In 2018, however, following the arrests of several hundred people in March 2017, the political opposition grew divided over the use of a conventional format. Some opposition politicians were in favour of a

march, even though it was not authorised by the municipal government. Others supported the idea of a concert to mark the BNR centennial in a festive manner. As many as 25,000 people attended an open-air concert, held near the National Academic Bolshoi Opera and Ballet Theatre of the Republic of Belarus in March 2018.

Figure 2 displays the number of individuals detained for participation in street actions in Minsk. To some extent, the international political opportunity structure affected the intensity of state repression against participants in Freedom Day celebrations. The Freedom Day street actions transpired without mass arrests in 2009–2010, while Lukashenka tried to improve the country's relations with the EU and secure loans from the West. According to reports compiled by the human rights centre Viasna, dozens of protesters were detained in Minsk on March 25 in the early 2010s. However, these statistics do not tell a full story because the coercive apparatus carried out a lot of preemptive arrests. In March 2017, for example, Lukashenka urged the police to carry out preemptive arrests

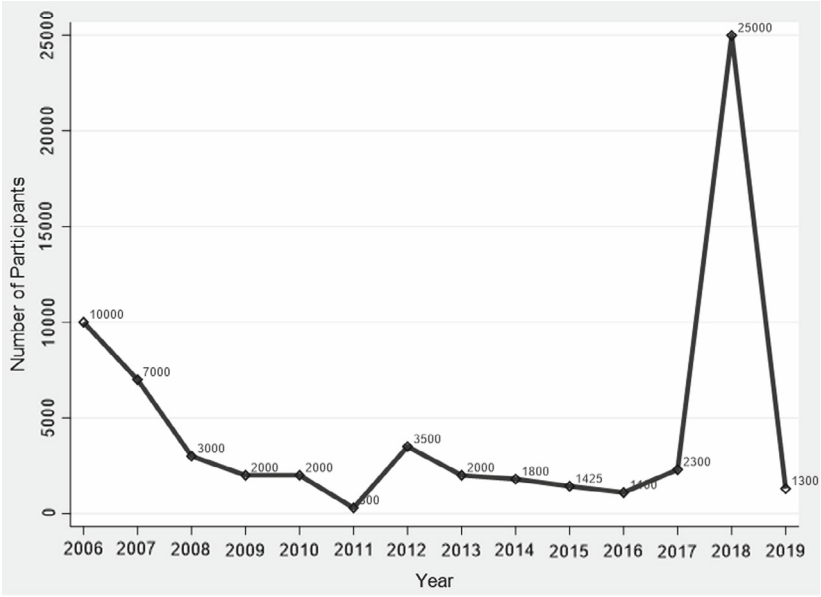


Fig. 1 Number of participants in street actions on Freedom Day in Minsk, 2006–2019 (*Source* The Human Rights Centre Viasna; *Radyio Svaboda*)

of civic activists and opposition politicians to crush mass discontent. "We need to pluck provocateurs like raisins from a bun," Lukashenka stated (*Euroradio*, 2017).

The largest number of people (700), including more than one hundred journalists and sixty human rights activists, were detained in March 2017 (Human Rights Watch, 2017). This spike in state repression was, to some degree, a reaction to massive protests against the law, requiring that individuals who worked less than 183 days a year pay the government a substantial amount of money (approximately 200 euros in 2017) for "lost taxes." Lukashenka signed the decree against the so-called social parasites in April 2015, and thousands of people received notices with their payments due in February 2017. In response, hundreds of people across the country participated in Marches of Non-Loafers (*Marshi nedarmaedau*) organised by opposition political parties and supported by the anarchist movement in February–March 2017 (Fomashov, 2018; *Nasha Niva*, 2017a). Some protesters chanted the slogans "Down [with

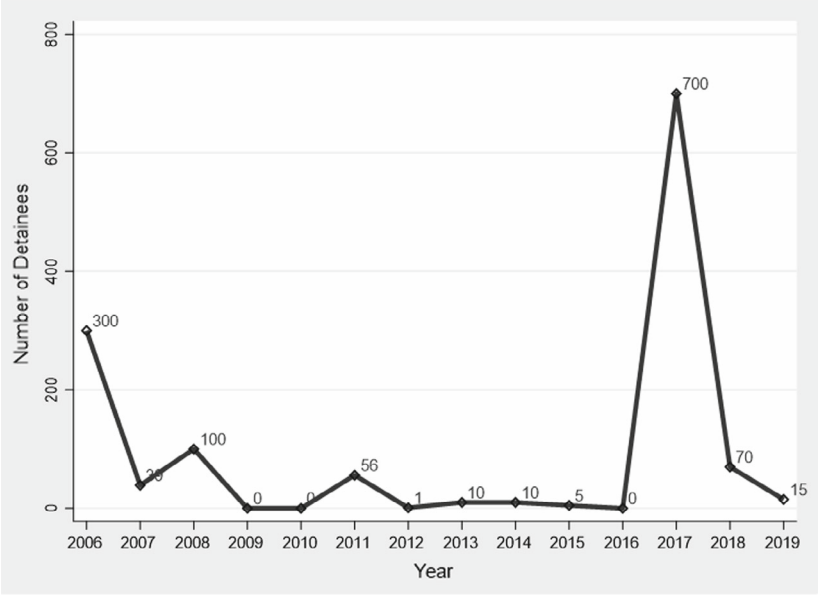


Fig. 2 Number of detainees on Freedom Day in Minsk (*Source* The Human Rights Centre Viasna)

the government]" (*Dalou!*) and "Lukashenka, Leave!" (*Lukashenka, ukhadzi*). This outburst of street actions signalled growing dissatisfaction with the government's inept economic policies (*Nasha Niva*, 2017b). In turn, Lukashenka declared that "there would not be a Maidan [occupation of urban space, with popular demands for regime change] in Belarus" (Illiash, 2017). State-run media propagated the idea that Belarusians should not emulate the example of Ukrainians and should not revolt against the status quo to avoid bloodshed (Kalynovskii, 2017).

An escalation in state repression influenced the celebration of Freedom Day from 2020 onwards. Given the pandemic, opposition political parties cancelled the organisation of public events in March 2020. Hundreds of people across the country, including at least 176 people in the capital city, were detained on 25 March 2021 (Viasna, 2021b). A lot of preemptive arrests took place in March 2022 to inhibit a mass gathering of people and suppress any public display of solidarity with Ukrainians in the aftermath of Russia's military aggression (Viasna, 2022b). Flash mobs were also subject to repression. A dozen people, for example, were detained for sitting on a bench in a Minsk park on 25 March 2022 (Viasna, 2022c). As a result, Belarusians in exile assumed a prominent role in organising public events and celebrating Freedom Day outside Belarus.

Charnobyl Way

The 1986 accident at the Charnobyl nuclear power plant, located 130 kilometres north of Kyiv and 20 kilometres south of the border with Belarus, had a devastating effect on the environment and the population in contaminated areas.[5] According to the World Nuclear Association (2022), "the accident caused the largest uncontrolled radioactive release into the environment ever recorded for any civilian operation." The long-term effects of the accident are not fully known due to the lack of access to public health data in the late Soviet period. Exhaustive research on radiation effects is further compounded by the fact that the Lukashenka regime hampered the collection and dissemination of data in the contaminated areas. Nonetheless, extant research finds a marked increase in thyroid cancer among children in Belarus in the aftermath of

[5] The nuclear power plant was named after a nearby Ukrainian town. The geographical name is spelt *Chernobyl* in Russian, *Chornobyl* in Ukrainian, and *Charnobyl* in Belarusian. The Belarusian-language spelling of the town is used in this chapter.

the accident (Astakhova et al., 1998; Mahoney et al., 2004) and a higher risk of leukaemia and other haematological malignancies among clean-up workers (Cardis & Hatch, 2011). More broadly, empirical evidence suggests that negative perceptions about radiation risks had a profound impact on the mental health of residents in the region (Havenaar et al., 2016). To commemorate the victims of the Charnobyl disaster, civic activists organised a public event, titled Time of Mourning and Silence (*Gadzina smutku i mauchannia*), on Lenin Square in Minsk on 26 April 1989 (*Nasha Niva*, 2015a).

The first march named Charnobyl Way (*Charnobylski Shliakh*) was organised by BNF and held in Minsk on 30 September 1989. Being in opposition to the Soviet regime, BNF criticised the Communist Party of the Soviet Union, as well as the Soviet government, for covering up facts surrounding the accident on the Charnobyl nuclear power plant. Despite state censorship in Soviet media, between 30,000 and 50,000 people participated in the march (Navumchyk, 2019). At the public rally, the Belarusian writer Ales Adamovich posed the question, "What kind of [political] system do we have if it constantly requires from us a sacrifice?" (*Radyio Svaboda*, 2008). Since the resurgence of authoritarianism under Lukashenka's rule, the march regained its significance as a protest event directed against the repressive political regime.

In April 2006, as many as 10,000 people participated in the march, commemorating the twentieth anniversary of the Charnobyl accident. "The catastrophe on the Charnobyl nuclear power plant occurred twenty years ago. The political Charnobyl began ten years ago. When the legally elected parliament was dissolved, and people who rely upon violence, rather than uphold the rule of law, came to power," stated Siarhei Kaliakin, leader of the Belarusian Party of Communists.[6] In conveying their main grievances, protesters underscored a connection between authoritarianism and environmental degradation by virtue of such slogans as "Radiation and Dictatorship Are Killing Us" and "Belarus Has Two Calamities – Charnobyl and Lukashenka" (Gushtyn & Yaroshevich, 2015).

The government's 2008 decision to open a nuclear power plant in Hrodna region reinvigorated environmental activism in Belarus. In addition, Russia's meddling in energy politics was a source of discontent.

[6] The quote comes from a repost of *Charter 97*'s article on the webpage of the civic initiative We Remember, http://www.ciwr.org/article/2006/04/27_shlyah.html.

There were safety concerns due to the construction of the power plant by Rosatom, Russia's state-owned nuclear energy corporation, within fifty kilometres of Vilnius (*Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty*, 2020). In April 2008, approximately 2,000 people participated in the annual march. Belarusian anarchists, for example, turned out with such banners as "No – to the Second Charnobyl" and "Nuclear Energy Is a Dead End" (Provalinskaya, 2008). Similarly, anarchists and Green Party activists were vocal opponents of the use of nuclear power in April 2009 (*Nasha Niva*, 2009). According to Tatsiana Novikava, a coordinator of the civic campaign "Astravets Nuclear Plant Is a Crime," organisers of the march sought to raise public awareness of the long-term consequences of the Charnobyl accident and warn about the risks associated with the construction of a nuclear power plant in Belarus (Glod, 2012).

Nonetheless, over the past decade, the number of participants in the annual march dropped below 2,000 people (Sharipkin, 2015). On 26 April 2011, 500 people gathered on Bangalore Square (*Nasha Niva*, 2011). Between 1,000 and 1,500 people joined the 2012 march (Viasna, 2012). In the wake of Russia's military aggression against Ukraine, some participants in environmental protests denounced Russian imperialism and displayed their solidarity with Ukraine through the use of Ukraine's blue-and-yellow flag and the chant "Glory to Ukraine!" For example, participants in the 2015 march—nearly 500 people—not only disapproved of Russia's construction of a nuclear power plant in Belarus, but also demanded the release of Kiryl Silivonchuk, a citizen of Belarus imprisoned in Russia for his social media posts in support of Ukraine (*Nasha Niva*, 2015b). Between 700 and 1,000 people attended the march organised by a coalition of civic organisations and political parties, including the BNF Party, the Green Party, and the movement For Freedom, in April 2016 (*Belsat*, 2016). Approximately 500 people joined the march in April 2018 (*Nasha Niva*, 2018). The white-red-white flag was an indispensable attribute of anti-government protests.

An escalation in state repression in the aftermath of the 2020 fraudulent election and Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine inhibited the organisation of the annual march. In 2021, the Minsk municipal authorities did not issue a permit for the conduct of a march with such main slogans as "Stop Legal Charnobyl" and "35 Years of Charnobyl, the Catastrophe Persists" (*Mediazona-Belarus*, 2021). Instead, some Minsk residents lit up candles in their windows to commemorate victims of the Charnobyl disaster. In 2022, the Minsk municipal authorities did not

approve the Belarusian Green Party's application for the organisation of the march under the main slogan "No to War" (*Ne vaine*) in Minsk (*Belsat*, 2022). To commemorate victims of the Charnobyl disaster and express their disapproval of Russia's barbaric war, Belarusian activists in Vilnius held a march under the main slogan "No to the War, No to Putin, No to the Nuclear Power Plant" (*Ne – vaine, ne – Putsinu, ne – AES*) (*Euroradio*, 2022a).

Overall, the annual march served as a gruesome reminder of the disregard of environmental issues in the authoritarian regime. Opposition political parties and environmental activists sought to raise public awareness of the negative consequences of the Charnobyl accident and underscore new risks associated with the Russian construction of a nuclear power plant in Astravets. Furthermore, participants in the march articulated the idea that the removal of the authoritarian incumbent from power was vital to ensure the country's environmental security.

Anti-War Activism

Belarus's involvement in the Russia-Ukraine war has been met with resistance in society (*Euroradio*, 2023; *Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty*, 2022). Hundreds of Minsk residents brought flowers to the Embassy of Ukraine to signal their solidarity with Ukrainians in the aftermath of Russia's full-scale invasion. On 27 February 2022, the day of a referendum over constitutional amendments, some voters gathered near polling stations and chanted anti-war slogans (*Radyio Svaboda*, 2022a). Over 900 people were detained on election day, most of them were sentenced to two-week imprisonment and subjected to inhumane treatment in detention centres (*Radyio Svaboda*, 2022c; Viasna, 2022a). Belarusians were also arrested for wearing blue and yellow colours, carrying bouquets of yellow and blue flowers, or singing Ukrainian-language songs.

Drawing on the World War II legacies of underground resistance in Belarus under the Nazi occupation (Tec, 1993), some Belarusians joined the railway partisan movement. A clandestine network of railway workers and hacktivists was formed to sabotage the transportation of Russian military equipment and ammunition across Belarus (*Charter 97*, 2022; Khadzinski, 2022; *Radyio Svaboda*, 2022b). Some of the first disruptions of railway traffic occurred in Mahilyow region on 26 February

2022 (*Nasha Niva*, 2022). Railway workers set fire to signalling cabinets, which brought railway traffic to a standstill. In media interviews, civil resisters stressed the idea that the destruction of signalling instruments did not pose any physical threat to the lives of ordinary citizens (*Euroradio*, 2022b).

In turn, state authorities declared that such sabotage would be treated as an act of terrorism and suppressed with the use of firearms (*Euronews*, 2022; *Novy Chas*, 2022). The KGB of Belarus placed the Community of Railway Workers of Belarus on the list of extremist organisations. Furthermore, the Belarusian government introduced amendments to the Criminal Code, making "attempted terrorist attacks" punishable by death (*Meduza*, 2022). The Belarusian special units were dispatched to guard the railway lines, and the security services conducted searches and interrogated the local population. Dozens of railway workers were detained for their anti-war activism (Viasna, 2022d). In December 2022, three "railway partisans" from the southeastern town of Svetlahorsk in Homyel region were sentenced to imprisonment for 21–23 years (Ruvina, 2022).

The collection and dissemination of information about the movement of Russian troops and military supplies have become another form of civil resistance in Belarus. In particular, the civic initiative Belarusian Hajun, named after a forest spirit in Belarusian folklore, collected data from various sources and spread information about the Russian military via its Telegram channel (Lukashova, 2022). In turn, the Belarusian government expanded a list of civic organisations and Telegram channels deemed as extremist in an attempt to inhibit the public's access to information and induce political conformity.

Belarusian artists and ordinary citizens mounted resistance to Russian aggression on the cultural front. A team of Belarusian artists in exile, in collaboration with Ukrainian curators, launched an open online platform that collected, shared, and distributed anti-war art.[7] The Russia-Ukraine war also gave rise to anti-war music (Korneevets, 2023). In March 2022, for example, the Belarusian musician Lavon Volski released the Ukrainian-language song "Glory to Heroes" in support of Ukraine's struggle for freedom and independence. Furthermore, social media users circulated TikTok videos with anti-war messages (Komlach, 2022). More broadly, Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine reinvigorated a public discourse

[7] For details, visit the webpage of the International Coalition of Cultural Workers in Solidarity with Ukraine https://antiwarcoalition.art/about.

about the significance of the Belarusian language and engendered the growth of civic initiatives to reverse the long-term effects of Russification, the forcible imposition of the Russian language and culture on the local population (Coakley, 2022).

Conclusion

This chapter has examined civil resistance and state repression in one of the most repressive political regimes in contemporary Europe. A close analysis of contentious politics in Belarus demonstrates that opposition political parties, youth movements, environmental groups, and various challenger organisations employed nonviolent methods to signal their disapproval of the regime. The main slogan of regime opponents is "Long Live Belarus," signifying that most Belarusians aspire to live in a free, democratic society. Another major symbol of nonviolent resistance is the white-red-white flag that predates the forceful incorporation of Belarus into the Soviet Union and the crackdown on Belarusian culture under communism. In turn, the coercive apparatus employed a wide arsenal of repressive methods to silence regime critics and keep the embattled strongman in power.

The case of Belarus suggests that nonviolent action might be an insufficient condition for the ouster of an autocrat in the absence of widespread security defections. Based on a statistical analysis of civil resistance from 1900 to 2006, Chenoweth and Stephan (2012) find that active and sustained participation of 3.5% of the population in a nonviolent campaign typically brought about political change. According to media reports, half a million people, comprising a quarter of Minsk population, participated in some of the largest anti-government protests in August 2020. Yet, this surge in civil resistance did not lead to massive defections within the security apparatus. Rather, the police functioned as an agent of repression and implemented a violent crackdown on regime opponents. Further research needs to investigate the conditions under which the security services might withdraw their support for the authoritarian incumbent and facilitate a peaceful turnover of power.

Another finding that emerges from an overview of state-society relations in Belarus is that the international political opportunity structure has a significant impact on contentious politics in a country. Over the past two decades, the Russian government has expended considerable political, economic, and military resources for the maintenance of the

non-democratic regime in Belarus and the reassertion of Russia's domineering position in the region. In particular, Lukashenka relied on the relatively cheap supply of Russian energy resources and Russia's loans to stall economic reforms and maintain the government's heavy-handed control over the national economy. Furthermore, since 2015, the Russian Federation, jointly with Belarus and Serbia, annually organised military drills under the banner of Slavic brotherhood. Under these circumstances, the Belarusian opposition grappled with the threat of Russia's military intervention.

Russia's defeat in the Russia-Ukraine war might open up an opportunity for the removal of the long-serving autocrat from power. Hundreds of Belarusians joined the Armed Forces of Ukraine to fight against Russian imperialism. The mission of the Kastus Kalinouski Regiment named after a leader of the January Uprising (1863–1864) is "liberation of Belarus through the liberation of Ukraine." If Ukraine succeeds in defeating Russia and placing war criminals on trial, the other former Soviet republics will have a greater chance of throwing off the shackles of Russian imperialism and safeguarding the consolidation of democracy in Eastern Europe.

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Bulgaria—Protest Movements Transforming the Party System

Ivaylo Dinev and Dragomir Stoyanov

In this chapter, we present Bulgaria as a relevant case for examining the mechanisms of interaction of social movements with political parties and wider electoral politics. The recent waves of protest cycles and elections provide ample empirical material. Our chapter contributes to the broader literature on political change in post-communist contexts, where social movement studies have tended to focus on specific movements and single protest waves, while mainstream political science is focused on conventional political behaviour and the measurement of individual-level participation.

According to della Porta and Diani, political process theories examine protest movements which challenge a "given political order… interact with actors who enjoy a consolidated position in the polity"

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(della Porta & Diani, 2006, p. 16) are one of the four major research directions in the analysis of social movements (ibid., p. 6). Research in this subfield has been successful in shifting attention towards the interaction between new (social movements) and traditional (political parties and states) actors and between less conventional forms of action and institutionalised systems of interest representation (ibid., p. 17).

In Bulgaria, since the beginning of the transition, the dynamics between protest mobilisations and elections have been important for understanding both long and short-term shifts in the party system development, the restructuring of political cleavages and electoral (in)stability. In the early stage of the transition, the oppositional movement Union of Democratic Forces (SDS) arose from an independent association to a broad electoral alliance that in the 1990s became the main adversary of the successor of the communist party, the Bulgarian Socialist Party (BSP). Following the 'honeymoon' period, since 2001 a number of personalist anti-corruption parties that challenged both the communist and 'transitional' political elites, appeared on the political scene. National Movement Simeon II (NDSV) and Citizens for the European Development of Bulgaria (GERB) were the most successful parties among these. After the accession to the European Union in 2007 and the beginning of the financial crisis in 2008, two massive protest cycles triggered resignations of incumbents and changes in the party system. The first of these were the protests against the political elite in 2013, which resulted in resignation of the first Borissov's cabinet (GERB) and indirectly to the fall of the coalition government of Oresharski (BSP-DPS) in May 2014. In 2020, protests against Borissov's third government (GERB-SDS and United Patriots) led to resignations of the incumbents and deep changes in the party system with six Parliamentary elections for four years. The country has been in a prolonged political crisis as the new political parties, which won the protest and anti-establishment vote, found themselves without sufficient electoral support to head a stable government. In 2022, these new parties and coalitions ("We Continue the Change", "Democratic Bulgaria" and "There is Such a People") formed a short-lived cabinet, supported by the socialist party BSP. After the fifth elections, the liberal coalition PP-DB ("We Continue the Change" and "Democratic Bulgaria") formed a second cabinet, supported this time by their main adversaries, GERB and the Movement for Rights and Freedoms (DPS). The main factor for this development has been the Russian war against

Ukraine and the shared pro-EU position among the ruling parties. After nine months, the cabinet resigned.

Our research design is building upon the two research approaches that have been the most influential in the attempts to link protest movements with institutional political processes (for a general overview, see the chapter of Hutter et al. [2018]). In the North American tradition represented by the contentious politics framework introduced by Charles Tilly, Doug McAdam and Sydney Tarrow, there is an emphasis on the study of specific mechanisms for analysis of the relationship between the two fields (McAdam et al., 2001; Tilly & Tarrow, 2015). Drawing on the dimensions identified by McAdam and Tarrow (2010, pp. 533–535), we propose three mechanisms through which movements influence change within the political parties and the political arena, in general:

1. *increasing electoral instability*: protest impacts by declining the public support of incumbents or leading to their resignation and snap elections;
2. *restructuring the party system through new protest parties*: large protest waves open windows of opportunity for political entrepreneurs to materialise the rising grievance;
3. *emergence of movement parties*: in a long-term, social movements transform from protest groups and coalitions to political parties.

The second key strand of the literature on the relationship between protest and electoral arenas deals with the rise of new cleavages. This approach, evolving in the Western European tradition, is characterised by analysis of the role of movements and parties in driving new political cleavages. A canonical example is the classical work on the new social movements (greens, pacifists, feminists) by Hanspeter Kriesi and his associates (Kriesi et al., 1995). As some of the works in the field have shown for the Western European context, two great waves of political change have fundamentally shifted the structure of political conflict since the 1980s, provoking rise to what they call a new "integration-demarcation" cleavage that divides the "losers" and "winners" of globalisation (Hutter et al., 2018). As Hutter et al. (ibid.) argue, the populist right beyond "simply articulating a populist challenge to the mainstream parties" has also given "voice to this new structural conflict by successfully mobilizing the cultural anxieties of those social strata that feel threatened

by increasing economic, cultural and political globalization" (ibid.). By contrast, the green and the new left "constitute their most clear-cut opponents in this new structural conflict".

After the end of the one-party state, in post-communist Bulgaria for more than a decade, the main divide remained on the question of communism, fuelling the two leading political forces, the socialist party, and the anti-communist oppositional movement SDS. The role of the protest movement in mobilising the framing and social base of this cleavage was vital, especially for the anti-communist block with two protest cycles in 1990 and in 1997. The globalist cleavage became important only after the end of the transition. The social and economic results of the reforms provoked rising grievances among those social groups that experienced a decline in living standards and did not go up the social ladder, while for others the regime change increased social and economic opportunities. Based on the case study of Bulgaria, we show how in the period since 2008, the protest mobilisations have affected the cleavage system in three ways:

1. mobilising the *centre-periphery* divide in the protest arena;
2. creating new cleavage between *protest parties–traditional parties*;
3. intensifying a *nation-global* cleavage: mainly through the actions of far-right and populist right.

The chapter is based on the analysis of secondary quantitative and qualitative information. To situate the recent developments within a broader context, we start with a historical overview of the party system dynamics and the building of capitalism since the beginning of the transformations. Then, we continue with mapping the tradition of protest mobilisations after the fall of communism. After that, the chapter describes the new protest waves and movements in the period after 2008. Finally, we explore the six mechanisms through which protests and movements induce change in the party system.

Historical Context (1989–2007)

Party System Dynamic

For a long time after the fall of communism Bulgarian political system followed a two-party model, with the renamed Communist Party (BSP) on the left and the newly formed pro-democracy opposition SDS on the right. This two-party system period was characterised with strong opposition between the two political formations. The opposition was based both on their different interpretations of the communist past and the different visions for the necessary political and economic reforms and future geopolitical orientation of the country. BSP found it difficult to separate from its communist roots and supported multi-vector orientation in its foreign policy that aimed to avoid antagonisation of Russia. On the other hand, anti-communist opposition represented by SDS sought a radical rupture from the communist past and fast integration into the EU and NATO structures. The third important political formation, the party of the Turkish ethnic minority, DPS, played an important role in this strongly polarised political system. The party became the key factor in forming several governments and played an important role in the falling of the first SDS government in 1991.

This highly polarised system lasted until 2001, when ex-Bulgarian king Simeon II returned from exile, and created a party under his name (National Movement Simeon II). To the surprise of many political analysts the formation succeeded to win its first National elections in 2001, and to form a coalition government with DPS.

National Movement Simeon II victory was due to the growing dissatisfaction, among the voters, with the two-party model. A significant number of voters were not represented by either BSP or SDS. On the other hand, the internal conflicts within SDS, during its governing period, weakened the party and made it less attractive to the voters. Thus, the return of the ex-King in Bulgaria became a trigger for the emergence of a new party, leading to its success in 2001. Next national elections in 2005 confirmed the changes in the Bulgarian party system. Another important development in the 2005 elections was the first parliamentary representation of a far-right party, Ataka. This nationalist and Eurosceptic party succeeded to significantly change Bulgarian party discourse and to impose nationalist agenda on the party competition. On the left, BSP retained its strong position. In the centre-right part of the spectrum,

various internal transformations were taking place leading eventually to the 2007 EP electoral success of the new populist party, GERB.

First test in National Assembly elections for this party came in 2009. GERB won those elections, with Boyko Borissov, a former security guard of King Simeon II, forming his first government. The party won the next national elections in 2013 and 2017. Its long stay in power allowed it to develop a strong party network and strongly centralised party hierarchy. Following the protests of Winter 2013 and especially the protests of the Summer 2020, GERB gradually lost its political attractiveness.

Capitalist Transformation

When the communist regime fell, the Bulgarian economy had a strongly centralised economic system, characterised by high levels of indebtedness and exclusion from trade with Western markets, as most of its foreign trade in 1989 was conducted with Comecon allies (Vassilev, 2003). The structural transformation of the economy, including broad privatisation, was slowed down by the high social cost of the reforms, the fragile parliamentary majorities, and frequent government changes. During Zhan Videnov's socialist government in 1996–1997, Bulgaria had a severe economic crisis caused, inter alia, by the state's inability to regulate reforms and maintain financial control (Baeva & Kalinova, 2011). The crisis plunged the country into a deep recession and hyperinflation. The harsh decline in living standards provoked nationwide street demonstrations, road blockades and labour strikes that overthrew the socialist government and paved the road to the next national elections. After 1997, the majority government of the centre-right SDS was able to establish a full package of neoliberal structural reforms. They provided stable macroeconomic growth; but their term in office was marked by increasing polarisation between social groups, corruption that emerged during mass privatisation, and state dysfunction in provision of basic services like healthcare and education. At this point, Bulgaria embarked upon neoliberal capitalism, although it lagged behind the Baltic states, which were regarded as paradigmatic cases of neoliberal transition (Bohle & Greskovits, 2012). During the transition, after the 1996–1997 crisis, the country was highly dependent on the relations with the International Monetary Fund (IMF). State officials were eager to obtain funds "at any cost", while the obligations of the IMF agreements adhered to neoliberal economic ideas such as rapid liberalisation, monetary and fiscal

austerity, pay reduction and the liquidation of state-owned enterprises. The expectation was that these reforms would produce a massive inflow of foreign direct investments and growth (see for the relations between IMF and Bulgaria: Nenovsky & Rizopoulos, 2003; Vassilev, 2003). From the very beginning of the transition, one social and economic feature became important for the rising grievance and polarisation: the boom of economic cartels, which were called by the Bulgarian people as *oligarsi* (oligarchs) or *mutri* (thugs; moguls). Most of these new class of capitalists were former members of the elite state army, the secret national agencies or athletes, who left the state apparatus and sports club after the structural reforms; and through their connections and networks gradually transformed to the new economic elite (Dinev, 2020).

The specific way of capitalist transformation provoked growing grievances among the citizens with lower income, e.g. the "losers of the transition", who did not climb the social ladder, but either stayed at the same income level or even got worse. In the beginning, these grievances did not negatively affect the structural reforms and the very basic characteristics of the economic regime, thereby criticising the neoliberal ideas or capitalism. Contrary to that, their protests challenged the political elite's accountability, specifically the two main political parties, BSP and SDS, which were blamed for the outcome of the transition.

Bulgaria's economic growth in the early 2000s was slowed down by the global financial crisis of 2008. The economic situation and social stability deteriorated in the five years from 2008 to 2013, but not as strongly as during the sharp decline from 1989 to 2001, as the general economic performance remained without significant disruptions. The governments of the populist GERB maintained conservative financial discipline and a low budget deficit of 2% of the GDP that even outperformed the Maastricht criteria of 3% (Stoilova, 2016). Relying only on GDP growth as an indicator, we could imagine that the protest movements in the recent decade were what Kerbo defined as "movements of affluence" (1982), which emerged in a growing economy to pursue a better quality of life. However, socio-economic indicators suggest a more complex picture of the social reality in the country. Even though the GDP growth in Bulgaria remained stable, GERB's three governments (from 2009 to 2021) failed to protect the most vulnerable social groups, such as pensioners and the working poor (those employed for minimum wage) by maintaining conservative fiscal policy (Dinev, 2020).

The ruling parties focused more on the absorption of European structural funds and building infrastructure projects, while a large portion of the population continued to live under or close to the poverty level. The country is still ranked highest in three negative measures: the highest income inequality in the EU (Eurostat, 2023), the lowest hourly labour cost in the EU (Eurostat, 2022) and the highest levels of material deprivation. A recent report on the cost of living by the Confederation of Independent Trade Unions of Bulgaria (KNSB) found that more than two-thirds of workers earn less than the living wage (Confederation of Independent Trade Unions of Bulgaria, 2023). Yet, none of the main political parties have committed to a fundamental change in Bulgaria's socio-economic system. A recent study of the political manifestos of the leading political parties depicts a strong imbalance towards economically right-wing measures and positions, while more socially oriented alternatives are almost absent (Dodov & Dinev, 2021).

Protest Culture

Two protest cycles were formative for the protest culture in Bulgaria: the protests against the communist regime in 1989–1990 and against the socialist government of Zhan Videnov (1996–1997). In the late 1980s, the first contention against the Bulgarian Communist Party was provoked by the campaign for the forced assimilation of ethnic Turkish population and the air pollution in Russe from the nearby Romanian power plant. Soon after, in the autumn of 1989, political conflicts intensified with mobilisations of environmental and civil organisations in Sofia. Simultaneously, tension within the party also emerged, with the BKP's leader Todor Zhivkov being criticised by the reformist faction of the party as the main cause of the country's political crisis. On November 9, a plenum of the Central Committee of the Communist Party was held, in which the majority obliged Zhivkov to resign (Baeva & Kalinova, 2011). On November 18, the first mass opposition rally for reform and democracy was organised by the oppositional movement. In the next year, various protests and rallies exploded across the country in response to the electoral defeat of SDS, most notably in Sofia. Throughout this transition period, 1990 was the year in which the political opposition staged the majority of its protest activities with support from the student movement and the anti-communist trade union KT Podkrepa, which backed the

centre-right coalition and had formed close relations with SDS. The polarisation between the socialist party and the anti-communists ended with the "democratic revolution" of 1997, when widespread anti-government protests—staged by SDS, the national labour unions KNSB and KT Podkrepa and students—led to the resignation of the socialist government of Zhan Videnov. For a long time, it was the struggle against the "red threat" which formed the core of the alliance between the political opposition, unions, and students (Dinev, 2020).

In the dramatic economic transformation that followed with high social costs, the trade union movement was the one actor which challenged the outcome of the structural reforms. In 2007, the school teachers began the biggest strike in Bulgarian history, with about 80% of teaching staff involved in the strike and 75,000 teachers and other workers protesting in the capital. Throughout the years, other public sector workers, such as medical specialists, transport workers, miners, and technical workers, demonstrated against the extremely low salaries or against the privatisation of state-owned enterprises.

In the 2000s, new actors of the protest arena emerged, namely far-right movements and political parties, which led to re-introducing of the ethnic cleavage by expanding nationalist and xenophobic rhetoric through mass gatherings and demonstrations. The far-right, further, framed their struggle for better public goods and social protection by blaming the political élite for having betrayed the interest of "ethnically pure" Bulgarians (Ivancheva, 2012; Stoyanova, 2018). Another new trend was the emergence of an ecologist wave, which mobilised through campaigns on issues such as the preservation of natural areas. This green wave of protests rose in response to the development of consumerist culture and real estate development in protected lands.

These three different strands—trade unions, far-right, and environmentalists—reflected the changing structural conditions and internal development of the protest arena in the period preceding 2008.

New Mobilisations and Movements Since 2008

Since the late 2000s, new mobilisations have taken place with a number of new protest groups emerging, often competing with each other. After 2008, the green movement became the most prominent new actor in Bulgaria. The movement included informal civil groups, non-governmental organisations, and one political party (the Greens)

who mobilised around environmental issues such as the preservation of natural areas. Alongside environmentalists, liberal-right civil society groups became an important segment of the protest scene, centring the fight against corruption in their protests. These two groupings often overlap and have in fact supported each other in a series of major protest mobilisations: against over-construction at the Bulgarian Black Sea coast (2007), the mass protest against the "triple coalition" of BSP, NDSV and DPS in January 14 (2009), fracking (2011–2012), over-construction on Vitosha mountain, the so-called Occupy "Orlov Bridge" protest (2012), the protests against the socialist-led government of Plamen Oresharski (2013) and for judicial reform (from 2015 onwards).

Important protest actors in this period were also the students and the anti-monopolies protest groups. Similar to the 1990s, students have continued to be one of the main protest movements in the country. In the new millennium, initially student campaigns developed on specific issues in the educational sector, such as against the budget cuts in higher education and the increase of university fees, for better living conditions in student dormitories, or other campaigns with a less conflictual nature, such as public meetings, discussions, publishing magazines. They successfully mobilised large street demonstrations in Sofia with thousands of participants and built informal student activist groups. During the political crisis in 2013, core members of the same initiatives from the University of Sofia participated in the mass protest waves and in the autumn of the same year, they began a movement called "Early Rising Students" (*Ranobudnite studenti*). The student activists provoked a third wave of protest by occupying university buildings and lecture halls across the country.

The so-called anti-monopolies protest groups were informal and formal organisations that held campaigns against the rising energy and electricity prices during the period. They used social media platforms such as Facebook for coordination and were able to mobilise demonstrations across the main cities in Bulgaria between 2011 and 2020. This protest group became the leader of the anti-monopoly movement in February 2013, which led to the resignation of first Borissov's cabinet.

The far-right sector became quite dynamic in the 2000s both in the electoral and protest arenas. Since 2005, the nationalist niche with about 10–15% voting support has become one of the major political strands with political parties such as "Ataka", VMRO-BND, NFSB and recently Revival (Vazrazhdane). The successful path of the nationalists to the

institutions developed by attracting anti-systemic, anti-elitist and anti-liberal voters, sceptical towards democratisation and Europeanisation. The nationalists had minimal role in the mass protest waves, however—in the investigated period, they mobilised several far-right and conservative campaigns.

The Anti-establishment Protest Cycle (2009–2014)

This protest cycle evolves in the context of a global wave of anti-systemic movements challenging the legitimacy of the traditional elite and demanding direct democracy, such as Occupy (Dinev, 2020; Gueorguieva, 2017; Tachev, 2023). In Bulgaria during this period the party system became fragmented, while voter turnout and trust in the national government and the parliament declined. Popular demonstrations have shown increased anti-elite and anti-party sentiments. In contrast to the historical protest movements in Bulgaria, when institutionalised organisations such as parties and trade unions played influential roles, the new protest groups relied on informal coordination through social media platforms like Facebook. By creating an original dataset of protest events in Bulgaria, Dinev shows that the new protest movements, organised through social media or informal and radical groups mobilised 54% of all events between 2009 and 2017 (Dinev, 2022a). The repertoires and symbols were also new—the Bulgarian tricolour replaced the party flags, and protesters began to speak of a struggle between "the people", without political affiliation, and the entire political elite and the oligarchy.

The cycle develops in three phases: the first phase is characterised by the emergence of the first major campaigns of new movements (2009–2012), a peak with the growth of protest events and the spread of mobilisations in many places and among different social groups (2013), and a demobilisation phase with a decreasing number of events and the beginning of the institutionalisation of protest groups (from 2014 onwards).

The peak represented three massive protest waves against the status quo, the traditional political elite and for democracy and justice. From January to March 2013 social unrest spread across 35 cities with reported more than 100,000 participants demanding a radical change in the political system and an end to poverty. Increasing electricity prices established by the private monopolies of the power distribution companies EVN, ČEZ and Energo-Pro became the initial trigger for the protests. Protesters

raised both economic and political demands, such as nationalisation of energy power distribution companies, new elections for a General Assembly to adopt a new Constitution, direct civic control over public institutions, and many others. One of the demands was the demolition of the party system.

The resignation of the GERB government at the end of February deepened the ongoing political crisis, and the new government of the BSP and DPS, after taking the unpopular decision to appoint media oligarch Delyan Peevski as director of the State Agency for National Security (DANS), triggered a new wave of discontent. Just a few hours later, ten thousand people took to the streets of Sofia and protested for 404 consecutive days demanding the resignation of the government. The second protest wave led to the establishment of a liberal-green alliance through the creation of the informal protest organisation called Protest Network. It aimed to unite different informal groups in one horizontal network that organised protest performances, symbolic actions, and social media campaigns. From the very beginning, it included influential activists of the green movement, liberal experts of the NGOs sector, intellectuals, journalists, social media and marketing experts.

After the first turbulent months of protests in Sofia, in the autumn the student movement "Early Rising Students" started a third wave of protest by occupying lecture rooms in nineteen universities, including full occupation of the rectorate of the University of Sofia. In the peak of the movement, the students held a mass demonstration against the outcomes of the transition with at least 15,000 protesters in Sofia's city centre and after two days several thousand students blocked the National Parliament, demanding resignation of the Oresharski's government. On 14 January 2014, students overthrew the occupation of the Aula in the Rectorate of the University of Sofia, and six months later, after the streets had been thinning for a long time, the government resigned and scheduled new elections.

The Anti-corruption Protest Cycle (2020–2021)

2020 was marked by prolonged protests in Sofia against Chief Prosecutor Ivan Geshev and the coalition government of GERB-SDS and United Patriots. Those protests united people with different political views and social positions under the slogans of the fight against corruption and restoration of the principle of checks and balances in the

Bulgarian political system. People protested against the merging of the executive, legislative and judicial powers during the period of Boyko Borissov's governing. Although the protests lasted for several months, they did not result in a change of government and snap elections, but created new protest parties and energised existing parties fighting against the status quo (discussed below). Protesters were united around two demands: effective struggle against corruption by the Prosecutor's office and effective separation of powers between the executive and judiciary. The government reacted with police violence. Despite this, the protest energy and protests' agenda remained relevant. Parties which were born from these protests were defined by political analysts as parties of change and reform (Lyubenov, 2021; Stoyanov & Lyubenov, 2022). After the regular national elections in April 2021, the parties succeeded in entering the Parliament and tried to form a new political agenda based on the protests' ideas for reforms and change of the status quo.

How Protest Induces a Change in the Party System

Mobilisations Provoking Electoral Instability

One of the most common mechanisms used by protest movements to influence the political process is to induce electoral instability. As a result, protests can mostly lead to a decrease in trust in the government or even to the overthrow of the cabinet. In the period from 2008 onwards, protests led to both outcomes in Bulgaria.

Just a few months after they began, the anti-monopoly protests in February 2013 caused the resignation of Borissov's first government and the scheduling of new parliamentary elections. In the second "big" Sunday, on 17 February, more than 100,000 attended the demonstrations in around 35 cities marking the largest mobilisation in Bulgaria since the protest wave in 1997. After two days, in Sofia, protests escalated into civil disobedience and riots, and police forces injured several protesters near the central cross-road "Orlov Bridge". On the following day, in Varna, the 36-year-old activist Plamen Goranov set himself alight in front of the Municipality building against the corruption of the mayor from GERB, Kiril Yordanov, and the local mafia cartel. Several minutes later, PM Borissov announced his resignation due to the violent clashes in Sofia, and the following day, the Parliament approved it. Despite the resignation, mass demonstrations continued in the following weeks.

The second and third waves of protest in 2013 indirectly led to the resignation of Oresharski's cabinet one year after the first major demonstrations began. The main factor driving the end of the cabinet was the internal split within the coalition partners BSP and DPS, but the protest had its own impact too. One of the mechanisms through which the protests influenced the political dynamics at this stage was the change in public opinion. The protests, which lasted 404 days, led to record low levels of support for the government at 17%, with 56% having a negative attitude towards its performance (Alpha Research, 2023a). Along with that, the protest affected very negatively the BSP, which declined in support from 26.6% in May 2013 to 15.4% in the next elections in 2014. Protests and protesters, by contrast, enjoy significantly high levels of trust from the majority of Bulgarians. In February, protesters were supported by 92% of respondents (Gallup International, 2014), in June by 85% (Alpha Research, 2013), and in November by 60% (Dnevnik, 2013).

In the period of the second protest cycle in 2020, the discontent led to even greater political instability, expressed in seven consecutive parliamentary elections (April 2021, July 2021, November 2021, October 2022, April 2023, June 2024, October 2024) in only four years. The political crisis began after a series of protests in Sofia and across the country, supported by opposition forces, who challenged the coalition government of GERB-SDS and United Patriots. Unlike the previous cycle, the protesters largely include supporters and members of the parliamentary and extra-parliamentary opposition, and the President Rumen Radev. Although the cabinet has completed its full term, the protests have negatively affected public opinion towards the government and the parties involved, leading to an unprecedented collapse in trust in the government (13%) and the national Parliament (7%).

Alongside all this, protest as a political action has gained such prominence in the public sphere that there have been numerous party-organised demonstrations in support of or against a particular government. At the peak of the anti-monopoly protests in 2013, GERB held a pro-government protest of its activists and supporters in front of Parliament (BNT, 2013). Similarly, during the anti-government protests in the summer and autumn of 2013, BSP and DPS held a huge demonstration in the centre of Sofia with tens of thousands of their supporters declaring their support for the Oresharski cabinet (Vasileva, 2013). At

the same time, GERB held a party anti-government rally in Plovdiv with over 15,000 people (Mediapool, 2013).

By the time of the second protest cycle in 2020, these types of mobilisations reached a new level of political conflict. This time, political parties held their rallies in the same place as the anti-government protests, thus leading to an escalation of tensions. For example, in Sofia's Independence Square, where the anti-government protests were held every day, GERB was holding a counter-protest in support of the government (BTV Novinite, 2020a). A day later, DPS organised hundreds of its supporters from across the country to protect the residence of its honorary leader Ahmed Dogan from protesters (BTV Novinite, 2020b). In both cases, police intervention was required to prevent clashes between the two groups of protesters.

Protest Waves Open Opportunities for Protest Parties

While protest mobilisations can indeed provoke political instability, they can also open an opportunity for political entrepreneurs who can transform the rising grievance into electoral ballots. The first mass protest wave in February 2013 reflected anti-establishment and anti-monopoly discontent. Major protest frames were incorporated in short-lived populist parties, such as "Bulgaria Without Censorship" and "Will" (Volya) as well as a transferable innovation of anti-elite rhetoric to the nationalist parties "Ataka", VMRO-BND and NFSB, and the socialist party BSP. The second wave of June 2013, instead, helped the traditional center-right forces to consolidate in the coalition Reformist block, which reached 8% voting support in the next elections.

The second protest cycle in 2020–2021 with six consecutive parliamentary elections is very different from the previous ones: there has been a simultaneous increase in the protest vote, but also its fragmentation into many forces—the liberal reformist "Democratic Bulgaria" (DB) and "We continue the change" (PP), the populist "There is such a people" (ITN) and "Stand up – Thugs out" (ISMV) and the far-right "Revival". While DB represents a case of movement-party (discussed later), and "Revival"—a continuation of the nationalist niche, the other three parties better can be defined as emerging protest parties (Dinev, 2022c).

The first party that succeeded in mobilising a large portion of the protest vote by using the energy of the protests was ITN. The leader and the founder of the party was the showman Slavi Trifonov. His career

as a singer and showman started a few years after the fall of communism and continued successfully throughout the new millennium. In the 1990s, he firstly appeared and led the TV shows *Ku-Ku*, *Kanaleto* and *Hashove*. During the anti-government protests in 1997, Trifonov and his band participated in the demonstrations and also produced the protest songs, successfully combining texts and themes from the Bulgarian revival period (late nineteenth century) with modern instruments and sound. From 2000 to 2019, Slavi Trifonov led the most popular TV talk show in Bulgaria, named after him, in which he skilfully combined political sketches with popular melodies, and interviews with famous public figures from politics, sports and arts (Stoyanov, 2021). In 2016, Slavi Trifonov started a campaign for a referendum aiming at significant changes in the electoral system and composition of the Parliament representation with increased measures for direct democracy. Although the referendum questions did not collect the required number of votes to become obligatory, it showed that Slavi Trifonov and his colleagues who organised it had significant political ambitions and public support. In 2020, Trifonov founded "There is Such a People" (ITN party)—a populist party heavily drawing on patriotic rhetoric which succeeded in winning the July 2021 snap elections. Although, after this electoral success the party was not able to form a government, after the November 2021 snap elections ITN became part of the coalition government of PP, DB, and BSP. According to Slavi Trifonov and ITN party officials, Bulgarian politicians are incompetent, corrupt, and immoral (Stoyanov & Ibroscheva, 2024). The party suggested radically changing the political elite, which would be formed by educated experts who prioritise national interests. In the first two elections in this period, ITN succeeded in attracting a major part of the anti-systemic vote from previous non-voters, young people, and the diaspora. The electoral base of the party is highly volatile, and this is obvious from the elections in 2021, 2022, and 2023. In April 2021 the party received 17.66%, a few months later in July 2021 the party received 24.08% of votes, in November same year the electoral support decreased to 9.52%, and in October 2022, it could not pass the electoral threshold of 4%. Currently, the party is represented in the Parliament following the April 2023 elections where it received 4.11%. So, this party, which was born in the protests, did not succeed in achieving long-lasting significant changes and is currently at the edge of the threshold after its initial success in July 2021.

Another party or rather a coalition which attempted to represent the demands of the protesters is the "Stand up – Thugs Out" (ISMV). This coalition was formed in the course of the protests against Chief Prosecutor Ivan Geshev and the coalition government of GERB-SDS and United Patriots. This protest coalition emerged ad-hoc and did not have a long political life. It was formed from two popular politicians Maya Manolova and Tatiana Doncheva, splinters from BSP, and some of the protest leaders. The coalition succeeded in entering the parliament after regular elections in April 2021 with 4.72% and the first snap elections in July 2021 with 5.01%. No one expected this coalition to have a long political life or a significant political influence, and it was not a surprise when the coalition under a new name "Stand up! We are coming!" was not able to pass the electoral threshold and enter in the parliament after the November 2021 snap elections. Shortly after the coalition fell apart and the voters of the coalition reoriented themselves to other protest parties.

The protests of 2020 and the regular and snap 2021 elections showed that there is space for new political parties with a protest profile and such a party appeared—this was the "We Continue the Change" party (PP). This party did not emerge directly from the protests. Rather, it was formed as a political organisation by Kiril Petkov and Assen Vassilev, who put the protest vote to action. They served as a Minister of the Economy and Finances respectively in the caretaker government of Stefan Yanev in the period May–September 2021. Petkov and Vassilev showed a direct communication style and desire to do politics transparently, and quickly gathered public support and became the most popular ministers of the government. The declared aims of these politicians included deep changes in the status quo and fast modernisation of the country, which after the EU accession in 2007 still cannot integrate fully into the Union's security and financial institutions. During their term in government, it became clear that their political ambitions go beyond the caretaker government and that they would start their own political party. PP party can be defined as a liberal reformist party, and it succeeded in uniting not just already politicised voters but also those who until then abstained from active political participation. PP voters are mainly young people with higher education from larger cities, a demographic, which can be defined as the urban middle class (Trend, 2021). The party performed well in the 2021–2022 elections, and in November 2021 PP won the elections and formed a coalition government with DB, ITN and BSP. After the snap April 2023 national elections, the party was again in the government, and

paradoxically it was supported by its main rivals GERB-SDS and DPS. The forming of government with the main rivals put strong pressure on the party, and currently the liberal coalition with "Democratic Bulgaria" has six points less public support compared to their results in the latest elections (Alpha Research, 2023b).

Movements Transform into Political Parties

Another mechanism through which protest influences electoral politics is the process of institutionalisation of social movement into a political party. In the investigative period, the green movement and liberal protest groups, which turned into a coalition "Democratic Bulgaria" (DB), is the ideal type of movement to party transformation. Their path to institutionalisation has been long and difficult. Firstly, a Green party, based on several green initiatives, was registered in 2008 but failed to attract voters beyond the most loyal supporters and activists. Subsequently, during the big protest waves in 2013, the Protest Network emerged, gathering mostly liberal activists from the NGO sector. Although the moment for institutionalisation seems ripe, these protests ultimately helped consolidate the remnants of the center-right into the Reformist Bloc coalition. Subsequently, the center-right coalition entered Borissov's second government, but not long after, firstly the Green Movement and then the conservative-right DSB left the coalition because of inconsistency in the policy proposals. Thus, it was only in early 2017 that the "Da, Bulgaria" (Yes, Bulgaria) party was created, in which activists from the 2013 anti-government protests and liberal protest groups had a significant influence. After the formation of the coalition "Democratic Bulgaria", consisting of members of the liberal "Da, Bulgaria", the Green Movement (renamed Green Party) and the DSB, the process of institutionalisation of the protest movement around the green and liberal protest groups has been completed.

This long process of institutionalisation of green and liberal groups, characterised by a double mobilisation of the electoral and protest scene, embodies the trajectory of the movement-party. Unlike the protest formations, which rely in their communication and political programmes on the denial of political ideologies and attracting different types of (disillusioned) voters, the formations in the coalition have a clear ideological-value profile of liberal-right political force and long-standing support from specific social groups in Bulgarian society—mostly young people living in

the capital with higher education (Trend, 2021). Not surprisingly, having a similar political programme for fighting against corruption and fast reforms, DB united with "We Continue the Change" in the liberal coalition PP-DB for the parliamentary elections in April and the local elections in October 2023.

Protest Re(Fueling) Cleavages

Centre-Periphery

Despite the efforts of the Communist party to mute the classic centre-periphery cleavage with the broad process of industrialisation, the cleavage persisted during the communist era (Todorov, 2004). With the fall of the regime in 1989, this divide became evident in the voting preferences for the anti-communist opposition, situated mainly in the urban centres, and the socialist party, which found major support in the small settlements. This divide was also articulated in the protest repertoire at the beginning of the transition when the major anti-communist demonstrations were staged mainly in Sofia (Stoyanova, 2018). In the recent decade, the centre-periphery divide has transformed into a division between those living in Sofia (*stolitsa*) and the rest of the country (*provintsia*). This cleavage resonates with the development of capitalism in Bulgaria, which led to an extremely high concentration of economic and cultural resources in the capital, with the highest levels of average salaries and more employment opportunities. In such a context, the green-liberal movement has emerged since 2006–2007 as a Sofia-based phenomenon and subculture, involving mostly young, well-educated, mobile cosmopolitans, demanding more participation in the political process beyond elections and more citizen control (Gueorguieva, 2017).

Along with this movement, consumer anti-monopoly rights protest groups, fighting against commodity and utilities prices evolved since the 2010s mainly in the regional cities and Sofia's suburbs. These two different protest movements peaked at the protest cycle in 2013. The division between Sofia and the rest of the country was initially prompted by the discourse of intellectuals, experts and some of the protesters in the anti-government protest wave (June 2013) and was based on political, ethical and aesthetic differences. They interpreted the anti-government protest as a struggle for rights and democracy as opposed to those protesting for their material needs. Along with that, the framing practices reproduced the anti-communist cleavage of the 1990s by shouting

anti-communist slogans against the "*red garbage*". This discourse was welcomed by the government, as well as by some leftist and nationalist journalists and intellectuals who grasped it and brought it to a confrontation. Thus, two opposing camps become visible: Sofia's protest of the urban middle classes and the national protest of the "poor and despicable" (Stoyanova, 2018). A similar division can be seen among a significant number of protest groups, although not infrequently leading activists have been part of both waves.

Beyond the discourse, the division between the protest waves also evolved in practice. Data on protest demonstrations held show multiple events across the country during the social revolt, while anti-government protests from June onwards concentrated entirely in Sofia. In his dissertation, Dinev compares the magnitude of protest events per population and illustrates the geographical diffusion of the first and second protest waves. In the social revolt, measured by the number of protest participants per inhabitant, the capital Sofia does not appear to be the centre of the discontent. Rather, there were several regional centres, such as Blagoevgrad and Shumen, where the protest demonstrations involved more than 10% of the inhabitants, while in Varna, the total number of participants reached 33% of the city population. On the contrary, in the anti-government protest wave, only in Sofia, the size of demonstrations reached high levels of engagement (14.5%), and to some extent, the second-largest city Plovdiv (2.3), but in any other regional city, only small-scale actions were organised, mainly in the first week (Dinev, 2020).

By the time of the 2020 protest episode, the divide between Sofia and the countryside had already lost its relevance as a structuring of political debate, because the hegemony of GERB led to the need for a new framework of discontent against the main rival. In the context of more than 10 years of Boyko Borissov's rule, for the first time since 1989, the traditional anti-communists and the successors of the Communist Party allied in the protest arena. The 2020 protest cycle has produced a temporary cleavage between the so-called status quo parties and the "protest parties", which will be discussed in the next section.

Protest Parties-Status Quo Parties

The specific dimension "protest"-"status quo" parties emerged after the mass protests against the GERB model from 2020 onwards and expresses the desire of the new generations for a new type of politics. Uniting various social groups with different political values, the similarity across

them was the negative perceptions of Borissov's leadership and the model of governance associated with GERB and DPS. As we have already shown, five political parties have tried to win the protest vote in the last three years, showing how fragmented it was.

The antecedent conditions for this cleavage have been evolving in different stages: the breaking of the polarised political model, which brought to the scene personalist populist parties, firstly the former *tzar* (in 2001) and then (since 2007) the former security guard and firefighter. Borissov's aura began to fade in 2013 when anti-monopoly protests led to the resignation of his first cabinet. But his ability to get out of uncomfortable situations and to establish coalitions with different parties helped him to stay in power and form three cabinets in more than a decade. Thus, in the summer of 2020, Borissov and his GERB party were already seen by the young generation as an example of the "status quo" and in numerous ways, protesters compared his persona and behaviour to the latest communist leader Todor Zhivkov. In 2023 this cleavage began to fade, following the increasing importance of traditional divisions, such as the geopolitical orientation (EU vs. Russia). This suggests that the protest parties–traditional parties' demarcation is of "transitional" character and may no longer impact the political terrain.

National-Global

In the Bulgarian context, the nationalist cleavage mostly represents the sentiments of the "losers of the transition", who expressed their scepticism towards the change in 1989. On the other hand, in recent years, the rhetoric of the global conservative wave has gradually entered with its rejection of progressive ideas and desire to preserve patriarchal relations in society.

When it comes to the link between this cleavage and protest mobilisations, it is through its nurturing at certain moments. Between 2007 and 2019, a series of large anti-Roma, anti-Turkish, anti-migrant and anti-globalist nationalist demonstrations took place in regional and small towns, along with anti-migrant demonstrations in Sofia (BNR, 2016; Otova, 2020). In these, nationalists engage with local residents, far-right groups, football hooligans, rockers and others. Only leftist collectives countered far-right protests, organising a demonstration in Sofia in support of refugees, feminist protests and an annual anti-fascist protest demonstration. Pro-European political parties, on the other hand, usually

shy away from these issues and do not even raise them in their political programmes.

In the past, the national-global cleavage has been driven by parties such as nationalist and anti-establishment "Ataka", but recently another party that was energised by the 2020 protests and led the protests against COVID-19 measures in 2021, and became the leading actor in the far-right populist segment—the party 'Revival'. The party was established in 2014 by its founder and leader Kostadin Kostadinov. Kostadinov has political background in such parties as VMRO-BND, "Ataka", and NFSB—the parties of the far-right end of the spectrum and for years expressed anti-establishment, xenophobic, and Eurosceptic positions. Kostadinov follows this tradition. Before the regular elections of April 2021, and snap elections of July 2021, the party campaigned against COVID-19 measures—it organised protests against the government's anti-COVID-19 policies. The leader of Revival accused the government of following the policies of global leaders and subordinating national interests to 'Big Pharma'. According to Party officials, the COVID-19 pandemic was created artificially in order to transform the country into a servant of Big Pharmaceutical companies. The party's campaign against COVID-19 measures was successful and made the party highly visible in the national political scene.

Beyond COVID-19, Revival supports close relations with Russia, military neutrality and leaving NATO. Following the war in Ukraine, the party successfully attracted pro-Russian voters, including some from BSP. Kostadinov frequently states that Bulgaria is in a colonial relationship with the US and the EU. Bulgarian governments from 1989 are accused of serving foreign interests at the expense of the interests of Bulgarian citizens. Thus, it was not surprising that before the April 2023 elections, the party began a campaign for the referendum for delaying Bulgaria's membership in the Eurozone for 20 years. The campaign against joining the Eurozone helped the party to broaden its support by attracting not only the pro-Russian, far-right voters but also people who are concerned that Eurozone membership will lead to rising consumer prices and worsening quality of life. Thus, the campaign for the referendum helped the party's performance in the national elections: Revival received 14.16% of the votes. It is important to note that Revival succeeded in attracting large parts of the voters of other far-right parties (VMRO-BND, Ataka, NFSB) which are currently in deep decline following 4 years of coalition government with GERB.

Conclusion

Our analysis has shown that in today's democracy, protest cycles and protest movements have a significant impact on political developments. By tracing the movement parties interactions in two protest cycles in Bulgaria, we have shown how mass protests and strong movements can provoke deep and long-lasting effects. In this way, our study provides empirical details that extend the research conducted within mainstream political science tradition. The chapter finds sufficient evidence also to contradict the popular, but negative picture of the Balkan Peninsula and former socialist states as having weak mobilisation and low public participation in collective actions. We can conclude that in some cases of the new democracies, protest waves and protest movements can be considered the strong parts of the political dynamic, and the political elite and state institutions as the weak.

First, protest waves and movements can increase electoral instability by leading to a sharp decrease in public trust in the national governments and parliaments, or in extreme cases, to the overthrow of the cabinet. In the period from 2008 onwards, protest waves led to both outcomes in Bulgaria. Along with that, protest as a political action has gained such prominence in the public sphere that there have been numerous demonstrations, organised by mainstream parties, in support of or against a particular government. Thus, for today's consolidated democracies, not only the act of elections is an important signifier for representation and accountability, but also to have the support of the civil society. Not surprisingly, in states with authoritarian tendencies (but not only), such as Hungary and Serbia, the ruling parties are creating government-sponsored NGOs, and in times of large-scale oppositional rallies, a counter-protest in support of the government is taking place.

Second, by provoking electoral instability and declining trust in traditional parties, protest mobilisations open political opportunities for new political parties, such as protest parties and movement parties. Bulgaria is an extreme case of one of the highest electoral volatilities in Europe, characterised by a large number of newcomers in recent years. Most of these parties came directly from the street demonstrations or tried to materialise the rising grievance by introducing the aims of the protesters in their programmes. A similar trend in other states can be observed, such as Slovenia and Croatia, where new left movement parties (*Ljevica* and *Možemo!*) entered the national assemblies, or Serbia (for Southeast

Europe, see: Milan & Dolenec, 2023), where a recent protest wave provoked the building of an electoral alliance between liberals, left-wing and right-wing ("Serbia against violence") oppositional parties. Specifically, the character of such protest parties and movement parties with long-lasting institutional presence in Bulgaria ranged from populist right to liberals and greens. This is due to the fact that the main agenda of the two protest cycles remained on the ground of political questions, such as the corruption among the political elite and the rule of law. Left-leaning protest actors have had a marginal impact in the last decade (Dinev, 2022b), the social and economic inequalities are under-discussed in the public sphere, and the voter support for the only, nominally left party (BSP), declined to historically low levels.

Third, protests can provoke new and resurrect old political cleavages. In the case of the most recent protest wave in Bulgaria, we show how the demonstrations can lead to an unprecedented and prolonged political crisis by creating a new dividing line—between the traditional political parties and the new political parties. But in consolidated democracies, protest movements also compete with each other in the protest arena, which lately is transferred to voting ballots for different political parties. The basis of such divide in Bulgaria has been the centre-periphery cleavage, which is illustrated in the different types of dominant protest actors and demands in the capital, compared to the countryside. Since the 1990s, Sofia has been considered the bastion of the pro-democratic and anti-communist movements, and still today, the city is the main space for liberal-right and green mobilisations fighting for the rule of law and against corruption. Precisely in Sofia, the ruling coalition PP-DP has won the mayor seat in the municipal elections in 2023 beating the candidates of GERB and BSP.

On the contrary, the protest mobilisations in the rest of the country have focused more on material needs and economic issues, but this tendency has never led to strong institutional changes. The protest parties born during the social unrest in February 2013 gathered less than 1% in the next elections in May 2013. A similar dynamic can be found in other East-Central European countries, where the anti-government movements evolved mainly in the capitals, e.g. Belgrade and Budapest, where the oppositional pro-EU parties have the strongest social basis.

But why does protest repertoire have such great importance for democracies in East-Central Europe? Part of the explanation is the critical juncture of the 1990s, the initial years of the transformation, when high

hopes met harsh social reality in most of the states, and three decades afterwards still part of the population perceived the socio-economic results as deficient and the political elite as corrupted. This led to constant political instability, frequent large protest mobilisations and the rise of protest parties and movement parties, a dynamic that is visible in most post-socialist states. Our findings provide an avenue for further comparative research with a focus on the importance of protest movements in democracy today.

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Czech Republic—From Apathy to Mass Mobilisations, 1989–2022

Kateřina Vráblíková

Similarly to other post-communist countries, for the first 20 years after the democratic transition, Czech Republic has been known for its general political apathy—low level of people's political participation, weak civil society, and NGO-ized social movements instead of having a vibrant grassroots-based activism (Císař, 2017; Kostelka, 2014). However, two mass protest campaigns—(1) the anti-austerity mobilisation "Stop the Government" (2012) and (2) the movement "Million Moments for the Sake of Democracy" (2017–2020)—took place and were very unexpectedly able to reach over hundred thousand people. Though protest in general remains rather an exceptional tool used in times of crises instead of being a political channel in routine politics, the Czech public shows that post-communist countries can mobilise in large numbers when the conditions are right.

The chapter first examines the period between 1989 and 2010 that laid the ground for many traits of current contentious politics in Czechia. The

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second part of the chapter then analyses the two mass movements—"Stop the Government" and "Million Moments" and conditions in which they mobilised. To analytically examine the important aspects of contentious politics in the country, the chapter uses main concepts from social movement theory. Specifically, it uses conceptual tools of framing (Benford & Snow, 2000; Snow, 2004), political opportunities and political culture (Kriesi, 2004; Meyer, 2004; Vráblíková, 2017), spatial opportunities and protest issues (Císař & Vráblíková, 2019), grievances and political economy (Buechler, 2004; Snow & Soule, 2009; Chapter 3), organising resources (Edwards & McCarthy, 2004), and political outcomes (Amenta et al., 2010; Giugni et al., 1999).

Protest in a Consolidating Democracy: 1989–2010

1989 Anti-communist Mobilisation and Framing of Faux Universalist Civic Ethos

The fall of the communist regime was accelerated in the Czech Republic by nation-wide collective action. The 1989 anti-communist mobilisation continued the tradition of a specific type of activism—civic ethos protest—that has been typical for the country (Kopecký, 2003; Mudde, 2003; Myant, 2005; Slačálek & Svobodová, 2017). Civic ethos protests have been used during the Prague Spring in 1968, anti-Nazi students' mobilisations in 1938, the national emancipation movement of the early twentieth and late nineteenth centuries as well as by several protest movements after 1989.

Civic ethos protests generally and the anti-communist mobilisation specifically did not have the character of a mass revolution done by an established grassroots movement (Bunce, 2003; Kopecký, 2003). Though anti-communist protests gained mass support, the mobilisation was rather episodic, consisting of a few mass-based demonstrations over several months. The core activist base of the anti-communist movement was around a hundred activists organised into an initiative Chart 77. Typically, the civic ethos protests have been led by cultural, intellectual, or religious leaders or respected public figures.

The framing of civic ethos protest was mainly developed by the 1989 anti-communist leader and the future President Havel in his conception of non-political politics. The movements declare themselves as uprisings of ordinary people against corrupt elites, the diagnostic framing

pictures their grievance in a universalist way as an unquestionable matter of morality and civility appealing to categories like "love and truth" that stand above particularities and conflicts of normal politics. Though this framework positions itself above the political game, in fact, the universalist aspiration is flawed as every political position is inevitably particularist. Here the specific political position usually taken by these protests has been (pro)Western liberal humanism (Slačálek & Svobodová, 2017). The prognostic framing that would provide an alternative solutions to the specific contested issues is less developed in protests using the universalist civic ethos framing. The abstract diagnostic framing that moves the issue above-politics contradicts the very idea of specifying concrete political solutions.

Though civic ethos protests have been able to reach a mass episodic mobilisation of the public, the political impact of such protests has been limited to short-term effects on mainstream politics. The 1989 anti-communist mobilisation lost its major political influence after the 1992 Parliamentary elections. After the fall of the communist regime in 1989, many activists from the anti-communist movement became part of the new political elite. Václav Havel became a President, others were ministers, various advisors, or generally played a significant political role in the post-89 establishment. However, in the 1992 Parliamentary elections, the political party of the former anti-communist movement did not even reach the number of votes necessary to enter Parliament. Some of the environmental activists previously involved in national politics moved on to civil society and protest; human rights activists mostly stayed away from the confrontation with the new political force.

A right-wing conservative neoliberal Václav Klaus and his Civic Democratic Party (ODS) won the 1992 elections. V. Klaus actively advocated ideological opposition to the demands of the anti-communist movement and civic ethos protests (Císař, 2008; Myant, 2005). His conception of politics was about rivalry of conflicting positions that compete in free and fair elections in opposition to the influence of un-elected non-accountable civil society activists. Democracy was mainly about free trade economy and prospering capitalism. Over the years he also actively advocated against new social movement issues such as the environment, human rights, LGBTQI+, and women's rights. Neither Social Democrats (ČSSD) who became the second major political force in the country after the 1996 election carried on the legacy of the 1989 anti-communist movement. Their leaders and party activists came from different circles and

their program also had very little overlap with the demands of the original democratic movement. Though making alignments with and involving trade unions and women's, environmental, and human rights groups in actual policymaking, Social Democrats did not engage in the public debate about the role of civil society and protest in democratic politics. Klaus's anti-participatory elitist democratic discourse thus remained unchallenged and has dominated the national discourse around civic activism and protest. Also, many activists engaged in the 1989 democratic movement interpreted their anti-communism as being generally anti-leftist. Due to their anti-leftism and facing an extreme ideological hostility of a mainstream right-wing party towards civic and political activism, many individuals and activist groups thus found themselves in political isolation and in a position that provided very limited opportunities for protest.

The 1989 anti-communist protest and its framing of civic ethos had, however, a profound influence on future protests. This framework indirectly narrated contentious politics as a method to be used in moments of existential crises and not as a tool for everyday politics. This, in combination with the closed discursive opportunities has made the use of protest as a routine tool in democratic politics challenging. The diagnostic framing of particularist issues, such as women's rights or the environment as political and as a challenge to the status quo have been difficult as there is no existing master frame the movements can rely on. For instance, almost no women's groups active in the nineties dared to call themselves feminist as it would be too alienating and controversial (Saxonberg, 2003). Often, even the social movement activists would not perceive themselves as political actors and would frame their issue as non-political. Survey of Czech social movements conducted in 2007–2008 (Czech SMO Survey) shows that over 80% out of surveyed groups including tens of women's, environmental, human rights, and radical groups as well as trade unions self-identified as non-political.

Institutional Opportunities and Political Culture

After the 1989 revolution, the new regime took the form of a parliamentary democracy with some institutional features usually encouraging higher non-electoral activism and protest (Kriesi, 2004; Vráblíková, 2017). Specifically, the institutional separation of powers should facilitate protest thanks to independent power centres checking and balancing each

other. This feature was implemented mainly at the horizontal level with the establishment of the constitutional court and two chambers of Parliament. Since 2012, the country also has a directly elected President that is not anymore dependent on the parliamentary vote. This change institutionalised an already existing practice by previous Presidents who were politically strong and had acted independently in the past. Another important institutional arrangement that facilitates protest is vertical separation of powers via territorial decentralisation. The Czech Republic shows a relatively high territorial centralisation that discourages protest (LaPlant et al., 2004; Vráblíková, 2017).

Another influential factor is political culture. Studies show that a high share of self-expression values among citizens usually leads to more protest of the local population and eventually increases the openness of political elites to contention politics (Vráblíková, 2017; Chapter 6; Welzel & Deutsch, 2012). The Czech Republic, however, seems to be an exception in this regard (Vráblíková, 2017). Though Czechia shows a relatively high level of self-expressive culture, this does not translate into a higher level of protest. Grzymala-Busse and Luong (2002) explain that the post-communist region developed a style of politics that is blocking democratic contestation despite having formal democratic institutions. Political competition in the region takes place through informal networks and/or is mostly self-contained. Czech politics has been dominated by clientelist networks including politicians across the political spectrum, state administration, courts, rich businessmen and oligarchs, and white-collar crime (Dvořáková, 2012). This led to fractious, personalistic, and autocratic tendencies and state capture by elites instead of transparent and accountable politics that potential protesters would have a chance to effectively influence (Dvořáková, 2012; Grzymala-Busse & Luong, 2002; Linek, 2010).

For instance, the first major scandal was the corruption related to financing of Civic Democrats revealed in 1997. The party had a secret bank account in Switzerland with fictional sponsors who were in fact major businessmen who profited from privatisation of heavy industry under the government of Civic Democrats. Unable to build a majority coalition with smaller parties after the 1998 elections, up to now the main rivals—Civic Democrats and Social Democrats—made a deal called the "Opposition Agreement". Social Democrats who won the elections governed as a minority government with a tolerance of Civic

Democrats who gained important positions in the parliament's administration. Though the two parties, who were supposed to represent the main left and right poles in the country's political competition, continued to defend their ideological positions rhetorically, they in fact failed to represent their constituents in practical politics making. As far as the local population was enthusiastic about democracy and tolerant of the malfunctioning of the new regime until that time, the scandals around the "Opposition Agreement" that started in 1997 dramatically and irreversibly damaged public's trust in politics (Linek, 2010). The non-accountable style of politics continued in the future years. Same corrupt politicians across the political spectrum repeatedly ran in elections or new political parties that won their seats on anti-corruption agenda, such as Public Affairs (Věci Veřejné) in Parliament in 2010–2013 or Movement ANO in parliament since 2013 (see below), turned out to be no less corrupt than the old establishment.

Relatively closed institutional and cultural political opportunities are probably one of the factors that contribute to the generally low level of non-electoral activism in the country. Similarly to other post-communist countries, Czechia has been known for its generally low level of people's political engagement, weak civil society, and NGO-ised social movements (Císař, 2017; Kostelka, 2014). As data from the European Social Survey collected every two years between 2002 and 2018 show, on average, only around 5% of Czechs take yearly part at a demonstration while the share of demonstrators in most Western democracies oscillates on average around 10% (the post-communist average is 4%). The same pattern applies to petition signing. In Western democracies on average around 30% of people sign a petition yearly, whereas in Czechia it is only on average 16% (the post-communist average is 10%).

An interesting fact is that the level of political engagement has not increased over time (Kostelka, 2014). Many had hoped that generational exchange with the arrival of new cohorts that have not experienced communist non-democratic regimes and would thus be socialised into political engagement in democratic politics would level the volume of political participation. However, 35 years after the democratic transition the low level of individual protest remains more or less the same. This suggests that the problem probably does not lie in non-democratic communist generations but in other aspects such as the character of national politics.

Spatial Opportunities and Protest Issues

In terms of protest issues, the socio-cultural agenda typical for new social movements has steadily dominated the protest politics in the country. After the 1992 elections, the Czech party system has developed a stable formula of dominant party competition around single-issue dimension focused on economic issues (Císař & Vráblíková, 2019; Mansfeldová, 2013). The largest parties—the Czech Social-Democratic Party dominant on the left and the Civic Democratic party dominant on the right—competed on issues such as taxes, health care, and pensions. The convergence of the party competition along a single-issue dimension focused on economy was profound and left almost no political space for other challengers like trade unions to address the economic issue. The 1998–2002 period of the "Opposition agreement" mentioned above mainly concerned the distribution of political power and did not really change the economic single-issue dimensionality of the Czech party system. The salience of other issues, such as socio-cultural topics like the social values around gender and sexuality, nationalism, the environment, was effectively eliminated and left for niche political forces like niche political parties and protest.

In line with the spatial theory of party and protest conflict, most of the protest in the country has thus been focused on the secondary niche socio-cultural issues and mostly opted for socio-cultural framing of the given issues rather than economic framing (Císař & Vráblíková, 2019). Specifically, as the analysis of all protest events organised in the country between 1993 and 2010 shows (PEA Czech Republic), 58% of protest events were focused mainly on socio-cultural issues like human rights, foreign policy, and environment whereas only 19% were focused on economic issues (Císař & Vráblíková, 2019).

This socio-cultural protest has mostly been done by groups representing the post-communist version of new social movements whose form of activism lies in a transactional style of mobilisation rather than broad public engagement (Císař, 2013a; Petrova & Tarrow, 2007). Specifically, typically new social movement agendas, such as feminism, environmentalism, or human rights have been advocated in Czechia mostly by small groups that over the time developed into professionalised non-governmental organisations dependent on funding from the State, foreign foundations, and the European Union. The transactional new social movements have a low participation capacity—their membership is small,

and they also do not have mass support in the local population and mobilise in the context of generally low levels of political activism. Czech SMO Survey (2007–2008) shows that the membership base of these groups is typically only from ten to fifty members (Císař et al., 2011).

The repertoire of these groups is based on a transactional style of advocacy: networking with other groups, various stakeholders including media, academics, and political authorities that help exchange important resources and amplify groups' political leverage. Transactional new social movements mostly organise information campaigns, do lobbying and political consultancy, and petitions. Street collective action is used to a lower extent in their repertoire—though they still organise by far the largest number of protest events in the country. Most of these protest events are, however, relatively small-scale, not going over a few hundred participants or they have a form of street performances and direct action that require only a few activists (such as environmentalists blocking a nuclear power plant) (Císař et al., 2011).

The second largest number of protest events has been organised by radicals including nationalist or radical right as well as radical left like anarchists. These actors mostly advocate the opposite issue pole of the socio-cultural issues related to international politics or national security like country's entering NATO or globalisation (Císař, 2008; Císař et al., 2011). Protest events of radical left and right are also often done in tandem—one camp's protest is met with a counter-protest from the other camp. The dominant repertoire of the radicals are petitions and demonstrations that are sometimes violent. The demonstrations, however, have only around one hundred participants on average (Císař et al., 2011). Similarly, to transactional new social movements, vast majority of radical groups have on average between ten to fifty members, however unlike the professionalised NGOs, 90% of radical groups surveyed are not formally institutionalised and do not have any employees and operate with no or minimal budgets (Císař et al., 2011, pp. 151–156).

An important observation is that unlike some other countries in the region like Poland or Hungary, Czechia has not had a larger grassroots radical right party-movement. One of the explanations is the character of spatial political opportunities with economic issues being a profound issue dimension of Czech party politics until 2010 that did not leave space for other issues. This, however, does not mean that a radical right agenda would not exist in the Czech Republic. Quite the opposite. Almost all parliamentary parties and Presidents have held xenophobic positions. For

instance, they unanimously advocated against refugees during the refugee crisis in 2015 and used racist rhetoric. Radical right agenda has thus been a widespread and uncontested position and there is not much space left for new significant political actors to mobilise around it.

Internationalisation of Protest: Transnational Opportunities, Resources, and NGOisation of New Social Movements

The social movements and protest politics in the country were subject to a strong international influence right after the fall of the communist regime in 1989. It mainly took place via foreign patronage—provision of financial resources to social movements from external sources like foundations or public authorities, such as the United States or various foundations like Soros's Open Society Fund (Císař, 2013a). Building on the assumption that a well-functioning and sustainable democracy requires a vibrant civic engagement and strong civil society, the donors used civil society building projects as the main instrument of their democracy assistance. Originally informal groups professionalised and formalised into NGOs with official registration, employees, formal budget, etc. Importantly, this approach was not an invention specifically designed for Easter Europe. This policy has been widely used in old democracies as well (Císař, 2013b).

The foreign patronage and related processes accelerated with the country's accession to the European Union in 2003. The EU itself is a second-order political arena that is primarily focused on secondary political issues that are in Western Europe aligned with socio-cultural new social movement topics like gender equality and the environment. Understandably, the EU promotes these policies and provides a large amount of financial support for organisations active in those fields. As a result, Czech transactional new social movements have been heavily dependent on external patronage—donations and grants from the Czech State that often re-distributes the EU funds, foreign foundations, and directly the European Union. As the Czech SMO survey from 2007 to 2008 shows, 87% of the groups falling under new social movements gained over a half of their budgets through this mechanism (Císař et al., 2011, p. 153).

The effect of the EU funds on the groups and the whole industry that eventually rely more on transaction advocacy mentioned above rather than on mass participation took place through several processes. Firstly, organisations advocating gender equality, human rights, and environment mushroomed in the country as the EU offered start-up grants to new

projects and groups. Secondly, the bureaucratisation and professionalisation of the organisations increased as the EU introduced demanding formal requirements and accountability processes for the management of the organisations. Thirdly, some of the groups shifted their focus from political advocacy to activities more related to social-policy implementation and service provision. Fourthly, the cooperation among local organisations within the individual issue industries increased as the EU required interaction of the groups receiving their funds and generally more connections to stakeholders.

The second channel of how international politics affected Czech social movements is that they function as a transnational political opportunity structure that directly affects domestic protest as well as indirectly via influencing domestic political opportunities during the time of the EU accession in 2003. The EU pre-accession requirements included a quick adoption of pro-environmental, pro-gender equality, pro-human rights policies and legislation, and active engagement of civil society organisations in various public administration processes. With Civic Democrats—strong opponents of all these policies—in the opposition, the governments led by Social Democrats complied and made use of existing expertise of the transactional new social movements in this process. The EU thus opened domestic political opportunities for transactional new social movements that started to have strong direct political influence on policymaking and implementation. Women's, human rights, and environmental groups became members of various governmental advisory groups and committees that were newly established, and they had a very active say in formulation of policies related to new social movement agenda. Some activists developed stronger links with Social Democrats, some even joined the party, and got employed by the government and respective ministries. Importantly, the privileged access to the political system and their political influence ended after the country entered the EU and Civic Democrats got back to power in 2006. Lacking the EU-accession pressure, the Civic Democrats were free to get back to Klaus's neoconservative ideology strongly opposing the new social movement agenda.

Political Economy and Economic Protest

As explained above, the profound convergence of Czech mainstream politics along economic issues did not leave much space for other political challengers like trade unions to address economic issues. The space for

economic protest was further complicated by the fact that the issue-ideological constellation of the mainstream party competition with Social Democrats and conservative Civic Democrats occupying the two poles of the economic dimension had not necessarily overlapped with their actual economic policies. In fact, the alignment of ideology and policy and practical politics was in the past in many aspects reversed. Though ideologically preaching neoliberalism, Civic Democrats were in many areas doing typically social-democratic politics while Social Democrats applied policies that would be characteristic for pro-capitalist right-wing parties. This confuses the political meaning of what right- and left-wing economic policy is and makes it harder for challengers to formulate their positions.

Unlike some of the other post-communist countries that experienced serious economic problems during the post-89 transformation, the Czech Republic avoided any big economic turmoil. One of the factors that supposedly contributed to this relatively smooth economic transformation was the political-economic model of nationally regulated capitalism adopted after 1989 (Císař & Navrátil, 2017; Myant, 2003). Though the governing party of Civic Democrats ideologically advocated neo-classical economic views and used rhetoric of necessary cuts and reforms, their politics was sensitive to socio-economic problems and avoided any radical changes. To prevent social instability and to pacify potential resistance, the government used the strategy of pre-emptive corporatism. The institution of Tripartite structure that brought together major employers, unions, and the government was a significant consultative body that the right-wing government used to pre-negotiate any major steps. Though observers disagree whether unions had actual influence or if it was rather a sign of their cooptation (Ost, 2000), the fact was that major trade unions were part of that negotiation arrangement and thus had an assured access to the political system via conventional means. Together with mainstream parties taking virtually all of the political space on the economic issues that were the single and main issue dimension, trade unions did not have the incentive or political room to opt for contentious strategies (Císař & Navrátil, 2017). As already mentioned above, protest event analysis between 1993 and 2010 shows that protest on economic issues was sporadic.

Though Czechia did not experience large economic problems during the post-89 transformation, still the economic performance did not meet the original expectations of reaching the quality of life comparable to Western democracies. In the second half of the nineties under the rule

of Civic Democrats, the country was showing poor economic performance. In this time, the country experienced first larger protests that were organised mostly by trade unions in close cooperation with Social Democrats and targeted the bad economic and political situation in the country (Císař & Navrátil, 2017). Trade unions also organised events to support the electoral campaign of Social Democrats that eventually won the 1998 elections.

Though advocating left-wing social policies, the newly elected social-democratic government focused on the integration of the Czech economy into global capitalism—a policy that would usually be seen as right-wing (Císař & Navrátil, 2017; Drahokoupil, 2010). By doing so, the Social Democrats indirectly decreased the importance of trade unions and minimised their political influence. Inefficient state companies were sold to foreign owners and the government introduced investment incentives to attract foreign investors. The political leverage of unions declined because of this process. The importance of traditionally unionised industries and companies decreased, unions did not have a base in newly established multinational companies or in a growing service sector (Drahokoupil, 2010). Unions, however, continued their engagement at the institution of Tripartite structure and organised several protests during this time. Newly, also radical left, informal, or community platforms mobilised separately from unions and sponsored a few demonstrations targeted at economic issues and social policy (Císař & Navrátil, 2017).

Economic Crisis, Party Politics Restructuring, and Mass Mobilisations After 2010

The political developments of the post-89 era still shape the character of current contentious politics in the country. The discursive opportunity for protest is limited due to Klaus' discourse of elitist democracy and the legacy of the civic ethos protest. Protest and social movements are either seen as exceptional tools that stand above conventional politics or as a threat to democratic electoral politics. Though the country shows some of the structural features facilitative to protest, such as horizontal power-separation and relatively high self-expressive culture, their effects are diminished by self-contained politics based on informal networks, corruption, and low accountability. As a result, potential protestors do not have an incentive to protest as their actions have a low chance of having an impact. Since the economic issues are mostly contested by mainstream

political parties, the protest arena has been mainly left with socio-cultural issues like environment, gender and sexuality, or human rights. Combined with the fact that the EU happens to focus primarily on socio-cultural issues as well, this situation helped create a strong stream of transactional activism in the country that has been responsible for most protest events: many professionalised NGOs focused on new social movement topics that use political networking with other actors, lobbying, and political consultancy rather than strategies based on broad participation of the public. All these factors probably contribute to the fact that protest is still not a routine channel of everyday politics that would be conventionally used by a larger group of people and advocacy groups in a parallel to lobbying or electoral politics.

However, this does not mean that mass protest is never an option. Two unprecedented mass protests related to the economic crisis in 2012 and to the rule of a technocratic populist Andrej Babiš between 2017 and 2020 took place in response to a major restructuring of the country's political landscape that opened political opportunities for mobilisation. Specifically, as the World economic crisis hit in 2008, Civic Democrats used it as an opportunity for extremely harsh and badly designed neoliberal austerity policies. With weak Social Democrats, the anti-austerity movement "Stop the Government" became the most vocal opponent in 2012 and gained until that time unprecedented level of mass mobilisation. After Civic Democrats' low governing performance and a serious internal political scandal in 2013 that almost erased the party from the political mainstream, the space for new actors and new political-issue constellations appeared. A populist party "Movement ANO" built by and around a businessman Andrej Babiš—an apolitical technocratic populist using anti-pluralist "expert and business-like governance"—appeared as a dominant political force. Facing fragmented opposition, the movement "Million Moments for the Sake of Democracy" became a strong protest opponent challenging Babiš. The following text focuses on the two mass mobilisations and examines the difference in external conditions—institutional, discursive and spatial opportunities, and economic conditions; and repertoire, framing, and organising resources of the two movements.

Anti-austerity Protest "Stop the Government!"

Protests related to the Great Recession peaked in the Czech Republic with mass demonstrations organised by the Stop the Government campaign in

April 2012. The protests were in many aspects unique in the context of the country's contentions politics. It was the first mass protest of Czechs targeting socio-economic issues in the modern history of the country. Moreover, the largest demonstrations had over 100 thousand people attending, which was, until that time, the largest turnout at a demonstration since 1989 anti-communist protests (iDNES.cz, 2012). Also, the protests were organised by a broad coalition of actors that have not collaborated before including the largest trade unions, radical left groups, and civic associations. Newly, the campaign also introduced an explicit anti-neoliberal framing into the Czech mainstream discourse. The organisation capacity and experience of the activist groups, the diversity and size of the coalition and innovating framing together with open political opportunities and economic grievances mostly caused by the government significantly contributed to the mobilisation success of the movement.

Unlike in some of the West and Southern European countries where the Great Recession brought severe socio-economic problems, the Czech Republic did not experience much economic decline and the economy performed relatively well (Saxonberg & Sirovátka, 2014). The growth rates were consistently above the EU average and the unemployment level never went over 8%. Instead of affecting country's economic material conditions, the Great Recession provided a significant discursive political opportunity for policymakers as well as protestors (Císař & Navrátil, 2017; Kriesi et al., 2020; Saxonberg & Sirovátka, 2014). A centre-right-wing government with an explicit neoliberal ideology had been implementing anti-austerity policies since 2006. Even though the performance of the Czech economy resembled more to the German situation during the time of the economic crisis, the right-wing politicians effectively used the threat of the alleged crisis to scare the public that the country needs anti-austerity measures to prevent the Greek scenario. The percentage of people who believed that the "unemployment situation in the country is very bad" more than doubled from around 15% of people on average in the pre-crisis years to around 40% in the anti-austerity crisis period (Vráblíková, 2018). Right-wing parties ran in the 2010 elections on crisis rhetoric. Though the Social Democrats won the elections, the coalition negotiations ended with the establishment of a new centre-right-wing government that then amplified the already ongoing austerity policies. Those then contributed to a lower economic performance and some socio-economic issues (Saxonberg & Sirovátka, 2014).

The high salience of the economic crisis and anti-austerity protests around the world, the fact that austerity policies were the most important issue domestically, and weak opposition of Social Democrats opened the opportunity for anti-austerity protests in the country. Protests addressing the economic crisis started in 2008 and were organised by various organisations (Císař & Navrátil, 2017). A new protest force that appeared on the scene of Czech contentious politics in this time was right-wing populist movements: Holesov Appeal (Holešovská Výzva) that was a nationalist movement attracting politically dissatisfied and socio-economically marginalised protestors, Dawn of Direct Democracy (Úsvit Přímé Demokracie) led by extreme right-wing populist Tomio Okamura, and Movement ANO led by one of the richest people in the country Andrej Babiš running on business-manager-style technocratic populism (Slačálek & Svobodová, 2017). Though protest events organised by right-wing populists had relatively low turnout, their voices got significant attention in media and public debate and some of them eventually succeeded in electoral politics.

By far the largest protests were organised by the Stop the Government campaign that was formed by until that time a unique coalition. Firstly, there were the main trade unions that despite the gradual loss of their members and low influence in new industries still had a large membership base compared to other social movement organisations and had the capacity to organise collective actions with a large turnout. Secondly, there were radical and liberal-left organisations that have focused on the issue of global justice and neoliberalism. An important group was an Initiative ProAlt (Iniciative PRO kritiku reforem a na podporu ALTernativ; Initiative FOR criticism of the reforms and to support ALTernative) that included activists, academics, and experts. Thirdly, the coalition included civic organisations and associations like Czech National Disability Council or the Initiative for Free Universities that involved students and representatives of higher education opposing the reform of higher education. Stop the Government thus brought together most organised workers, organisations representing other social groups as well as important political groups and experts. Some of the groups were old organisations with a lot of campaigning experience and were seen as authentic representatives of the specific social groups, others were relatively new initiatives including experienced individual organisers and newly engaged activists. Unlike the Occupy movement that was, according to some, disorganised due to their horizontal style of coordination, Stop the Government

was a highly organised professional campaign with appointed speakers and developed alternative policy proposals.

The main target of the campaign was the government's public policy, specifically they demanded from the government that they stop brutal anti-social reforms, resign, and organise new elections. Stop the Government framed their main demands in terms of social solidarity pointing at how harmful the anti-austerity policies are to specific segments of the society (Rácová, 2014). In addition, Stop the Government also formulated a more structural and novel criticism that has not resonated in any large protest in the past. Their diagnostic framing called out the neoliberalist approach that had dominated Czech politics since the nineties and negatively affected Czech politics, society, and culture. They demanded that politicians leave the neoliberal style of governance and instead promoted a better democracy based on a broad engagement of citizens and social solidarity (Rácová, 2014; Střižíková, 2012).

A large part of the campaign's framing focused on the presentation of Stop the Government as a legitimate and respectable political actor. They emphasised the size and the plurality of groups involved in the coalition in their framing, arguing that they speak for various social groups and a large segment of society that have been negatively affected by the government's anti-austerity policies (Rácová, 2014). Turning around Klaus's anti-protest framing when movements have been accused of dividing and polarising society by protesting, Stop the Government appropriated this very framing and criticised the government for destroying the society and escalating the situation (Rácová, 2014). The representation of the struggle between Stop the Government and the government in the mainstream media suggests that the movement was more or less successful with their framing (Rácová, 2014). Media gave voice to the Stop the Government and when talking about the issue, and unlike in many other cases in the past, the media did not overtake the governmental anti-protest framing and instead presented the Stop the Government as a legitimate political actor.

The Stop the Government used escalation of their repertoire throughout the campaign. The mainstream unions took part in the Tripartite consultations at first. Emphasising that they had extensively used all the "conventional" channels of negotiations, but all their demands and proposals were rejected, they left the Tripartite institution and went on to protest. Similarly, ProAlt has been campaigning since 2010. They organised talks, ran an information campaign, and brought

together experts and activists to develop alternative proposals for individual policy areas. The various anti-austerity efforts peaked with a "Week of protest" in April 2012. Though the week was successful in terms of the number of people attending, with the last demonstration having a turnout of over a hundred thousand people, the campaign did not manage to sustain high mobilisation afterwards. The unions threatened a general strike that however did not happen. Following demonstrations organised by Stop the Government had only a small attendance.

In terms of political outcomes, Stop the Government probably contributed to the low popularity of the coalition parties and general desire for a structural change. However, mainstream political parties had already suffered from low support. The government resigned in 2013 due to a political-corruption scandal. The main opposition party of Social Democrats also went through an internal crisis at that time. The open political space was not taken by actors following the Stop the Government, it was new movement-parties that grew from the right-wing populist parties mentioned earlier that profited from the crisis the most (Slačálek & Svobodová, 2017). Movement ANO led by Andrej Babiš came second in the next elections and the extreme right-wing party Dawn of Direct Democracy led by Tomio Okamura entered Parliament as well. Neither of these actors represented the demands and politics style that the Stop the Government fought for.

A Million Moments for the Sake of Democracy

A Million Moments for the Sake of Democracy (Milion chvilek pro democracii) was a protest campaign primarily against Prime Minister Babiš that took place from 2017 to 2020. The protests reached a mass scale. A Million Moments organised the largest demonstrations since 1989 protests with a turnout around three hundred thousand people, they developed regional network of local groups, and sustained mass mobilisation for almost a year until the restrictions on collective actions related to the COVID-19 pandemic were put in place (Sehnalová, 2021).

A Million Moments mobilised during the time of restructuring of the mainstream political landscape in the country characterised by unstable political alignments and divided political elites that provided opportunities for mobilisation. In 2013, the standard formula that has organised the main party competition in the last 20 years collapsed. The support of the Civic Democratic Party that was the main coalition party dropped at one

point to just a few per cent after the arrest of the adviser and mistress of that time Prime Minister, a few MPs, and military intelligence personnel for bribery and illegal spying. The Social Democrats, that were the main opposition party, were going through an internal crisis as well and gained in the next elections way fewer votes than expected. The open political space was taken by a new actor—Movement ANO led by Andrej Babiš—that ended up being the second largest party in the Parliament and a coalition partner in a government led by Social Democrats.

Andrej Babiš is a billionaire who ran on an exemplary populist agenda leaning neither to right-wing nor left-wing ideology and primarily focusing on valence issues like corruption, anti-establishment sentiments, quality of state administration, etc. Babiš's valence populism radically changed the 20 years lasting spatial-issue formula of Czech politics that was based on competition taking place mostly on economic left–right dimension. Babiš mostly de-politicised the political discourse using the strategy of technocratic populism (Buštíková & Guasti, 2019). Technocratic populism claims that instead of ideologies and politics, "the State should be run as a Firm" freeing people from political participation. The policymaking is not guided by consistent ideology or principles, instead it eclectically chooses even contradicting policies and different issues. After the next elections in 2017 that ANO won and led a minority government that included Social Democrats and had an external support of Communists to reach a parliamentary majority as well as of the pro-Russian President Zeman. The minority government faced a lot of scandals related to Babiš' non-democratic practices and the dependency on Communists was very controversial. These fragile and unstable political alignments provided a lot of political opportunities for some sort of mobilisation. Lacking a unified major opponent on the mainstream party scene, A Million Moments took a position as a main political counterforce of ANO. The immediate trigger of the largest protest events organised by the movement was Babiš' activities undermining the independence of the justice system. Right after the police announced their plan to charge the PM Babiš for EU funds fraud following the decision of the European Commission, Babiš replaced the Minister of Justice with a person more inclined to stop the charges (Sehnalová, 2021, p. 22). A Million Moments protested many other issues such as Babiš' involvement in corruption, oligarchic connections, conflict of interests, independence of media. On these grounds, the movement demanded Babiš' resignation.

A Million Moments explicitly drew on the tradition of the faux universalism of civic ethos protests described earlier. The movement used the framing of civic ethos included in two main themes (Slačálek & Svobodová, 2017). Firstly, its diagnostic and prognostic framing as well as self-presentation evoked the position of standing above or beyond standard politics by focusing on the very democratic procedures and rules of the game. A Million Moments presented themselves as a "watchdog of democracy" or a "gardener of society" (Kloučková, 2021, p. 16). The actions, history, and the very personality of Babiš were primarily framed as non-democratic and as a violation of fundamental civilised rules.

The second main characteristic of the movement's narrative was a framing embedded in higher principles, morals, and values such as civility, decency, morality, and civic virtues (Kloučková, 2021). For instance, the movement used slogans calling for "decent PM and decent government" or "respectable government" fighting for "decent Czechia" and politics that is "normal". The "above-politics" framing and the lack of specific ideological affinity and concrete political issues of the Million Moments' framing, in fact, matches quite well to Babiš's valence populism. Like Million Movements and its anti-communist 1989 movement predecessor, Babiš also used the framing of ordinary people against corrupt elites and positioning himself above politics. However, unlike the two movements, Babiš was directly attacking the demand for morality and civic values. Also, his "above-politics" position meant depoliticisation and the requirement for a decreased citizens' involvement in politics—a position that was not unsimilar to Klaus's vision of politics.

The authenticity of the high moral claims of the movement also comes from the personal history and qualities of the organisers and prominent supporters of the movement. The leaders of A Million Moments were Mikuláš Minář who is an evangelical and a student of theology and Benjamin Roll who is an evangelical priest (Sehnalová, 2021). As neither of them was involved in politics before and was not connected to prominent transactional new social movements, they could authentically position themselves as concerned citizens who care for the common good and not particularist private interests. Though being a political outsider must have come with challenges in terms of activist-organising experience, it paid off in terms of being an authentic and genuine non-establishment opponent to Babiš. This was probably the key element of the Million Moments' successful public mobilisation.

Though these factors helped mobilise large amounts of protestors, they, however, also limit the potential impact of the movement. As already explained, the above-/non-political framing prevents the very formulation of specific policies and applicable alternatives that are needed after the defeat of the specific opponent of the movement. When the abstract framework is to be translated to everyday politics, the paradoxes of this theoretical framework make it practically impossible to do democratic politics.

Though Million Moments significantly challenged their opponent, their demands and political style did not make it to mainstream party politics. Firstly, the support for ANO did not decline much. ANO still won the next election gaining one mandate more than the right-wing conservative electoral coalition SPOLU (Together) led by Civic Democrats that came second. Compared to the previous elections in 2017, ANO again gained around one and half million votes losing only 42 thousand votes which is a very low loss for an incumbent that has been in government for the last two election cycles. A Million Moments also failed in forming a parliamentary opposition or having their demands carried on by other mainstream political actors. The leader of A Million Moments intended to run in the upcoming elections in 2021, but he did not manage to put together enough support to even run. Million Moments then appealed to all democratic opposition parties to form electoral coalitions and defeat ANO. As the movement at this time did not have an explicit parliamentary ambition, most parties responded positively. The goal to defeat ANO, however, was the only input that the mainstream parties took on from Million Moments. Since ANO could not find a coalition partner to form a majority government despite their electoral victory, the government was eventually formed by SPOLU, Pirate party and by a party of local mayors. The only actor that promotes political style like the movement is a Czech Pirate Party. However, their political trajectory runs relatively disconnected from the movement—their national electoral success and political program came before the movement's mobilisation (Pink & Folvarcny, 2020). Also, the two actors have not really established an alliance that would be stronger than with other mainstream parties. The longer-term mobilising potential of the movement cannot be judged. The movement's grassroots mobilisation was interrupted at its peak by COVID-19 pandemic.

Post-2010 Open Opportunities and Two Modes of Mobilisation

What led to the mass popular mobilisation in the country that until this time saw only small-scale protest events? The main factor is probably the restructuring of national politics that opened political opportunities for protest. Other aspects like political institutions, anti-protest discourse, the character of existing social movement organisations have not really changed between pre- and post-2010.

In the case of Stop the Government, political opportunities opened in response to an external shock of the World economic crisis. The government of Civic Democrats exploited the crisis and deflected national politics to extreme right-wing economic policies through their brutal anti-austerity measures. Even though the country did not experience major economic issues during the crisis, Civic Democrats successfully put through a scary narrative that the country is close to an economic collapse. Social Democrats were at that time in a weak and isolated position. Despite winning the 2010 elections they were unable to create a government and form other political alliances due to their controversial leader. This instability of the national political landscape—the deflection to an extreme right-wing economic position and weakness of the main party holding the opposing position—opened the opportunity for mass anti-austerity movement.

In the case of Million moments of Democracy, the open opportunities resulted from the internal dynamics of national politics. Czech party politics experienced unprecedented restructuring starting in 2013. With the collapse of Civic Democrats due to the corruption and power abuse scandal and already weak and isolated Social Democrats, a businessman Babiš and his party Movement ANO emerged as a major political force in the country. Babiš' valence populism distorted the existing economic left–right competition. Existing political parties that have relied on the economic logic of political contestation were incapable to effectively compete in this new situation. Moreover, Babiš' political power relied on new and unstable alignments—a minority government supported by various left and right-wing populist extremists. This created a political space for a new political actor that would become the major opposition pole to Babiš—movement Million Moments.

The argument about a major influence of political opportunities is further supported by the fact that the two mass campaigns differed

in many ways. In fact, the two campaigns represent two radically different modes of mass mobilisation. This shows that different mobilising resources, movements' infrastructure, and framing can be utilised for mass mobilisation under open political opportunities. Stop the Government protests were organised by a large coalition of diverse organisations representing all kinds of social groups like trade unions, radical left organisations, organisation of disabled people, students' initiative and had a lot of activist experience, know-how, and organising capacity. They also successfully utilised a new type of framing. The movement effectively turned around the anti-protest discourse that pictures protest as a polarising threat to democratic politics and utilised the diversity and broadness of the movement coalition. As a result, the movement was seen as a legitimate and authentic political actor that presented well-elaborated specific political demands as well as a structural criticism of neoliberalism.

Million Moments, on the contrary, drew their legitimacy and authenticity from being a political outsider. The activists were new to political and civic organising, the movement did not have networks with existing social movement organisations and originated in a regional city. They managed to build a strong movement and organise large and long-lasting protest events without the support of mobilising resources and infrastructure usually seen in social movement organising. Unlike Stop the Government, they fully embraced the framing of civic ethos with its faux universalism of moral values and "above-politics" narrative. Given the outsider character of the organisers and their personal profiles, the civic ethos framing worked and helped mobilise unprecedented amounts of protestors. Overall, the two campaigns show that the Czech public is not notoriously apathetic towards politics as some have assumed. Obviously, there is a segment of the population that, though normally not engaged in protest politics, appears to be "standby" citizens, who stay politically alert and are ready to get politically involved if needed (Amnå & Ekman, 2014).

A commonality between the two campaigns is their framing of protest as a "last resort" intervention in the moment of national crisis and not as a routine standard political tool to be used in everyday politics. The exceptionalist narrative also materialises in the country's overall character of contentious politics. The two mobilisations seem to have been isolated incidents. Their vibrant and participatory style of mass collective action did not spill over to everyday non-electoral politics. The protest politics in

the country remains to be dominated by transactional new social movements while other issues like economics are not contested much in the protest arena.

Also, the political impact of the campaigns seems to have been limited. Though they were successful in mobilising large numbers of people and probably in attracting public attention to their issues, the movements and/or their agenda mostly did not make it to the mainstream politics. Instead, the open opportunity was seized by other actors—new or revived political parties that did not have more established connections with the two movements.

Conclusion

The chapter first analysed the main aspects of Czech contentious politics particularly dominant between 1989 and 2010. At the beginning of this period, the core elements of the new political system were developed and laid the ground for the political, cultural, and economic context that influenced the organising of Czech social movements. Except for the time when the country was accessing the EU, social movements in this period faced closed political, discursive, and issue-spatial opportunities. The single-dimensional constellation of Czech mainstream politics firmly established around socio-economic issues, the corrupt non-accountable political system did not provide potential challengers with effective chances to be successful, and the anti-protest and anti-new social movements discourse of V. Klaus created a very hostile environment for new social movements and pacified/co-opted potential for trade union mobilisation. Combined with the strong legacy of the 1989 anti-communist movement framing of faux universalism of civic ethos that pictures protest as a tool "above politics" advocating unquestionable moral values, the Czech social movement organisations did not have a suitable framework to face the adversarial political environment. Protests were characterised by low participation—only a small part of the population took part, most protest events were relatively small, and no larger mobilisation campaigns took place. Political advocacy was mainly taking place outside of the streets: trade unions mostly focused on lobbying within the Tripartite negotiations with the government and employers' representatives and new social movements developed a transactional style of activism with professionalised NGOs focusing on low-turnout forms

of advocacy like information campaigns, consultancy, and small protest events.

However, as two mass mobilisations Stop the Government and Million Moments that appeared in 2012 and 2017–2020 suggest, when the conditions are right, the Czech public and civic groups and movements can mobilise in large numbers. However, though the two movements were successful in terms of protest turnout, they seem to be exceptional incidents of protest that are used in a moment of "national crisis". Their effect on mainstream politics and the general character of protest politics in the country seem so far limited.

Interestingly, similar large-scale mobilisations have taken place in other post-communist countries. People rose in Latvia in 2007, in Romania and Bulgaria in 2013, or in Hungary repeatedly since 2012 to protest the Prime Minister Orban, etc. This suggests that the problem of weak civil society and low participation in post-communist countries does not lie in the local population that is by some seen as inherently politically apathetic. Though episodic, these mobilisations show that there is a mobilising potential in the region. However, the challenge seems to be the translation of the episodic protest eruptions in times of crisis into routine political tools of everyday politics. It seems that this has been mainly prevented by generally closed political opportunities in the region because of non-accountable political systems where despite having formal democratic institutions, the political competition is self-contained, based on informal networks and corruption (Grzymala-Busse & Luong, 2002). This kind of politics does not provide potential challengers with effective chances to be successful and thus does not motivate protest.

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Georgia—Backstage Decisions, Frontstage Agenda, and the Return of Political Activism

Lia Tsuladze

Georgia as a post-Soviet country that was under the Soviet rule for 70 years (1921–1991), similar to other post-Soviet countries, lacked the experience of civic protest until independence movements were launched in the Soviet republics and the Soviet regime collapsed. Since that time, hardly any Georgian government has changed through the constitutional transfer of power and only massive political actions ensured the change of governments. Thus, political activism was the major type of protest that would take people into streets and in each case the protest would result in their demands of the government's resignation.

The situation changed in 2012, when the country witnessed the first constitutional transfer of power. The new ruling coalition of Georgian Dream (GD), shifting from the presidential to the parliamentary rule, declared its mission to establish a new form of governance with "active participation of public" (Civil.ge, 2012). This change triggered the first occasions of policy-oriented activism, targeting various policy issues

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such as protection of environment and preservation of cultural heritage, protection of human rights (including anti-homophobia rallies and the miners' protests in Chiatura and Sakdrisi), student protests calling for the higher education reform, etc. (Tsuladze et al., 2018). However, alongside these developments, informal governance became the new government's style of rule from its early years.

How come that the two seemingly incompatible trends—the first constitutional transfer of power and the emergence of informal governance—proceeded simultaneously? The fact is that the ruling GD coalition was established and financially supported by billionaire Bidzina Ivanishvili, who accumulated his economic capital in Russia. Since 1990 his company had been one of the largest resellers of computers and electric appliances in Russia, which resulted in his opening of the Roscredit bank. He also bought shares of various Russian enterprises from factories to insurance companies, which he sold before returning to Georgia in 2003. Instead, he bought shares of Volkswagen, Barclays, Apple, Google, and more. In Georgia Ivanishvili owns JSC Cartu Bank, Cartu Fund, a number of estates, a vast art collection, and other assets (Khurtsia, 2014). Before establishing his own party a few months prior to the parliamentary elections of 2012, Ivanishvili had financially supported the Saakashvili government and the ruling party of United National Movement (UNM), and was considered one of the largest philanthropists in Georgia. However, soon Ivanishvili declared that President Saakashvili was violating the principles of democracy, making the people "love him by using fear, force, and pressure from the police" (Palitravideo.ge, 2012). He qualified such actions as Saakashvili's "attempts to reverse the river flow and direct it to a different route", which he called an "absolute fairytale and irrationality" (ibid.). Thus, Ivanishvili and his party came to power with the ambition to support Georgia's democratic development and enact the will of the people. Ivanishvili served as a PM of the newly elected government only for a short period and as promised, resigned after a year. While explaining the reason for his resignation, he announced:

> I don't have anything personal against Mikheil Saakashvili or any other politician. My mission is to end missions of messiahs in Georgia and to do this it is not enough to only defeat the messiah. It is necessary to guarantee not to become a messiah myself. (Democracy & Freedom Watch, 2013)

Thus, in Ivanishvili's words, he left Georgian politics to avoid becoming a "messiah" himself. Furthermore, he underlined that he had come "to power in order to protect society" and as this mission had been achieved, he was leaving and distributing "power and responsibility among his political partners" (ibid.). However, as often noted by local and international political experts and media, despite "retreat(ing) back into the shadows", Ivanishvili continued [and still continues] "providing cash and 'control' to the government" (Walker, 2013), which has owned Georgia the title of "captured state" (Transparency International Georgia, 2020).[1]

The chapter discusses how the "captured state" operates, focusing on the impact of informal governance, that is, the power exercised from the political "backstage", on the frontstage political decisions. Furthermore, it discusses how such informal decisions, translated into the governmental decrees and legislation, trigger civic activism and public protest in Georgia. The paper follows the developments that affect a shift from policy-oriented activism to the political one and looks at how the state reacts to various occasions of public protest, as well as how civic activists and citizens resist the authorities' attempts to challenge their actions.

"Along with the State": Informal Governance Translated into the State Decisions

In an attempt to reveal the essence of informality in the post-Socialist countries, authors identify two types of informal practices referred to as "in spite of the state" and "beyond the state" (Morris & Polese, 2015). "In spite of the state" implies the actions that do not correspond to formal rules or laws, while "beyond the state" refers to the attempts to regulate what is insufficiently regulated by the state (idem, p. 4). Considering the Georgian reality, we can add the third element to this list, which I have labelled elsewhere as "along with the state" (Tsuladze, 2021). This term describes the situation when the state regulations are present and "informal actors try to correspond to such regulations or laws though not adapting their actions but making the state adapt to their needs via modifying formal rules or laws themselves" (idem, p. 43). In this way, informal

[1] For more details see Nergadze, N. (2019). *Who Owns Georgia*. Tbilisi: Transparency International Georgia. https://www.transparency.ge/sites/default/files/who_owns_georgia.pdf.

actors act within the realm of the laws that have incorporated informal practice as "legal". Informal actors utilise the state weaknesses and strategically use them to maintain their power, while the state becomes fully dependent on their support, especially the financial one. How does the concept of "along with the state" apply to Georgian politics?

As noted above, Georgia is governed from the political "backstage" by the founder of the current ruling party, billionaire Bidzina Ivanishvili. At the moment, Ivanishvili does not hold a political position; however, he has staged leaving and returning to politics each time the ruling party faced a crisis: Ivanishvili served as a PM for the newly elected government for a year, resigned in November 2013 (Netgazeti.ge, 2013), announced his return to politics in April 2018 (Imedinews, 2018) and retreated "into the shadows" again in January 2021, after the GD party won the parliamentary elections of 2020 (Agenda.ge, 2021). Ivanishvili has appointed or lobbied appointing persons loyal to him on the leading political positions, enacting in this way his own political as well as economic agenda. According to Transparency International (TI) Georgia, the highest positions of key executive and law enforcement bodies are taken by persons considered members of his close circle, who used to work for him in the past. To bring just a few examples, former PMs Giorgi Kvirikashvili and Irakli Garibashvili, who is currently a Chairman of GD, held leading positions in his companies—JSC Cartu Bank and Cartu Fund; Minister of Internal Affairs Vakhtang Gomelauri used to serve as head of Ivanishvili's personal bodyguard service (holding the position of Head of the State Security Service in 2015–2019), likewise Head of the Special State Protection Service Anzor Chubinidze; Deputy Chair of the Supreme Court Shalva Tadumadze, appointed as a lifetime judge, used to serve as Ivanishvili's personal lawyer (2020); Minister of Healthcare Zurab Azarashvili, who previously held the position of Deputy Minister of Defense, had a leading position in JSC Cartu Bank in 2003–2008 (Gelantia, 2021), etc. Considering the abovementioned, no wonder the executive and legislative bodies are tailored to Ivanishvili's needs and can adjust laws within a few days to fit his personal interests (Tsuladze, 2021). In fact, one of the first occasions of such an adjustment, related to the "Panorama Tbilisi" project initiated by Ivanishvili, triggered the largest waves of environmental activism in Georgia back in 2014 (Tsuladze et al., 2018).

As noted above, Ivanishili's heavy influence on policymakers and high officials has resulted in Georgia being referred to as a captured state. TI Georgia (2020) lists a number of features characteristic to the captured

state, focusing on the strategies the ruling party utilises to silence its opponents, such as fabricating criminal cases against and prosecuting political rivals, using judiciary against independent and critical media, prosecuting disloyal businessmen, as well as using political manipulations such as election-related frauds. An important aspect that can be added to this list is the ruling party's attack on the CSO/NGO sector, which started back in 2015 with Ivanishvili's statement that NGOs "undermined the country's image". As a result, 45 NGOs sent an official response to the government, asking to abstain from attacking them and stressing that "Bidzina Ivanishvili's statement about NGOs was not the position of an individual citizen but the one of the state's informal governor" (Netgazeti.ge, 2015). In fact, it was the first occasion when the NGO representatives overtly labelled Ivanishvili as the country's "informal governor". However, the declaration by 45 NGOs was ignored and later the parliament even started discussing a draft law on banning the NGOs that received international funding (Avaliani, 2017). This can be considered the first attempt to introduce the law on "Transparency of Foreign Influence", referred to as the "foreign agents" law, which triggered massive public protests in March 2023 and later in April–May 2024.

Another strategy of the GD party to silence the CSOs/NGOs protesting against the oligarch's influence on governmental decisions is the politicisation of their protest. The ruling party labels them as politically biassed and controlled by its main political rival, the UNM party (Tsuladze et al., 2018). Titles such as "UNM's satellites" and "grant-eater NGOs" are usually attributed to the most outspoken activists and NGOs (such as TI Georgia, Georgian Young Lawyers Association (GYLA), Open Society Georgia Foundation known as the Soros Foundation), in order to discredit them in the eyes of wider society. Thus, alongside legislative adjustments, discursive manipulations such as blame games and "fabrications" aimed at spreading false beliefs about particular events and actors (Goffman, 1975, p. 83) are utilised by the ruling party to challenge the CSOs/NGOs' attempts to counter the impact of informal, backstage political decisions on the formal, frontstage ones. Among the abovementioned discursive strategies, the portrayal of the CSO/NGO sector and oppositional parties as harmful to the national interests, thus enacting "the politics of fear" (Wodak, 2015), is one of the key tools instrumentalised by the GD party to silence its opponents and smoothly implement its own political agenda.

Resisting Informal Governance: The Case of Environmental Activism

As noted in the previous subchapter, Ivanishvili has officially left politics a few times, the first occasion of which lasted from November 2013 to April 2018. However, he remained an actor having a major impact on governmental decisions, which is clearly demonstrated by the case of environmental decision-making. On March 25, 2014, in a few months after leaving the post of PM, Ivanishvili came up with the idea of "Panorama Tbilisi" that implied a massive construction worth of half a billion USD, uniting four multifunctional complexes in the city's historical centre to be connected via cable cars and leaning elevators. Because of the lack of legally required documents, the City Hall denied a construction permit (Anderson, 2014). Almost immediately a few legislative amendments followed: On April 4, 2014, the government changed the law on normative acts for granting construction permits and the projects with a status of "state importance" were allowed to start construction without providing required documents. Furthermore, on December 30, 2014, the City Development Plan for Tbilisi underwent special changes that resulted in the "softening" of restrictions on newly approved zones (Tsuladze et al., 2018, p. 330).

In response, environmental experts, activists, and citizens launched protest actions against the "Panorama Tbilisi" project, considering it extremely harmful to the city's urban landscape, as well as historical and cultural heritage. Environmental NGOs and activist groups initiated the "United Civic Movement for a New Urban Order", which later transformed into the movement "Together", to challenge what they called "urban genocide" or "urbocide" (Democracy & Freedom Watch, 2016; Magaldadze, 2015). On December 29, 2014, a demonstration with thousands of citizens, holding banners calling for "civic participation and urban democracy", took place in front of Tbilisi City Hall (Meparishvili, 2014). This large-scale protest later transformed into small but regular reactive actions notable for the Georgian activists' first use of innovative strategies of policy advocacy, such as flash mobs and theatrical performances in the streets of Tbilisi (Tsuladze et al., 2018, p. 331). The protest gained momentum in June–July 2015, when the government disregarded the NGO's and activists' request for participation in the public administrative process and secretly issued a permit for the project. The public gathered in front of the city hall again with banners: "NO to Panorama,

the city is ours!" (Democracy & Freedom Watch, 2015). More tension followed when on July 19, 2015, several activists were arrested and fined upon the allegations of hooliganism and the use of offensive language. In response, GYLA organised a protest in front of the City Court of Tbilisi declaring that "freedoms of assembly and expression [were] threatened in Georgia" (Tabula.ge, 2015). Despite continuous protests, the government did not terminate the "Panorama Tbilisi" project that, after a decade, is still in progress. Moreover, although Ivanishvili announced that "if it had not been for his persistence, no investor would have been willing to undertake this project, still, any attempt to argue against 'Panorama Tbilisi' was assigned a political connotation by the GD government and especially Ivanishvili himself, assessing it as 'voicing UNM's position'" (Tsuladze et al., 2018, p. 331). The abovementioned shows how the state facilitates the informal actor to smoothly proceed with the construction by legalising informal practices and politicising the opponents' claims.

The situation got even more complex after February 2016, when Georgian media started disseminating the information on century-old, giant trees being displaced from Adjara, the seaside region of Georgia, to Guria, its neighbouring region. Despite the fact that Ivanishvili himself confirmed that he had purchased century-old trees from the government of Adjara for his dendrology park, stating that he was very fond of gigantic trees and calling their collection his hobby and entertainment (Kokoshvili, 2016), the government persistently stated that there was "no formal evidence" to assume that the displacement of trees was connected to Ivanishvili and that the resistance to transplanting century-old trees was politically biassed (Tsuladze, 2021, p. 42). Thus, like in the previous case, the government enabled Ivanishvili to smoothly implement his project and displace trees weighing tones that travelled both by sea and onshore, though with certain complications. For instance, Ivanishvili's barge sank with several trees aboard; a 250-year-old beech broke while travelling to the dendrology park; highways and railroads were not only blocked for hours, but also dismantled if they prevented huge trees from reaching their destination, etc. (idem, pp. 49–50).

In response, environmental experts announced that the displacement of trees would harm both the local surroundings and century-old trees themselves that could not survive in the new settings, while environmental activists launched a new wave of protest actions (Turadze, 2016). The protests took place both in Tbilisi and at the sites of displacement, where activists were joined by local residents. However, the government

continued arresting and fining activists upon the allegations of insubordination (Meparishvili, 2016), as well as blaming them for the attempts "to earn political dividends" (Timer, 2016), while "Ivanishvili continue[d] 'entertaining' himself by moving trees around" (Jamnews, 2017). In a few years, he completed his dendrology park and made it publicly available.

Shifting to Political Activism: Questioning the Government's Pro-European Aspirations

According to the Freedom House's latest assessment of political rights and civil liberties, Georgia is a "partly free" country with 58 scores out of 100. Based on the respective summary,

> [Georgia's] democratic trajectory showed signs of improvement during the period surrounding a change in government in 2012–13, but recent years have featured backsliding. Oligarchic influence affects the country's political affairs, policy decisions, and media environment, and the rule of law is undermined by politicisation. (Freedom House, 2023)

This assessment hardly sounds surprising considering the presented example of environmental decision-making. What is especially noteworthy in the Freedom House's assessment is the emphasis on oligarchic influence, as well as on the rule of law being undermined by politicisation. One more significant aspect is the mentioning of Georgia's democratic backsliding within the recent years. In fact, this backsliding has been especially visible in relation to the country's European trajectory, which has been contested by the ruling GD party in the last few years.

Although Georgia decided to integrate with the Euro-Atlantic structures after the collapse of the Soviet Union, this idea became an inseparable part of the country's foreign policy, as well as political and popular discourses, after the Rose Revolution of 2003. However, it was only in November 2013 that the EU-Georgia Association Agreement was initiated, which was signed in June 2014, while in March 2017 Georgia's citizens were granted visa-free travel to the EU. GD considers these events solely its own accomplishment, and hence the emphasis on the achievements towards the country's European integration has constantly been part of its election campaigns. This strategy does target the electorate whose more than two third has been steadily supporting the country's

Euro-Atlantic integration, as confirmed by regular public opinion polls (CRRC Georgia 2009–2021; NDI 2010–2023).

However, the government's pro-European/pro-Western stance was questioned in 2019, when Sergei Gavrilov, the Russian MP from the Communist Party who came to Georgia for the Inter-parliamentary Assembly of Orthodoxy, addressed the delegates in Russian from Georgia's parliamentary speaker's seat on June 20, 2019. Gavrilov, who had voted for Abkhazia's and South Ossetia's independence from Georgia, was confronted by the opposition MPs from the UNM and European Georgia parties, who occupied the Speaker's chair and did not let Gavrilov return to it, while President of Georgia Salome Zurabishvili blamed Russia for "using religion for political reasons" (OC Media, 2019). An immediate public protest followed with the protesters throwing eggs at the Parliament building and demanding that Gavrilov leave Georgia. In fact, after leaving the parliament, Gavrilov was pursued by the protesters all the way to the hotel where he stayed. The protest actions further expanded and took place not only in the capital city of Tbilisi but also in the towns of Western (Batumi) and Eastern (Gori) Georgia. The public outrage was so strong that GD officials had to become defensive: both then parliamentary speaker Irakli Kobakhidze and then PM Mamuka Bakhtadze announced that it was "very hard" for them to see a Russian politician occupying the parliamentary chair, though it was a "protocol blunder" (Civil.ge, 2019), while then chairman of GD Bidzina Ivanishvili, who returned to politics in April 2018, said that "he shared the outrage of the public" (OC Media, 2019). Despite GD officials' excuses, the police used rubber bullets and tear gas against more than 10 000 protesters, the majority of whom were young people carrying posters "Russia is an occupier" and EU flags, resulting in 240 people being hurt and two young people losing their eyes. Nevertheless, the protesters breached the police cordon and demanded the resignation of the parliamentary speaker. Consequently, Irakli Kobakhidze had to resign (BBC, 2019). Another demand by the protesters was the introduction of a reformed electoral system by the 2020 elections. As the semi-proportional electoral system enables the ruling party to build a constitutional majority, it is considered useful for the concentration of power under one party. The GD party had to also agree to this demand and its chairman Bidzina Ivanishvili promised to introduce a reformed electoral system in time for the 2020 parliamentary elections (DW, 2019).

Another wave of young people's protest took place in spring 2020, a few months prior to the parliamentary elections of October 2020. An anti-government youth movement—the Shame Movement—that was founded in response to the events of June 20, 2019, referred to as "Gavrilov Night", was leading these protests. As Georgian youth had been considered politically passive, even characterised by limited institutional participation, a few would expect that their main demand would be the switch to a proportional electoral system, which was explained by the leaders of the Shame Movement based on the following rationale: "Why did we ask for electoral reform in response to 'Gavrilov Night'? Because we see it as the only way for Georgia to avoid single-party rule or endless political crises" (Kinchia, 2020). The failure of the promise by Ivanishvili to introduce a reformed electoral system by the 2020 elections (Edwards, 2019) took young people to the streets again. Alongside street rallies, the young people from the Shame Movement started creating the online content to counter the government's propaganda, especially after Facebook's announcement in December 2019 that it had taken down a network of fake accounts run by the ruling GD party (Gleicher, 2019).

Escalation of the Conflict

The situation escalated in July 2021, as a result of the far-right groups' attack of journalists covering the news related to the anti-homophobia rally in Tbilisi (the rally itself was cancelled because of the threat of attack). The police did not ensure the safety of journalists; as a result, 53 journalists were injured and one journalist died (Mchedlidze, 2021). Then PM Irakli Garibashvili stated that the Pride organisers had provoked the violence, claiming that public display of LGBTQ+ relations was unacceptable and could lead to "civic confrontation". Furthermore, he politicised the issue, stating that the march was organised by allies of the "radical opposition" (implying UNM and its offspring parties) (Agenda.ge, 2021, July 5). In response to violence, thousands of Georgians gathered in front of the Parliament building, waving a rainbow flag next to the iron cross erected by far-right groups the previous day. This time the police ensured the protesters' safety, though as soon as they dispersed, far-right groups reclaimed the space. They removed and burnt the EU flag in front of the Parliament building that was put back the next morning by the Head of Parliament. Thousands of protesters gathered in front of the Parliament building again. Despite a peaceful protest,

more than 10 protesters were arrested, including a few journalists who were especially vocal in their critique of the authorities (Agenda.ge, 2021, July 6). These events developed alongside discursive clashes between pro-European and ultra-conservative powers, with the former chanting a popular motto "I am Georgian and, therefore, I am European", while the latter confronting it with "I am Georgian and no therefores" (Tsuladze et al., 2022). The above processes have been assessed by experts as "the weakening of the EU in its role as a liberal power […] favouring illiberal tendencies in Georgia" (Schiffers, 2021). Indeed, in the same month, the government withdrew from President of the European Council Charles Michel's agreement aimed at assisting to overcome the political crisis in Georgia (Gotev, 2021; Lomsadze, 2021). Furthermore, two years later, when the GD government attempted to introduce the "foreign agents" law and resumed direct flights with Russia resulting in all 27 EU states' diplomatic demarche to Georgian authorities (Civil.ge, 2023, May 29), GD officials started openly claiming that liberalism was a threat to the country's sovereignty (Civil.ge, 2023, May 12).

June 2022 witnessed another wave of pro-EU rally that took place on the third anniversary of "Gavrilov Night". Entitled "Home to Europe" and organised by the Shame Movement, the rally attracted tens of thousands of students, civil society organisations, opposition politicians, and the wider public. The main concern of the protesters, carrying Georgian, European, NATO, and Ukrainian flags, was the ruling party's failure to secure candidate status for Georgia. Indeed, on June 17, the European Commission issued a recommendation for the Council to grant candidate status to Ukraine and Moldova, while setting a list of preconditions to Georgia with a special focus on the country's depolarisation and deoligarchisation (OC Media, 2022, June 24).

Thus, each summer a new wave of pro-Europe rally took place in Georgia, simultaneously protesting against the government's democratic backsliding. Starting from 2019, Georgians were demanding the government to introduce a reformed electoral system, to protect the rights of sexual minorities, and to firmly follow the pro-European path. Despite the abovementioned backsliding, the government was still characterised by pro-European rhetoric and was rather defensive while criticised by its local opponents and EU officials for diverging from the European course. This has changed since March 2022, after Russia's invasion of Ukraine and the ruling party's refusal to join the EU's sanctions against Russia. The government's defensive discourse has changed to the offensive one,

which was rather mild in the beginning, questioning the opponents—"So, do you want the war?", gradually shifting to the blame game in June 2022—"The EU has punished us by not granting candidate status because Georgia is not in the state of war", and further escalating and transforming into the politics of fear after June 2022—"They (the EU/West) want to drag us into the war" (Tsuladze et al., 2024).

The more the ruling party tried to justify its reluctance to join the EU's sanctions against Russia and the more it enacted the politics of fear, connecting the issue with the potential Russian aggression towards Georgia, the more the civil society expressed its concern that Russia would try to circumvent the sanctions, using its neighbouring countries, including Georgia, for this purpose. In fact, as noted by TI Georgia (2022), the GD government always underlined the importance of the so-called non-irritation politics towards Russia and over the years, made the Georgian economy heavily dependent on Russia. The organisation questions "what business interests the Georgian ruling elite [might] hold in Russia, as this may impact their decisions on issues of strategic importance for Georgia" and argues that despite the fact that while entering politics in 2011, Ivanishvili announced that he was selling all his assets in Russia in order to avoid unnecessary questions by the Georgian public, he sold only those assets that were directly related to his name and continued owning at least 10 Russian companies through certain offshore entities. TI Georgia provides detailed information on how Ivanishvili runs his business and assets through trusted individuals, in particular, his close relatives and even government officials, including the former PM and the current chairman of GD Irakli Garibashvili (ibid.). Thus, returning to the issue of captured state, it is obvious that the oligarch with business interests in Russia makes strategic decisions from the political backstage and enacts them "along with the state".

The Government's Attack on Civil Society and Protest Against It

The EU-Russia dichotomy became even more intense after the ruling party initiated the law on "Transparency of Foreign Influence", known as the "foreign agents" law, targeting CSOs/NGOs (legal entities under public law being exempt from it). This fact triggered a new wave of protest with more than 100 000 citizens rallying in front of the Parliament building (Camut & Sheftalovich, 2023). As noted above, the idea

that NGOs posed a threat to Georgian society has been voiced by Ivanishvili and his party officials since January 2015, while later the Parliament started discussing a legislative initiative on banning the NGOs that received international funding. Back in 2017, this bill was initiated by one of the minor parties and failed, but this time the ruling party overtly supported the "foreign agents" law initiated by its former members who established a political movement "People's Power" in August 2022. It is argued that these nine people "left" the ruling party in order to freely criticise the country's Euro-Atlantic course (Machaidze, 2023). In fact, this small group of MPs, who has formally split from the ruling party, remains in the GD-led parliamentary majority. Despite its recent emergence, "People's Power" is famous for inventing various conspiracy theories about the West, one of which is the blaming of then US Ambassador to Georgia Kelly Degnan for secretly meeting the founder of the GD party Bidzina Ivanishvili to blackmail him. Ivanishvili then broke his long silence to confirm that Degnan had indeed met him and also added that "People's Power" was acting on his behalf. It is noteworthy that this group was especially vocal in attacking the West in the context of Ivanishvili's financial hurdles with the Swiss bank Credit Suisse (Gabrichidze, 2023), as well as when certain members of the European Parliament announced that Ivanishvili was the major obstacle on Georgia's way to European integration, calling for the country's "deBidzinisation" (Chkareuli, 2022) and discussing the prospects of sanctioning him (Radio Tavisupleba, 2022). The group immediately made a public announcement that if Georgia's candidate status was achieved at the expense of sanctioning Ivanishvili and giving up the sovereignty and traditional values, then the country did not need candidate status at all (Kavkazplus, 2023). Thus, this discourse represents the country's sovereignty as inseparable from the oligarch's well-being. It is another evidence of how the oligarch's personal interests might clash with the societal ones and influence the government's decisions on issues of strategic importance for Georgia. In order to defend the abovementioned "sovereignty and traditional values", which were viewed as threatened by liberal values (Radio Tavisupleba, 2023, May 11; 2023, May 12; Civil.ge, 2023, May 12), the People's Power, backed up by the ruling party, initiated the "foreign agents" law against the CSO/NGO sector as a watchdog of the state.

The CSOs/NGOs immediately started an online campaign "Russian Law is Not the Will of Georgia". Furthermore, 400 CSOs/NGOs signed

the petition against this draft law and sent it to the European Parliament (ISFED, 2023). In response, then chairman of the ruling party Irakli Kobakhidze announced that this draft law was even "much softer" than the respective American law and those who stated that it was the Russian-style law were liars (Interpressnews, 2023, February 16). Furthermore, he underlined that NGOs "triggered polarisation" in the country and this law would have a "preventive effect". Adding to this politics of fear, he claimed that the majority of those protesting against this law were "attacking the church". To further reinforce his populist discourse, Kobakhidze stressed that the people should know who finances such offensive actions against the church (Civil.ge, 2023, March 3) that, according to the public opinion polls, has been steadily reported as the most trustworthy institution in Georgia (CRRC Georgia 2009–2021; NDI 2010–2023). In response to the harsh reaction from the civil sector and EU officials (Civil.ge, 2023, February 27), the government announced the postponing of the discussion of the draft law for a few days, though suddenly the information disseminated via the social media that the ruling party had secretly resumed the process. In a few hours, NGO/CSO representatives gathered in front of the Parliament building, later joined by students from various universities, even high school pupils, and the wider public. As noted above, more than 100 000 protesters rallied on the capital's main avenue and each day more people joined the rally. The police used water and tear gas against the protesters, especially young people (Cordell, 2023; *The Guardian*, 2023), and the government deployed special forces (the so-called robocops) on the second day (OC Media, 2023), which caused further escalation of the protest. Fearing the public outrage and an excessive attention of the international community, especially vocal accusations of the Western partners, after three days the ruling party urgently voted down the law. In fact, out of 76 MPs from the ruling party who voted for the law on March 7, none voted for it on March 10 (Civil.ge, 2023, March 10). It is widely acknowledged that these 76 MPs' support of the law and after three days their collective abstention from its support was guided from the political "backstage" (Gabrichidze, 2023).

One of the Most Effective Protests in Georgia's Current History

What are the specifics of the protest against the "foreign agents" law that make it so effective in contrast to the former ones? Firstly, a very fast consolidation of CSOs/NGOs and their coordination via social media should be underlined. As soon as the government announced its support of the draft law, a closed Facebook group was created with the representatives of around 400 CSOs/NGOs who had signed the abovementioned petition. They started disseminating all necessary information, including professional explanations of the draft law, and updating the members about ongoing events on a regular basis. In fact, it was through this and other similar channels that the information was disseminated on the ruling party's unplanned launch of discussion of the law (which was officially appointed after two days) and CSO/NGO representatives immediately gathered in front of the Parliament building (this is how the protest actions started).

Secondly, the participation of various age groups, especially young people, in the protest actions is remarkable. Students of various universities in Tbilisi mobilised to protest against the "foreign agents" law. In fact, young people turned out to be most vocal and showed the strongest resistance to the police, which resulted in the arrest of 133 protesters on administrative charges on March 7–9 (Agenda.ge, 2023). Furthermore, the deployment of special forces drove more people to the main avenue, and the ruling party clearly saw that the use of force could hardly stop the young people who danced under the water streams targeting them, used masks to protect themselves from teargas, and even handed flowers to the robocops (Civil.ge, 2023, March 9). Thus, the government encountered very strong resistance from the citizens, especially among the younger generations (in fact, Gen Z was recognised as a major actor in this protest).

Thirdly, the citizens did not allow any political party to speak from their name and even to occupy a tribune during the rallies. In a highly polarised Georgian society, where the citizens report a very low trust in any political power, with 64% stating that not a single political party expresses their interests (Civil.ge, 2023, May 3), the self-organised protest that was not led by any political party drove to streets a considerable number of citizens. Although there were a few attempts by the largest opposition party UNM and its smaller offspring parties to join the protesters, these

attempts failed as the citizens overtly expressed their distrust in any politician trying to occupy the tribune during the protests. In fact, we can argue that the protest actions had such a massive character because none of the political parties managed to take the lead.

Finally, the issue was interrelated to Georgia's foreign policy course. The protesters referred to EU officials reproving this law and made parallels with the Russian "foreign agents" law, which had silenced the civil society and further deteriorated the state of democracy in Russia. Because the ruling GD party had to constantly prove for the last few years that it firmly followed the European path, it had an enormous pressure from both the local community (with the protesters' motto "Russian Law is Not the Will of Georgia") and international actors (especially the EU[2]). Therefore, it had to hastily withdraw the "foreign agents" law. However, as noted by the local media, despite the fact that the "bill is down, […] the ruling party rhetoric [is] not out" (Civil.ge, 2023, March 10). Moreover, after withdrawing the law, the authorities launched active disinformation campaigns against the CSOs/NGOs and young people involved in the protest actions, using their long-practised tactic of politicising these young people and depicting them as controlled by opposition parties, especially UNM. Quite often, disinformation campaigns as "indirect" measures were accompanied by "direct" measures: A few days after the rallies, a 19-year-old participant of the protest action was detained upon the allegation of throwing a "Molotov cocktail" at the policeman and sentenced to 11 years of prison.[3] As the parliamentary elections of October 2024 are approaching, the ruling party is expected to expand its utilisation of both "direct" and "indirect" measures, especially its disinformation campaigns (using its "troll factory" in the popular social networks such as Facebook [Jgharkava, 2020; OC Media, 2022]) against the political opponents and civil society, which further endangers the state of democracy and aggravates the existing political polarisation in the country (Gegeshidze & De Waal, 2021).

[2] The government had to satisfy 12 recommendations set by the EU as a precondition for being granted candidate status, while the EU stressed several times that this draft law violated at least two of the 12 recommendations (Kupreishvili 2023).

[3] The protest action against his detention was even attended by member of the European Parliament Viola von Cramon who was highly criticised by the ruling GD party (Civil.ge, 2023, April 3).

Conclusion

To reflect on the issue of how the dynamics of power and protest have been developing in Georgia in the twenty-first century, we encounter a constant upturn and backsliding in democratic governance, followed by the adjacent shifts in civic movements, from political to policy-oriented activism and back to the political one. The major issue currently faced by the country is the rise of informal governance enacted "along with the state": The ruling party is controlled by the oligarch periodically reemerging on the political front stage or retreating to the political backstage. As illustrated above, the oligarch has the key impact on the government's strategic decisions, whether it comes to the environmental ones or those related to the country's foreign policy course. It is these backstage decisions and their harmful effect on the country's democratic development that are resisted by the civil society and citizens in Georgia.

What impact might these protests have on the country's democratic trajectory and its European future, whose safeguarding is the driving force of the recent protest actions? While awaiting the EU's decision on candidate status, despite EU officials' concerns and public discontent, the ruling party still initiated the "foreign agents" law that was withdrawn due to the massive demonstrations, resumed direct flights with Russia that took citizens to streets again (Demytrie, 2023; Nechepurenko, 2023) and caused all 27 EU state's diplomatic demarche to Georgia's government (Civil.ge, 2023, May 29), as well as passed the draft law on deoligarchisation (Business Media, 2023), viewed by the Venice Commission as an instrument of political manipulation (Civil.ge, 2023, June 13). Opposition parties expressed their scepticism, announcing that "Bidzina's 'tails' should decide whether Bidzina Ivanishvili is an oligarch or not" (Interpressnews, 2023, June 14). CSOs and youth movements continued their small-scale protest actions behind the Parliament building, stating that the ruling party was sabotaging the country's EU candidacy (Civil.ge, 2023, April 11). Despite the fact that GD boasts of having implemented most of the 12 recommendations set by the EU and promises that the remaining two—depolarisation and deoligarchisation—will be implemented in the near future, it is obvious that there is a heavy political polarisation in the country (Tsuladze & Abzianidze, 2025) and that the ruling party will not turn its back on the founder—the oligarch whose cash and control it is dependent on. Despite the abovementioned issues, the EU still granted candidate status to Georgia in December 2023. One of the main reasons

is considered to be the citizens' successful effort to prevent the government from adopting the legislation harming the country's democratic development and endangering civil society, as well as their persistence to guard the country's European path and resist informal politics enacted "along with the state". In fact, on September 12, 2023, the European Conservatives and Reformists group nominated "pro-European people of Georgia" together with Nino Lomjaria, former Public Defender of Georgia, for 2023 Sakharov Prize for Freedom of Thought, stressing that the people of Georgia have "fought fiercely for their rights and aspirations, positively influenced government decisions and formed the core of the country's resilience" (ECR Group, 2023). The citizens of Georgia have to continue fighting for their rights and aspirations, as before this volume is published, GD has re-introduced the rebranded "foreign agents" bill. As a justification of its re-introduction, the current PM Irakli Kobakhidze has cynically noted that GD officials are fully "European-style" transparent and this bill is meant to also "Europeanise" NGOs and their donors (Civil.ge, 2024, April 3).[4]

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[4] The ruling party re-initiated this bill on April 3, 2024, and despite continuous and massive protests with more than 100 000 people involved, 84 GD MPs overrode the President's veto and adopted the law on May 28, 2024.

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Hungary—The Changing Roles of Civil Society and Social Movements Facing Autocratisation

Márton Gerő and Szabina Kerényi

Scholarship on mobilisation has been traditionally focused on either civil society or grassroots social movements and protests. This general approach has slightly started to change in recent years (della Porta, 2020). In this paper, we contribute to the discussion by focusing on the changing roles of both movements and organised civil society in regard to protest activities and political participation. The chapter examines how civil society organisations and social movements were shaped in the changing political context in Hungary since the early 2000s. In doing so, the elections of 2010 will be regarded as a critical juncture, when Fidesz, the ruling party of the last 14 years, first gained constitutional majority. This juncture is important because we argue that under different circumstances, different meanings and expectations are attributed to civil society. Thus, civil society itself is constantly transforming. While such

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changes may have various backgrounds and can be economic, social, or technological, in this paper we focus on the political context. The main reason for this is that even though the socio-economic changes are similar to those in other countries in the region after 2010, democratic institutions deteriorated to a point that today it is debated whether Hungary can still be seen as a form of democracy, it is a hybrid regime or has even passed the threshold of an electoral authoritarian system (Ágh, 2016; Bogaards, 2018; Bozóki & Hegedűs, 2018).

Thus, based on recent theoretical insights into the development of civil society, we assume that the structure and repertoire of civil society transform with the changing political landscape (Bernhard, 2020; Pietrzyk-Reeves, 2022). Civil society, in our perspective, is a field of formal and informal organisations and groups, which—in their view—promote social change, collective action, or certain common goods (social or communal goods, or services, etc.). These organisations and actors do not distribute the profit of their activities, while being institutionally independent from the state, authorities, and for-profit organisations (Anheier, 2004; Diani, 2015). This concept involves two domains of civil society, often discussed separately: organised civil society and social movements. The separation between them is often unclear and mainly stems from different theoretical traditions and as such has been repeatedly challenged (della Porta, 2020, Diani, 2015). First of all, drawing on Arato and Cohen (1992), we see movements as a dynamic part of civil society enabling the emergence of new issues and ideas, while formal organisations represent the 'backbone' of civil society. Secondly, in accordance with Diani (1992) we understand social movements as networks of actors, within which the actors might be loose, informal groups as well as formal organisations, such as CSOs, trade unions, or even in some cases, political parties. Social movements then are created by the shared identity of the actors, and their dynamic nature stems not only from their informality, but from the complex relationship between the actors.

We discuss the changes of civil society from the viewpoint of these two approaches in the light of the changing political context. We examine the processes of structural transformation that began in 2002–2003; the period before and after the electoral turn in 2010, until the early 2020s. These changes include legislative changes, the transformation of the domestic funding environment, changes of the governmental policies regarding civil society, and other major events triggering collective actions.

The discussion of the two approaches together will allow us to challenge some of the widely accepted views on Hungarian civil society: First, the overall picture about Central and Eastern Europe (CEE), including Hungary, is that political participation, and especially participation outside of the electoral arena, is considered to be low compared to the West. While CEE has been described as having a chronically 'weak civil society' (Jacobsson & Korolczuk, 2020; Kutter & Trappmann, 2010) due to limited access to institutions, lack of resources and, accordingly, the absence of any significant infrastructure to mobilise citizens, as well as a political culture that discourages collective action (Szabó & Gerő, 2015; Zgut, 2022), the situation is more complex. We intend to show that although the overall picture might show low activity, there are circumstances when large societal groups still engage in collective action.

Another widely accepted notion is that civil society in CEE engages in advocacy through transactional activism, instead of 'participatory activism.' Petrova and Tarrow (2007) state that instead of mobilising citizens (participatory activism), CSOs rely on a network of organisations. In some sectors, CSOs are fairly well organised and have a considerable impact on public policies, even without large popular support. However, this argument relies on the assumption of open communication between the state and CSOs, and available channels of communication. Also, Petrova and Tarrow's (2007) concept is based on a generalisation of research on the environmental sector, while overlooking right-wing mobilisation in the 2000's, which makes it impossible to address the impact of autocratisation. As we will show, the changes after 2010 generated more active participatory activism (Buzogány et al., 2022; Gerő et al., 2022).

One would assume that the restrictive regulations on civil society organisations and political events affecting civil society (e.g. funding limitations, campaigns against CSOs) have a uniformly negative impact on civil society organisations and become obstacles in organising collective action. However, based on recent research, (Boda, 2023; Gerő et al., 2022; Szikra & Vajda, 2020; Szikra et al., 2020) and on the analysis of the data provided by the Central Statistical Office, as well as our desk research on Hungarian social movements, we conclude that: (a) the changes influenced policy-making as expected, resulting in a decreasing role of civil society; (b) however, these changes affected CSOs operating in various fields differently; (c) and, furthermore, the intensity and frequency of

collective action are also changing in different ways than expected. Collective action did not cease to exist after the authoritarian turn. After 2010, first the left-wing and liberal parties, and later civil society, took the streets, which were previously dominated by extreme right-wing actors.

Below, we first present how the concepts of (organised) civil society and social movements emphasise different roles and processes in politics, and how these can be reconciled. We then briefly examine the changes in structural conditions in Hungary since 2010 and finally show how they have transformed the structure of important segments of civil society, social movements, and protests.

Civil Society and Social Movements—Different Frameworks, Coinciding Actors?

Scholars, such as Hasenfeld and Gidron (2005) or della Porta (2020), noted that research on civil society, social movements, and the third sector developed in parallel, with little reference to each other, despite the similarities of actors and phenomena examined. Hasenfeld and Gidron (2005) see the intersection of the three theoretical traditions in increasingly conspicuous multi-purpose organisations, suggesting multiple goals and activities that traditionally belong to separate types of organisations. Multi-purpose organisations have goals connected to certain cultural values, they provide services, through which they further social change, and they also foster collective identity. Together, these three goals enable them not only to engage members but also to initiate mobilisation processes. della Porta (2020) sees the overlaps and connections between the traditions of civil society and social movement research to be even more extensive, despite the differences between the two approaches. Civil society theories underline questions of autonomy from the state (and political parties) and the development of universalistic values versus particularistic ideas (see also Chambers & Kopstein, 2001), while social movement studies emphasise conflicts and always-changing networks. An even more visible difference is that civil society research often focuses on formal organisations, whereas social movement studies consider movements as networks of individuals and organisations. della Porta (2020) contends that in the last decade, social movement and civil society studies cross-fertilised each other: the features mentioned above as distinctive for one or the other appear increasingly in both fields of research. More importantly, della Porta identifies the 'social movementisation' of civil society

organisations thus becoming more conflict-oriented (della Porta & Steinhilper, 2021) and the institutionalisation processes of social movement organisations, referred to as NGO-ization (della Porta, 2020). Along with these developments, we see organisations, actors, and networks engaging in action mainly in conflict with the state and using contentious repertoires, and propose that organised civil society and social movements have to be examined together.

Furthermore, we also think that the distinction between the integrative role of organised civil society, and the disruptive, conflict-oriented nature of social movements is unclear. Both organised civil society and social movements have integrative functions on the one hand, and they are expected to sometimes be in conflict with the state (and economy) on the other.

Scholarship basically attributes three functions to civil society and its organisations. The first one is to democratise the political and economic spheres through various advocacy tools; that is, to force the use of deliberative procedures, to involve marginalised groups in decision-making, and to represent the principles of preserving and broadening participation rights in general. Although this function is also often referred to as a mediating role, it certainly implies conflicts with the state. At the same time, civil society organisations also provide legitimacy and mediate the intentions of the state (Arato & Cohen, 2021; Cohen & Arato, 1992). The second function is the social embedding, strengthening and maintenance of democratic values, thus managing the conflict between particular and universal values (Chambers & Kopstein, 2001; Morgan, 2021). The third function results from the previous two functions. Associations either represent some diversity in their membership (through the acceptance of positions and the resulting inclusion), or the meeting of associations leads to the creation of overlapping relationships between social groups. Thus, associations will not only be a school of democracy but will also provide connections between different social groups (Diani, 2015).

Social movements may primarily represent two types of integration mechanisms. On the one hand, they create channels by which the movements coordinate the citizens' problem and goal definitions, or even their worldviews and interpretive frameworks through mobilisation processes. This is the process of framing (Snow et al., 1986; Snow, 2013), which is a movement task consisting of interpreting, focusing, articulating, and transforming social conflicts into action. On the other hand, movements contribute to the thematisation of public opinion or the political agenda

through the disclosure and exacerbation of conflicts. In this way, they also contribute to the coherence or polarisation of ordinary worldviews by infusing conflicts in the public sphere (Snow et al., 1986).

To summarise, action-coordination mechanisms appear in both approaches towards organised civil society and social movements: in civil society, they are present in the mechanisms of socialisation in associations; in movements, they lie in the mechanisms of mobilisation. In addition, common (or different) interpretations are created by (what are thought to be) deliberative procedures and the framing processes. Mechanisms that regulate the relationship between social groups also appear in both research traditions. In civil society theory, these are cross-group characteristics of civil organisations; in social movement approaches, the relationship is manifested in the connection of discursive conflicts and different frameworks. To what extent these different parts of civil society might be able to fulfil their roles depends on the political context.

Michael Bernhard (2020) proposed a model, which links the characteristics of civil society to the types of regimes. According to this model, in liberalising autocracies (for example, in the Central European socialist states of the 1980s), 'insurgent' civil society, primarily characterised by collective action and political protest was typical, which was essentially of a movement nature, since there were few opportunities to set up formal organisations in the given political environment. However, in democracies, institutionalised civil society emerges, with formal organisations and the services and advocacy they provide as a central element. In addition to human rights, advocacy and political organisations with an expressed democratic commitment, a 'non-democratic' civil society is also emerging. This also means that the balance of power between certain segments of civil society will change, and while non-democratic organisations will align with, or explicitly support, the new political system, democratic organisations will have a conflicting relationship with the state, which will specifically seek to weaken them.

Political Context, Legislative Framework, and Major Events Before and After the 2010 Turn

The post-1989 framework governing the relationship between civil society and the state and politics reached their final form around the mid-1990s and remained relatively stable until 2011, when a new legislation was adopted. At least formally, legally guaranteed forms of a

social dialogue were established, creating opportunities for dialogue and influence. The overall framework of the civil society-state relationship unquestionably followed the European norms (Rixer, 2014; Szabó, 1998), which, however, also provided the framework that contributed to the demobilisation of civil society after the mass mobilizations between 1989 and 1994 (see Szabó, 1995). The low level of political participation and the availability of formal channels created an environment in which professionalisation, negotiating tools, expert work, and participation in public policy programmes seemed to be a more cost-efficient and effective strategy than expanding relations with citizens and emphasising direct participation (Petrova & Tarrow, 2007). Throughout the 1990s, ministries established offices working with civil society organisations, and the first time liasoning with civil society was elevated to the governmental level was during the first Orbán government in 1998 (Bocz, 2009).

In the 1990s, the financial resources of CSOs were provided by various funding bodies, which led to substantial inequalities in resources among organisations. The majority of Hungarian CSOs were small and resource-dependent. The source of income, however, changed between the 1990s and the 2000s. International donors played a significant role in the establishment of civil society, similarly to other Central and Eastern European countries (Carothers, 1999; Farkas, 2018; Hahn-Fuhr & Worschech, 2014). Around 40% of the private donations came from international donors in the 1990s, which percentage decreased to 34% in the mid-2000s or, more precisely, it fluctuated between 31 and 41% during 1996 and 2000 (Bocz, 2009, p. 295). In parallel with the significant decrease in share of private donations, state funding became increasingly important. From 1997 on, the 1% of personal income tax also became an increasing resource of the sector.

Increasing state funding did not help to solve the uncertainty challenge with the strengthening of the project-logic of funding. Individual organisations were under constant tender pressure, engaged in fast-paced projects rather than large-scale projects, which often resulted in strong staff turnover and rapid burnout, while the emphasis shifted to day-to-day operations rather than achieving long-term goals. The accession to the European Union opened up new opportunities but did not change this logic, even after joining the EU in 2004 (Börzel, 2010; Fagan, 2011).

In 2003–2004, the Socialist-Liberal government introduced a Strategy for the Development of Civil society, involving representatives of CSOs (Szász, 2003). The main element of this strategy was to introduce the

National Civil Fund, the first fund to offer small but important grants to CSOs for operating expenditures. The management of the fund relied heavily on self-government: 2/3 of the governing bodies was selected based on elections among CSOs, and only 1/3 of them was appointed by the relevant ministry. The other main feature of the funding programme was that the amount of the funds disbursed was based on the amount of 1% of personal income tax citizens redirected to civil society organisations. The Fund operated until 2011, when the newly elected Fidesz government changed the funding scheme (Nagy, 2016).

The period between 2002 and 2010 was marked by turbulent events, political turmoil, and protests. In 2002, the electoral loss of Fidesz invoked the birth of a nation-wide right-wing movement, the so-called Civic Circles. The EU accession in 2004 was followed by a large domestic political scandal in 2006, when PM Ferenc Gyurcsány's internal speech to the party fraction at Őszöd was leaked, which led to a series of street demonstrations. Finally, the global economic crisis of 2008 resulted in a financial crisis and economic instability. The cumulative effect of the various crises and right-wing mobilisation was the landslide victory of Fidesz in 2010, leading to essential transformations in the domestic political scene.

This change has been termed *democratic decline* (Cianetti et al., 2018) a *diffuse democracy defect* (Bogaards, 2018), a reversal of democratisation (Kornai, 2015), hybridisation of the political regime (Bozóki & Hegedűs, 2018), or electoral autocracy (Unger, 2018). The political and institutional changes in 2010 also affected the relationship between civil society and the state, reflected in three dimensions: legislation, methods of communication between the state and the citizens, and increased harassment of civil society organisations by state agencies. The first changes of the basic regulations of non-governmental organisations took place relatively quickly, already in 2011.

The law on the right of association was repealed, and a separate law on non-governmental organisations was adopted (see Act CLXXV of 2011 on the Freedom of Association, Non-profit Status and the Operation and Support of Civil Organisations). This regulation brought about two important changes: the conditions of eligibility for public benefits became stricter and the National Civil Fund (NCA) was transformed. While two-thirds of the management of the NCA used to consist of NGO delegates, in the case of the newly created National Cooperation Fund (NCF) this ratio was reversed; now two-thirds of members of the governing body

is delegated by the government, while only one-third by CSO representatives. Accordingly, the number of applications for funding dropped by roughly half after the change (Sebestény, 2016).

The second area subject to transformations was the communication between the state and the citizens. First, the arenas of social dialogue and the former negotiating fields between citizens and the state disappeared one by one (Arató & Mikecz, 2015; Gerő et al., 2020). Second, the range of issues to be discussed in a popular referendum narrowed, and the institutions of popular initiative and *actio popularis* were abolished (Chronowski, 2014). The government introduced the institution of the so-called national consultations, essentially large push-polls with manipulative questions addressing directly the citizens. Not surprisingly, the results always support the government's proposals with a huge majority (Bocskor, 2018). Thus, instead of multi-directional and horizontal communication, an exclusively one-way channel between the state and the citizen was created.

The state also supports organisations that call themselves independent civil society organisations from the state, while representing the interests of the state, more specifically, of power. These are often referred to in the literature as GONGOs *(Governmental Non-governmental organisation)*, but in our view, these are not just organisations created by the power and representing the position of power; they also pretend to be independent, while providing the government a basis of legitimacy. A less explicit way of strengthening the legitimacy of the government is for the state to 'divert' or co-opt independently existing organisations through subsidies (Fejős & Neményi, 2020; Kapitány, 2019; Szikra et al., 2020).

The harassment of civil society organisations involves a range of tools. In public communication, the stigmatisation of non-governmental organisations in Hungary has intensified to an unprecedented extent. As a result, organisations that were previously active in public life were completely excluded from decision-making processes, and, as a consequence of repetitive campaigns, they were presented as agents of foreign powers (Gerő et al., 2020; Majtényi et al., 2019). Besides campaigns, several times (such as in 2014 during the NCTA case, state authorities investigated CSOs. In 2017, the Act on Foreign-funded Organisations was adopted, which provided for mandatory registration of 'foreign-supported organisations.' While the practical consequences are not clear, the new regulation did not only impose an administrative burden on NGOs but also conveyed a kind of symbolic message, namely that international support entailed

some vague, potential risk from the outset. This also fit into the narrative that began to label NGOs as dangerous and hostile and thus moved civil society within the political system to another value category: out of the essential, emancipatory elements of the democratic system, transforming it into an entity that mediates alien values, which are undesirable or even dangerous for the country. That is to say, a kind of categorisation of civic actors began and a distinction was drawn between 'good civic actors' and 'bad civic actors.' Those critical of the government or having international connections were replaced by organisations that provide services and which, apart from professional issues, do not deal with public life, the promotion of democracy or politics; that is, they do not express open criticism of government measures. A new legislation was adopted in 2018 aimed to introduce a special tax for organisations 'supporting immigration.' Following the European Court of Justice ruling, both of the latter legislations had to be withdrawn.

The Transformation of Organised Civil Society

The following section reviews the trajectory of organised civil society in the last 20 years, and especially the impact of post-2010 changes on the structure of civil society. Based on the Central Statistical Office (KSH) annual data collection on non-profit organisations, we can draw the conclusions from the tendencies of the transformation of civil society. The data of the period between 2003 and 2021 are available on the KSH's website and in its publications (KSH, 2024). As already indicated, the data collection of the KSH applies to registered organisations, so non-institutionalised, informal movements and communities are excluded from it; we only have data of them aggregated according to areas of activity. However, since the most significant part of civil society in Hungary is organised civil society—in Bernhard's typology, 'institutionalised' civil society that emerged after the change of regime—the examination of this segment can give an idea of the most important transformations. The data used here are from a survey organised by the KSH each year, based on answers and classifications provided by the organisations themselves. Although the scope of the available dimensions is limited, relying on this data, we are able to examine the time series of the number of organisations, their resources, and the number of employees by activity fields (KSH, 2024). The KSH defines a total of 18 main areas of activity based on the category system of the National Register

of Non-Profit Organisations. The main tendency is that between 2003 and 2011 the number of organisations increased from around 50,000 to a little more than 61,000 and decreased by almost 8% between 2010 and 2021 (to around 56,000). The 18 activity fields are different in their size: the bigger fields, such as culture, sports, leisure, education, and welfare, include more than 4,000 organisations. It is important to note that, even within this group, there are large differences. For example, the number of educational organisations ranged from 8,471 to 11,066, while the number of welfare social care organisations ranged from 4,308 to 5,461 during the period under review. The number of professional and economic interest organisations exceeded 4,000 only in 2004. The least numerous types of organisations (of which there are less than 1,000) are those active in the areas of human rights, economic development, labour, law enforcement, multi-purpose grant distribution, international relations, and politics.

Between 2003 and 2021, there is a change in the number of organisations, differing by activity fields. Between 2003 and 2011, the peak year, the overall number of organisations, i.e. organised civil society increased by 22% and most fields were growing. After 2010–2011, however, these tendencies turned, and an 8% decline in the number of organisations took place, with most of the fields losing more than 8%. The only fields where there is an increase in the number of organisations are sport, culture, and environmental protection, while the arena dedicated to human rights and politics became smaller by more than 40%. This doesn't necessarily mean that the weight of the fields of activity was changing in the same way in terms of the allocation of material resources. We examined the share of resources of potentially conflict-oriented and depoliticised activity fields in order to show the changing balance between them, and to point out the rise of a non-political (not necessarily anti-democratic, but neither explicitly pro-democratic) civil society.

Thus we divided the 18 groups of organisations into two large groups: (1) the group of organisations dealing specifically with advocacy, interest representation, and politics, which are more likely to come into conflict with the state due to their activities, and (2) the group of depolitised organisations typically providing services. We classified the following areas of activity into the first group: Human rights, Environment, Politics, Professional and Economic Advocacy, Multi-Purpose Donation, while into the second group, we included Health, Economic Development and Labour, Protection of Public Security, Culture, Research, International

Table 1 Conflict-oriented and depoliticised spheres of activity

Advocacy, political, conflict-oriented activities	Club-like or service-focused, depoliticised activities
Human rights, Environment, Politics, Professional and Economic Advocacy, Multi-Purpose Donation,	Health, Economic Development and Labour, Protection of Public Security, Culture, Research, International Relations, Education and training, Civil Defence and Firefighting, Sport, Leisure, Social Work, Urban Development, Religious Activities

Source Own compilation

Relations, Education and training, Civil Defence and Firefighting, Sport, Leisure, Social Work, Urban Development, and Religious Activities. Of course, neither group is completely homogeneous, and organisations engaged in other types of activities may be included in both (Table 1).

The same mechanism is also true for the number of organisations: in the period under review, depoliticised organisations accounted for the majority of operating non-profit organisations. In 2003, 13,5% of organisations operated in conflict-oriented areas of activity. At the same time, this proportion gradually decreased: in 2010 it was 12,4%, while in 2021, only 9,8% of organisations belonged to this group. Examining financial resources, the change appears even much more drastic. While in 2003 organisations operating in conflict-oriented areas of activity accounted for 30% of the total revenue, in 2021 this proportion became 13%. The decline is continuous, although not entirely uni-directional, and it was accelerated after 2016 (see Gerő & Kerényi, 2020).

To explore the financial situation of organisations, we consider it appropriate to operate with the average resources per organisation. For a year-to-year comparability, we examine the 2003 value of the organisations' resources, based on the CSOs' total consumer price index. Revenues for the whole sector declined compared to 2003 and then started to rise in the last few years. In general, however, the average revenue per organisation in each area stagnates rather than increases. That is, typically, an increase or decrease in revenue usually moves together with a change in the number of organisations. The most spectacular change occurred in the area of sports organisations, where revenues have grown drastically. This is obviously due to the sports funding rules introduced in

recent years and the subsidies given to sports organisations under various titles. By 2018, revenue per organisation increased 2.5 times compared to 2003, while the number of organisations has also been steadily increasing.

In other areas, where the decline of the number of organisations was observed, there are controversial tendencies. While there is a drastic increase in revenue in health care, revenues of multi-purpose donor organisations suffered a drastic decline in 2014, in the year of the attack of the Norwegian Civil Fund, although their revenue was growing even a couple years earlier. For the next period, the government no longer concluded an agreement with the Norwegian Fund, so the support did not reach the organisations dealing with its distribution. In the areas of human rights, politics, and professional and economic advocacy, the changing environment led to a concentration of resources and, on average, an increase in revenue of the organisations. Thus, larger, more professional organisations were able to increase their revenues.

The fact that conflict-oriented organisations lost resources and members compared to depoliticised organisations, which grew relatively and —in some cases—in absolute numbers as well, signals that there are at least three parallel processes going on in the Hungarian organised civil society, due to the changing environment after 2010. First of all, we can identify a shrinking space for conflict-oriented organisations, or as Krizsán and Rogebband (2021) put it, a selective closure: domestic opportunities for critical organisations are closed, while—in financial terms—there is an opening up for loyal or apolitical organisations. Our analysis shows that a selective closure applies to smaller circles of organisations as well. Recent studies also confirm how the revenue based on governmental support has increased for a number of organisations promoting the government's family policies, while more confrontative feminist or women's right organisations were shut out from funding opportunities and consultation processes. The price to be paid in exchange, of course, is a dependency on the state and, consequently, loyalty towards the government (Kapitány, 2019; Krizsán & Roggeband, 2021; Szikra et al., 2020).

The second process we have outlined is the concentration of resources on activity fields affected by the 'shrinking space' policy of the government. The decreasing number of organisations and the concentration of resources imply that larger, more professional organisations tend to survive the hostile environment, while smaller organisations might descale or terminate their activity (Gerő et al., 2020, 2022; Petri & Hruskó,

2023). This goes hand in hand with the third phenomenon identified: the proliferation of presumably loyal, typically right-wing organisations. While the data cited above is clear about the proliferation of sport and culture organisations, research also reveals the strong role of local organisations led by the local elites (Kovách, 2020).

At the policy-making level, the government tended to neglect organisations critical to its positions, while—albeit in an ad-hoc manner—it still consults with civil society organisations in certain areas. In family policy, the government adopted the ideas of Victim Care Centers, originally raised by feminist organisations (naturally, the government claims to be the owner of the idea as well) (Szikra & Vajda, 2020). It showed relative openness during the Ukrainian refugee crisis as well, even adopting new legislation to address several problems, which arose mainly due to the lack of preparedness of the infrastructure. Therefore, in fact, the government had to rely on civil society to aid the refugees fleeing from the war in Ukraine (Zakariás et al., 2023). In the field of Roma inclusion or child poverty, the government also relied on various, mostly religious organisations, such as the Malta Charity, the Reformed and Baptist Charities (Ragadics, 2019). Thus, overall, there have been significant, substantial changes, which, however, vary by activity fields. The next section mainly deals with the question of how these changes are associated with changes in protest activities.

Protest Activities: Repertoires, Issues, and Organisations

To review the change in dynamics of protest events, we relied on protest event data based on the events registered with the Police. In principle, based on Act III of 1989 on the Freedom of Assembly, and the law replacing this in 2018 (Act of 2018 on the Freedom of Assembly), events falling under the effect of the law have to be registered with the Police. The Police keep these records for two years. We aggregated monthly data for the period between 2005 and 2010, while Susánszky et al. (2020) worked with similar data referring to later periods. It is important to note that not all of the registered events are protests but also other types of events held in public spaces (commemorations, cultural events, etc.). Even though the data is sporadic, we were able to detect several profound changes in the second half of the 2000s. In 2006, the year of the political scandal related to the leaking of PM Gyurcsány's speech in Őszöd, the

number of events rose to 6981, compared to the previous year's 2863. In the next few years, the number of registered events slowly returned to around 2000. Data from the second half of the 2000s shows a similar frequency, and thus, it seems there were around 2000 events (Susánszky et al., 2020).

Representative surveys also confirm the relatively stable participatory tendencies of the Hungarian population. For example, the European Social Survey measures protest activities in every two years since its first round in 2002. The questionnaire asks the participants whether they participated in any of the following actions: signed a petition, took part in a lawful demonstration, or boycotted certain products. Participation in each of the three forms peaks at 6 or 7% in 2009/2010, while the average is around 3–5%. Thus if there is any tendency, it is a small decline in the late 2010s.

Tendencies appear more surprising when protest activities are examined by political orientation. Between 2002 and 2010, people affiliated with the right scale of the political spectrum participated in protest activities to a much larger extent than people on the centre or even on the left, similarly to other countries in the region (Borbáth & Gessler, 2020). In 2010, when Fidesz seized power, this tendency changed after a brief period of balance, and people on the left side of the scale mobilised to a greater extent. Nevertheless, while people on the left (or in the opposition) are now more likely to participate in protests, the constituency of Fidesz is much better organised than any of the challengers of the incumbent (Gerő & Szabó, 2024).

Protest Activities, 2002–2010

The tendencies mentioned above shed light on some developments characterising the tendencies in the field of social movements and protests in Hungary in the last two decades. As mentioned above, Viktor Orbán announced and urged the establishment of the so-called Civic Circles after the electoral loss of Fidesz in 2002, which also marked the transformation of Fidesz into a movement party. The civic circles built on local non-political and religious organisations and communities quickly absorbed 100,000–150,000 people (Enyedi, 2005; Greskovits, 2020).

Besides the Fidesz-led movements, there were two other important types of protest activities. First, the early millennium was characterised by grassroots activism with environmental mobilizations (such as the protest

at the Zengő Hill or the Critical Mass in larger cities). Later, partly the success of these activities led to the birth of the green party, LMP (Politics Can Be Different), which was able to enter the Parliament in 2010 and stay there for three consecutive cycles.

The second important protest series was the mobilisation by the extreme right. The scandal in 2006 gave momentum to extreme-right organisations and groups, which was channelled by the extreme right party, Jobbik (Movement for a Better Hungary) (Tóth & Grajczjár, 2015). In 2007, Jobbik established a 'paramilitary' wing to the party, named the Hungarian Guards. The Guards, making various references to the Nazi Cross-Arrow party of the 1940s, organised a series of violent marches and used excessively racist language in villages where there were ethnic tensions, in order to intimidate the Roma people (Varga, 2014).

Protest Activities After 2010

After 2010, the Hungarian protest scene changed significantly, starting with the legislative changes initiated by Fidesz, now governing with a supermajority, meaning that since 2010, it has been able to pass any law at any time, with or without the opposition. After the passing of legislative packages in 2011—with overall changes concerning the Constitution, the media law, the law on civil society, several symbolic measures and others involving direct institutional and legislative changes furthermore the amendment of the Labour Code (with serious limitations, among others, of the strike law, which has been seen as an essential achievement of the regime change), the adoption of a new civil law (virtually excluding the civil sphere from decision-making) and of a new media law (Bánkuti et al., 2012; Kovács & Trencsényi, 2020)—a series of opposition protests with tens of thousands of participants took place in large cities in early 2012. Based on the number and types of protest events in this period, reflecting on the changing political landscape after 2010, we classified the protest activities into four major categories: those concerned with democracy, with education, mobilizations focused on labour, and pro-governmental activities. Due to the overlap in agents and issues, the democracy category cannot be entirely separated from the other categories. Nevertheless, we specified a group of collective action focusing primarily on issues explicitly addressing democracy. Due to the limitations of this text, we elaborate in detail only one case, the issue of education,

since we believe that it best represents the tendencies of collective action in shrinking spaces, and also because it is well researched and connects to all the other issues.

Democracy

Within the first group, we classified a series of events, which primarily targeted the government, and mobilizations that focused on democracy or the democracy deficit within the legislation, the media, related to the freedom of speech, or concerning other areas. These were predominantly anti-government protests organised by various agents: parties, grassroots movements, or other types of organisations, from NGOs to unions. The main issues were the freedom of the media and the constitutional changes. The first massive street demonstrations took place right after the change of government in 2010, to protest against changing the media law. A protest movement called One Million for the Freedom of Speech emerged as a loose network of organisations and actors, staging relatively large protests (with tens of thousands participants) around the media, also including other topics. Another wave of events were focusing on the Constitutional changes with the slogan, 'The Constitution is not a game.' The largest protest, with cca 70,000 people according to media reports, took place on the 2nd of January 2012. While the media protests were a series of large protests, usually organised on national Holidays (Bozóki, 2012), the constitutional change attracted a mass this large only once. Otherwise, protests revolving around the rule of law, the Constitution, etc. were attended by only a few thousand people (Bozóki, 2012; Hinsey, 2012).

Interestingly though, the largest demonstration took place against the initiative of the taxation of the Internet in 2014 (Mikecz, 2023a), proving to be successful as the proposal was later withdrawn. Further protests that made claims for democracy took place around 2017—these were the demonstrations organised by NGOs gathered in an informal network called Civilization, mobilising against the act on the so-called foreign funded organisations, which aimed to intimidate organisations receiving a certain amount of funding from a foreign agency (Mikecz, 2023a).

The problems targeting democracy also included the issue of academic freedom. In 2017, tens of thousands of protesters organised through petitions and mass demonstrations, when the government made amendments in the law on higher education that basically forced the Central European University out of Hungary. The issue was symbolic owing to the

government's narrative against philanthropist George Soros, founder of the university, and at the same time a key figure targeted by the hate speech of Fidesz against 'foreign agents' acting against national interests. Notwithstanding the CEU-protests, overall, it seems, that 'democracy' as an issue had a mobilising potential mainly in the first 3–4 years of the newly developing regime.

Education

Education has been a recurring topic of the protest arena in the last 14 years. Although undergraduate and higher education have been addressed separately in protests, and there are different movements evolving around them, we considered both as they reflect on the same structural problems. Both in the case of public and higher education, the first mass protests were organised by political parties. For example, the transformation of higher education in 2011 was addressed by a protest organised by opposition parties, while there were phases when students were more active, or when the employees of educational institutions took initiative. First, we discuss the movement focusing on higher education and then we turn to undergraduate public education.

Student movements are among the best documented and studied social movements in Hungary (Éber, 2018; Gerő & Susánszky, 2014; Susánszky & Gerő, 2014; Szabó & Oross, 2017). The student movement gained momentum in the early 2010s, when the newly emerging Student Network (HaHa) dynamised student organisations and student representation. The Student Network could be considered not only a challenger of government policy but also of the establishment of student representation, the National Conference of Student Self-Governments (HÖOK) and its predecessors, which were dominant in the field of student representation. The HÖOK and its members (university and faculty level student autonomies) have a status guaranteed by the law of higher education, and resources sufficient to build up a relatively large, bureaucratic organisation and to remunerate, to some extent, those working in it at various levels.

This was the context in which the Student Network emerged in 2011. The specific reason for the formation of the Network was the leak of government plans for higher education. The news of the closure of Corvinus University of Budapest, followed by plans to introduce tuition fees and so-called student contracts, caused indignation among students. Since they felt that HÖOK was not representing them, a group of students

started to organise a new, more dynamic representative body for students. The Network took a decentralised form, made up of various, initially loosely connected groups. The actions in 2011 and 2012 (such as the occupation of a lecture hall in the University Square of ELTE in the so-called Last Open Day) were organised by the founders, who were mainly students from Budapest. In parallel, groups from other cities (notably Szeged) and later on other non-Budapest groups also joined in by organising protests. The student forum organised in December 2012 led to the spontaneous occupation of a bridge in Budapest and also a spontaneous march throughout the inner city, marking the beginning of the most active phase of the Student Network and the student movement. It is noteworthy that when the visibility and mobilising power of the Student Network as a challenger grew to utmost visibility, suggesting that the movement might have an impact on government policies, HÖOK sought to emphasise the alliance between the two organisations (Gerő, 2013).

At the same time, HÖOK tried to maintain its partnership with the government and to act as an organisation capable of representing the demands raised by the more dynamic new movement (Szabó & Oross, 2017). The Student Network established the National Higher Education Consultative Forum and demanded negotiations with the government. As a response, the government set up the Higher Education Round Table, to which it invited only a few actors, such as the HÖOK, but excluded the Student Network from the discussions. The difficulties of institutionalisation, the lack of resources, and the disappearance of the possibility to directly influence public policy eroded the commitment of the Network's members (Susánszky & Gerő, 2014), which led to the slow decay and eventual dissolution of the Student Network. However, a small group of members acted as carriers of protest know-how: they provided information on the access of tools and gave advice about the strategy of new actors later on, at a time when the government decided to close down a number of university units. University teachers and students at Eötvös Loránt University protested against the decision, with the help of former Student Network members, and they were able to achieve partial success.

A third phase of protests arrived with the transformation of the higher education system in 2020–2021. The government initiated the quasi-privatisation of most of the universities between 2019 and 2021, which meant that the Parliament established new public asset management foundations as the maintainers of institutions that acted as owners, meaning they received the property, including buildings and equipment, as well

as all the rights, that is, everything associated with the given university. Some of them received extra property, too, such as stocks of the Hungarian Oil Company (MOL). By the end of 2021, with the exception of a few universities, the Hungarian higher education institutions were turned into private institutions, with politicians and government loyalists on board. Despite formal structures for negotiation, resistance was scarce and mainly took place as individual actions or, as in the case of the Teacher's Network, targeting the Hungarian public rather than the government. Probably the main impact of the quasi-privatisation on collective action was strengthening trade unions in the HE sector: active groups of the Higher Education Workers' Union and the Democratic Trade Union of Teachers were formed at several universities, such as Corvinus, ELTE or the University of Pécs.

Interestingly enough, the topics of higher education and public education were interconnected only in the public discourse and only during the first wave of protests organised by the Student Network and its allies. High school students were also protesting at the time, and the Network of High-school Students was formed (Gerő, 2013). Although this organisation did not exist for long, in 2014 a new organisation was established, the Independent Student Parliament. This organisation was founded by high school students, and on the basis of earlier critiques of the institution of the National Student Parliament, originally intended to raise the level of public education's student representation to the national level. The National Student Parliament faced much criticism before 2010, but the Fidesz government emptied the institution further. To address this problem, students created an independent, democratically elected body of representation, meeting two-three times a year Although initially the movement worked quite separately from other movements, in 2015–1017, when movements were more active, local (school-level and town-level) student autonomies were politicised, which was reflected in the Independent Student Parliament as well (Csákó & Sebestyén, 2017). Teachers' trade unions were also protesting since the beginning of the 2010s. The time of the first protests in education, with approximately 3000 participants in June 2011 against the centralisation of public education. However, the movement on education gained momentum only in 2016, when alternative organisations were formed: the Tanítanék (I would like to Teach) movement and the Civil platform on Public Education. These organisations, together with trade unions, organised the first

mass protest on March 15, 2016, and later organised further demonstrations. Even though the quality of education was a frequently discussed topic in the 2000s and the early 2010s as well, movements of students and teachers gained impetus in 2016 only. In this period, symbols of the movements were born: the checked shirt and the umbrella, which gave identity to the movements.

Labour Issues

We identified labour issues as the focus of a third type of protests, which are partly also connected to anti-government mobilizations, but nevertheless represent issues on their own. Workers' movements, and in particular unions, were rather weak after the regime change: unions lost prestige as they were seen as relics of the past (Meszmann & Szabó, 2023), and were continuously losing membership and representation, which only became more radical with the enforcement of the new Labour Code in 2012 (Neumann et al., 2013). However, some sectors started to organise around 2016, such as the teachers' unions, backed by non-institutional groups and networks, with the support of tens of thousands of protesters. The protest, which became famous, like the already mentioned I would like to teach movement, mobilised teachers, parents and high school students as well as anti-government actors all across the country, with demonstrations and strikes at several schools. The movement continued in 2022, when the so-called Status Law was passed, which further weakened the autonomy of schools and secondary school teachers, prescribed them additional working hours and limited their freedom.

The workers' strikes were successfully organised not only among the white collar unions, but also in a specific area of factory workers—the unions of the car industry. This sector is sensitive and special due to Hungary's exposure to the German car industry (brands like Mercedes, VW, and Audi), which made them key players in the Hungarian economy (Gagyi & Gerőcs, 2019). The story is of course more complex and controversial, since Orbán gained political capital by emphasising Hungary's independence from 'the West.' The protests followed the passing of the Overtime Act in 2018, known by its popular name as the Slave Law, which favoured employers' interests, seriously restricting workers' rights by enabling them to work overtime, while getting paid with a delay of up to three years. The issue became a symbolic one first of all within the industry, which was a great achievement of the workers'

movement, since it aligned unions across the traditional political cleavages. The alliance was visible not only in the declarations and the fact that even right-wing unions condemned the new proposal, but also in the mobilisations. The protests went beyond the unions' mobilisations and involved oppositional parties, NGOs, students, and different citizens' groups, thus escalating in a series of demonstrations against the government in the end of 2018 and in 2019, with tens of thousands of people demonstrating in the streets (IndustriAll, 2018).

Pro-government Demonstrations

After 2010, the main right-wing demonstrations were organised by the Civic Alliance Forum (CAF). CAF is an organisation run by members of the political community close to Fidesz, or even by Fidesz members. The organisation has two main functions: to nurture a pro-government network thus framing civic life and to organise mass demonstrations, from time to time, to prove that Fidesz has a massive popular support.

Although the foundation of CAF took place in 2009, the largest demonstration it organised was after 2010. The main strategy was not to organise frequent demonstrations, but to ensure a large number of participants. Thus, between 2010 and 2024, CAF organised ten Peace Marches, the first one as early as on 21st of January 2012, to support the Constitutional change. Most of the other demonstrations were organised on national holidays commemorating the revolutions of 1848 and 1956, respectively, taking place on the 15th of March or on the 23rd of October. A frequent choreography is a march to the Parliament or another symbolic location in Budapest, where, at the point of arrival, Viktor Orbán delivers a speech. It is hard to tell the actual number of participants, but usually it is between 50 thousand and two–three hundred thousand people, according to news reports. The main difference between anti-government demonstrations and Peace Marches is the political affiliation of the participants and their media consumption, which tends to be more reliant on the public media and pro-government newspapers in the case of the latter (Susánszky et al., 2016). Probably, the share of participants arriving from the capital is smaller here than in the case of protests organised by independent social movements or the opposition. Altogether the Peace Marches and the organising movement can be considered a centralised continuation of the Civic Circles (Metz, 2015). Pro-government protests are centralised: besides the Peace Marches, it is rare that other actors organise collective action in support of the government.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we discussed the ways in which civil society and social movements responded to the structural changes in the democratic system brought about by an autocratising actor, Fidesz, under the leadership of Viktor Orbán. We argued that the distinction between organised civil society (seen as integrative) and social movements (seen as disruptive) is unnecessary, and the exact repertoire of actors depends on the political context.

The political context can be defined partly by regime-type, but more specifically, governmental policies towards civil society. While in the pre-2010 period the government was mainly supportive towards NGOs, there was a radical change in the relationship of civil society and the state after 2010. The harassment of civil society organisations involves a range of tools. In public communication, the stigmatisation of non-governmental organisations in Hungary has intensified to an unprecedented extent. As a result, organisations that were previously active in public life were completely excluded from decision-making processes, and in repetitive campaigns, presented as agents of foreign powers. This fits into the narrative that began to brand NGOs as dangerous and hostile, and thus moved civil society to another value category within the political system: no longer considered an essential, emancipatory element of the democratic system but an entity that mediates alien values, and is therefore undesirable and even dangerous for the country. In this new context, the characteristics of civil society were also changing: with autocratisation, the weight of organisations not committed to democratic values increased, while organisations critical towards the government, trying to defend the remaining democratic institutions. In the Hungarian context, it seems that the changing political context, namely the development of democracy, followed by autocratisation influenced civil society and social movements in the following ways. (1) Among democratic circumstances, formal civil society grows and thus becomes more institutionalised. This does not mean that civil society abandons conflict-oriented activities but—at least in the Hungarian context—organisations apply more transactional than participatory means. (2) The social movement and civil society literature claiming that protest participation is low overlooks right-wing activism in the 2000s. This activism, in the Hungarian case, is largely organised by political parties: mainly Fidesz and Jobbik. (3) Autocratisation tendencies promote large waves of protests and the birth of new

social movements, thus creating a 'firewall civil society,' as Bernhard (2020) argues. However, the fields of formal organisations and especially human rights, political, and grant-distributing organisations suffer great losses in terms of the number and resources of organisations. These organisations also need more time to engage in participatory action, and thus, they do not really contribute to the organising of movements. (4) However, the framing work of movements might also help these organisations to increase their social embeddedness.

Autocratisation transforms right-wing or pro-government movements as well: instead of clearly party-organised movements, we see that a seemingly independent actor organises centralised, large events in support of the government. Besides describing the transformation of civil society, we aimed to challenge the notion that Hungarian civil society is mainly characterised by transactional activism. We think that the results of the seminal study of Petrova and Tarrow (2007) were overgeneralised. First, as our data shows, protest activities (considered as participatory activism) characterised right-wing movements dominated by right-wing parties. Although democratic institutions were in a better shape before than after 2010, Fidesz and, to a smaller extent, Jobbik, as well as other right-wing groups successfully nurtured the notion of the illegitimacy of the ruling socialist-liberal government, and the political and economic crises of the 2000s served as a trigger to mobilise these relatively well organised citizens.

Second, our research does not consider the changes in the regime: after 2010, left-oriented, and oppositional protesters dominated the streets (although there has been significant pro-government mobilisation from time to time as well), and also CSOs that cannot apply transactional activism successfully and turn towards more participatory means. Maybe a specific tendency in Hungary is that issues of protests represent a shift from general matters concerning the transformation of the system, towards particular policies and labour issues, which have become the core topics of these movements. Although in a centralised regime everything is 'political,' thus anything can be considered critical towards the regime; it seems that most of these movements try to refrain from formulating an overall critique of the system and mainly focus on certain public policies.

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North Macedonia—Two Sides of the Same Coin Pleading for Democratisation from Below

Ivan Stefanovski

Protests have been omnipresent in North Macedonia before and after the country's independence in 1991, following the dissolution of Yugoslavia. However, the frequency of protest and other contentious actions have largely intensified from 2014 onwards, as numerous actors voiced their grievances against the ruling of former Prime Minister (PM) Nikola Gruevski. Actions which were at that time directed against a ruling largely described as a regime and captured state (Auerbach & Kartner, 2023), provided space and opportunities for larger anti-government protests even after the shift in power perceived as an entry point towards re-democratisation of the Macedonian society. In this regard, this contribution looks at four larger protest waves between 2015 marked by the offspring of the Citizens for Macedonia platform (CfM) and the mobilisation against the so-called French Proposal in 2022, i.e. the country's framework for starting negotiations with the European Union.

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Following a theoretical approach mostly based on Political Opportunity Structure (POS), this work looks into the complex relations between social movements, political parties and state institutions, and how social movement outcomes in Macedonia are largely dependent on this entangled relationship. Combining social movement literature (della Porta & Diani, 2020; Tilly & Tarrow, 2015; Bieber & Brentin, 2018, etc.) with works on (de)democratisation (Huntington, 1991; Levitsky & Way, 2002; Zakaria, 1997, etc.), this work analyses the oscillation of democratic processes and the plea for a better society for all. At the core of this analysis lay the interactions between contentious actors and their friends and foes.

From a methodological perspective, the reconstruction of the main events will follow a variant of process tracing analysis, emphasising critical junctures such as the coalition building between social movements and political parties during the CfM mobilisation, the pardon by former President of the republic George Ivanov which triggered the Colourful Revolution (CR), the referendum for the change of the constitutional name of the country in 2018, as well as the protests against the "French Proposal" which marked 2022. This analysis is mostly based on Qualitative Discourse Analysis (QDA) of news articles accessible through online news generators, interviews with numerous stakeholders gathered during previous research, as well as participant observation.

The introduction looks at a brief history of the dynamics between movements and other actors, as well as key moments in the country's recent political history, followed by a presentation of the structure of the chapter, and the selection of cases. The next section provides insights into the reasons behind the data collection and methodological approaches used in order to present the relationship between various actors. The following section summarises the state of the art regarding social movements and power, with emphasis on North Macedonia, looking at what other recent works have highlighted and how this chapter could potentially fill the existing voids by bridging social movements and democratisation literature. The central part of this work provides a holistic presentation of the key actors and events from several protest waves between 2014 and 2022, looking at critical junctures which triggered and/or shaped the outcomes of these mobilisations. The common denominator of all analysed mobilisations is their anti-governmental character, amid their profound ideological differences. The final part of the chapter provides conclusions and key takeaways regarding the relationship

between protest and power, and identifies the potential steps forward for analysing social movements and contentious politics in North Macedonia.

Democratisation Versus Competitive Authoritarianism—A Cyclical Dilemma?

Following the dissolution of Yugoslavia and the creation of the new independent states, many dreamt of societies resembling the Western European model democracies. Expectations were raised even higher following the end of the armed conflicts in the region marked with the signing of the Ohrid Framework Agreement (OFA) in 2001, following the internal conflict between the Macedonian security forces and the UÇK. However, the rather fragile peace in the region, which is constantly put to test in almost all Balkan countries, with Kosovo and Serbia being the frontrunners, probably resulted more with competitive authoritarianism rather than stable and durable democratic episodes? More than two decades ago, Levitsky and Way (2002, p. 52) defined competitive authoritarian regimes as polities where "formal democratic institutions are widely viewed as the principal means of obtaining and exercising political authority…" where "…Incumbents violate those rules so often and to such an extent, however, that the regime fails to meet conventional minimum standards for democracy". Bieber and Brentin (2018) took a step forward in contextualising these patterns of competitive authoritarianism in the Western Balkans (WB) by arguing that in the early 1990s countries in the WB dominantly fostered pure competitive authoritarian regimes blending multi-party elections, nationalist rhetoric and privatisation of state-owned capital, which was followed by a democratic glimmer of hope at the beginning of the new millennium. However, by the end of the decade (2010s) authoritarian practices slowly creeped back and remained in place in many of the countries. However, objectively so, Bieber (ibid., pp. 337–8) argues that today's forms of competitive authoritarianism are different, and largely based on the newly formed democratic institutions' weak transformative powers, as well as the insufficient engagement of external powers, primarily the European Union (EU). North Macedonia is a stark example of an "oscillating democracy", or a polity constantly moving back and forth between democracy and authoritarianism, with scores/values of certain democratic processes shifting and changing throughout the years. In my previous work I have also labelled Macedonian society as being in a state of "shallow democracy" (Meghian, 2001, p. 297; Stefanovski, 2016)

characterised by significant economic deprivation, violation of human rights, accompanied by impunity and a functional legal state based on rule of law principles.

The mobilisations depicted further in this work are largely based on pleas for "more" or "better" democracy in its widest and most general meaning. The four cases are characterised by being anti-governmental, and accusatory to incumbents of power which have allegedly failed to listen and respond to citizens' needs. The four examples also tend to present small steps being taken back and forth in relation to particular democratic processes, further emphasising the democratic uncertainty in which Macedonian society has been lingering in the past decade. The relationship between protest and power, or between governmental challengers, state institutions and other important societal actors operate within peculiar political opportunity structures which open and close as a result of critical junctures which act both as triggers of protest, but also to a large extent shape movement outcomes. Through a political process approach favoured by Tilly (2008) and Tarrow (2011) and largely based on mechanisms and processes composed of different combination of sequences, I argue that relationships between political parties and more traditional social movement actors, paired with the mechanism of international intervention are critical for social movement outcomes in North Macedonia, furthermore, significantly important for societal steps taken in the direction of democracy or competitive authoritarianism respectively.

Based on data largely gathered through qualitative discourse analysis of in-depth interviews with several categories of interviewees such as protest organisers, activists, key informants, politicians, and news articles presenting in-depth description of contentious actions, this work aims to deconstruct the political processes behind the four mobilisations and to delve deeper into the relationship between key movement actors. The main intent behind the case selection was to look at contemporary protest waves, at the same time securing a temporal vacuum which leaves sufficient time and space for a more objective analysis of the processes. In regard to the size and strength of the mobilisations, these protests were by far the largest, but also the most politically significant and socially relevant. One must underline that prior and after the analysed period, Macedonian society witnessed many mobilisations regarding various topics such as privatisation of state-owned capital, healthcare, and improving workers' rights through trade union activism. However, the political and policy relevance of these protests can be deemed largely insignificant compared

to the four selected cases. Furthermore, it was important to choose cases which are anti-governmental in their substance, but come from both sides of the ideological spectrum, thus trying to evade ideological bias, and try to decrease the limitations of the study which are present and cannot be fully eliminated. However, it is important to mention that this text looks only at several aspects of the analysed movements, applying the conceptual lens of POS and based on a political process mechanistic approach. Other theoretical and methodological approaches will surely provide results and takeaways which will vary largely in comparison to what has been presented in this chapter.

Before looking at the peculiarities of the four cases, it is important to set the stage by presenting the scope conditions being omnipresent and influencing the mobilisations in the background, often playing the role of triggers of protest, activating the mechanisms of mobilisation, understood in the sense of increase of available resources to political actor(s) for collective claims-making (Tilly & Tarrow, 2015, p. 120). Linz and Stepan (1996), which looked at problems of democratic transition and consolidation in several parts of the world, including post-communist Europe, argue that scope conditions are mostly entangled between three important types or sets of variables: the international influences, the political economy of coercion and legitimacy, and the special legacies of totalitarian and post-totalitarian regimes (p. 236). In this vein, the Macedonian society, as well as several other societies in the region, faced systemic deficiencies linked to competitive authoritarianism, such as significantly high levels of unemployment, especially among the younger population; a process of privatisation of state-owned capital which was largely deemed as a failure due to the unequal, unjust and often criminal redistribution of wealth; a media landscape trapped in a malign triad of business, crime and politics as well as rampant corruption spearheaded by systemic abuse of power (Stefanovski, 2019). These conditions individually, or oftentimes in combination, largely influenced mobilisation against power structures in the four cases of interest.

Citizens for Macedonia (2015)

The Citizens for Macedonia (CfM) platform did not emerge without prior notice. It was preceded by student protests, opposition boycotts, freelance workforce revolt and other challenges that had been targeted by power structures (Stefanovski, 2016), oftentimes without any substantial

reason, but rather a systemic inability to accommodate basic grievances. The CfM "formalised" a coalition between established political parties, non-governmental organisations, academics, journalists as well as students and informal groups of activists (ibid., p. 401). Building on previous contentious episodes, the CfM played the role of an umbrella which wanted to unify all actors in opposition to the ruling of former PM Nikola Gruevski. SDSM, the largest political party in opposition at that time, seized the moment of accumulated dissatisfaction to unite multiple societal actors. However, these movement actors were everything but homogenic. Bearing in mind the diversity of the movement actors and the different ideological positions, grievances and goals, one would arguably expect a fluctuating and unstable relationship which varies throughout the duration of the protest activities. These expectations largely materialised. Large divisions were frequently happening between political party members and civil society activists. Regarding many issues, especially the political negotiations, the two categories of challengers had different attitudes, positions and expectations. For example, a significant number of political party members saw the Przhino Agreement as a victory, unlike many activists. As one of the activists had put it in early 2016 "…from today's distance, I think that the opposition came out as a loser, and that Macedonia is in general—the loser. If we could somehow measure that, I think that we lost much more than we gained. The energy from the May 17 protest was worth much more than we got…" (INT 2, 2016). However, in the end, another interviewee reflected on the coalescing for the greater cause "…so we have a common enemy, we have an evil which is terrorizing us, and we should get rid of our personal frustrations and vanities, and we should sit together, and create a joint strategy…" (INT 2, 2015). To some extent, that had happened. Without bridging the main differences between various movement actors, the CfM platform would have remained an unrealised political endeavour.

Another unifying element for the different movement actors were the main grievances and the claims-making process asserted through the numerous repertoires of contention. Having in mind the dire state of democracy and governance at the time, as noted in several key documents such as the "Priebe Report" (EC, 2015) and the EU Commission country reports from 2015 (EU Commission, 2015) and 2016 (EU Commission, 2016), a plethora of grievances had been communicated by movement actors. Clustering them into more general categories, one could say that

emphasis was put on abuse of state power, deteriorated media freedoms, widespread corruption and economic hardship (Stefanovski, 2019, pp. 58–65). Zooming in closer into a Political Claim Analysis (PCA) based on two daily newspapers, protesters mostly put forward resignation claims towards politicians in power, had an anti-governmental standpoint and were continuously advocating for rule of law and protection of human rights (ibid., p. 129). Speaking to movement actors, the resignation of the government was always the central and key demand. All other grievances were closely linked to the resignation of the government per se. Although this analysis is largely based on a political process approach which emphasises the openness of the POS, the claims-making process should be factored in as possibly influencing the political outcomes. This is of strong importance, mainly because varieties and types of claims can have a substantial effect over types of challengers which were mobilised (Snow et al., 1986; Tarrow, 2011) as well as the number of protesters participating, which eventually had a strong impact on the movement outcomes (Stefanovski, 2019, p. 12).

One of the key critical junctures shaping the initiation and the outcome of the movement was the release of the wiretapped conversations by former Macedonian Prime Minister (PM) Zoran Zaev. Several key events and developments, some acting as critical junctures influencing movement outcomes, deserve to be at the heart of the analysis due to their importance and relevance. Drawing from the energy that had been generated through the student movement supported by a significant portion of their professors, the #Protestiram (#IProtest) group, which has later been at the core of the Colourful Revolution as well, and the "Stop Police Brutality" movement which was sparked by the murder of the young Martin Neshkovski, dating from earlier, the CfM was promoted during the large rally on May 17. The rally was transformed into a two-month-long occupation in front of the Government resulting with the "Camp of Freedom" as well as the numerous activities which were organised throughout the two months in the camp. Drawing on accumulation of resources, the challengers managed to activate two crucial mechanisms for contention—brokerage and diffusion. Brokerage is understood as a "production of a new connection between previously unconnected sites" (Tilly & Tarrow, 2015, p. 31), which is evident in the CfM platform, while diffusion refers to the "spread of a form of contention, an issue, or a way of framing" (ibid.), another mechanism which is more evident in the transition from the CfM to the CR, which as movements substantially nurtured similar

claims and values. As time passed by and movement activities proceeded, several other critical points occurred. Well-informed interlocutors highlighted the arrival of Assistant State Secretary of State for European and Eurasian affairs Victoria Nuland to Skopje on July 13. On the way to her meeting with PM Gruevski, she was welcomed by the activists in front of the government, who had waved placards and chanted "No Justice, No Peace", "No Compromise with Crime and Corruption", "Return the Money" and "Freedom and Democracy". As a background tune, protesters played on loudspeaker parts of the previously mentioned wiretapped conversations. Immediately following this meeting, the Przhino Negotiations were completed, and the protracted political crisis was partially toned down. The leaders of the four biggest parties at that time in the Macedonian political arena—VMRO-DPMNE, SDSM, DUI and DPA, on June 2 signed the political agreement known as the Przhino Agreement, foreseeing participation of the opposition SDSM in the government, the early resignation of PM Nikola Gruevski in early 2016, and a caretaker government which would organise the next parliamentary elections. Probably most important at that time, the agreement contained provisions for the creation of the Special Prosecutors Office (SPO) which led the investigations related to the potential crimes stemming from the wiretapping scandal (Euractiv, 2015). This deal facilitated by the EU was subject to several versions, lastly being signed on July 15 (Annex to the Przhino Agreement, 2015 and Protocol to the Przhino Agreement, 2015). This is one of the more relevant examples of the mechanism of international intervention, oftentimes very important for shaping the outcomes of political processes in the region (Stefanovski, 2019, pp. 223–224). One should not infer that the international community was the sole shaper of the political outcomes, but it undoubtedly played a pivotal role. Interviewees spoke with a great deal of certainty about the movement's substantial role in influencing political party leaders and the international community while drafting the final provisions of the agreement. Their impression is that parts of civil society substantially influenced segments of the international community: "regarding the external…the international community, EU and the others which are involved in this process, there was a significant influence by the NGOs…" (IV 1, 2015), "…I think they (CSOs, I.S.) dominantly influenced the international community, because they had extensive meetings with international community representatives and they listened to their arguments…" (IV 2, 2015), "…the civil society, which is traditionally…this civil society, which organized these

activities… is traditionally pro-European and pro-American…because they are their main donors…they had blogs, op-eds, statements, or attitudes which were directly communicated and through which they pressured the international community…" (IV 3, 2015), "…in the initial phase, in that first phase, especially within this informal coalition, now I am referring to that period somewhere…March–April, on the eve of the May 17 protest, the civil society exerted much greater pressure over the international community in comparison with the political parties…" (IV 4, 2015).

The CfM movement is a relevant study-case in terms of generating policy outputs and policy outcomes alike. Distinguishing between the two concepts, policy outputs are referred to as formal changes of laws, bylaws and other forms of erga omnes legal acts, while policy outcomes embody the implementation and the political effects of the adopted policy outputs, assessed in relation to the movements' grievances and their accommodation by the political system (Stefanovski, 2019, 5). The policy outputs embodied in the Przhino Agreement and later transliterated in the numerous laws in parliament just set the stage for the policy outcomes discussed later while analysing the CR. This is where the mechanism of political party engagement played a crucial role. However, the undisputedly largest outcome from the CfM platform is the inciting of the 2016 mobilisations per se. Amid general pessimism, isolated cases of activists strongly believed even in late 2015 that the cycles of protest will continue: "…My impression is that the citizen capacity still exists and I think that the real role of the civil society will follow after this situation changes… this means that it will be a long-lasting process…the authority and the power which were built during this period should be used in the future…" (IV 1, 2015).

The Colourful Revolution (2016)

While the CfM set the stage, the Colourful Revolution (CR) culminated in terms of mobilisation potential and capacity, innovative repertoires of contention as well as substantial policy and political outcomes. Unlike the rather formalised actors in the CfM which heavily amounted to registered political parties and civil society organisations, the CR was genuinely citizen-driven, building on the previous #Protestiram networks, sparked by an unlawful action by a high-ranked politician, grew faster and stronger than anyone could imagine at that time. The mechanisms

of brokerage, diffusion, but also coordinated action in the sense of "two or more actors' engagement in mutual signalling and parallel making of claims on the same object" (Tilly & Tarrow, 2015, p. 31) were present at their finest. However, one needs to underline that key actors in the CfM platform have also been protagonists during the CR, primarily political parties in opposition and more prominent NGOs. One university professor and activist said that the name "Colourful Revolution", apart from the colourised repertoires of contention, also refers to the political, ideological, confessional, linguistic and social diversity of the protesters (Jovanovic, 2017), who managed to unite against a common enemy and a joint cause. However, the role of the largest party in opposition—SDSM, cannot be downplayed. Although it was not formally embedded in the protests compared to the CfM platform in 2015, high-party officials were regularly present at the marches beginning every day at 6 p.m. in front of the offices of the SPO. When tensions would occur between citizen and partisan activists, and political parties took a step back, the drop of support in the streets was easily noticeable. From a resource mobilisation theory point of view, in the two analysed contentious episodes the political parties are the resource backbone providing people, logistics and finances. At times more openly, at times in a more secluded manner. In the case of the CR, SDSM and other established political parties in opposition once again proved to be the main resource. This once again reaffirms the importance of the political party engagement mechanism (Stefanovski, 2019, pp. 233–234). As in most liberal, pro-democracy and anti-governmental mobilisations, actors participating in the movement were diverse, representing various groups and channelling a plethora of claims and grievances. Primarily, imposing bottom-up pressure for the demise of the VMRO-DPMNE and DUI government, the movement actors had been able to agree and put forward a structured set of eight (8) main grievances: the urgent revoking of President Ivanov's pardons related to individuals prosecuted by the SPO; an urgent and irrevocable resignation by President Ivanov; a final decision by the Macedonian Constitutional Court regarding the constitutionality of the SPO; creation of a special division/section in the basic criminal court in Skopje which would exclusively judicate cases under the jurisdiction of the SPO; an urgent amendment to the political decision that early general elections will be held on June 5, 2016; mandatory inclusion of independent civil society representatives in the process of solving the political crisis; resolution of the crisis on the territory of Macedonia, and creation of

an interim/technical government which will fully implement the urgent reform priorities outlined in the "Priebe Report" (Colourful Revolution Facebook Page, 2016). By July 21, 2016, half of the pivotal movement claims had been accommodated: President Ivanov withdrew his initial pardons (Georgievski, 2016), the SPO was functional and further unfolding new cases (Akademik, 2017), the parliamentary elections had been postponed for late 2016 (Fokus, 2016) and the "centre of gravity" for solving the political crises had been further shifted towards the Macedonian institutions, albeit the mechanism of international influence had been largely present since 2015, and the wider opposition had largely betted on the international community to facilitate the demise of Gruevski. Looking at the main claims, one could easily notice a rule of law dominance, further amplified by the #НемаПравдаНемаМир (No Justice No Peace) hashtag. However, the economy also played a significant role in the claims-making process. A lot of emphasis was put on criticising the further indebting of the state, which according to the activists, was used to fuel the regime in order to maintain power through clientelism and cronyism.

In addition to the several critical junctures described through the claims-making process in the previous paragraph, one distinct feature of the CR is very contrasting when compared to the CfM—the strong presence of the mechanism of diffusion (Tilly & Tarrow, 2015, p. 31). From a theoretical perspective, diffusion is often linked to contentious actions which are innovative and contain a performative mix of "newness" in order to "generate notice from audiences and the references for audience comprehension to previous repertoires" (Walsh-Russo, 2014, pp. 33–34). Walsh-Russo (2014) provide a comprehensive theoretical overview of diffusion of protest in social movements. In the case of the CR, we can argue that the innovative element lies in the non-standard repertoire of throwing paint at state institutions, monuments and other infrastructure built during the reign of Gruevski. For protesters, this repertoire of contention was appealing for at least two reasons: to ridicule physical objects which according to them had been the symbol of the regime's potency and corruption, as well as to show that they can reclaim power from below by marking their territory. This made diffusion easier, as newly built or renovated state institutions, as well as monuments could be easily found and accessed in almost all larger cities throughout the country. One should also give credit to the mechanism

of political party engagement as well, having in mind their nationwide presence, but it is worth noting that the same political parties in opposition had been very active during the CfM mobilisation as well, arguably with even greater intensity. This diffusion of protest exercised even greater pressure over power holders, and changed the dynamics of the relationship between institutions and challengers. By incrementally gaining small "wins" and additionally expanding political opportunities, the CR eventually managed to secure numerous political, cultural and policy outcomes which are explained below in detail. However, one of the biggest challenges which echoes through Macedonian society is why the path to democratic consolidation was not secured, but another slip towards competitive authoritarianism empowered corruption, lack of trust in state institutions and general societal disenchantment.

Many would argue that the key political outcomes of the CR were the results from the early 2016 parliamentary elections and subsequently the "effective regime change" (Marković & Damjanovski, 2022) in May 2017, when VMRO-DPMNE was voted into opposition amid the violence in parliament which escalated on April 27, 2017. As a protest movement which in continuity opposed government decisions and pleaded for claiming political responsibility, the CR substantially impacted the increase in turnout during the elections, and greater inclusion of citizens in the political processes (Ozimec, 2017). This is particularly candid if one looks at the votes received by SDSM in 2011, 2014 and 2016. In 2011, the largest party in opposition received 368,496 votes, while in 2014 their support shrank to 283,955. In 2016, before transiting into power, the coalition led by SDSM won 434,032 votes, accompanied by one of the highest voter turnouts in Macedonian electoral history—67.11% (SEC, 2023). One could never tell with a significantly high level of certainty to which extent the electoral result was influenced by the protest movement, but having in mind the magnitude and the length of the mobilisation, it is fair to assume that at least 20.000–30.000 non-traditional voters backed the joint opposition in 2016. Some activists argue that this is the number of traditionally passive and inert observers, disenchanted by the dire reality they face daily (Ozimec, 2017). However, based on initial conversations, news reports and participant observation, an in-depth protest event analysis will probably show that this mass citizen participation is concentrated in the urban areas of the City of Skopje, shrinking as it moves to the periphery. Furthermore, regarding the electoral outcomes from the 2016 elections, it is fair to mention that albeit

SDSM achieved its best result in the last several election cycles, VMRO-DPMNE transited into opposition winning slightly more votes, which points towards a strong and deep cleavage in society, as well as to the fact that it was not a "black-white" division as the majority of activists would like to describe it.

Another political outcome is related to the incentivisation of citizens to take part in collective actions. Research conducted in 2016, and focusing on the period 2012–2016 in Macedonia, shows that in 2012, 2013 and 2014, between 8% and 13% of the respondents actively participated in protests and demonstrations. However, in 2015 and 2016, these figures increased to 21% and 18%, respectively (Leshovska et al., 2016, p. 78). This finding is largely in line with the main arguments set forth by Tarrow (2011, 188–189) regarding the mechanism of mobilisation in contentious politics, and how it often leads to further appropriation of resources on the side of the challengers. Although the main outcomes of the CR are mostly political and policy-related, unlike the other three examined cases, this movement also gave birth to cultural outcomes (Bosi et al., 2016, pp. 1–38). In late 2016, an exhibition was organised in the USA, at the American University in Washington, presenting art inspired from the CR. Photographs, a documentary movie, photo-collages and posters were just the key artistic elements presented in front of the American audience. Coordinated by a Macedonian expat non-partisan organisation named Forum for Democratic Macedonia, as well as university professors, curators and activists originating from Macedonia, the exhibition was discussed during an academic conference at the University of Maryland, and also curated in Indiana, Montana and Illinois (OKNO, 2017).

Protests Against the Name Change and the Constitutional Referendum—"Bojkotiram Movement" (2018)

Moving to contentious actions positioned on the other side of the ideological spectrum, another relevant wave of protest was prompted by the change of the constitutional name of Macedonia. We should make a distinction between actions aimed at boycotting the referendum held in September 2018, mainly through the #Bojkotiram (#IBoycott) citizens' initiative, and the protests against constitutional changes adopted by

the Macedonian parliament, which happened following the unsuccessful referendum, mostly organised by the same initiative.

Similar to the previous two movements, numerous civil society organisations, academics, activists and marginal political parties, mostly belonging to the political right, engaged in a campaign to boycott the referendum regarding the name change. However, what is substantially different from the previous two cases is the lack of public and clear involvement by VMRO-DPMNE as the largest party in opposition, and its coalition, therefore leading to a limited possibility for activating the mechanism of political party engagement. Even with the start of the referendum campaign, the party had not had a clear stance on whether their members or supporters should vote, or boycott the referendum (Blazhevska, 2018). Only after the campaign had started, the party announced through its leadership that every citizen should vote according to his or her own convictions: "…Every citizen should act in line with its own conscience…The name agreement is unacceptable…" (Fazlagic, 2018). VMRO-DPMNE being rather passive in the campaign, left a void which was strategically used by the Bojkotiram activists. With the campaign intensifying, the movement profiled itself as the "only viable solution for all who were against the Prespa Agreement, and thus branding those who wanted to vote (including those against) as supporters of the name change" (Tumanovska, 2018). Regarding its identity, Bojkotiram united under one main slogan "Nikogash Severna, samo Makedonija" (Never North, Only Macedonia). On their webpage, the movement defines its mission to strengthen citizens' capacity, awareness and internet activism, with the task to organise the Macedonian people to boycott the referendum, to prevent manipulation of voters and to discover and counter a potential fraudulent referendum (Bojkotiram, 2018). The movement claims to appeal to the general public in the Republic of Macedonia, albeit constantly highlighting the Macedonian People. This is another stark difference when we compare this mobilisation to the other two analysed previously. Having in mind the wording, the framing of the grievances and the iconography, one could clearly differentiate the dominantly monoethnic character of Bojkotiram, from the profoundly multiethnic character of the CfM and the CR. This framing could be largely rooted in political strategising, as a significant majority of the ethnic Macedonian electorate opposed the name change, contrary to the sentiments of the smaller ethnic communities in the country.

In regard to the central claims and grievances, activists campaigned against the change of the constitutional name of the country. Looking at Bojkotiram's website, the movement underlined that Macedonia has its own name, and that it is one's duty to prevent the "generational sin" and to safeguard Macedonia for future generations. Bojkotiram is a citizen rebellion against legitimising the historical treachery by an illegal government and a faked referendum. The movement underscores that its goal is to incite and organise a wide public action: "Stop North, for the Republic of Macedonia erga omnes" (ibid.)! However, looking at the movement's online activity, primarily the Facebook page, as well as claims made during the key protests, one can easily detect claims calling for government resignation, prevention of corruption as well as allegations for vote buying and coercion, i.e. claims largely similar to those put forward by the CfM and the CR (Bojkotiram Facebook page).

From a diachronic perspective, one of the initial protests was held in February 2018, when the negotiations for the Prespa Agreement were already under way through backdoor diplomacy. It is worth noting that the #Bojkotiram hashtag was still not omnipresent, but the core group of actors would remain largely the same as the one later affiliated to the Bojkotiram initiative. Although the mechanism of party engagement was absent, high-party officials of the opposition VMRO-DPMNE could be spotted in the front rows as well as bishops from the Macedonian Orthodox Church—Ohrid Archbishopric (MOC-OA), a traditional promoter of ethnic Macedonian nationalism and conservative values. During the march through the city of Skopje, protesters waved the national flag, as well as the former national flag with the Vergina sun, often treated as one of the ethnic Macedonian flags. Apart from the claims previously elaborated, protesters also called for amnesty of the individuals sentenced to long prison sentences for storming the parliament building on April 27, 2017 (DW, 2018). Protesters asked for immediate halt of the negotiations regarding the country's name, as well as for dismissal of the referendum, urging the government to withdraw from constitutional changes, and the opposition to defend the name and identity of the Macedonian nation. Protesters also denounced the "bilingual state", claiming that it undermined the unitary character of the state, and changed the ethnic map of the country. Interestingly, the protesters also denounced the Agreement with Bulgaria much before gaining prominence and becoming an obstacle for the country's European integration, claiming that it is revisionist for Macedonian history, and that it negates

the existence of the Macedonian people (ibid.). However, apart from the omission of the mechanism of party engagement, and having to oppose the mechanism of international engagement, having in mind that the traditionally engaged international community was significantly in support of the name change, underlining the significance through high-level state visits before and after the referendum held on September 30, 2018, the movement managed to prevent a successful referendum.

Positioning themselves strategically, and having in mind the constitutional provisions, the activists had been quite aware of their advantage, amid the ruling parties spearheading the pro name change campaign, which needed to mobilise over 50% of the registered voters in order to have a successful referendum. Although both sides had "declared victory", ex lege, the referendum for the change of Macedonia's name was unsuccessful (Constitution of the Republic of North Macedonia, Article 73). However, as presented later, it would end up being a Pyrrhic victory. One very important critical juncture highly influenced the movement itself, but also the movement outcomes. In October 2018, 8 opposition MPs coming from the VMRO-DPMNE-led coalition changed allegiance and decided to support the initiating of the constitutional changes (DW, 2018), which were eventually adopted in early January 2019 (Veljanoski, 2019). These developments led to additional closing of the POS (Kitschelt, 1986), and enlarging the number of movement foes. During the interim period, October 2018—January 2019, the movement intensified its activities, especially online, similar to the tactics and repertoires applied during the referendum campaign. On October 29, 2018, Bojkotiram issued a Proclamation for boycotting constitutional changes, referring to the September 30 referendum results (Bojkotiram, 2018). The proclamation sets forth five concrete claims: urgent and unconditional stopping of the process of illegal constitutional changes; unilateral legal rescission of the octroyed and already rejected, so-called, Prespa Agreement; strict compliance with domestic and international public law; permanent protection of the name of the state—Macedonia; and dissolution of the Assembly followed by early parliamentary elections (ibid.). By November 11, 2018, 94 organisations and individuals, ranging from CSOs, political parties, religious communities, university professors, politicians and other activists, had formally supported the proclamation (ibid.). The last effort from the activists to prevent constitutional changes began with a big protest on November 18, 2018 (DW, 2018), where protesters reiterated the key messages from the proclamation. During

the rally, speakers announced continuation of the protests in Skopje and throughout the country as well as roadblocks of key crossroads in the capital using cars and mechanisation (DW, 2018). Occasional roadblocks took place in Skopje and throughout the country (Faktor, 2018; Nezavisen, 2018), but a drop in resources and outreach is easily noticed, when looking at the intensity of protest, the number of participants as well as the presence in online and traditional media. Following the adoption of the constitutional amendments in January 2019, the mechanism of demobilisation (Tilly & Tarrow, 2015, p. 38) was activated, and contention activities steadily dropped.

Although the Bojkotiram movement did not accomplish the previously set political and policy goals, it created a network of like-minded actors, densely grouped around Macedonian identity issues, with strong anti-governmental sentiments. Reactivating occasionally, in particular before elections and during politically contentious events such as corruption scandals, passing of key legislation in parliament, or articulating discussions around global topics such as COVID-19 and the War in Ukraine, the movement created a social network which provided the base for the protests against the so-called French Proposal in 2022. The two movements follow the ideological and identitarian similarity resembling those of the CfM and the CR discussed previously.

Protests Against the "French Proposal" (2022)

The country's European integration has been a poignant story since the early 2000s. Once a frontrunner in the Western Balkans, North Macedonia went through three decades of dispute with Greece regarding the name of the country. The discord had been finally settled in 2019 with the Prespa Agreement, which paved the road to NATO membership. However, another international actor became an obstacle for the beginning of the accession negotiations with the EU. Bulgaria expressed its own grievances and concerns, mostly based on historical, educational and linguistic interpretations. This led to another indefinite halt to the country's EU accession negotiations, with Bulgaria formally blocking the negotiation framework in November 2020 (National Post, 2020). Following a protracted deadlock and attempts for mediation between key EU member states, a breakthrough was made in June 2022, when the Bulgarian parliament voted to lift the veto under the condition that

North Macedonia agrees to change its constitution and add the Bulgarians "on an equal footing with other peoples", and sign the bilateral protocol for the implementation of the 2017 bilateral agreement for good neighbourly relations (France24, 2022). After the Macedonian government initially rejected this proposal, a final push by the French presidency of the EU resulted with a last-minute persuasion of the government to accept the proposal and commit itself to the international community that actions will be taken, in return for an immediate political intergovernmental conference, which would be finalised and formally verified in the autumn of 2023 amid the constitutional changes. In the meantime, it had been agreed that the country would undergo bilateral screening showcasing its compliance with EU's acquis communautaire (Radio Free Europe, 2022).

This decision was the critical juncture which activated the mechanism of mobilisation, urging thousands of people to take the streets in front of the governmental building. Unlike the Bojkotiram movement, it was now VMRO-DPMNE, the largest party in opposition which called for a massive protest in front of the government. Party leader Mickoski called the "French Proposal" shameful, resulting in treachery which fulfils all Bulgarian requests. He further underlined that his party will never accept the proposal which is an ultimatum based on megalomaniac requests with aspirations undermining Macedonian history (Тумановска, 2022a, b). Another opposition political party—Levica (The Left)—also joined the protests immediately and urged its members and supporters to gather against the government's decision to support the "French Proposal" (MKD.MK, 2022b). Similar to the three previously analysed waves of contention, numerous civil society organisations, individuals, activists, journalists, poets and entertainers also took active part in the protests. Although the protests did not have an official organiser, they united under a slogan—"Ultimatum – No Thank You" (Телма, 2022). Looking at the wording, the scenography, the framing and the claims, one could see the resemblance to the Bojkotiram movement. Many of the speakers and regular rank-and-file attendants were the same protesting against the referendum for the name change. One can easily detect the ideological coherence and similarity between the two movements. However, as explained below, as soon as the document for acceptance of the "French Proposal" was adopted in the Assembly, the most influential political parties in opposition abruptly revoked their support in the streets, thus largely weakening the mechanism of political party engagement. This

created a dual cleavage, on two different levels: weakening the relationship between VMRO-DPMNE and Levica, and distancing the political parties from the non-partisan, but most persistent protesters which had continued to camp at the park opposite of the Macedonian Assembly. From a resource mobilisation perspective, this significantly weakened the movement.

Looking at the main grievances and claims put forward by the protesters, one can see a stark similarity to the Bojkotiram movement. In addition to the traditional claim for resignation from the "treacherous and corrupt government", the protestors asked for revoking of the "French Proposal", restoring the sentiments regarding the name change through the "Nikogash Severna, samo Makedonija" chant. Patriotic songs and pleas for recovery of the "loss of identity" and the general "sense of loss" of the Macedonian ethnos were also put forward (Faktor, 2022). However, looking at the interaction between protest and power, the relation between movement actors and the structural elements of power, largely resembled the ones of the CR. Speaking about the "level or degree of eventfulness of the protest" (della Porta, 2011, pp. 282–283), one could easily detect the marches, sit-ins, rallies, speeches, crossroad blockades and camps, and what was the colour in the CR, was now substitute with Macedonian ethnic insignia and the patriotic performances by artists (RFE, 2022). From an ideological perspective, this contentious episode shares multiple similarities to the Bojkotiram movement, in particular regarding Macedonian ethnocentrism.

The announcement of the acceptance of the "French Proposal" by the Macedonian government as a trigger for protest and an important critical juncture has already been reflected upon. The third and fourth days of protest, July 4 and 5 2022, are of great temporal significance, mainly because disruptive (confrontational) events transformed into violence, i.e. violent events (Tarrow, 2011). Members of Levica started throwing stones, eggs and toilet paper on the government and assembly buildings, and later entered into violent clashes with the police (RFE, 2022). These actions activated the mechanism of overt state repression, which immediately resulted in the reduction of protesters in the street. Opp and Roehl's rational choice model of collective action arguing that state repression would raise costs of protest and reduce the number of activists in the streets (1990), was once again reaffirmed during these protests. This

forced protesters to change tactics and turn towards blocking of crossroads (RFE, 2022), in order to try and amplify disruption while having fewer resources.

The adoption of the conclusions regarding the "French Proposal" by the Assembly, amplified further the mechanism of demobilisation. July 16, the day on which 68 MPs voted FOR the conclusions, marked the last day of large protests in the streets of Skopje (AA, 2022). However, although VMRO-DPMNE held a press conference and reaffirmed their stance that there will be no constitutional changes, and the vote in parliament has absolutely no meaning, the next day only hard-line rank-and-file protesters could be noticed in the Zhena Park opposite of parliament. Disenchanted protesters commented how the majority of protesters are controlled by political parties, and that party leaders left the streets and began to prepare for summer vacations (TB 21, 2022). On the other hand, movement activists had to once again confront the mechanism of international intervention, as the key actors from the international community lauded the policy outputs adopted in the parliamentary arena (RFE, 2022).

The movement opposing the "French Proposal" is rather uncertain and open-ended regarding its political outcomes, mainly because the procedure for amendments to the Macedonian constitution had not yet started. Although the activists failed to prevent the Assembly from adopting the conclusions stemming from the "French Proposal", there are still possibilities for reactivation of the mechanism of mobilisation, amplifying further coordinated action, as well as potential scale shift, having in mind the political and emotional weight of the contentious issue. Furthermore, polling from July 2022 shows that 56% of the respondents and 72% of the ethnic Macedonian respondents are against the "French Proposal" (MKD.MK, 2022a). A more recent poll from March 2023 presents similar trends, with 65% of the respondents opting against the constitutional changes (Telma, 2023). This leaves space for substantial shifts regarding the movement outcomes.

Conclusions

The four movements under scrutiny can be easily grouped for the purpose of paired comparisons (Tarrow, 2010), juxtaposing the CfM and the CR, with the Bojkotiram and the anti "French Proposal" mobilisation. In

regard to movement outcomes, observed through the prism of the relationship between protest and power analysed through a political process approach, variations can be noticed regarding the relative "success" of the movements, in which the mechanism of political party engagement, and the mechanism of international intervention seem to have played a pivotal role. The CfM and the CR had significant overt support from political parties in opposition, primarily SDSM, in their anti-governmental struggle, while Bojkotiram and AFP did not manage to create strong and durable connections with VMRO-DPMNE and Levica. On the other hand, the mechanism of international intervention was activated in support of the CfM and the CR, contrary to the Bojkotiram and AFP movements, where it played the role of a foe.

Regarding the overarching similarity between the four movements, an anti-government sentiment prevails and puts forward government resignation as a central claim, which is one of the key elements when assessing movements and power.

The extent to which Macedonian democracy evolved during the period 2015 – 2023 is highly questionable, and needs an in-depth quantitative analysis of multiple categories imminent to democracy. However, the repetitiveness of the movement claims coming from two different ideological camps indicates that key societal problems and grievances remain largely intact. Figures show that media freedoms, violation of human rights and civil society inclusion have improved, but the rampant corruption, high level of political polarisation and multiple cleavages in society have either remained equally worrying, or even declined further. Similar conclusions can be derived regarding citizens' trust in institutions and rule of law. Ultimately, as one activist would put it in an interview "…if protest movements are instrumentalized only for achieving electoral results, democracy remains hollow, because it is incapable of creating channels through which needs and claims of ordinary citizens can be articulated and effectuated. These channels are yet to be strengthened" (Ozimec, 2017).

In this vein, it should be underlined that the incremental steps which the Macedonian society had taken in the recent past, especially during the period between 2017 and 2020, have opened the political opportunities for protest and other forms of contention. Additionally, other institutionalised channels for keeping governments accountable have opened and cooperation between state institutions and other non-state actors have

undoubtedly improved. However, what still remains a starkly open question is whether protests in North Macedonia contribute to, or hinder democratisation? Having in mind that even the two more nationalist and anti-Western waves of contention which were analysed—the Bojkotiram and the AFP movements, have in essence been pro rule of law, and advocating for "the ordinary people to be heard", paired with the fact that radical illiberal movements and almost non-existent, one could argue that mobilisations in North Macedonia, in general, contribute to democratisation.

Another element closely tied to the general political outcomes of the three analysed movements: the CfM, the CR and the Bojkotiram movements, is the lack of rise of new more radical and populist parties oftentimes running on an anti-establishment and anti-elite platform. Possibilities remain following the completion of the AFP movement. However, one needs to underline the strength gained by The Left, which albeit formed in late 2015 (prior to the CR and Bojkotiram movements), had risen to prominence and current polls suggest larger parliamentary presence amid the following parliamentary elections. Other changes to the political party landscape and the emergence of new parties and movement parties are more the result of intra-partisan power contestations than popular dissatisfaction.

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Poland—Changing Patterns of Protest Mobilisation in a Polarised Society

Piotr Kocyba

Before the fall of communism, civil society in Poland was considered relatively vibrant and robust by East Central European standards, capable of mobilising large groups of people (Bernhard, 1993). After all, Solidarity had managed to briefly break the Communist Party's monopoly on social organisations in the early 1980s. Although the success story of an independent trade union in a socialist state (as such, a contradiction in terms) was initially halted by the imposition of martial law, it was the Solidarity movement that led to the fall of the communist government in Poland in 1989, triggering a domino effect in other satellites of the Soviet Union, before the USSR itself collapsed (Ost, 1990).

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Early System Transformation, Power Constellations, and Popular Protest in the 1990s

While Solidarity was founded as a trade union in its early stages, it was also a mass movement with millions of members. This changed after 1989. It lost its mass movement character, but remained a trade union and gave rise to a number of conservative, liberal, and nationalist parties, which frequently changed their names in the early 1990s or disbanded only to be re-registered with new constellations of personnel, and which competed fiercely with each other. Nevertheless, they had a serious and consolidated political opponent in the post-communists, who managed to form their first government in coalition with the Polish Peasant Party (Polskie Stronnictwo Ludowe, PSL) from 1993 to 1997. The post-Solidarity camp responded by uniting under the name Solidarity Electoral Action (Akcja Wyborcza Solidarność, AWS), an electoral coalition of various parties initiated by the Solidarity trade union itself. Although AWS won the elections in 1997 and was able to govern with the liberal (and also post-Solidarity) Freedom Union (Unia Wolności, UW), internal disputes quickly grew. The process of disintegration began as early as 1998, and AWS was dissolved shortly after, not even entering parliament in the elections of 2001. Altogether, the post-Solidarity camp governed for six years in the 1990s, including the particularly important early phase of system transformation.

During this crucial period of laying the foundations for social, political, and economic change (1989–1993), the latter was the greatest challenge for the post-Solidarity governments. The economy they inherited was in deep crisis and had to be radically restructured. Although the reforms, known as "Shock Therapy" or "the Balcerowicz plan," contributed to Poland's economic success in the following years, they were accompanied by severe social welfare cuts, the closure or downsizing of many former state-owned companies, high unemployment, a sharp drop in real incomes, and an increase in social inequalities. This led to a wave of protest mobilisation, which continued to be dominated by trade unions (mainly by Solidarity), was often directed against the privatisation of companies, and in most cases, made economic claims. For example, by public sector employees demanding higher wage increases (Ekiert & Kubik, 1999, pp. 183 ff.). It was a paradox that the political parties that emerged from the Solidarity trade union implemented one of the harshest economic reform policies in East-Central Europe, causing widespread

popular discontent (Ost, 2005). However, this also explains why most protesters did not question the reforms as such but only demanded minor changes to help them cope with the personal consequences of the transformation (e.g., better social compensation for miners who had lost their jobs) (Ekiert & Kubik, 1999, p. 112).

The radical reform programme led to an economic recovery and thus to a steady decline of the importance of trade union (strike) mobilisation and a constant decrease in economic motives for protest participation, against the background of a general decline in the intensity of protest. At the end of the 1990s, Polish civil society was less contentious than at the beginning of the system transformation (Ekiert et al., 2017, p. 342).

Partisan Stabilisation Between Two Post-Solidarity Parties and a Change in Protest Patterns

The Polish party system has stabilised since the mid-2000s in the sense that it has been dominated since then by the competition between two post-Solidarity parties, namely the radicalised conservative Law and Justice (Prawo i Sprawiedliwość, PiS) and the liberal-conservative Civic Platform (Platforma Obywatelska, PO). Both parties were founded in 2001 in the context of the foreseeable collapse of AWS. PiS and PO initially aimed to replace the government led by the post-communist Democratic Left Alliance (Sojusz Lewicy Demokratycznej, SLD), which, shaken by corruption scandals, since losing power in 2005 has gone from being the main opponent of the post-Solidarity camp to a minor political force that does not always meet the electoral threshold to enter parliament. In the 2005 parliamentary elections, both post-Solidarity parties announced that they would form a coalition to take over government from the post-communists. The break came when PiS surprisingly outperformed PO, winning the presidential and parliamentary elections, and subsequent coalition talks broke down. Since then, the central political divide in Poland has been between these two parties, which alternate in government. In 2005, instead of partnering with PO, PiS formed a coalition government with the far-right League of Polish Families (Liga Polskich Rodzin, LPR) and the populist peasant party Self-Defense (Samoobrona). The coalition collapsed after just two years, and PO formed a government with the moderate agrarian PSL in 2007. This government was re-elected in 2011, the first time this had happened in Poland since the fall of communism, and was therefore celebrated both

nationally and internationally as evidence of the advanced consolidation of Polish democracy (Szczerbiak, 2013).

Poland appeared to be developing in a politically stable manner and also coping comparatively well with the global financial crisis. It was one of the few countries in the European Union to consistently show economic growth, even during the years of the EURO crisis (Duszczyk, 2017). It came, therefore, as a surprise when PO lost first the presidential and then the parliamentary elections in 2015. PiS won an absolute majority and was able to govern without a coalition partner, which was the first time since the fall of communism that a single party had formed a government on its own.[1] The former model nation of successful regime transformation, celebrated as a consolidated democracy with the confirmation of the first PO government, now, along with Hungary, became one of the pioneers of democratic backsliding (Bernhard, 2021). In quick succession, among other things, the PiS government took control of the public broadcaster and turned it into a mouthpiece of the government, undermined the independence of the judiciary, took over public institutions, publicly devalued the opposition parties—especially Civic Platform—as traitors to the country. It was not until 2023, after the second term of the PiS government, that the democratic opposition gathered around PO was able to mobilise a majority at the ballot box. This time, it was a coalition of several parties: an alliance of the post-communists and progressive left parties forming the party New Left (Nowa Lewica) and the Third Way (Trzecia Droga), which was a union of PO's former coalition partner, the agrarian PSL, and a new political formation, the conservative Szymon Hołownia's Poland 2050 (Polska 2050 Szymona Hołownia).

As already mentioned, the high level of protest mobilisation in the first years of transition has declined noticeably since the second half of the 1990s. The 2000s thus represent a transition in protest behaviour. First, broadly understood "identity politics" (abortion rights, rights of sexual minorities, etc.) increasingly began to replace economic motives for protest. Second, actors to the (far) right of the centre gained importance (Ekiert et al., 2017). Third, the new divide between PiS and PO led to a renewed rise in protest at the end of the decade, with the number

[1] Nevertheless, it was actually a coalition. Several small right-wing parties, the most important of which at that time was Solidary Poland (Solidarna Polska, SP), ran in the elections under the umbrella of the PiS electoral committee.

of protests exploding when PiS took power in 2015. Typologically, two different types of protest mobilisation have been central in Poland since this change in protest patterns: (1) mobilisation by independent civil society organisations or social movements and (2) direct party mobilisation, in which individual parties or party alliances call for protests against specific political decisions and/or before elections. In addition, hybrid forms of protest and attempts of hybridization can be observed in Poland. On the one hand, this refers to demonstrations organised by civil society actors that are very close to political parties, sometimes even representing quasi-party organisations (oscillating between the categories of "fellow travellers" and "ersatz movements," see Ekiert & Perry, 2020, pp. 17–18). Such hybrid mobilisations are characterised by personal overlaps and are supported by the resources of a political party (or the state), as in the case of the protests commemorating the plane crash in Smoleńsk, which will be discussed later in this chapter. Hybridization, on the other hand, represents attempts by political parties to bind or "take over" protest movements—an example of this is the Independence March, described as the first case. Because hybrid protests are not directly (or officially) partisan events, they are treated as a special form of civil society mobilisation despite their proximity to a party, which in some cases can go so far as to be called quasi-party mobilisation.

Theoretical Framework—Political Opportunity Structures

Below, the different types of mobilisations just identified will be described along the core dimensions of "political opportunity structures" (POS), which, despite the abundance of research literature, remain essential for understanding the development and impact of protest. In general, political opportunities refer to the characteristics of a particular context that facilitate (or hinder) a movement's efforts to pursue its goals (Tilly & Tarrow, 2015, p. 103). These characteristics can be either long- or short-term (Tarrow, 1996, p. 56) and will be analysed in relation to the protest actor under study. Thus, the aim is to briefly outline which framework conditions led to which dynamics between (government-challenging and -supporting) protest and political decision-makers in Poland. In the following, reference will be made to Doug McAdam's still influential

(though not uncontested) typology (cf. Abrams, 2023), which distinguishes four critical dimensions of political opportunity (McAdam, 1996, p. 27).

The first dimension involves "the relative openness or closure of the institutionalised political system" within a state. This dimension encompasses the formal and structured opportunities available for a movement to grow, including the current configuration of the state or polity and the access points to power or influential figures. These opportunities may vary depending on the government in power, systemic reforms, temporary laws, and the alignment of institutional decision-makers, including public opinion. The second dimension focuses on the relationships between those in power and other actors outside formal institutions. These relationships reflect "the stability or instability of the broad set of elite alignments that typically support a polity." This includes the role of political parties, politicians, media, and public institutions in representing particular groups or ideologies and thus providing or denying avenues for movement influence. The third dimension is the "presence or absence of elite allies" who can support a movement by disrupting existing power relations among elites. These allies may include opposition politicians, influential public figures, and economically powerful individuals who use their positions to support the movement. The fourth and crucial dimension is "the state's capacity and propensity for repression," which can be implemented through formal mechanisms such as anti-protest laws and temporary police powers, or informal means such as violence by state-affiliated groups or armed repression by military forces.

These four dimensions also highlight what the absence of political opportunity entails: a closed political system, stable power relations, a lack of supportive elites, and a state willing and able to suppress political activity. This framework is instrumental in analysing the political opportunities available in Poland since the mid-2000s and in explaining the different outcomes of the various waves of mobilisation.

Mobilisation of Civil Society Organisations and Movements

The most common case of mobilisation in established democracies is when independent civil society actors organise protests (Ekiert & Perry, 2020; Susánszky & Tóth, 2016). In Poland, both sides of the political spectrum have mobilised: progressive and regressive independent

movements have positioned themselves within the fundamental political conflict between PiS and PO, and both have challenged the respective government and acted under different political opportunity structures depending on which party was in power. In the following section, the key independent and hybrid protest mobilisations will be traced, and their impact within the changing conditions analysed—protest mobilisations that are inscribed in the logic of competition and conflict between PiS and PO, a divide that seems to dominate all other issues.

The Independence March as an Example of an Attempt at Hybridisation

The Independence March has the longest history of all the protests discussed in this chapter. Even before it was institutionalised as the central march of the far right in 2010, smaller marches were held in many Polish cities after the transformation of the system to commemorate Polish Independence Day on November 11.[2] Most of these marches were organised by the subcultural neo-Nazi scene and usually attracted only a few hundred participants. For a long time, such events were only marginally noticed by the public (Szymanik, 2012). However, this began to change in 2008 when a group of about 150 counter-demonstrators protested against the Warsaw march and forced it to change its route. The controversy stoked passion and interest, leading to a growing number of participants in subsequent years, as well as increased coverage by the mainstream media, which condemned the march organisers as radicals and fascists (Napiórkowski, 2019). State authorities began to police march organisers and activists heavily,[3] inadvertently helping the event to grow. Starting in 2010, a single, large march in Warsaw replaced most of the smaller regional events, and this joint march became the main topic of debate surrounding Polish Independence Day. In 2011, the Independence March Association was formed by two major far-right organisations: the All-Polish Youth (Młodzież Wszechpolska) and the National Radical Camp (Obóz Narodowo-Radykalny), both of which have roots in the interwar period and share a nationalist agenda (Jajecznik,

[2] The history of the March actually began at the end of the 1970s, when they were still illegal and were often organised after Masses, but were not events dominated by the far right (Siedziako, 2018).

[3] For a right-wing activist's perspective on increased policing, (see: Gładysz, 2019).

2015). Following centralization in terms of location and organisation, combined with criticism from left-wing and liberal actors, attempts to block the march, and confrontational policing, a dramatic increase in the number of participants has been observed. In 2011, the organisers spoke of 20,000 participants, a number that grew steadily and quickly settled at an average of over 40,000, with two exceptions: the 2018 Independence March on the hundredth anniversary of Poland's independence, with almost 250,000 participants, and 2020, when public events with more than five participants were banned due to anti-covid measures and the organisers called for a motorcade.

Openness or Closure of the Institutionalised Political System

Until 2015, the political system in Poland was relatively open to protest, even to far-right mobilisations. Attempts by the liberal-conservative PO president(s) of Warsaw to ban the march on security grounds were unsuccessful, as the courts ruled in the name of freedom of assembly—both before and after PiS came to power (Politico, 2018). Nevertheless, there were two factors that opened up the political space for the March. On the one hand, when PiS came to power, the approach of the security forces to the event changed fundamentally. From then on, the police were much more restrained, there were no more checks on the buses of arriving participants, and the policing of the March became more discreet (the police visually withdrew, waiting with hundreds of officers hidden behind houses or under bridges, and masked demonstrators, for example, were no longer pulled out of the crowd as they had been during the PO government). As a result, the marches no longer escalated into riots and more participants joined them (the exception was the 2020 march held during the COVID-19 pandemic; Machajski, 2015). Legally, the PiS government also provided another boost to the March organisers with a change in the law on assembly, which prioritised regular protests and made counter-protests more difficult.

Stability or Instability of the Broad Set of Elite Alignments

When it comes to questions of the stability or instability of elite alignments, significant shifts can be observed. Perceptions of the March are deeply divided, reflecting party-political polarisation: PiS and the political milieu to its right paint a picture of a peaceful family celebration of

Polish patriotism, while PO and the political spectrum to its left point to riots, far-right organisers, and racist slogans—tensions that generated publicity and thus opened a window for mass mobilisation (Kocyba & Łukianow, 2023). In addition to this split between the two main political camps, there was also a change in the parliamentary majority in 2015. After PiS took control of the public broadcaster in 2015, there was a shift in public discourse that pushed it further to the right and centred the dispute around the Independence March as one of the main axes of polarisation, making it *the* symbolic event that proved Polish patriotism (Napiórkowski, 2019). Moreover, with the establishment of a central Independence March, the far right re-established itself in party politics after the LPR—one of the two coalition partners of the first PiS government—faded into political insignificance following the premature collapse of the coalition in 2007. In fact, the National Movement (Ruch Narodowy, RN) was founded in 2012 in the wake of the Independence March, as a consequence of joining forces for a joint event in Warsaw (Winnicki, 2013). Although the RN had limited success in various elections, it is a central part of Confederation Liberty and Independence (Konfederacja Wolność I Niepodległość), which was founded in 2018 as a coalition party of various far-right actors, all of whom are either directly or indirectly involved in the organisation of the March. Since its inception, the Confederation has not only consistently surpassed the five percent threshold in national elections but has also regularly outperformed left-wing parties, sometimes coming third in polls and regularly polling above 10 percent. Thus, the Confederation established itself as a far-right party with a solid parliamentary representation, changing the political landscape and further opening the Polish political sphere to the March. The deep conflict over the perception of the Independence March provided opportunities for its establishment as the largest "patriotic" street event and guaranteed the public attention necessary for the success of the mobilisation.

Presence of Elite Allies

Against the backdrop of a deeply divided polity, as just outlined, the March had an increasingly strong and influential representation among the elite. Even though the central event in Warsaw was initiated by two far-right youth organisations and is still organised by them, it was advantageous that the right-wing milieus in Poland have blurred boundaries. This means that activists, intellectuals, and media professionals close to

PiS have shown great sympathy for organising a central Independence March from its very beginning, regularly defending it against left-wing and liberal critics and presenting it as a patriotic march of proud Poles—and in some cases taking legal action against the accusation that it is a fascist march (Gazeta Wyborcza, 2019). From the very beginning, all political actors and organisations sympathetic to PiS and other right-wing groups have participated in the March. These include individual PiS politicians and smaller right-wing parties, civil society organisations, such as the Gazeta Polska Clubs or the ultra-conservative Catholic think tank Ordo Iuris, which is now acting as an official observer of the protest, and many others. A further push for the success of the Independence March came in 2015, when PiS came to power. The now-ruling elite were staunch supporters of the March, which they later tried to hijack (Grochal, 2018). The Polish president, Andrzej Duda, in particular, made efforts to move closer to the March. For example, at both the 2016 and 2017 marches, Duda addressed the participants in an official letter read on his behalf at the beginning of the event (Duda, 2016). In 2018, a whole series of events were organised by the state to mark the centenary of Poland's independence, but the March, organised autonomously by the far right, was expected to receive the most public attention, as it would attract by far the most participants. Efforts were made in advance to have President Duda lead the centenary march, but this failed because Duda wanted to allow only Polish flags, presumably to ensure that no racist banners would be visible under his leadership (Gazeta Wyborcza, 2018). When the mayor then tried again to ban the March, without waiting for the court's decision the president and prime minister announced a "White and Red" march on the same route at the same time, which was not registered as a public gathering that could possibly be banned, but as a state-organised event. After the court overturned the president's ban, both events took place virtually simultaneously on the same route, meaning that even though the presidential march started first, many participants weren't sure which event they were participating in (Kocyba & Łukianow, 2023, p. 128). In the end, because of the heavy security at the presidential event, only about 3,000 people were able to participate in the official, state-organised march. Most people, intentionally or unintentionally, participated in the nationalist Independence March, which followed the presidential march and gathered about a quarter of a million participants. The support of the ruling elites went so far in 2018 that PiS

almost took over the March. Consequently, Robert Bąkiewicz, the long-time organiser of the Independence March at the time, was accused of treason by some of the people around the March's founders (Witkowski, 2019), while associations led by Bąkiewicz were partially funded by PiS, and he even ran on the PiS list in the 2023 parliamentary elections. To sum up, the Independence March is a case of attempted hybridization, where a political party with the corresponding state resources tried to incorporate the largest street event of the "patriotic camp". It seems, with the removal of Robert Bąkiewicz, that the Independence March Association has resisted this attempt and will remain an independent actor, manoeuvring as a bridge between PiS and those far-right organisations that distance themselves from the established parties.

State's Capacity and Propensity for Repression

The Polish state has the ability to tightly control public events, particularly through the use of well-equipped police forces trained to deal with large crowds and potential riots. In the first years of its existence, organisers and participants of the central Independence March regularly reported what they perceived as hostile police work (such as the use of tear gas, water cannons, numerous arrests, etc.), which they saw—along with counter-protesters—as the cause of the riots. Regardless of whether such accusations can be convincingly proven, in the years before PiS came to power, the state made efforts to strictly control the event. It had the capacity and willingness for repression, but it acted within the framework of a democratic rule of law that limited excessive forms of repression. However, such a strategy had no demobilising effect. On the contrary, by creating scandals over the actions of the police (and other security agencies such as the secret services, which were blamed for provocations, TVN24, 2017) in the right-wing media, which already had a considerable reach in Poland in the early 2010s, an increasing number of people were mobilised to participate in a kind of defiant reaction. Due to the limited legal possibilities and against the background of the public's critical attitude toward the use of force against demonstrators (connected with the communist past), the repressive actions under the PO government did not result in deterrence (on deterrence through repression in general, see Opp, 1994). Given the rapid increase in the number of participants, no further radicalization followed the clashes (on repression-induced radicalization of protest, see Ellefsen, 2021). Rather, the alliance within the

"patriotic camp" became stronger and broader (for a general discussion of the strengthening of alliances as a result of repression, see Minkenberg, 2006), and the March enjoyed increasing sympathy across the Polish right-wing spectrum. When PiS ended the police strategy of repression and confrontation after gaining power in 2015, the window of opportunity was finally wide open for the March to develop the mobilising power it has had since.

The Manifestations Commemorating the Plane Crash in Smoleńsk as a Hybrid Challenger and Government Support Protest Mobilisation

On April 10, 2010, the Polish presidential plane crashed while landing in Smoleńsk, leaving no survivors. Among the victims were the President of the Republic of Poland, Lech Kaczyński, and his wife Maria Kaczyńska; the last President of the Republic of Poland in exile, Ryszard Kaczorowski; deputy speakers of the Sejm and the Senate; 18 members of parliament; commanders of all branches of the Polish Armed Forces; heads of state institutions; clergymen; representatives of ministries, veterans' and social organisations; the accompanying persons who were part of the Polish delegation to the celebrations of the 70th anniversary of the Katyń massacre; and the airplane crew. After an initial shock and a brief consolidation of Polish society, the plane crash led to further polarisation. Spontaneous commemorations initiated from below centred around a cross erected by activists in front of the presidential palace a few days after the crash (Olszewska & Szpala, 2010). This became a symbol of an even deeper social divide when, against the strong resistance of the activists, the cross was moved to the president's palace chapel in August 2010 and to a nearby church in September 2010. The relocation of the cross marked the eruption of a dispute over the proper way to commemorate the plane crash (Lichocka, 2012, p. 17), which evolved from a quasi-permanent commemoration (or occupation of the square) in front of the presidential palace to increasingly ritualised monthly memorial events (Krzemiński, 2017, p. 51). Such monthly marches, central for the movement from this point onwards, were officially organised for a total of eight years, until the twin brother of the dead president, Jarosław Kaczyński, declared the "Miesięcznice Smoleńskie" over on the eighth anniversary, which was also the 96th monthly event (a highly symbolic

act reflecting the 96 victims of the plane crash). The events, which had grown from bottom-up initiatives and were largely supported by the families of Radio Maria and, in particular, the Gazeta Polska clubs (both civil society groups organised around radicalised conservative media), as well as the small Solidarity 2010 group, which emerged after the crash, not only became part of the growing polarisation but were also increasingly co-opted by PiS.

Openness or Closure of the Institutionalised Political System

The monthly commemorations emerged at a time when the political elite and the media were deeply affected by the plane crash and a wave of empathy affected the whole of Polish society. The closing of ranks did not last long, however. A new president had to be elected, and Civic Platform candidate Bronisław Komorowski beat Jarosław Kaczyński, whose brother had died in the Smoleńsk plane crash while serving as president. In the spontaneous commemoration initiated from below, voices of those who questioned whether the crash had been an accident for which the Polish side was mainly responsible (as proved by several commissions), soon grew louder. The fact that the investigation of the air disaster was left to the Russians—albeit in accordance with international agreements—was also increasingly criticised. Above all, the change in attitude towards the memorial movement, which found less and less recognition in the public and in the left-liberal media, and the decline of its central demand for a central memorial site near the presidential palace, which culminated in the forceful removal of the cross, led to a profound alienation. Even if the political framework did not change at first, what followed was marginalisation and stigmatisation (e.g., through derogatory media coverage; cf. Nasierowska, 2010), accompanied by a simultaneous merging with PiS and its sympathetic radical-conservative media. It is, therefore, not surprising that the victory of PiS in the 2015 presidential and parliamentary elections led to an opening of the political system. The monthly events were prominently broadcast on public television—quickly taken over by PiS—and secured by an immense police presence. As previously mentioned, the PiS majority even changed the law on assembly in 2017 to prioritise regular protests and make counter-protests more difficult.

Stability or Instability of the Broad Set of Elite Alignments

With its monthly events, the memorial movement became a central arena of Polish polarisation, especially after its virtual fusion with PiS. The increasing role of conspiracy narratives in the interpretation of the air disaster made the evaluation of the monthly events dependent on political self-positioning. Politicians from PO and other parties, the left-liberal media, and the public broadcaster (until it was taken over by the PiS in 2015) distanced themselves from the commemorations, sometimes in a way that was disparaging because of the conspiracy narratives. At the same time, the plane crash and the commemorations became a central issue for PiS and its milieu. It was no coincidence that Gazeta Polska, which together with its Clubs was mainly responsible for the emergence of the remembrance movement, had the first live broadcast of its 2012 newly established TV channel, TV Republika, from an annual commemoration event. The founding of another important radical-conservative weekly—wPolityce—on June 17, 2010, shows that the commemorative events were able to benefit from a significant shift within the elite, leading to a change of power in 2015, which would have been less likely without the monthly memorial marches.

Presence of Elite Allies

Even after the onset of marginalisation, the remembrance movement maintained a close alliance with the main opposition party of the time and the entire spectrum of the radical-conservative media. Jarosław Kaczyński and all of the top PiS politicians were regular speakers, and candidates such as Andrzej Duda, who ran for the presidency in 2015, also delivered speeches at the events, as did key representatives of the supporting media, of whom Tomasz Sakiewicz is the most prominent example. The support of PiS became fully visible after the party came to power. After 2015, the monthly and especially the annual events were elevated to quasi-state commemorative rallies, part of which was completely shut off from outsiders and counter-protesters by immense police forces. Not only did the highest representatives of the state (the president and ministers) speak, but some of the annual events were also organised by ministries (mostly the Ministry of Culture). Overall, the closeness between PiS and the memorial movement was so great from its very beginning that it was almost impossible to distinguish who had the greatest influence, the party

or the grass-root initiators (Kondzińska & Kucharski, 2013). Whatever the case, it was the party that provided its resources—and after 2015 the state's resources—for the highly symbolic public gatherings.

State's Capacity and Propensity for Repression

Only in the initial phase did the state assert its authority by using the security forces. After the newly elected president, Bronisaw Komorowski, decided to move the cross in agreement with church representatives (July 2010), a kind of "battle for the cross" arose (August 2010). Commemorative activists defended the cross (Nasierowska, 2010), which meant that the security authorities had to make several attempts to enforce the transfer of the cross to the chapel in the Presidential Palace and later to St. Anne's Church. This led to clashes between the demonstrators and the municipal police, which further aggravated the conflict and deepened the rift between the memorial activists and the PO. After that, there were no major confrontations between the security authorities and the participants of the periodic commemorations reported. On the contrary, during the time of the PiS government, the police ensured that counter-protests were hardly possible with an immense police presence (the number of police officers sometimes exceeded the number of participants in the marches).

The All-Poland Women's Strike—A Case of Independent Protest Mobilisation[4]

The women's movement has a long tradition in Poland, originating in the nineteenth century. However, the All-Poland Women's Strike (Ogólnopolski Strajk Kobiet, OSK) dates back to the first attempt to tighten the law on abortion when two citizens' legislative initiatives on

[4] It should be noted that the Women's Strike is a particularly significant example of independent protest mobilisation, but there have been other similar protest waves, some of which have been able to bring large numbers of protesters onto the streets over a long period of time, such as the Komitet Obrony Demokracji (Committee for the Defence of Democracy, KOD) and other groups protesting against the dismantling of the rule of law. However, as in the other case studies presented here, only one group per type of mobilisation is described and analysed, although the aim was to present the most significant example of independent, hybrid, hybridised, and party mobilisations.

abortion were submitted to the Sejm in September 2016. While the liberalising initiative "Let's Rescue Women" ("Ratujmy Kobiety") (215,000 signatures) was rejected, the one banning abortion entirely, "Stop Abortion" ("Stop Aborcji") (400,000 signatures), was approved in the first reading. The progressive left-wing party Together (Partia Razem) then called for protests under the hashtag #blackprotest (#czarnyprotest). At one of these events in Wrocław, the later co-founder of the OSK, Marta Lempart, called for the first OSK protest, which took place in 147 Polish cities on October 3, 2016, mobilising up to 200,000 people under the slogan "Black Monday - All-Poland Women's Strike" (Kowalska & Nawojski, 2020, p. 50). Just a few days later, on October 6, 2016, the Sejm, stunned by the protests and despite a safe majority for PiS, rejected the legislative initiative for a total ban on abortion. A year later, on October 23, 2017, another citizen's legislative initiative to liberalise abortion rights (called "Let's Save Women 2017", "Ratujmy Kobiety 2017") was submitted to the Sejm (400,000 signatures) (Chrzczonowicz, 2017a). On November 30, yet a further citizen's initiative to tighten the law was submitted to the Sejm: "Stop Abortion" ("Zatrzymaj Aborcje") no longer proposed a total ban, but instead 'only' added to the already strict Polish law a ban on abortion in the case of a high probability of serious and irreversible disability of the foetus or an incurable, life-threatening disease (830,000 signatures) (Radio Maryja, 2017). On January 10, 2018, the initiative to liberalise the law was rejected at first reading and referred to the Committee on Social Policy and Family for further work. This was followed by the second major protest mobilisation: On January 17, 2018, the "DÉJÀ-VU" protest was organised in Warsaw, followed by "Black Friday" on March 23, in which up to 90,000 people participated in Warsaw alone (Szczerbiak, 2018). Again, under the influence of the protest, the legislative initiative was transferred to an extraordinary subcommittee, which discontinued its work on the bill. As a result, the second attempt to tighten the law was also unsuccessful. These two largest street mobilisations for women's rights were the only ones to challenge the PiS government majority successfully. Despite pressure from radicalised conservative civil society organisations, parts of the party, and the Catholic Church (Banaś, 2023, p. 121), which remains influential in Poland, the initiatives to ban or further restrict abortion did not pass through the legislative process—an exception in light of PiS's usual practice of passing controversial judicial reform laws despite major

protests. Nevertheless, the abortion legislation was tightened by a back-door. On October 27, 2017, a group of MPs from PiS and parties to its right submitted an appeal to the Constitutional Tribunal to review the constitutionality of abortion in cases where there is a significant probability of severe and irreversible foetal disability or incurable life-threatening illness (Chrzczonowicz, 2017b). On October 22, 2020, the politically controlled Constitutional Tribunal declared abortion unconstitutional in these cases—a decision that was immediately questioned by experts (Zarząd Helsińskiej Fundacji Praw Człowieka, 2020 or Iustitia, 2020). As a result, the largest wave of women's protests broke out in Poland, probably the largest in the country's history in general—and this despite the actual ban on public gatherings due to pandemic restrictions and the threat of infection. At the peak of the wave of protests on October 28, 2020, more than 400,000 people participated in 410 cities, an unprecedented scale that extended to small and peripheral towns (a phenomenon that had already characterised the earlier women's strikes, see Muszel & Piotrowski, 2018). The enormous public support was shown in a representative poll conducted in November 2020 by Kantar for the liberal Gazeta Wyborcza. According to the poll, 70% of respondents supported the protests and 13% of respondents had participated in the protests (4% even several times) (Mieńkowska-Norkiene, 2020). The protests continued until January 2021, when they further intensified with the publication, and thus legal implementation, of the near-ban on abortion on January 27, 2021 (TVN Warszawa, 2021). During this wave of protests, unlike the previous ones, demonstrators were arrested and the police used force. However, the protests were unable to prevent the further tightening of the abortion law this time.

Openness or Closure of the Institutionalised Political System

The women's strike was initiated during the illiberal PiS government, which not only publicly agitated against progressive activists, especially through public broadcasters, but also generally restricted the space for independent civic engagement (Kocyba & Lewicki, 2020). One example of this was the change in the funding of civil society organisations (conservative and right-wing associations, such as the Independence March, now received financial support; Kim, 2023). Laws were also often rushed through parliament, bypassing the necessary social consultations (Maj, 2015). In addition, the pandemic restricted all social movements, not

only in Poland, from organising protests. Despite this relatively closed political system compared to before PiS came to power in 2015, the Women's Strike quickly grew as a grassroots movement and became one of the most important challengers to PiS, not only because of its impressive mobilisation power in even in the smallest towns but also because the conflict over the right to abortion became one of the policies that was core to the struggle between the democratic opposition and the government.

Stability or Instability of the Broad Set of Elite Alignments

The Polish elite is also deeply divided over the Women's Strike, perhaps more so than over other controversial issues. After all, the question of abortion rights is being raised in one of the most conservative societies in the EU, where the Catholic Church continues to play a strong role. Although this dispute is basically being fought out between the PiS and the opposition parties, there is still no agreement within the latter on how to proceed in the case of abortion legislation. This also applies to PO, which is a conservative party at its core. While all left-wing parties are in favour of liberalising the abortion law and fully support the women's strike, PO or the Third Way are not so clear in their solidarity. This is illustrated by the fact that during the vote on the two citizens' legislative initiatives in January 2018, the liberalisation initiative did not receive the necessary majority to be further processed by the Sejm due to the absence of some opposition politicians—i.e., even some PiS deputies voted in favour of it with the reference that although they did not agree on the content, a citizens' initiative should at least be discussed in committee (Wilgocki, 2018). As a result, the aforementioned "DÉJÀ-VU" protest on January 17, 2018, also explicitly marched in front of the PO party headquarters, illustrating potential friction on this topic within the democratic camp in Poland. The more so as during the last wave of mobilisation in late 2020 and early 2021 the protests were dominated by vulgar slogans expressing anger and resistance, sometimes protesting in front of or even in churches (Kampka, 2022). The conservative parties of the democratic opposition find it difficult to unconditionally support a liberalisation that goes beyond the so-called abortion compromise of 1993, preferring a return to the already strict regulations in existence before PiS came to power. Some conservative politicians even call for a plebiscite instead of a quick resolution of the issue (Matoga, 2024).

Thus, despite the immense politicisation of this conflict, which is deeply inscribed in Poland's party-political polarisation, there is no consensus among parties supporting the Women's Strike on how to respond to the protesters' demands, which helps to further mobilise the anger of feeling abandoned by decision-makers.

Presence of Elite Allies

It can, nevertheless, be argued that the tightening of the abortion law, which amounted to a virtual ban, was generally rejected by the opposition parties, especially for the way it was implemented through the back door of the delegitimized Constitutional Court. With respect to resisting attempts at illiberalising Poland, the women's strike could count on the support of not only of the left but also of the conservative opposition parties, even if the attitude of PO, for example, did not always meet the expectations of the protest movement. This was different with non-political power holders. The support of the liberal and left-wing media, which all acted as allies and not only reported on the women's strike but openly supported it, was unambiguous, as was the support of public intellectuals, artists, and pop-culture elites. This immense support explains how the women's strike was able to use the division within the Polish political sphere to mobilise, despite the closed political system and the partially restrained solidarity of the conservative parties of the democratic opposition.

State's Capacity and Propensity for Repression

In the first two waves of the women's strike, there was no systematic or significant state repression—at least not during the protests. This fundamentally changed during the last wave, when the government used the pandemic to legitimise violent action in two ways: first, through the use of police violence itself, as when civilian officers used batons to beat protesters for no reason and without warning (Gruca, 2020), or when they ruthlessly cordoned off Jarosław Kaczyński's home (Zubik, 2020). Second, by—presumably—tolerating attacks by far-right activists, some of whom used violence against women activists in the streets (Hume & Zabicka, 2020). Ultimately, this did not lead to less willingness to protest out of fear, but rather to the public perception of this violence against women as a scandal and thus to even greater anger, which is seen

as a central mobilising emotion for this unprecedented protest wave (Blackington, 2023).

Direct Party Mobilisation—Donald Tusk Mobilises for Election Victory

In addition to the civil society mobilisations just described, which, as in the case of the Independence March, were exposed to the takeover efforts of the incumbent PiS party, and the hybrid mobilisations, such as the movement commemorating the crash of the presidential plane near Smoleńsk, there were also significant cases of direct party mobilisations. First and foremost, there were calls by Donald Tusk, who has regularly used this instrument since his return from the post of President of the European Council in November 2019. For example, for the first time on October 10, 2021, when he called for nationwide protests under the slogan "We remain in Europe" (Zostajemy w Europie) after the politically controlled Polish Constitutional Tribunal declared parts of the European Union treaties incompatible with the Polish Constitution. Protests were held in over 100 cities in Poland and abroad, with the largest demonstration in Warsaw gathering tens of thousands of people—organisers claimed as many as 100,000 participants (Krawczyk et al., 2021). Donald Tusk repeated such tactics after the PiS majority voted on April 14, 2023, for a law on a commission to track Russian influence in the years 2007 to 2022. The legal basis contained some questionable powers that went so far that they were considered unconstitutional by experts (Ojczyk, 2023). It was also relatively clear that the aim was to go after Donald Tusk—including his "responsibility" for the plane crash in Smoleńsk—before the upcoming elections in October 2023, which is why the law was also called "lex anti-Tusk" in the independent media (Gawlik, 2023). Tusk then called for a protest on the highly symbolic date of June 4, the day in 1989 when the first semi-free elections were held in then-communist Poland and won by Solidarity in a landslide victory. The protest was joined by other democratic parties, representatives of the independent media, and cultural figures. The mobilisation was a success not only because of the number of participants—the organisers initially planned 50,000, the police spoke of 100,000 to 150,000, independent media spoke of up to 380,000, and the organisers themselves claimed that

500,000 people took part in the event (Pawłowska et al., 2023). Moreover, Civic Platform's approval ratings rose by 5 to 6 percentage points, and PO managed to pull level with PiS in the polls for the first time since 2010 (Fakty, 2023). The president also decided to amend parts of the law, while the PiS majority partially softened the law, both of which amounted to political success. This success was one of the reasons for another similar mobilisation. The immediate cause was the experience of a woman from Kraków who, in accordance with the law, decided to take an abortion pill as the pregnancy endangered her health. She was, nevertheless, interrogated by police in the hospital, strip-searched, and had her cell phone and laptop confiscated—a story that shocked public opinion (Theus, 2023). The "March of a Million Hearts" (Marsz Miliona Serc) called for by Tusk on July 19, 2023, took place on October 1, 2023, just two weeks before the parliamentary elections. The success of the march on June 4, 2023, was surpassed. Although the police spoke of only up to 60,000 participants, independent media estimated the number of demonstrators at 600,000 to 800,000 based on drone videos, while the city of Warsaw and the organisers spoke of as many as one million protesters (Onet, 2023). Regardless of the precise figure, it was the largest demonstration in the history of independent Poland. Although PiS remained the strongest political force in the subsequent elections, the coalition of democratic opposition parties from the Civic Platform, the Third Way, and the Left won a majority. The protest was, therefore, an important moment in the closely contested election campaign and contributed to a change of government.

The political opportunity structures are quite predictable in the case of a classic party mobilisation. The political system was open just like in the other cases described above; the supporting elites included the entire spectrum of democratic opposition in politics, the media, and beyond. The state had no legitimacy (like during the pandemic) to take repressive measures. In addition, despite some concerns about the dominance of Civic Platform (with Tusk being the face of the mobilisation once again), mainly raised by the Third Way, the two marches organised in 2023 consolidated the unity of the democratic opposition parties, and thus breaking the PiS streak of ten consecutive election victories since 2015.

Conclusion

Overall, the impact of protest movements on changes in political power in Poland is profound, even though the link between protest and mainstream politics is less direct than in the countries of Southeast Europe, where waves of protest regularly not only force governments to resign but also give rise to new and, in some cases, influential movement parties (see Dinev and Stoyanov [2025] and Gubernat and Mărgarit [2025] for Bulgaria or Romania in this volume). Nevertheless, contemporary and especially historical protests in Poland have had a significant impact on the changing dynamics of political power. The initial success of the Solidarity movement against the communist regime laid the foundation for political pluralism after 1989. However, as the political consolidation (and later de-consolidation) evolved, so did the nature and impact of protests.

In the early 1990s, Solidarity's transformation from a mass movement to a political actor led to the emergence of several conservative, liberal, and nationalist parties that shaped the early phase of Poland's transformation. Economic hardship and cuts in social services during this period fuelled significant trade union-led protests, which, paradoxically, mobilised against the policies introduced by the very political entities that Solidarity had created, thus explaining why protest in the early 1990s did not question the economic reforms as such but just aimed to adapt them. These protests, largely economic in nature, gradually subsided as Poland's economy recovered, suggesting a correlation between economic stabilisation and reduced protest intensity.

The mid-2000s marked a pivotal shift characterised by the stabilisation of the party system around two post-Solidarity parties: the radicalised conservative Law and Justice (PiS) and the liberal-conservative Civic Platform (PO). This period also saw a shift in protest patterns, with a notable increase in identity-based issues and the emergence of right-wing mobilisations. As the political divide between PiS and PO intensified, the level of protest mobilisations increased, especially during periods of PiS government, which were often marked by controversial policies and democratic backsliding. With the deepening polarisation, the protest mobilisations also fall in line with the partisan division. Protest, regardless of its core claims, was either pro- or anti-governmental, allying with milieus close to or in opposition to the government—sometimes despite its differences, like in the case of PO and the feminist protests. This was different in the

1990s when the trade union Solidarity regularly protested against its own government.

In considering the influence of the POS on the various protest mobilisations described here and its ability to influence the political system itself, it is worth looking at three different contextual factors that have become increasingly relevant in recent decades. Although the Polish political system has been described as relatively open to civil society actors, at least before PiS came to power, all of the case studies described in this chapter functioned at least in part under a government that was considered an opponent and that used both the police and its allies in the media to create a (mostly) derogatory atmosphere. In each case, this did not prevent mobilisation; on the contrary, it shows that mobilisation can be triggered despite narrow POS (see Abrams, 2023; Kocyba & Płuciennicza k, 2023). This can be explained by the quasi-symmetrical polarisation of the Polish political system, in which protest mobilisations that fall within the logic of polarisation can always count on the support of a significant part of the political or media elite—sometimes despite differences on the core demands of a particular mobilisation. In addition to polarisation, another important element is the general shift in the balance of power. During the period under study, there was an increase in radicalised conservative and far-right media actors, who received substantial financial support after PiS came to power in 2015 and were strengthened by the takeover of public broadcasters. All of the case studies described here have thus mobilised against and profited from the instability of the elite. Finally, it should not be underestimated that even the restrictions imposed by the POS, such as the use of police force (within the narrow framework of the rule of law, even under the illiberal PiS government), can lead to greater mobilisation if these (hostile) actions of the security forces are treated discursively as a scandal (due to social norms) and generate even more defiance. This brief overview of the various recent central protest mobilisations in Poland shows that it would be worthwhile to look systematically and comparatively at how deep polarisation and the current trend of shifting discursive power relations affect the influence of POS within liberal democracies and what this, in turn, means for how protests can influence the sphere of politics within them.

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Romania—Democratic Change and Protest Movements

Ruxandra Gubernat and Diana Mărgarit

After the fall of communism, Romania's political and economic transition was marked, like other countries in the region, by privatisation and de-industrialisation, leading to significant socio-economic inequalities and migration waves (Cizmović et al., 2021; Horváth, 2008; Horváth & Anghel, 2009), and social unrest. The first two decades were largely dominated by strikes and protests organised by trade unions against privatisation, layoffs, precarious working conditions, and enterprise restructuring (Varga, 2016; Vasi, 2004). However, those episodes of protest mobilisation were scattered, fragmented, and exclusive in terms of participation. They usually addressed specific categories, with large parts of society remaining passive. Trade unions' influence in mobilising and initiating negotiations with governments reached momentum in the

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90 s but declined the following decade due to legal provisions constantly becoming more restrictive regarding social dialogue as well as radical changes in the industrial landscape (Varga & Freyberg-Inan, 2014). As a counterpoint, that was when the civic sector, namely non-governmental organisations (NGOs) and informal citizens' initiatives, reached visibility. Preparations for the EU membership in the early 2000s, access to international financing programmes, and reforms in democratising state institutions created windows of opportunity for civic actors to emerge (Nimu, 2016).

In many regards, the evolution of civil society was correlated with the significant transformations at the political level. Since 1990, when the first free elections took place, electoral turnout has decreased dramatically, resulting in acute legitimacy crises of the political system. Simultaneously, the multi-party system went through different phases, from the proliferation of parties in the early years of post-communism to party dominance and hegemonic coalitions more recently. The social-democrats and the national liberals—and sometimes their factions—were constant players in the parliamentary arena over these past thirty years (Borbáth, 2019; Gherghina, 2016). Moreover, these parties not only dominated but, in many instances, monopolised the political arena by reshaping the state's structure and governance mechanisms to consolidate their power. This phenomenon, termed "over-particization" by Agh (2002, p. 76), highlights the saturation of the political field by numerous political parties, a common characteristic observed across several other post-communist countries during their political transformations. Soare (2006) describes the Romanian political regime as a "democracy of parties and not of citizens", emphasising the preponderance of political parties to the detriment of other types of associations, such as trade unions or civil society organisations (p. 80).

The volatility of the party system and the instability of political majorities, accompanied oftentimes by ideological ambiguity (Jiglău & Ghergina, 2011), frequent changes in electoral rules (Stănuș & Gheorghiță, 2022) and party switching (Cinpoeș, 2015) increased citizens' distrust in political parties (Iancu & Soare, 2020). Cartelisation (Gherghina, 2018; Mateescu, 2011), seen as the use of public resources to maintain privileges and discourage competitors' appearance, state capture, politicisation of public administration (Volintiru, 2012, pp. 138–139), political clientelism—the use of public resources in order to enhance the

relationship with private donors instead of general electoral support—(Gherghina & Volintiru, 2017) have deepened the gap between political elites and society.

The depreciative perception of the political arena corroborated with the unpopular austerity measures following the economic crisis in 2008–2009 contributed to the accumulation of general dissatisfaction and discontent. During that time, the Occupy movement was reaching global dimensions and its features—leaderless organisation, youngsters' participation, symbolic reappropriation of public spaces, social justice claims, non-violent repertoire, social media as tools for dissemination and mobilisation—were adopted and dispersed to a variety of contentious initiatives, including the ones in Romania. As a result of both indigenous political conditions and exogenous frame resonance, between 2011 and 2018, Romania witnessed the most intense waves of street protest movements since the fall of communism. Ranging from the anti-austerity protests of 2011–2012, the Save Roșia Montană campaign in 2013–2014, the Colectiv nightclub fire protests in 2015, to the demonstrations against Governmental Decree no. 13 (OUG 13) in 2017, and the diaspora protests in August 2018, hundreds of thousands of citizens engaged in demonstrative and partially disruptive repertoires. These movements highlighted the capacity of Romanian citizens to mobilise in pro-democracy and pro-European demonstrations that tackled a variety of anti-governmental and anti-corruption issues. Even though the list of protests was much more diverse than the ones listed above, we decided to focus only on these five episodes due to their mobilisation resourcefulness, visibility in media, and significant political consequences. Besides their affinity in terms of broad claims such as anti-corruption, dissatisfaction with the political elites, and pro-European (EU) demands, these protests progressively gathered a significant number of citizens not only in Bucharest, but also in many other cities.

Previous scholarship on recent Romanian protests either analysed one of the above-mentioned episodes as a case study (Abăseacă, 2018; Arpad, 2017; Creţan & O'Brien, 2020; Gubernat & Rammelt, 2012; 2017; Mărgarit, 2016; Soare & Tufiș, 2021; Vesalon & Creţan, 2013, 2015; Velicu, 2012a, 2012b; Velicu & Kaika, 2017; Volintiru & Buzașu, 2020), or conducted binomial comparative research between similar episodes in different geographical areas (Abăseacă & Pleyers, 2019; Rammelt, 2018) and even comparative historical research on most similar system

design premises (Abăseacă, 2018; Stoica, 2012). At the same time, fact-findings examined participants' incentives and motivations (Abăseacă & Pleyers, 2018; Abăseacă & Pleyers, 2019; Creţan & O'Brien, 2020; Gubernat & Rammelt, 2012; Mărgarit, 2018; Vesalon & Creţan, 2015; Volintiru & Buzaşu, 2020), strategies and repertoires of action (Arpad, 2017; Vesalon & Creţan, 2013), discursive frames (Abăseacă, 2018; Crăciun, 2015; Gubernat & Rammelt, 2021, 2023), and opportunity structures (Mărgarit, 2016; Soare & Tufiş, 2021).

This chapter focuses on the political consequences of this long and sinuous seven-year period of civil unrest. In line with Abăseacă and Pleyers (2019), we posit that protests between 2011 and 2018 are intrinsic to the same cycle of protest, not only in terms of thematic convergence—pro-European, anti-corruption, pro-democratic—but also regarding incentives for participation. We suggest that beyond the immediate and expected outcomes as reflected in slogans, manifestos, and public interventions, this wave of civil demonstrations had deeper political consequences. Employing a mixed-theoretical framework, this chapter integrates the political opportunity structures approach and social movement impact theory to dissect these protest movements. Our investigation draws on a wide range of primary sources, including media reports, manifestos, public statements, and social media posts, as well as an extensive review of the scholarship dedicated to Romanian protest movements. This methodological approach allows us to unravel the complex dynamics between power structures and protest movements in Romania, shedding light on the transformative impact of civic engagement on the country's social and political landscape.

The chapter is structured into three sections: the first one reviews the literature on change and outcomes in social movement studies concerning opportunity structures and critical mass. The second section provides an overview of the five protest movements, emphasising their specificities and similarities. The third section is dedicated to the typology of outcomes which includes four categories derived from the intersection of two dimensions: temporality and purposeness.

Theoretical Framework

Social movements are strategic actors in contentious politics and, oftentimes, promoters or generators of contentious politics. According to McAdam, Tarrow, and Tilly, contentious politics consist of "episodic,

public and collective interaction among makers of claims and their objects when (a) at least one government is a claimant, an object of claims, or a party to the claims and (b) the claims would, if realised, affect the interests of at least one of the claimants" (McAdam et al., 2001, p. 5). In this respect, recent Romanian protests made a case for contentious politics in that civic actors repeatedly challenged the government and, in general, the entire political scene, asking for multiple democratic reforms. In some situations, they opposed certain political decisions such as the gold mining exploitation in the Roșia Montană village in 2013 or the governmental decree that would pardon high-level corruption in 2017. In others, they asked for structural reforms in local administration and health services in order to prevent tragic events such as the fire in the Colectiv club in 2016 or judicial independence and anti-corruption measures in August 2018. Thus, the relationship between power and protest can be understood through the lens of contentious politics (McAdam & Snow, 1996; McAdam et al., 2001; Tarrow, 1994), where societal stakeholders increasingly tried to influence decision-making outside institutionalised politics, to assert a role as a watchdog and to counterbalance state's authority.

Social movements may seek to change institutions, norms (Jenkins & Form, 2005; McCarthy, 1996), values (Earl, 2004), and even structural foundations of the society. Among many civic initiatives, some struggle to bring innovation in terms of the content of politics, procedures, formal and informal interactions, networks, and agencies, while others engage in collective action to block the formers' initiatives or reverse the direction of the change. They use an entire repertoire that addresses what is considered as unjust, unfair, or inefficient. They engage resources, strategies, tactics and different types of actors in order to modify the political scene according to their own visions and goals. However, the relationship between means and goals reflects not only the capacity of the movements to mobilise resources (Giugni, 2008), including their ability to build and/or participate in coalitions and activist networks (Van Dyke & Amos, 2017; Wang et al., 2018), but also their responsiveness to new political and social contexts, actors, and events. Political outcomes can shape the movement even after its activity ends (Bosi, 2016).

Social movements challenge the state (Amenta & Caren, 2004) to react according to their goals and interests, which they portray as legitimate and entitled. Their success depends not only on their ability to articulate their claims but also on their capacity to consolidate the interaction between members and communication with the wider social and political

environment (Diani, 1997). By "politicising solidarity", they formulate solutions to crises (Zamponi et al., 2018). In a similar manner, Romanian protesters address both political and moral crises, relevant for the political elites and society. Their discursive frames engage references to overlapping and coexisting crises: political crises generated by party antagonisms, lack of legitimacy and accountability; moral crises generated by corruption and clientelism; identity crises derived from the difficulty of reconciling reality and projections on how reality should look like.

Civic activism can determine policy, cultural, and institutional consequences (Andrews et al., 2022) within the political and social environment. However, "the interactions between a social movement and its wider social movements field can lead to a variety of positive or adverse and even paradoxical outcomes" (Useem & Goldstone, 2022, p. 33). Thus, change is the simultaneous result of both immediate and gradual transformations (Bosi et al., 2016). Some of them may be part of the claims and grievances formulated by social movements in their interaction with the government and society, while others may be "unintended consequences" (Giugni, 1998, 1999; Useem & Goldstone, 2022, p. 33).

The consequences of a social movement extend beyond the immediacy of their actions and impact "process, institutional practices, organisations and individuals" (Meyer, 2003, p. 35). In addition, the transformative nature of the activism concerns not only the *milieu*, but also the actors involved in contentious politics, including the movement per se (Malamidis, 2021). The process of "forward and backward infiltration" (Klein & Lee, 2019) in which civil society and the political forces are engaged is sinuous and challenging. Correspondingly, the constant interactions, and sometimes clashes between protesters and political authorities, have consequences for all the actors involved. Ultimately, the success of a social movement depends, paradoxically, on its ability to adapt to the constantly occurring transformations and resist the seductive force of popularity. "[…] if the social movement's actions polarise the social movement field, creating enmity and/or opposition among a variety of actors in the wider field, then even if the movement obtains a policy change or formal policy access from its specific target, then that success is unlikely to last" (Useem & Goldstone, 2022, p. 33). This idea can provide a key to understanding why, in spite of their immediate success, structural-changing claims of the Romanian protests remained echoless. Nevertheless, before examining the outcomes of civic activism at that time, a chronology of each of the episodes can contribute to

the understanding of the actors, claims, and strategies used during their interactions.

Protest Movements: An Overview

During the past thirty years, Romania witnessed successive waves of protest mobilisation correlated with shifting political and socio-economic conditions. Soon after the fall of communism, in April 1990, protesters took place in University Square in Bucharest, against the political reconversion of former communist party members into newly democratic politicians. Thus, the Golaniad movement, as it called itself in response to the derogatory term 'hooligan' [*golan*, in Romanian], was the first civic manifestation born on anti-communist and pro-democratic grounds. The anti-communist rhetoric would also dominate in the political arena. The first one involved intellectuals and members of the National Liberal Party (PNL) and the Christian Democratic National Peasants' Party (PNȚCD), which claimed historical roots in two pre-World War II parties forbidden under the dictatorship for more than fifty years. The other one was represented by the National Salvation Front (FSN), which gathered former communists turned into social-democrats whose leader was a former member of the communist nomenklatura. The nowadays Social-Democrat Party (PSD), highly contested during the 2013–2018 protests is the direct descendant of the FSN.

The *golans* accused FSN of monopolistic use of state resources and media in organising the first post-communist elections, portraying it as an obstacle on the path of democratisation and decommunisation of the country (Beck, 1991). In June 1990, miners of the Jiu Valley, endorsed by leaders of the newly installed leftist government, transformed the peaceful pro-democracy demonstrations into riots that violently confronted the participants (Abraham, 1990). University Square would remain a symbol of peaceful and democratic protests (Young et al., 2018) that would be revitalised periodically over the next 30 years. At the same time, it would be a foreshadowing metaphor for the struggles of Romanian civil society in becoming a relevant democratising actor in its future interactions with political authorities.

2011–2012 Protests: From Anti-austerity to Anti-establishment

The first social movement to emerge in the post EU accession period was mobilising around different austerity measures taken by the Democratic Liberal Party (PDL) centre-right government—led by the President Traian Băsescu and Prime Minister Emil Boc—during the winter of 2011/12 (Gubernat & Rammelt, 2012).

As a result of the financial crisis of 2007/2008 and the recession it triggered, there were significant protest movements against austerity measures in countries on the European periphery (della Porta et al., 2017; Giugni & Grasso, 2021; Kriesi et al., 2020). In the winter of 2011/12, protests against the austerity policies introduced by Emil Boc's government also took place in Romania. These protests represent a turning point in Romania's protest history. On the one hand, they set in motion a wave of anti-establishment protests that culminated in the mass protests of 2017, and on the other hand, they initiated the mobilisation framework of "corrupt politicians versus the population".

These protests had important material and social issues as base, notably social precarity and the increase of poverty in Romania, and were urging for a rejuvenation of the political sphere and of political actors, made responsible for the failures of post-communist transformation in the country. They coincided with other movements in Europe and the United States, notably those of *Los Indignados* or local/regional versions of the Occupy Movement while showing certain differences on a programmatic level, the most important being the lack of anti-capitalist rhetoric (Nicolescu, 2012). The ideological discourse against globalisation was poorly developed, the movement focusing on rather pragmatic demands, directed against political authorities. It is worth noting that national authorities were most of the time the target of the occupy protests across Europe and that the demands were mostly based on domestic problems (Kriesi, 2016).

In January 2012, protesters gathered at the University Square, against Boc's decision to privatise emergency health services and dismiss the state secretary who opposed it, Raed Arafat. In line with civic actors, political parties in opposition, namely the social-democrats and liberals who formed the Social Liberal Union (USL), asked Prime Minister Boc to resign. As a consequence, Mihai Răzvan Ungureanu, the Head of the Foreign Intelligence Agency, replaced him for the following three

months. In May, USL took advantage of its majority seats in the Parliament and voted on a motion of censure against Ungureanu. Victor Ponta, the Social-Democrats' leader, became the third PM in just half a year. However, the newly appointed PM's popularity started to decline once the first accusations of plagiarism in his PhD thesis reached the public opinion. In July, the Quotation Mark Protests, organised in several cities that host the largest universities in Romania, foretold the anti-governmental mobilisation that would eventually lead to his resignation in 2015.

Roșia Montană Protests: Anti-corporate and Anti-corruption

The anti-corporate and anti-corruption movement that emerged around the Roșia Montană mining project in late 2013 and ended in February 2014 stands as a significant chapter in Romania's contemporary social and political history. This period marked not only a surge in environmental activism but also highlighted the broader concerns over corporate influence and globalisation's impact on local communities and natural landscapes. The "United, we save Roșia Montană" protests were a crystallisation point for these issues, drawing in a wide array of participants and creating a lasting collective identity among them.

The Roșia Montană mining project was a highly controversial gold mining venture proposed by Roșia Montană Gold Corporation, a company majority-owned by the Canadian firm Gabriel Resources. It aimed to establish Europe's largest open-pit gold mine in the heart of Transylvania, within the Roșia Montană commune. Proponents of the project argued that it would bring significant economic benefits, including job creation and local infrastructure improvements. However, the project faced staunch opposition from environmentalists, local residents, and a broad coalition of activists who were concerned about its potential environmental impact, the use of cyanide in gold extraction, and the destruction of cultural heritage sites in Roșia Montană, which is also a region of significant archaeological and historical importance.

The protests against the Roșia Montană mining project were notable for their scale, intensity, and the diversity of the participants. The movement attracted a new generation of activists: young, well-educated individuals who were increasingly disenchanted with traditional politics and were seeking more direct forms of democratic engagement. This new

wave of activists was characterised by their innovative use of social media and other digital platforms to organise, mobilise, and raise awareness both domestically and internationally.

The Roșia Montană protests had a lasting impact on Romania's civil society and political landscape. They demonstrated the power of grassroots mobilisation and set a precedent for future environmental and social justice movements in the country. The collective identity and networks formed during these protests persisted, playing a critical role in subsequent demonstrations. Moreover, the movement succeeded in bringing the Roșia Montană project to a standstill. In 2016, UNESCO added the Roșia Montană site to its tentative list for World Heritage status, recognising its cultural and historical significance. This decision was seen as a major victory for the activists and a testament to their efforts to protect Romania's natural and cultural heritage from the encroachments of global corporate interests. As such, the anti-corporate, anti-globalisation, and anti-corruption movement that coalesced around the Roșia Montană protests marked a pivotal moment in Romania's post-communist history. It underscored the growing concern among citizens about the environmental and social costs of unfettered corporate activity and globalisation. Furthermore, it showcased the emergence of a new political consciousness among Romania's youth, who were willing to engage deeply with these issues and mobilise for change.

During the six months of street demonstrations, participants would gather each Sunday in the main squares of the cities in Romania and would engage in peripatetic actions meant to popularise their ideas in neighbourhoods outside city centres. Thus, the Save Roșia Montană community reached a high number of supporters not only through social media but also through sit-ins and marches. However, the popularity of the protests was also the result of anti-governmental claims, besides anti-corporate and anti-globalisation ones. By displaying a highly aestheticised and ironic repertoire of contention, protesters accused politicians involved in the central and local administration of complicity with the mining company.

Encouraged by the success of the protests, the United We Save group, along with environmental NGOs, mobilised to protest illegal logging, a controversial and sensitive topic for public opinion. Despite its mimetic articulation of the Roșia Montană case (similar slogans adapted to the idea of protecting the forests and online and offline mobilisation), these protests did not result in significant policy changes (Mărgarit, 2022).

Even though it did not have more than 300 people in the street, we would call to mind the Citizen Strike organised by United We Save prior to the 2014 European Elections. The organisers advocated for the boycott of the vote or vote annulment as a protest against one of the most restrictive electoral laws in Europe. Their call was met with outrage by political actors and parts of mass media and civil society but it put electoral reform on the political agenda. Later on, their reform proposals were adopted and detailed by a larger coalition of civic NGOs who initiated an advocacy campaign under the name Politics without Barriers. Following the presidential election in 2015, whose first round was marked by the impossibility of many Romanian citizens to cast their vote abroad and widespread contestation for that reason within the country, the new president and parliamentary majority agreed to reform both the party and the party financing laws. Following that reform, the registration of political parties was liberalised, the minimum number of required members decreasing from 25.000 to 3 but other obstacles, for example the number of signatures needed to register a candidature, remained the same. Albeit not as a result of a protest, but of an advocacy campaign the electoral reform of 2015 was one of the most influential actions of organised civil society and citizens groups, whose claims weighed more in a period of significant street-level protests.

Colectiv: The Anti-corruption Movement Gaining Dynamic

The tragic fire at the Colectiv nightclub in October 2015 marked another pivotal moment in Romania's recent history, representing not only a profound tragedy but also a catalyst for widespread social and political mobilisation. This event, the deadliest of its kind in Romania since the fall of communism in 1989, saw 64 people perish and another 148 injured, prompting a significant outcry from the public and leading to the Colectiv protests. These demonstrations were not just a response to the fire itself, but also to the systemic corruption and lack of accountability perceived to have contributed to the tragedy. Moreover, even though the anti-corruption issue was reflected in the other previous protests, it was only with Colectiv that it became the leitmotiv of the civic mobilisation. This time, the movement responsible for organising the demonstrations called itself "Corruption kills".

The Colectiv protests were a defining moment of collective action in Romania, with young, educated individuals forming the backbone of the movement (Chiș et al., 2017). This demographic, largely untouched by the ideological divides that characterised older generations, brought forth a new kind of civic engagement (Gubernat & Rammelt, 2017) to describe a form of activism that is innovative, unburdened by previous political and ideological conflicts, and focuses on creating a shared identity and cognitive framework among participants. This approach to activism emphasises collective experiences and shared goals over traditional political ideologies, marking a shift in how civic engagement is conceptualised and enacted.

The significance of the Colectiv protests lies in their ability to galvanise a broad segment of Romanian society around issues of governance, safety regulations, and political accountability. The movement highlighted the potential of civil society to demand change and hold authorities accountable. The aftermath of the protests saw increased scrutiny of public safety regulations, government accountability, and a renewed debate on the role of civic engagement in democratic societies.

Protests lasted a week and, atypically, gathered thousands of participants also in smaller cities, not only in large ones as before. Besides reforms in public administration and health services, protesters asked for PM Victor Ponta's resignation. In his place, Dacian Cioloș, with no political affiliation, was appointed responsible for forming a technocratic government. Similar to the Ungureanu executive, Cioloș's one had a short life and ended once the social-democrats won the general elections.

OUG13: The 2017 Mass Protests

The forth important wave of protests was the one around the controversy created by the OUG 13 on pardoning some corruption-related crimes and amendments on the abuse of power. Sparked in late January and continuing through March 2017, this movement represented the climax of nearly a decade of growing dissatisfaction among the Romanian population. This period of intense civil unrest highlighted a progressive escalation in both the scale and frequency of demonstrations, alongside a shift in the nature of the participants' demands. These protests were predominantly driven by the country's "middle class" or those aspiring to middle-class status, who formed the visible majority of the protestors.

The organisational structure of these protests evolved significantly from the earlier demonstrations of 2011–2012. While the initial protests were characterised by a wide range of demands and a diverse participant base, they were united by a strong sense of coherence and solidarity within their mobilisation networks. As the protest movement progressed, the role of online social networks became increasingly pivotal, often taking the place of formal organising bodies in catalysing and directing the protest activities. By 2017, the dynamic of protest had shifted to inhabit both the online and offline realms, bridging the gap between digital mobilisation and physical demonstrations.

Notably, the recent protests in Romania, including those against OUG 13, have been marked by a lack of fundamental critique against the existing socio-political mechanisms and power structures at both ideological and programmatic levels. When compared with similar movements across the region and even in Western Europe, Romanian activism during this period is distinguished by a lower level of ideological commitment, greater flexibility regarding ideological positions, and a diminished emphasis on formal organisation and active activist groups. This characteristic approach to activism reflects a broader trend within contemporary protest movements, prioritising broad-based engagement and the use of digital platforms for mobilisation over traditional forms of political critique and organisational structures (Chiș et al., 2017; Gubernat & Rammelt, 2017).

The high exposure in international media, which called them "the biggest anti-corruption protest in decades" (Reuters, 2017), and the high number of participants, making it the largest mobilisation in thirty years, led to significant political changes. The two movements responsible for the civic mobilisation were Corruption Kills and #Rezist, whose narratives converged on anti-corruption and anti-governmental claims. Among the successes of the protest were the withdrawal of the ordinance and the resignation of the social-democrat Ministry of Justice.

Diaspora Demonstration in 2018

The "Diaspora at Home" demonstration took place on August 10–11, 2018, as a sequel to the 2017 ones. As its name suggests, it was organised by groups of Romanian citizens living abroad. This initiative was the culmination of a long process of solidarity mobilisation by the Romanian diaspora. Starting with the Roșia Montană protests and continuing with

Colectiv and OUG 13, simultaneous gatherings of Romanian citizens took place in many countries where they emigrated mostly for economic reasons. In addition to the claims formulated by the national participants, the diaspora's contentious narratives focused on condemning the precarious and corrupted domestic conditions that forced them to emigrate, with the cost of sacrificing their families and friends.

The August 10 and 11 protest participants gathered in Victoria Square before the government headquarters. They asked for the resignation of the social-democrat PM, Viorica Dăncilă, the depoliticisation of the judicial system, and a more efficient anti-corruption directorate. The first day of the protests ended after the gendarmerie violently dispersed the participants with gas grenades and water cannons.

A Taxonomic Perspective on the Outcomes of Romanian Protests

Regardless of their specific claims, the five above-mentioned demonstrations belong to the same cycle of protest for a number of reasons, including the participants' profile, strategies and tactics of mobilisation, narratives on the political scene, and expectations. Thus, except for Roșia Montană, which also had a rural component in terms of mobilisation, all the other protests engaged mostly young urban middle-class participants, with rather centre-right ideological preferences, pro-democratic and pro-European orientations. In fact, as a result of an accumulation process throughout those events, the European Union was increasingly portrayed as a supporter and warrantor of democratic norms and values.

In contrast, the domestic political actors, and especially the social-democrats, faced harsh criticism for attempting to compromise the efforts made so far in consolidating democracy. Starting with OUG 13, the anti-government dimension of the protests was overshadowed by the anti-social democratic component. The explanation for this peculiar turn lies in the perception that the doubtful quality of Romanian politics mirrors the performances of the party that led most governments and occupied the highest number of seats in the Parliament so far. The Social-Democratic Party (PSD) became the epitome of party hegemony, prone to clientelism, corruption, and abuse of power.

Overall, protest movements embraced several narratives concerning the political parties, sometimes complementary, sometimes antagonistic. The way protesters pictured political parties and specific actors converged

to some extent to the assumption that structural issues that Romanian society had to deal with were the responsibility of the political elite. The slogan "all the parties, same filth" which was intensively chanted from 2012 until 2018 summarises this idea. Moreover, civic movements engaged in protests between 2013 and 2017 defined their identity through the rejection of politicians. As a result, not only were the protests free of politicians, but they embodied an expression of civic engagement opposed to political activism. The legitimacy of the protests was built on the moralising assumption that the will of people should overcome party-driven interests. In this respect, the 2017 protester's remark eloquently summarises this very idea: "the voice of the street is the strongest political party in Romania" (Grigorescu, 2017). A number of particularities can be observed in what concerns Romania's protest culture, as displayed by these protests. We witnessed a very pacifist way of protesting in recent years; the protesters now try to present themselves as representatives of the "new Romania", entitled to wear the flag with pride and opposing its use by post-communist and/or corrupted political actors. The mobilisation frames identify the corrupt elites (political institutions and especially to political party leaders) as enemies of "modern" Romania. This culture of protest is fuelled by the discrepancy between the expectations raised by the democratisation process and its actual outcome, hence the actual living conditions. Hence, these protests are a succession of anti-establishment social movements.

In terms of claims, all five protest episodes expressed specific expectations that can be summed up under the umbrella of accountability—decision-makers responsible for an unpopular or unjust political reaction should resign. A common denominator among the five waves of protests was discontent with political parties and dissatisfaction with the political performances of those in power. At the same time, their narratives converged to a moralising, essentialist, and idealistic understanding of political ends, governance rules, and institutions, hence politics.

However, the outcomes of these protest movements reveal a certain contrast between their immediate or temporary successes and the long-term structural changes. We hereafter suggest a matrix of outcomes, based on their temporality and purpose. Based on the temporality criteria, we distinguish between immediate and gradual outcomes. In our understanding, the immediate outcomes occurred at or put an end to protests, while the gradual ones may have been initiated during the protests, but evolved even after protests stopped. Following the purpose

Table 1 Outcomes of social movements (2011–2018)

	Intended outcomes	*Unintended outcomes*
Immediate outcomes	1. Resignations, legislative changes, government changes	3. Fragmentation and polarisation
Gradual outcomes	2. New parties	4. Civic apathy (unrealistic expectations)

criteria, we rely on the intended-unintended dichotomy, introduced above. Often, collective action may determine unforeseeable or unexpected changes for the participants. As we shall see next, recent Romanian protests made no exception. From the intersection of the temporality and purpose axis, four categories result: immediate-intended outcomes (1), gradual-intended outcomes (2), immediate-unintended outcomes (3), and gradual-unintended outcomes (4) (Table 1).

In the first category, immediate-intended outcomes, we include changes related to political accountability and reform, namely resignations and legislative and government changes. A direct outcome of the protests, particularly those in 2012 and the Colectiv nightclub fire protests in 2015, was the resignation of high-ranking officials and government leaders (both Prime Minister Emil Boc and Prime Minister Victor Ponta resigned from their positions). In addition, the Minister of Justice, who was considered responsible for the OUG 13, had to quit his office. These resignations were significant victories for the protestors, signalling the power of public dissent in holding officials accountable. In some cases, such as Colectiv, the entire government suffered structural changes as a response to the public backlash. After Victor Ponta resigned, the government was dismissed and replaced with a technocratic one. Taking into consideration the depreciative reputation of political parties at that moment, a technocratic government led by Dacian Cioloș, a former European commissioner, and composed—with one exception—of independent personalities seemed to be a viable option for both the president and important parts of society. The government would have a short-term mandate, and some of its members would become afterwards members of newly born parties.

In the category of immediate-intended outcomes, we further include the rejection of two pieces of legislation with different statuses. The first

is the bill concerning the mining exploitation in Roșia Montană which was submitted to the Parliament in September 2013. If the bill were voted, RMGC would have received a green card for conducting the exploitation, and local opponents would have been forced to leave their houses. Protests ended in February 2014 when the Parliament rejected the bill under public pressure. The second relevant case concerns the protests against OUG 13 in 2017, specifically targeted at preventing the decriminalisation of certain corruption offences. The mass mobilisation successfully pressured the government to repeal the controversial ordinance, showcasing the direct influence of protest movements on legislative processes.

The second section, referring to gradual-intended outcomes, includes newly born parties, namely new parties, which were risen out of anti-establishment grievances and closely related to protests. The protests facilitated the rise of new political parties, such as the Save Romania Union (USR), the Party of Freedom, Unity and Solidarity (PLUS), the Alliance for Romanian Unity (AUR), and Renewing Romania's European Project (REPER), which emerged as significant players in the political arena and succeeded in occupying seats in the Romanian legislative. These parties, rooted in the protest movements, signalled a shift towards a more diverse political landscape, challenging the traditional party system.

The pro-European, anti-corruption movement in Romania, exemplified by entities such as USR, PLUS, and the civic initiative Corruption Kills has significantly influenced the country's political and civic landscape. Central to the mobilisation efforts surrounding the Colectiv nightclub fire and the protests against the OUG 13 decree was a unified message against corruption, effectively communicated both online and offline.

This effective use of communication to mobilise against corruption has not only transformed protest participation into traditional political engagement but has also led to the emergence of new political actors within the Romanian party system. Notably, USR and PLUS emerged as significant forces, with USR evolving from a citizen's initiative into a formal political party by late 2016, under Nicusor Dan, now the mayor of Bucharest. The name of Nicușor Dan is also linked to the Save Roșia Montană campaign, whose name was given after the NGO Save Bucharest, which he founded in 2008.

Their political stance, centred on combating corruption, was epitomised by the "Fără penali în funcții publice" (Without convicted individuals in public office) initiative, which garnered nearly 900,000 signatures

by the end of 2018. This initiative underscored the public's demand for political integrity and paved the way for a proposed referendum.

Before the European Parliament elections in May 2019, USR and PLUS emerged, leading to the centre-left ideology of PLUS melting in the centre-right ideology of PLUS. In 2022, a faction split from USR and created REPER, ideologically closer to the defunct PLUS than USR.

AUR is a nationalist and populist party that was founded in September 2019 and made a surprising entry into Romania's Parliament in the December 6, 2020, general elections, securing 9% of the vote. It gathers different groups affiliated with different ultra-conservative orientations: the radical unionists who push for the unification of Romania and the Republic of Moldova, and the traditionalist anti-LGBTQ and anti-abortion initiatives. The party's campaign strategy blends online efforts with grassroots activism. Despite recognising similarities with the USR regarding anti-establishment messaging, AUR differentiates itself by aligning with European conservatives and reformists, championing the causes of small producers and the Romanian peasants, and underscoring the importance of national identity over the EU membership or affiliation.

The third category concerns immediate-unintended outcomes, which include fragmentation and polarisation of the participants. Starting with Roșia Montană protests and ending with the Diaspora at Home ones, participants were characterised by high heterogeneity. In the case of Roșia Montană for instance, the anti-mining claims were equally supported by environmentalists, nationalists, anti-globalists, and anti-corporatists. Similarly, under the anti-corruption umbrella, the 2013–2014, 2015, 2017 or 2018 protests gathered people dissatisfied with the political system or the ruling party and the structural issues for which the former were the first to blame. For this reason, precise claims other than resignations or the enunciation of the urge for structural changes without properly naming them were hard to articulate.

Last, civic apathy is added to the category of gradual-unintended outcomes. Protests increased public awareness about various issues, including government corruption, public safety regulations, and the importance of democratic processes. This heightened awareness has contributed to an informed and engaged citizenry. This seven-year period saw a strengthening of civil society, with the emergence of numerous groups and organisations dedicated to promoting transparency, accountability, and democratic governance. These entities have continued to play a crucial role in advocating for social and political reforms. There has

been a noticeable shift in Romanian political culture, with an increased demand for transparency, accountability, and participation in the governance process. The protests have contributed to a more vibrant and dynamic political discourse, encouraging greater citizen participation in political life.

However, the post-2018 social and civic *milieu* was rather characterised by apathy. This leads us to the paradoxical observation that civic apathy behaves as a gradual and unintended outcome. The installation of apathy is the consequence of sequences of outcomes. The first phase regards the high expectations from the political actors. The euphoria of the protests, as well as their moralising narratives, raised the standards so high that it may be hard for actors to meet the expectations. Second, repeated failed attempts to find efficient political solutions lead to disappointment and demobilisation. Third, the appropriation of the contentious repertoire by radical actors may discourage the dissatisfied ones from engaging in the absence of ideological compatibilities.

Conclusion

In Romania's recent history, protests have demonstrated a significant capacity to effect short-term political change, influencing both policy decisions and the careers of individual politicians. This phenomenon is indicative of deeper structural issues within the Romanian political system, where the dominance of a few parties limits ideological diversity and competition. Consequently, protests have become an essential avenue for voicing political dissatisfaction, cutting across traditional party lines and ideologies. The dynamic interplay between political parties and protests in Romania highlights the ongoing challenges of democratic consolidation, the legacies of the past, and the evolving demands of its citizenry, emphasising the vital role of protests in the democratic process. They serve not only as reactions to the political elite's actions, but also as a crucial form of political participation capable of steering policy and governance directions. This relationship forms a feedback loop, with the actions of dominant parties prompting public protests, which in turn push for governmental and policy changes, illustrating a political landscape where formal participation through elections and party membership coexists with direct civic engagement (Kaltwasser et al., 2017; Mudde, 2004).

However, a learning curve is evident in the short history of protests in Romania, affecting both protesters and political institutions. Politicians have capitalised on the electorate's short-term memory, exploiting the lack of deep political culture and the ensuing "fatigue" among protestors. Despite waning enthusiasm among protestors, commentators, and analysts, a heightened public awareness of the importance of politics and individual roles in the democratic process persists.

Simultaneously, the region witnesses a significant shift from liberal democracy principles towards populism and nationalism, emphasising traditional values and national identity over transparency, fairness, and social justice. This trend, fuelled by populist strategies that resonate with emotional and cultural sentiments, reflects a critical questioning of liberal democracy's efficacy in addressing modern societal challenges (Eatwell & Goodwin, 2018; Norris & Inglehart, 2019). The rising appeal of populism and nationalism, suggesting a reconfiguration of political priorities, presents formidable challenges for the future of liberal democracy, as societies struggle to balance traditional identities with democratic principles. Hence, the anti-elite discourse of Romanian protests of the past decade made room for the appearance of political parties that present themselves as the "true" representatives of the people against "corrupt" elites.

The ascendance of populism and nationalism marks a transformative shift in the political landscape, standing at a critical juncture in the region's—and Romania's—democratic evolution. As societies navigate this balance, the outcome will significantly influence future political attitudes and governance models, determining the extent to which values such as transparency and social justice can coexist with demands for solidarity and cultural preservation. This ongoing dialogue between protests and political dynamics encapsulates the complex interplay of forces shaping the trajectory of democracy in the region, highlighting the crucial role of civic engagement in confronting the challenges posed by populist trends. This chapter contributes to the understudied topic of the outcomes of social movements in Romania as a case study relevant to the wider context of Central and Eastern Europe. Based on the intersection of two criteria—temporality and purpose—it provides a typology of outcomes which includes four categories—immediate-intended, gradual-intended, immediate-unintended, and gradual-unintended outcomes. However, extended studies on the outcomes of the 2011–2018 protests on the protest arena and the evolution of civic society in Romania are

needed. For instance, future research directions could question if the anti-corruption narratives led to improvements in terms of anti-corruption politics and if the Romanian case is comparable to other states from Central and Southeast Europe.

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Russia—Dynamics of Protest Activity in Putin's Regime

Radzhana Buyantueva

What this chapter will show is that, in Russia, protesting is an essential part of contentious politics despite (or even because of) increasing authoritarianism and repression. In authoritarian states, protest dynamics are largely dependent on the regime's ability to manage civil society and contain discontent through various means. Russia presents an interesting case in this regard. In the last three decades following the dissolution of the Soviet Union, protest activity and the state's responses to it have undergone significant changes. The 1990s, or Boris Yeltsin's era, established favourable political opportunities but offered limited resources for protesting. That period was characterised by a small number of protests, citizens' overall political passivity, and an inability to unite around public issues (Mandel, 2001). Most protests of the 1990s were issue-based and focused on economic demands since economic issues were profound (Petukhov, 2006). Since Vladimir Putin came to power in 2000, Russia has witnessed significant changes in political opportunity structures and

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availability of resources for protesters, which affected the intensity and dynamics of protest activity in the country. In the 2000s-early 2010s, political opportunity structures were wider, with greater political freedoms offering more opportunities to protest. As such, between the mid-2000s and early 2010s, Russia saw a growing wave of protests (e.g., protests against election fraud, protests against the reform of the social benefits system) as well as the formation and development of several movements such as the car drivers' movement and the environmental movement. The protest intensity peaked in the early 2010s when protests were the most numerous and spread across the country, involving a significant part of the urban population. Hundreds of thousands of Russian citizens mobilised to protest parliamentary electoral fraud and Vladimir Putin's return to the presidency. In the following years, protest activity did not reach the level of intensity of the early 2010s due to the state's solidified authoritarianism and strengthened repression. Nevertheless, the state was not able to completely contain protest activity. Up to date, Russians continue mobilising, despite ceaselessly narrowing political opportunities and growing constraints. Since Putin rose to power, the state has undertaken consistent efforts to contain civil society and curb protest activity through various means: policy changes, police repression, campaigns to discredit opposition, censorship, and mobilisation of pro-regime sentiments.

This changing protest environment in Russia has led to an increase in scholarly attention to the topic. There are many studies on various Russian protests and social movements, trying to explain that phenomenon. A number of scholars have begun to examine Russian protests through the prism of social movement theories. Some of them employed resource mobilisation (Flikke, 2004) or new social movement theories (Clément, 2008). Many studies (Cheskin & March, 2015; Dmitriev, 2015; Greene, 2014) analysed Russian protests and social movements in relation to power (the state and authorities), utilising some features of the political process theory. For instance, Robertson (2011) analysed the interrelation between protests and the regime, investigating how elites, political institutions, and society interact with each other. Some studies employ all three approaches (Buyantueva, 2022a; Clément, 2007; Clément et al., 2010; Khaliyi, 2007). On the whole, changing socio-political and economic conditions have had a profound impact on the dynamics of protest activity in Russia, which was reflected in rich scholarly research on the topic.

This chapter adds to this literature by offering an analysis of protest dynamics during Putin's era (from 2000 until the present). To do so, the chapter draws on social movement theories (political process and resource mobilisation approaches) to explore how changes in the political environment and availability of resources affect the protest activity of Russian citizens. The chapter will demonstrate that, despite increased repression and limited political freedoms, there is a potential for a future wave of protest activity when there is an opening in political opportunity structures and adequate resources to mobilise.

The chapter is structured as follows. First, it will outline Russia's political system and political opportunities for protest activity in the post-Soviet period. Then the chapter will focus on the Russian legislation on organisation and participation in protest events. The chapter will proceed with discussing factors affecting protest dynamics in Russia. Finally, it will explore the Kremlin's response to mobilisation and protests.

Russia's Political System and Political Opportunities for Protests

Since the disintegration of the Soviet Union, Russia's political regime has been considered hybrid (Robertson, 2011), semi-authoritarian (Lanskoy & Suthers, 2013), authoritarian (Gel'man, 2015b), electoral authoritarian (White, 2013), or contemporary or new authoritarian (Lewis, 2020). Notwithstanding the exact labelling of the Russian political regime, for many scholars (Gel'man, 2015a; Obydenkova & Libman, 2013; Sakwa, 2015), it demonstrates increasing state repression of the political opposition and efforts to control and/or supervise civil society. I agree with Pain (2011) and Gel'man (2015a) who argue that after the fall of the Soviet Union, Russia failed its transition to democracy, its regime being semi-authoritarian in the 1990s and becoming fully authoritarian in the 2000s, characterised by the highly centralised executive power, limitations of political freedoms, escalating political repression, and exclusion of potential regime challenges.

If we take Sarah Henderson's (2011) model of state-society relations in the post-Soviet years, we see that the Russian state can be distinguished into a 'negligent state' (Yeltin's era) and a 'vigilant state' (Putin's era). During Boris Yeltsin's presidency (1991–1999), Russia was the 'negligent state,' when the state made little attempts to assist or impede activism. Activists and organisations had to rely heavily on foreign (Western)

donors, who had narrowly limited agendas to sponsoring projects and prioritising international (Western) norms and values over local needs (Hemment, 2012). In the harsh economic conditions of impoverishment during the 1990s, the population viewed NGOs as elite-driven and self-interested (Richter, 2002). Since Vladimir Putin became president in 2000, Russia has gradually turned into a 'vigilant state.' The state has assumed a goal to control civil society. As part of that goal, the Kremlin adopted a strategy of 'import substitution': creating domestic incentives to replace foreign donors, and efforts to reshape civil society into one that would assist the regime's goals. Foreign links have become viewed by the Kremlin as a threat to the state and society. In part, that was a reaction to 'colour revolutions' in Georgia (2003), Ukraine (2004), and Kyrgyzstan (2005), which were perceived by the Kremlin as orchestrated by the West (Carothers, 2002). Another reason for tightening state control over civil society was the significant increase of protest activity in the early 2010s, challenging the regime. Putin also intended to contain domestic challengers such as influential oligarchs, who were sponsoring civil society projects (Hemment, 2012).

Since Putin's regime is presently more relevant, this chapter will focus on the direction of state-society relations in Russia in the last two decades. Since Putin acceded to power in 2000, the state has started to show increasingly authoritarian tendencies. While Yeltsin's period demonstrated greater political pluralism, Putin took a path of establishing the superiority of vertical over horizontal decision-making, which has been assured among other means by the removal of opposition political parties from the federal parliament. According to the Russian Constitution, the Russian federal legislature, termed the Federal Assembly, consists of the State Duma, the lower chamber, and the Federation Council, the upper chamber. The Federation Council consists of two representatives from each Russian region. The State Duma consists of 450 elected deputies. In legislative matters, the Duma has more powers than the Council. The laws are adopted by the Duma, approved by the Council, and signed by the President. The Duma may overcome the Council's veto by readopting the law by two-thirds of votes. Under Putin's rule, the Russian parliament has essentially lost its decision-making powers, having to fast-track and rubberstamp the Kremlin's legislative initiatives. In 2002, the electoral threshold for the State Duma, the lower chamber of the federal parliament, was raised from 5 to 7%. After the 2003 elections to the

State Duma, United Russia became the only political party with sufficient power with no other alternative. Notably, the first (unsuccessful) attempt to establish a dominant party regime was undertaken under Yeltsin by creating a pro-Kremlin party Our Home Russia. Putin, in contrast, was rather successful in achieving this goal. United Russia was formed in 2001, becoming the largest party with majority seats in federal and regional legislatures. The party was built drawing on the image of Putin as a strong leader, who brings stability and security to the nation (Remington, 2008). Interestingly, all Russian presidents (Boris Yeltsin, Vladimir Putin, and Dmitry Medvedev) were non-partisan.

These changes displayed Russia's direction to strengthen authoritarianism when elections are a tightly controlled affair without real uncertainty (Levitsky & Way, 2010). While political parties in opposition to the regime can still be organised, they have been effectively excluded from the federal parliament, their protest events have often not been authorised and broken up by the police, and prominent members have been frequently harassed and arrested. The limited possibility to influence the state's decisions through such means as elections left Russian citizens with few alternatives than to use protests as a tactic to be heard (Lankina & Voznaya, 2015).

Despite Putin's increasing authoritarian tendencies, political opportunity structures of the 2000s-early 2010s continued to be at an adequate level for protesting. The organisation of protest events became legally regulated in 2004 when the federal law N54-FZ 'On Meetings, Rallies, Demonstrations, Marches and Pickets' was adopted. According to the law, the authorities could not prohibit a protest event unless it posed a security threat or was organised next to certain places such as presidential residences and court buildings.

Remarkably, Dmitry Medvedev's presidency (2008–2012) took a course of liberalisation and modernisation that was characterised by more governmental openness in decision-making and more public involvement in policy discussions (Sakwa, 2015). That period saw attempts at dialogue between the state and society and greater political opportunities for the development of civil initiatives and social movements (Gel'man, 2015b). At the same time, the period highlighted a growing public discontent with a lack of systemic democratic reforms and blatant corruption. These developments facilitated the increase in protest activity in the late 2000s and early 2010s.

Putin's return to the presidency in 2012 underlined the executive's dominance over state institutions, actively promoting conservative nationalist discourse, built on militarist patriotism, religious ideals, promises of stability, and anti-Western sentiments. The Kremlin has prioritised the securitisation of society, convinced that the West (the USA and the EU in particular) is poised to keep Russia from regaining its status of great power in the global arena. The annexation of Crimea in 2014 and the full-scale war on Ukraine since February 2022 have solidified the dominant discourse. The imagined enemy can now be perceived anywhere and made of anyone. Tightening state control over the media has helped in promoting hegemonic narratives to gain public support for the regime and silencing alternative voices (e.g., regime critics, LGBTQ + activists, feminists). Nowadays, the Kremlin owns or controls through loyal companies all traditional media sources (TV, radio, and press) and has undertaken persistent efforts to contain freedom of expression in the digital space. Regarding digital communications and information exchange, the state has adopted an approach of sovereignty over the internet, tightening control over online content and infrastructure. In 2019, for example, the so-called sovereign internet law was adopted, outlining the development of digital technologies to allow the isolation of domestic internet from the global network. The full-scale invasion of Ukraine has hastened the Kremlin's urge for internet sovereignty, facilitating greater surveillance and censorship of communications and information exchange online. A range of legislative changes has been adopted to limit public discussions online, especially on the topics that challenge the hegemonic discourse, such as political rights, LGBTQ + themes, and the war in Ukraine.

Overall, the Russian political system shows a low level of representation of citizens' interests, a low level of political participation, a high rate of corruption, election manipulations, and a low level of public trust in the government (White, 2012). Putin's rule is characterised by continuous limitations of political freedoms and intensifying repression of alternative opinions to the dominant discourse. We should also remember that the strengthening of repression might be comprehended by citizens as a weakening of the regime (Koesel & Bunce, 2012). Most importantly, activists might respond to repression, or a threat of it, by seizing existing opportunities to protest (Tilly & Tarrow, 2007), which can be seen in the 2017–2018 protests against corruption and the 2022 protests against the war in Ukraine. Since the political stage in Russia became closed to

opposition, it got harder for citizens to influence politics by most means other than protesting. We will take a closer look at the dynamics of protest activity in Russia after discussing Russian legislation on protests.

Russian Legislation on Protests

Russia of the late 1980s–1990s witnessed positive changes in political opportunity structures in the form of decreased repression and greater political freedoms of speech, assembly, and media facilitated by policy changes in the form of *perestroika*, *glasnost*, and consequent liberalisation of society. The 1993 Constitution declared political rights and freedoms, including freedom of peaceful protest. Apart from the Constitution, there was no other legislation regulating protest activity until the mid-2000s. In 2004, the aforementioned federal law 'On Meetings, Rallies, Demonstrations, Marches and Pickets' was adopted to outline the procedure of organising and participating in protest events. It established that if a public event involved more than one participant, event organisers should notify and get approval from the local authorities a few days in advance. This procedure involved the assessment of the possibility of a protest event to be organised in terms of time, place, number of participants, and the threat it poses to participants and other people. According to the law, the authorities could not prohibit such public gatherings unless they posed a security threat or were planned to be held near hazardous or important facilities (e.g., railways, courts, presidential residences, and cultural monuments). Therefore, Russian citizens were free to hold peaceful protests, but it could vary from region to region since, even now, that highly depends on the local authorities that should 'approve' protest events to be organised.

The legislation on protests became stricter in the wake of the 2011–2012 protests for Fair Elections. The legislators tightened the administrative responsibility for violating the legislation on protests: higher fines, administrative detention, and a new type of penalty in the form of compulsory work. In 2014, the legislators introduced criminal responsibility for a repeated violation of the laws on protests, punishable by up to five years in prison, while first-time participation in an unauthorised protest may commonly invoke fines. Since the adoption of this legislative change, around 500 people faced criminal charges for violating the protest legislation, and over 60,000 people were charged for minor offences (Financial Times, 2023).

To contain the involvement of the younger population in protest activity, the legislators introduced administrative and criminal responsibility for organisers of unauthorised protests with participants under 18 years of age.

On the regional level, in the early 2010s, most regions adopted laws allowing protesting in specific places (so-called Hyde Parks) without the authorities' approval. However, many cities (e.g., Saint Petersburg, Moscow, Tomsk) allocated 'Hyde Parks' at remote locations, which decreases the main purpose of protesting, that is, to address the public. The authorities also frequently blocked the organisation of 'unwanted' protests even in these 'Hyde Parks,' using various pretexts such as the spaces being already 'booked' for other events. Therefore, *de jure* the introduction of 'Hyde Parks' could serve as a positive policy change, but de facto the local authorities put various constraints to prevent the organisation of protest events even there.

Protest Dynamics and Factors Affecting It in Russia

In the early 1990s, changes in political opportunity structures proved to be advantageous for the Russians to start mass demonstrations, demanding democratic reforms. Various political parties and organisations (e.g., the Memorial Society, Democratic Russia) appeared and began engaging in protesting. The largest protest event of that period was organised on March 10, 1991, demanding Mikhail Gorbachev's resignation and supporting the candidacy of Boris Yeltsin with around a million participants across the country (Skillen, 2017). Since then until the early 2010s, however, the number of protests was low, and they were mostly concerned with economic grievances (i.e., unemployment, payment of wages) (Robertson, 2011). The low level of protest activity is explained (Busygina & Filipov, 2015; Mandel, 2001; Petukhov, 2006) by the difficult economic situation and, thus, a lack of resources, overall citizens' political inactivity, and inability to unite around public issues.

By the early 2010s, there was an increase in public calls for the rule of law and better governance combined with outrage about widespread corruption and the disappointment about Medvedev's unrealised promises for liberalisation and modernisation. The pensioners' and car drivers' movements present interesting examples of citizen mobilisation defined by specific socio-political issues. The pensioners' movement

emerged in 2005 to protest the cuts in social benefits and other reforms in the pension system in the following years, involving thousands of people across the country. Elderly Russians, young people with leftist views, human rights activists, and trade unionists joined the movement with slogans and banners criticising Putin and his government (Clément, 2008). In response, the Kremlin organised pro-reform protests and made a few concessions such as the gradual increase of the pension age. The car drivers' movement (the so-called Blue Bucket Society) emerged in 2010, protesting the abuse of traffic regulations by bureaucrats, who used blue lights on cars to have priority on the road and frequently endangered the lives of other drivers and pedestrians. Protesting drivers used blue buckets on top of their cars as a symbol of inequality and corruption (Evans, 2018). The drivers' movement challenged various issues such as priority on the road and violation of traffic rules by bureaucrats, expansion of paid parking in urban spaces, and traffic police corruption. The government made some legislative changes in response to the protests. For example, in 2012, Putin signed a decree decreasing the number of cars with priority privileges. However, these concessions were small and not sufficient. To contain the movement, the law was introduced in 2016 with stricter regulations on protests with vehicles such as obtaining approval from the authorities. The movement ceased street protests but is still active on social media, distributing news and advice for drivers.

The intensification of overall protest activity was in the early 2010s, culminating in the protests For Fair Elections that spread across the country between the winter of 2011 and the autumn of 2012. Following Javeline's (2009) and Tucker's (2007) arguments about grievances, the blatant manipulation of elections served as a triggering point when public frustration against the regime turned into mobilisation. The protests For Fair Elections started in December 2011, stirred up by the allegations of poll manipulation during the State Duma elections and the possibility of Putin's return to the presidency. They involved the largest number of participants—tens of thousands of protesters across the country. The protests engaged various groups and political parties with large ideological diversity (e.g., nationalists, monarchists, and liberals), demanding fair elections but not putting forward specific socio-political programmes. The largest number of protest events and participants was in Moscow. For example, a protest organised on December 24, 2011, involved around 100,000 participants. The protests For Fair Elections engaged people, who were previously not involved in protest activity and were generally

apolitical up to that point. Following the protests, the Kremlin introduced the aforementioned stricter legislation on the organisation of protest events.

It is important to note that due to the economic crisis of 2014 protests of that period were mostly concerned with economic issues (e.g., protests of bankrupt bank depositors, protests against increased utility fees, truck drivers protesting a new road fee system). Soon, however, they again switched to more political concerns. In 2017, Russia witnessed the largest wave of opposition protests since the early 2010s. These protests involved thousands of people across the country, protesting corruption. Even though the scope of these protests and the number of participants was significantly lower than in the early 2010s, it still was the highest level of Russians protesting in the last decade. Even protests in smaller cities involved a relatively large number of participants. For instance, on March 26, 2017, a protest in Tyumen, a city in Western Siberia with a population exceeding 800,000 people, drew over 1,500 protesters, while, in contrast, Moscow, home to over 12 million residents, saw around 7,000 people taking part in a protest (Nashgorod.ru, 2017). Similarly to the 2011–2012 For Fair Elections protests, observers noted a large number of protesters, who were previously not involved in political activism (Albats, 2018). The protests were triggered by the online video released by the opposition and anti-corruption activist Alexey Navalny on the alleged corruption of Prime Minister Dmitry Medvedev. Opposition protest activity continued in the following years, spurred by political and economic grievances such as the lack of meaningful competition at the presidential elections, the 2020 constitutional reforms, governmental measures against the COVID-19 pandemic, and pensions reforms. The annexation of Crimea in 2014 and the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 triggered anti-war protests. In March 2022, for example, over 13,000 people across the country went onto the streets to oppose the war, facing police violence and arrests (Human Rights Watch, 2022).

As part of the response to the growing protest activity with political demands, the Kremlin initiated counter-protests and pro-regime events such as concerts and demonstrations organised by the government-supported youth organisations, which will be discussed in more detail later in the chapter.

Having outlined the overall dynamics of protest activity in Russia, let us have a look at the impact of various factors such as networks and organisational basis on it. As various studies (Clément et al., 2010; Gel'man,

2015b) show, material resources and social movement organisations did not play a very substantial role in the mobilisation of Russian citizens. Most protesters (e.g., protests for fair elections, the environmental, feminist, and LGBTQ + movements) lacked numbers and resources. However, it did not deter them from getting involved in protest activity. A significant portion of the urban population across the country engaged in protests, calling for political reforms and addressing social and economic grievances.

An organisational basis does not seem to be an important determinant in protest activity in Russia. Protests and social movements of the 2000s started spontaneously without organisational involvement. The pensioners' movement, for example, emerged from protests and grassroots initiatives against the legislative changes in the social benefits system (Wengle & Rasell, 2008). According to Robertson (2011), an improved economic situation at the beginning of the 2000s has led to the appearance of numerous NGOs. They, however, did not have a significant impact on protests in the 2000s. Some scholars (Daucé, 2010; Henry, 2010) explain it by the fact that, due to the state's continuously increasing repression since Vladimir Putin came to power in 1999, many NGOs were weakened and for the most part refrained from political activity. The lack of resources due to the withdrawal of Western funding can be another explanation for the insignificant role of NGOs in protest activity (Hemment, 2012). NGOs contributed some resources in the form of knowledge, human capital, and infrastructure but at the later stage, their involvement was not critical.

Protest activity of the late 2000s, however, saw greater organisational participation. For example, the 'Save Baikal' movement was initiated and organised by the Irkutsk regional organisation 'Baikal Ecological Wave' in 2011 with a goal of addressing ecological issues and preserving the biodiversity of Lake Baikal located in East Siberia, becoming one of the most active movements in the region. Still, most protests throughout the 2000s–2010s happened spontaneously from grassroots initiatives. For instance, the For Fair Elections protests started spontaneously and later formed into a social movement. Among the largest and most organised social movements, the ones that stood out the most were the environmental movement, the movement against reforms in the housing and urban planning sector, and the car drivers' movement. Most of these movements started from grassroots initiatives. Despite spreading across the country, they lacked organisational stability, strong leadership, and

shared goals to unify them (Busygina & Filippov, 2015). While the environmental movement that emerged in the late 1980s is one of the most long-lasting and widely spread in Russia, it is largely decentralised and lacks organisational strength. The movement consists mostly of grassroots initiative groups and organisations that often form around certain issues and dissolve after addressing them. They have struggled to mobilise larger numbers of activists and have been rarely successful in influencing policy changes. One of the few successes of environmental protests was the cancellation of limestone mining in Bashkortostan, the region located between the Volga River and the Ural Mountains.

Many studies (Clément et al., 2010; Greene, 2014; Gel'man, 2015b) demonstrated that networks played an important role in protest activity in Russia. As some social movement scholars (Diani, 1992; della Porta & Diani, 1999; Melucci, 1989) point out, a social movement presents a network of interactions between individuals, groups, and organisations engaging in collective action to achieve or resist social, political, or economic changes. Thus, the role of networks is critical for mobilisation, being 'a central dynamic for any social movement' (Ash-Garner & Zald, 1987, p. 179). They bring and hold movements together, supplying the means of communication, meeting spaces, and potential leaders. In Russia, as Gel'man (2015b) argues, activists compensated for the lack of resources (e.g., material resources, social movement organisations) by widely employing social media and everyday networks to mobilise protesters. For instance, the movement of defrauded co-investors was started by building interpersonal networks and organising through social media (Clément et al., 2010). The protest networks generated broad 'personalized action frames' (Bennett & Segerberg, 2013) that protesters from various ideological backgrounds could relate to. Such frames were, for example, 'For Fair Election' and 'Against Swindlers and Thieves' that brought diverse groups (e.g., nationalist, leftist, liberal, anarchist, and feminist) into protesting.

Moreover, according to Clément (2008), coalitions present an important factor in the development of Russian protests and social movements. To maintain their activity, various grassroots initiative groups started building coalitions with each other. For example, the Soviets Coordination Union brought together pensioners, students, liberal oppositionists, workers, and independent journalists (Clément et al., 2010). The Petersburg Civic Opposition presents another example of coalition building, consolidating political parties (*Yabloko*, *Nash Vybor* [Our Choice], the

National Bolshevik Party, the Social Democratic Party), trade unionists, and social organisations. In line with Kriesi's (1996) argument, such coalitions mobilised the 'constituency for collective actions' based on 'a political goal' (p. 152).

Digital media has been extensively employed for protesting. Activists' growing digital and security literacy (e.g., the use of security tools and protocols, encrypted communication) helps them to utilise social media for protesting despite the regime's increasing control over the internet (Lokot, 2018). Activists have widely employed digital media to organise protests and criticise the authorities. Despite increasing repression and censorship of digital media, activists have still been able to access and exchange information on protest events online. For instance, Navalny and his team used his social media (YouTube, Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram) to mobilise people in street protests for fair elections and against corruption. Digital media has also been useful in organising protests online. Various forms of online protests such as petition gathering, hashtag activism, hacking attacks, and data leak have spread increasingly, especially in the context of growing legislative limitations and repression of street protests.

Overall, the dynamics of political protests in Russia demonstrate that, despite strengthening state repression, the protest activity of Russian citizens has not been fully contained. However, political opportunities have been narrowing continuously with increasing political constraints and shrinking resource bases.

The State's Response to Citizen Activism and Protest Activity

Putin's regime has responded to persistent dissent by adopting several strategic approaches aimed at containing it, including coercion, diffusion, and de-politicisation. First, the state introduced a range of policy changes to restrain protest activity and limit activists' access to international support. Among the most impactful would be the so-called foreign agent law and undesirable organisations law. The 'foreign agent' law (adopted in 2012 and amended several times) requires politically active Russian organisations and individuals, who receive financial and organisational support from abroad, to register as foreign agents. The law includes media sources and individuals distributing information on social media. If organisations fail to register as foreign agents, they face substantial

fines. If individuals fail to register, they face fines and imprisonment. The 'undesirable organisations' law (adopted in 2015 and amended multiple times) bans foreign and international organisations that threaten Russia's security, public order, and health. The law also prohibits Russian citizens and organisations (even those located abroad) from working with organisations that are labelled 'undesirable.' The label 'foreign agent' allows NGOs to continue their work in the country, albeit under severe restrictions. Being included in the list of 'undesirable organisations' prohibits all kinds of activity in Russia (e.g., having representative offices, working on projects, and transferring money). Because of these legal changes as well as in response to the war in Ukraine and sanctions imposed by the West, many international donors ceased supporting Russian initiatives, which has had a detrimental effect on activist resources.

As part of the state's attempt to cut off international (Western) support, Russian activists face a scarcity of funding. State funding is not enough to compensate for the loss of most foreign financing that has resulted from the above-mentioned crackdown on external influences. Activists have to rely on crowdfunding to cover expenses related to court procedures and administrative fines, although individual donations might diminish further due to tighter governmental control. The authorities find various ways to minimise opposition activists' chances of utilising crowdfunding to collect money even through private donations. For instance, due to pressure from the authorities, Yandex.Money (a popular Russian online payment service) changed its rules making it impossible to donate and collect money through that service for political purposes. Among the first accounts to be blocked on Yandex.Money was an account collecting money for Navalny's election campaign. Thus, the ways of obtaining financial resources for the organisation of protest events were further limited by the state.

Protest activity has also been severely impacted by the legislative changes on the organisation and conduction of protests such as the mentioned above greater administrative and criminal responsibilities for the violation of legislation on protests. Organisations and activists can also be prosecuted under the anti-extremism legislation. The legislation lists several examples of extremist activities, including advocating a forcible change of the constitutional order, justifying terrorism, inciting social, racial, national, or religious strife, claiming racial superiority, and using neo-Nazi symbols. Organisations engaged in such activities are banned in Russia and participation is punishable by jail sentences of up to 10 years.

While the list contains several legitimate targets, it also includes Jehovah's Witnesses and the Mejlis, an elected body that represents Crimean Tatars, as serious threats. In June 2021, Russia adopted a law banning members of extremist organisations from standing in elections for three years. The law targeted regime critics such as the late Alexey Navalny and his team.

The state has also increased repression of opponents by arresting and prosecuting activists. Being under investigation or convicted puts certain constraints on individuals (e.g., limited freedom of movement, inability to run for parliamentary or executive positions). One of the most prominent cases was the 'Bolotnaya Square' case when, in May 2012, a peaceful For Fair Election protest organised in Moscow was met with harsh police violence. Around 400–700 protesters were arrested, several dozens were brought under administrative charges, and 35 were prosecuted under criminal charges. Criminal charges and conviction of the opposition leader and anti-corruption blogger Alexey Navalny for money embezzlement could serve as another example. In August 2020, Navalny fell seriously ill during a flight to Moscow. He was evacuated to Germany for treatment Experts from several countries later concluded that he had been poisoned by a prohibited military-grade nerve agent from the Novichok family. In January 2021, he returned to Russia and was immediately arrested. In March 2022, Navalny was sentenced to 9 years in prison on charges that he allegedly stole from his Anti-Corruption Foundation. He died serving his sentence in February 2024. Another famous case that attracted international attention was the prosecution of the feminist punk band Pussy Riot (two members spent two years in prison) on the grounds of 'hooliganism motivated by religious hatred' for performing a song in February 2012 in a Moscow cathedral criticising Putin and the Russian Orthodox Church. The performers were convicted to prison for 'hooliganism motivated by religious hatred.' This case falls in line with the conservative nationalist anti-Western discourse, promoted by the state and backed by the Russian Orthodox Church. In this vein, the punk rock band's protest action was presented as 'part of a global conspiracy against Russia,' which defiles 'values sacred for the Russian people' (Markov, 2012). As these cases show, the level of repression has been steadily increasing for overall protest activity. However, as Gel'man (2015a) argues, rather than exercising total repression and suppressing protests, the state targeted more prominent activists like Alexey Navalny and Vladimir Kara-Murza, who were more visible and could be easily presented as public enemies. Such

selective targeting served as a preventive measure and warning to potential regime challengers (White, 2012). In this sense, the Kremlin pursued a strategy of 'smart authoritarianism' by allowing a certain level of dissent to construct a notion of accountability for the public (Rosenfeld, 2017). However, in the last few years, the state has assumed a wider range of repression, arresting protesters in large numbers and prosecuting people for various charges such as the distribution of 'fake news' and extremism.

Furthermore, the Kremlin has undertaken continuous efforts to limit internet freedom and establish tighter control over digital communications. The policy changes regarding internet freedom have targeted the mobilisation capacity of digital technologies. Independent news outlets and international social media (e.g., Facebook, TikTok, Instagram, Telegram, and Twitter) were blocked, and social media companies such as Meta were declared extremist and banned in Russia. The authorities monitor internet sources for 'hotbeds of tension,' 'instances of the destabilisation of Russian society,' and 'anti-regime plots' (Sherman, 2022). Online users face a constant threat of administrative and criminal charges when disseminating information that differs from official narratives. As such, the lawmakers introduced the criminal responsibility for the dissemination of 'fake news' about all Russian state bodies working abroad punishable with large fines and prison sentences of up to 15 years. Those who spread false information about state, military, law enforcement, and judiciary bodies can receive a 10-year jail sentence, or up to 15 years if their actions cause 'grave consequences.' Hundreds of people already faced criminal charges and prison sentences for 'fake news' about the war in Ukraine.

The state has also utilised digital technologies to monitor, prosecute, and even prevent street protests. The state used the excuse of fighting the COVID-19 pandemic to tighten the surveillance of Russian citizens through facial recognition technologies and biometric data. When, in 2021, Russians protested the imprisonment of Navalny, the technologies allowed the authorities to find and detain protesters. When, in the summer of 2022, a partial military mobilisation for the war in Ukraine was declared, these technologies were employed to detect draft dodgers. These developments signal the state's direction towards establishing a system of complete digital surveillance with overreaching repressive consequences for protest activity.

Among other tactics, the authorities intimidate and harass website owners, bloggers, and activists to remove information on protests posted

online. For instance, in 2014, following Euromaidan protests in Ukraine, the FSB (the Federal Security Service) demanded VK (formerly known as Vkontakte) social network remove over one hundred activists' groups and share users' private data with security services. VK is a popular Russian social media and social networking service, which was used by activists for building networks and mobilising supporters. After VK refused to comply with the FSB's request, the pro-governmental Mail.ru media group took over VK, effectively making the company fall under governmental control. Nowadays, VK fully cooperates and shares users' data with the authorities, leading to the prosecution of activists. For example, in May 2023, a human rights activist was sentenced to six years in prison on extremism charges for a series of posts on VK. Extremism charges have been frequently used against opposition activists and regime critics. In the wake of the 2022 invasion of Ukraine, one of the most widely employed charges aimed to constrain the employment of digital media has become the distribution of 'fake news' online.

Digital media has also been used by the regime to delegitimise and demobilise political activism. In addition to the state-controlled traditional media's consistent defamation campaigns to discredit activists as traitors of the Russian nation, working for the West, internet trolling has become a popular tool employed by the regime to distribute confusing and contradictory narratives with the goal of defensive de-politicisation (Kurowska & Reshetnikov, 2018). Pro-Kremlin trolls and bots have been actively employed across various social media platforms to cyberbully regime opponents (Sanovich, 2018). For example, prominent regime critics such as the late Boris Nemtsov and Gary Kasparov were frequently targeted by pro-Kremlin social media posts, aiming to discredit their statements. Since TikTok has become popular among the younger population and was used for mobilisation, the state also targeted that online platform to demobilise Russian youth. For example, in 2021, several videos were circulated on TikTok warning children of the implied dangers of street protests and advising them to stay home for safety (Demydova, 2021). Ultimately, the Kremlin has successfully leveraged media resources to regain control over a means of communication (digital media) that initially appeared to benefit the opposition (Spaiser et al., 2017).

The regime has also put a lot of effort into promoting pro-regime sentiments. For example, digital media has been utilised during federal and regional elections to shore up support for the president and incumbent candidates for the federal and regional parliaments (Garina, 2023).

One of the major elements of fostering pro-regime sentiments was the state's active promotion of conservative nationalist discourse. Russian conservative nationalism is drawn on a collective identity of 'Russianness,' patriotism, Tsarist and Soviet nostalgia, and European radical-conservative ideas (Johnson, 2016). The discourse is constructed by juxtaposing conservative traditional values and liberal democratic values. Traditional values (that are inherently Russian and in need of protection) and the rejection of gender norms and LGBTQ + rights (that are foreign, imported from the West) have become particularly powerful narratives, even turning into a point of geopolitical conflict as can be observed in the war on Ukraine (Buyantueva, 2022b). The Kremlin's narratives have also articulated the perceived enemies of the nation, including regime critics, opposition activists, and other organisations and individuals that do not conform to the hegemonic discourse (e.g., feminists, LGBTQ + activists). The narratives were institutionalised in the above-mentioned legislative changes (i.e., the 'foreign agent' law and the ban of 'undesirable' organisations).

Among successful strategies to cultivate pro-regime sentiments was the establishment of groups and organisations such as the *Nashi* [Ours] movement, a Kremlin-backed youth organisation with a firm patriotic and anti-Western stance. The main goal of these groups was to redirect public attention and displace the subjectivity of collective action by organising street protests and other events in support of the regime. For example, according to the *Nashi* manifesto, the movement aimed to uphold the country's values and sovereignty, build an active civil society, and protect Russia from internal and external threats. They had a military rhetoric of patriotism and pronounced hostility towards regime critics, intending to hinder the opposition and disparage Western aid to civil society (Hemment, 2012). The Kremlin utilised such groups and organisations to narrow political opportunities for political protest activity, rally public support, and channel civil discontent through demonstrations in support of the regime (Robertson, 2009). It is important to note that, as Wedeen (1998) argues, citizens of authoritarian states may be coerced or persuaded into acting in support of the regime. Thus, pro-Kremlin protests can be less indicative of an actual level of public support.

Russian repressive legislation has created a divide between officially tolerated 'socially oriented' activism with activities and values that are more closely aligned with the Kremlin's agenda, and 'political' activism that is, in the eyes of the state, linked to the West (Stuvøy, 2020).

Whereas the authorities view political activism with suspicion, they are more welcoming of socially oriented initiatives, which do not challenge official policies and help to fill the gaps left by government action in fields such as healthcare, education, and the arts. However, even these 'socially oriented' initiatives are not completely safe from prosecution. The legislation allows the authorities to declare any individual or organisation that does not align with the state traditionalist nationalist discourse as a 'foreign agent.' For example, many charitable organisations (e.g., organisations that provide support for HIV-positive people, people with diabetes, ingenious peoples of the North, or victims of domestic violence) were labelled 'foreign agents.' As a result, organisations and activists have faced the dilemma of becoming 'non-political' (which is rather difficult considering the loose interpretation of the term by the authorities), abandoning activism, leaving the country, or persisting and facing the risks of being prosecuted.

Conclusion

Drawing on social movement theories, this chapter has discussed the dynamics of Russian protest activity and how changes in the political environment and resources have affected it. Having greater awareness of protest dynamics in Russia's increasingly repressive political climate and shrinking resource basis might offer better insights into protests in other non-democratic states. Instead of utilising one approach, the chapter demonstrates that synthesising certain features of social movement theories can offer a greater understanding of protest activity in authoritarian contexts. As the case of Russia shows, it is important to account for socio-political and economic issues that drive people to protest, while also paying close attention to the political system and resources (protest networks in particular) that are critical for mobilisation. Without positive changes in political opportunity structures to engage in protests, mobilisation is problematic to accomplish. Even having favourable political opportunity structures is not indicative of the emergence of protests if potential protesters do not have the resources to do so. As we could observe throughout Russia's post-Soviet period, Russian citizens, having networks developed through interpersonal connections and social media, have been able to utilise political opportunities and began protesting.

At the same time, people engage in protests with certain goals in mind. The success of protest activity relates to the achievement of their goals.

Such success, however, is highly dependent on the availability of resources (human and material) as well as positive changes in political opportunity structures. As Andrews (2001) argues, in addition to favourable political opportunities any social movement should be organisationally strong to be viewed seriously by the state to initiate policy changes demanded by protesters. That is not the case for Russia, where networks rather than organisational involvement have played a more impactful role in mobilisation. To see a successful outcome, thus, protesters should form and develop social movements with a strong organisational basis.

Most importantly, however, the Russian regime has set out to block any potential political opportunity for protest activity. State repression has intensified significantly, raising the costs of protesting. As a result, Russia faces the issue of a growing number of people leaving its territory for fear of prosecution and in search of asylum abroad, which affects the resource basis of protest activity in the country.

Negative changes in political opportunity structures as well as diminishing resources indicate another issue, that is, the increasing possibility of political passivity, inactivity, and self-censorship. In the current political environment, political protests have little capability to instigate meaningful democratic changes due to the high level of repression as well as weak and disorganised conditions of political activism.

That is not to say that the increase of protest activity in the near future is impossible. In authoritarian regimes, any opening in political opportunity structures adds to the possibility of protesting (Schock, 1999). In Russia, that might facilitate what McAdam (1982) termed 'cognitive liberation,' when people perceive the change in political opportunity structures and recognise it as a potential vulnerability of the regime to begin mobilising. The main challenge is, thus, to sustain collective action until such an opening in political opportunity structures occurs. Protest activity that still continues to persist even at a small scale across the country, despite the strengthened repression, shows future potential and mobilising capacity that might lead to a more democratic system and liberalisation of Russian society. Persisting protesters might be core activists of the potential wave of protests, providing the organisational basis, sustaining networks, and generating other resources for future collective action when they could potentially seize the political opportunity and mobilise dissent.

Competing Interests

The author states that there is no conflict of interest.

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Ukraine—Power and Protest Interplay Amidst Geopolitics

Olga Zelinska

With blurring the boundary between institutionalised and non-institutionalised politics, social movements become a part of a normal political process (Goldstone, 2003; Tarrow, 2021). Protest episodes, carried out by collective social movement actors, are shaped by the various characteristics of the political system. At the same time, the outcomes of contention often involve changes in power relations and shape the system in which they originated. Ukraine's turbulent post-Soviet history, marked by major economic and political transformations and multiple contentious episodes, illustrates this interdependency between power structures and protest mobilisation.

In this chapter, I analyse political contention in post-transition Ukraine. In particular, I focus on two of the largest, in terms of participation, protest episodes: the 2004 Orange Revolution and the 2013–14 Euromaidan/Revolution of Dignity (Khmelko & Pereguda, 2014; Onuch, 2014; Pishchikova & Ogryzko, 2014)[ii]. In 2014 the country

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was hit by Russian aggression, which escalated into a full-scale invasion in 2022. Therefore, I also outline post-Euromaidan political developments and their impact on contentious politics in Ukraine.

Ukraine is a large country with a complicated history and a peculiar geopolitical location. The country's complex landscape of ethnic identities, language preferences, and religious belongings, as well as regional economic development, had long influenced multiple religious, socio-economic, political, and geopolitical cleavages (D'Anieri, 2007). Some scholars consider these cleavages aligned with geographical borders and suggest Ukraine's east–west division as a basis for tracing potential political tensions (see Riabchuk, 2015; Vinnykova & Zaporozhchenko, 2023). Others argue that cleavages are more complex, fluid, and dynamic (Barrington & Herron, 2004; Onuch & Hale, 2022; Грицак, 2002). Still others point to other than territorial bases for the divide (Ishchenko, 2023; Mykhnenko, 2009). Numerous political parties that formed in Ukraine since the 1990s hardly reflected these multiple societal cleavages (Vinnykova & Zaporozhchenko, 2023). Neither the majority of parties have had a coherent membership base nor acted as a linkage mechanism between the state and society (Fedorenko et al., 2016). One of the reasons behind the weak institutionalisation of the party system was the involvement of various financial-industrial groups (FIGs) in politics. Big businesses formed multiple "technical" parties and sponsored (often multiple) existing political projects to further their interests (Whitmore, 2014). The rules of party politics were additionally complicated by the fact that some of the first parties that formed in Ukraine were initially based on former dissident groups and/or civic associations (Rybiy, 2013). This meant that these parties inherited the contentious repertoire of their founders and, as further analysis shows, often used street politics as a tool to improve their position within the broader political field. In the absence of a clear ideological agenda, many political parties often instrumentalised and fuelled (instead of addressing and reconciling) societal cleavages to gain political leverage (Грицак, 2002), which impacted the dynamics of Ukrainian politics, defining groups of incumbents and challengers. Among the many divisive issues, this chapter focuses on the geopolitical orientation cleavage, which arguably had split Ukrainians into proponents of integration with the European Union (EU) and the broader West, and those who favoured closer ties with Russia and other Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) countries. Although some call for a more nuanced approach, highlighting, e.g. positions of those

who preferred neither the EU nor CIS integration prospects (Filippova & Giuliano, 2018), others refer to this geopolitical orientation cleavage as the most salient division in Ukrainian politics that structured party competition consistently over numerous election campaigns (Chaisty & Whitefield, 2018). Additionally, over the years, Ukraine's challengers' protest repertoire expanded, as did the arsenal of coercive and repressive measures incumbents had on hand (Zelinska, 2020). From labour strikes to sit-ins, tent camps, building occupations, road blockages, rallies and marches, to hunger strikes and self-immolation, challengers expanded their repertoire of protest performances and tested society's reaction to these (Onuch, 2014). For incumbent governments, a special police force, "Berkut," was among multiple repressive tools used since the late 1990s to disperse protests (Якимчук, 2013). Co-optation of protest leaders by offering government positions was another effective tool to end protest (Казанський, 2015). Even after seemingly "losing the fight" and agreeing to concessions, incumbents nevertheless managed to retain superiority within the field by altering its rules. Frequent changes in electoral laws in terms of the electoral system (1994, 1998, 2002) and key features of the electoral process (such as raising the age threshold) often deprived challengers of the means to gain lasting leverage (Whitmore, 2014).

With this rich background as a starting point, the chapter aims to trace the interplay between structural conditions and contentious dynamics in Ukraine. Relying on the burgeoning literature on contention in Ukraine, I demonstrate how the frequent alternation of structural conditions affected the change in mobilisation. At the same time, the analysis below is filled with examples of the outcomes of contentious politics feeding directly into the national political set-up. For the empirical evidence, I use election results, official documents, and mainstream media reports. To demonstrate shifts in geopolitical orientation issue salience, I draw on the electoral agendas for the 2007, 2012, 2014, and 2019 parliamentary elections, accessed via the Manifesto project (Volkens et al., 2020). I focus on the Block of Yuliya Tymoshenko/Fatherland and the Party of Regions/Opposition Block as parties that participated in the abovementioned four consecutive electoral campaigns to illustrate how geopolitical orientation cleavage gained salience and transformed during the studied period. The unit of analysis in this chapter is a *contentious episode* rather than a social movement organisation or a social movement. Following a theory outline, I analyse the major properties of the Orange Revolution and Euromaidan. I group these properties into (a) field composition, including key actors,

their resources, interests, and triggers of contention; (b) challenger mobilisation and incumbent response dynamics; and (c) mobilisation outcomes and field settlement. I then focus on post-Euromaidan developments. I offer conclusions and discussion at the end of the chapter.

A Theory of Fields

My analysis is based on the fields conceptual framework (Fligstein & McAdam, 2012). The field framework is particularly useful to study Ukraine, as it presupposes the analysis of positions of multiple collective actors within broader relational fields. A *strategic action field* (SAF) is a constructed meso-level social order in which actors are attuned to and interact with one another based on shared understandings about the purposes of the field, relationships to others in the field, and the rules governing legitimate action in the field (Fligstein & McAdam, 2012). Fields comprise *incumbents* who wield disproportionate influence within a field, *challengers* who occupy less privileged niches within the field and attempt to redefine their own position, and *governance units* charged with overseeing compliance with field rules (Fligstein & McAdam, 2012).

All SAFs *change,* and the impetus for change may be internal and external. An endogenous or exogenous shock, along with the generalised sense of uncertainty, changes the consciousness of field actors by exposing rules taken for granted, calling into question the perceived benefits of those rules, and undermining the calculations on which field relations had been based (Fligstein & McAdam, 2012). In response to such a crisis, challengers mobilise resources and engage in innovative action to reassert the *status quo* by incumbents and/or their allies (Kluttz & Fligstein, 2016). Incumbents, in turn, would use the accumulated resources, including their control over governance units, to preserve the *status quo.* Depending on the ability of the actors to redefine or maintain the balance of power, the field begins to gravitate toward a new—or refurbished—settlement regarding field rules. A field is no longer in crisis when a generalised sense of order and certainty returns, and there is a consensus about the relative positions of incumbents and challengers (Fligstein & McAdam, 2012).

The Orange Revolution

Field Composition

Although popular discontent after the 2004 fraudulent presidential elections formed the political opportunity structure for the Orange Revolution, the key field characteristics were formed earlier. On the one hand, President Leonid Kuchma's incumbent regime enjoyed substantial power and vast administrative resources and, as activists argued, relied heavily on repressive law enforcement in its conflict with the challengers (Солодько, 2011). On the other hand, the 2000–01 "Ukraine without Kuchma" protest campaign, although it ended with no concessions, caused significant reputational damages to the incumbent regime (Onuch, 2014). The parliamentary elections that followed in 2002, enhanced the position of the opposition parties: the Communist party lost votes, and Our Ukraine, led by Viktor Yushchenko, received 119 seats and became the biggest parliamentary faction. The Bloc of Yuliya Tymoshenko received 23 seats, and the Socialist Party got 22. The opposition took over half (170) of the 450 seats (ЦВК, 2002), though enjoyed comparatively limited influence under Ukraine's presidential-parliamentary system of governance (Мацієвський, 2014).

Western democracy-building assistance in the form of training and expertise on party development, although not earmarked for either incumbents or challengers (Kempe & Solonenko, 2005), benefited largely opposition political parties (McFaul, 2007). Support for civil society organisations in general and activist groups and NGOs in particular was crucial for election-related informational and monitoring activities during the campaign (Bunce & Wolchik, 2011; Kempe & Solonenko, 2005; Sushko & Prystaiko, 2006).

Geopolitical orientation gained salience as one of the most divisive issues in the run-up to the 2004 presidential elections. Kuchma's announced successor, Viktor Yanukovych, was seen as a Russia-leaning candidate, and Russian authorities openly supported the Yanukovych campaign. One of the main opposition leaders, Viktor Yushchenko, was portrayed by his opponents as pro-Western (Haran, 2012; Lane, 2008). As the campaign developed, the latter accused Yushchenko of being a radical nationalist who would "oppress" the Russian-speaking population and serve as a "puppet" of the West (see Åslund & McFaul, 2006; Wilson, 2006).

Mobilisation

Despite the rampant vote-rigging during the first, and then the second round of the 2004 presidential elections, the electoral commission announced the victory of Yanukovych. This triggered the national resistance campaign, as Yushchenko accused the regime of electoral fraud and called his supporters to take to the streets. Kyiv central Independence Square (*Maidan Nezalezhnosti*) hosted 17-day protest performances. Protesters blocked access to the presidential office, the government and the parliament buildings. Nearly 2,000 tents went up on the Maidan (УП, 2004c). An estimated 500,000, and in peak moments, up to 2 million, participated in protests (Onuch, 2014). The protests were coordinated by a broad challenger coalition, which included Yushchenko's and other opposition parties, individual members of parliament, and non-governmental organisations ("It's the time!", "I know" initiatives, and student organisations). Although there was disagreement over the extent to the protest was centrally coordinated by the political opposition or more grassroots (McFaul, 2007; Шамайда, 2013), sustaining such large-scale mobilisation would have been impossible without the involvement of various collective actors, including the "ordinary" people living in Kyiv (УП, 2004c). Many "revolutionary symbols," which included bright orange stripes and characteristic chants, were developed by the activists at the grassroots level (Polese & O Beachain, 2011; Солодько, 2005). Incumbents were prepared to use an array of repressive measures to contain the mobilisation (Kuzio, 2010). In 2004, Maidan was surrounded by the Berkut special police force, officially "to guard the public order" (УП, 2004c). An apparent split inside the security forces and their consecutive inability to "clean up" the protests, partially due to unexpectedly large numbers of participants, was one of the reasons behind mobilisation effectiveness (Маціївський, 2014). In Ukraine's regions, many local governments assumed a contentious identity and sided with either the incumbents or the challengers. Kyiv protests diffused to supportive rallies held in Ukraine's western and central provinces (*oblasts*) (Помаранчева революція: хід подій, n.d.). There, city councils protested against the official election results; they declared Yushchenko the winner (УП, 2004a, 2004b). At the same time, eastern Ukraine became the centre of countermovement and support for the incumbents. On November 29, the Donetsk Oblast Council recognised Yanukovych as the legitimately elected president. They issued a decree to hold a referendum on

amending the Constitution and announcing Donetsk regional autonomy within the "Ukrainian Federation." The idea of the autonomy of eastern *oblasts* was also supported by Kharkiv and Luhansk governors and loyal *oblast* councils (Катеринчук, 2005). This apparent split in the country was later used as leverage during negotiations, pushing challengers to accept less-than-optimal field rules as the field settled (Kuzio, 2010).

Field Settlement

Yushchenko, one of the challenger leaders, engaged the governance units by filing a case to the Supreme Court questioning the election results. Following rounds of negotiations, which included the government, the opposition, and international community representatives, the Supreme Court issued the decision that the actions of the election results were illegitimate (УП, 2004d). The so-called third electoral round was held in December 2004 and led to Yushchenko's victory with 52% vote (Помаранчева революція: хід подій n.d.). The decision for the repeated vote was a compromise for both candidates and became an institutional solution to the escalated field crisis and a starting point of field settlement (Мацієвський, 2014). Ukrainian experts consider the outcomes of the 2004 protests a mixed result (5-річчя Помаранчевої революції в оцінках експертів, 2009). Against soft repressions, the Orange Revolution boosted the development of civil society and led to a better international image of Ukraine. Moreover, after Yushchenko's inauguration, the parliament voted for a constitutional reform that limited presidential powers. The amended 2004 Constitution turned Ukraine into a parliamentary-presidential republic (Сапицька & Золотар, 2014), which limited presidential powers and enhanced the role of parliament and political parties. This change in the rules of the field meant that the "winning" challenger coalition gained a less privileged position within the field than expected and that the rules of the game became altered. Nevertheless, this was a new *status quo* all actors accepted, returning (albeit temporarily) a sense of certainty. At the same time, the "victory" of challengers and the restructuring of the field in Ukraine was not in the interest of neighbouring Russia, which initially backed the incumbent candidate. The Kremlin saw the Orange Revolution as a "Western-orchestrated coup" aimed at undermining Russia's influence in its "legitimate" sphere of geopolitical interest (Haran & Burkovsky, 2015; Herd, 2005). After

2004, Moscow increased its support for pro-Russian groups and organisations in Ukraine, especially for those actively promoting western-sceptic and anti-western rhetoric (Zhurzhenko, 2014). During 2005–10, the fusion of politics and big businesses flourished. Some even call the post-Orange revolution period an "oligarchic democracy" (Молдован, 2022). An absence of a single centre of power prevented authoritarian tendencies and contributed to what Way (2015) labelled as "pluralism by default." Some experts further claim that after 2004, the Ukrainian political process became "maidanized," meaning that street protests were increasingly used as leverage in any political dispute (5-річчя Помаранчевої революції в оцінках експертів, 2009). A "negative" challenger coalition, initially assembled to counter the incumbent regime, proved not durable (Beissinger, 2013). Yushchenko and Tymoshenko started an open political conflict that discredited the "revolutionary achievements" (Haran, 2012). This split inside the challenger coalition contributed to dismantling the achieved consensus and to the gradual restructuring of the field. In 2010, Yanukovych consolidated his supporters to win the presidential elections, while his Party of Regions formed a strong majority after the 2012 parliamentary campaign.

Revolution of Dignity

Field Composition

Creeping authoritarianism combined with the legacy of street protests formed the political opportunity structure for Euromaidan 2013–14. After his victory in the 2010 presidential elections, Yanukovych reformed the judiciary, and the loyal Constitutional Court terminated the 2004 Constitution, granting the incumbent president the powers his predecessor, Yushchenko, never enjoyed. Yet another version of the electoral law terminated the participation of political blocs, which reduced the power of the opposition and eliminated small parties from gaining access to the parliament. As intended, the 2012 parliamentary elections solidified the position of Yanukovych's Party of Regions (185 MPs) and their loyal Communist faction (32 MPs) and left a divided and weak opposition: Tymoshenko's Fatherland 101 MPs, PUNCH—40 MPs and Freedom 37 MPs (ЦВК, 2012). Experts noted that during the 2012 electoral campaign, voters were primarily guided by party stance on rapprochement with the EU or with Russia (Fedorenko et al., 2016). Fatherland,

one of the most experienced players in the volatile Ukrainian politics, positioned itself as a defender of the "threatened" interests of the pro-European community. "*We will eliminate the crisis in relations with the European Union*"—opened the agenda's foreign policy section. The party promised to sign and ratify the EU-Ukraine Association Agreement and further achieve visa-free travel with the European Union. At the same time, the "partnership with the Russian Federation" was to be preserved. The incumbent Party of Regions was consistently striving for Ukraine's non-aligned status, combined with "openness" and "good neighbourliness principle." EU membership was seen as "not an end in itself" but as a means of improving the well-being of citizens. The 2012 agenda called for obtaining associate membership in the European Union, creating a free trade zone and removing visa barriers between Ukraine and the EU. That was to be done under the preservation of Ukraine's non-aligned status—"a guarantee of the safety of every citizen," and the simultaneous strengthening of economic cooperation with Russia and other CIS countries. Yanukovych's "soft authoritarian" regime enjoyed its greatest power by 2013 (Валевський, 2014). The president controlled the executive, legislative, and judicial branches, while his administration de facto became the fourth branch of the polity, intervening in the activities of the local and regional administration. This diminished the role of the opposition, including through representative institutions at all levels, as regime-related large corporate interests solidified their influence over parliament. Loyal law enforcement and security services carried out repressions, targeting parliamentary opposition but also independent public organisations, limiting dissent (Цимбал, 2014). Deprived of meaningful legal instruments to impact law-making after the change in the constitution and the elections of 2012, the challengers to the regime reached out to street politics (Lyubashenko, 2014; Рудич, 2014). Calls for a general mobilisation became a "common denominator" which united the heterogeneous agendas of the opposition parties (Цимбал, 2014). Just as in 2004, challengers practised to act collectively. For example, Fatherland and Freedom held a series of protests in the *oblasts* and the capital, Kyiv, during the spring and summer of 2013. Yet, the politically engineered protests failed to attract wider participation beyond party supporters (Цимбал, 2014).

Mobilisation

At a time when the geopolitical cleavage was arguably the most acute in Ukraine, the Ukrainian government's 21 November 2013 decision to suspend the EU-Ukraine Association Agreement triggered popular mobilisation. Following multiple campaign promises, the official foreign policy agenda of Ukrainian EU integration and more than a year of preparations at all levels, the reversal of the European foreign policy course by the government was perceived as a "stolen dream" (Yermolenko, 2014). Challengers assembled a coalition to engage in collective action. The collective actors mobilised first were students and NGO activists from Kyiv, who gathered on *Maidan Nezalezhnosti*. This protest was later called Euromaidan (Wynnyckyj, 2019). In a few days, more than 100,000 participants were participating in the protest (DIF, 2013b). A "political" Maidan emerged on the neighbouring square, organised by the opposition parties. The two Maidans ("civic" and "political") merged a month after the protest began, and both activists and political opposition formed an alliance and entered a joint Maidan council, a protest coordination body. Initially, Euromaidan demanded the resignation of the government and the signing of an Association Agreement (Батьківщина, 2013). After President Yanukovych refused to sign the EU deal, Maidan demanded his impeachment (Gorchinskaya, 2013). Further demands included a return to the 2004 Constitution and a parliamentary-presidential governance model. Incumbents used the loyal security apparatus decisively. A little over a week after the protests began, Berkut special police forces began the violent dispersal of demonstrators on Maidan (Gorchinskaya & Shamota, 2013). As a result, over 60 people, mostly students, were injured, and over 30 were detained. Euromaidan, which started as a nonviolent demonstration for European integration, eventually gave rise to a nationwide movement against the usurpation of power, corruption, police violence, and human rights violations (Колодій, 2014). Tents and barricades emerged as protest performances in central Kyiv (Wynnyckyj, 2019). After the Ukrainian parliament failed to vote on the dismissal of the government, on December 8, the "March of the Million" went on (KyivPost, 2013). The same night, the crowd destroyed the monument of Lenin in Kyiv (DIF, 2013a). Protesters occupied administrative buildings. Following another police attempt to empty the square, the barricades were supported with self-defence units. The Maidan of Kyiv became a fortified area (Wynnyckyj, 2019).

The Kyiv protests also diffused into mass demonstrations in the *oblasts*. Across Ukraine, protesters held rallies—local Maidans—in support of Kyiv Maidan, demanding the resignation of the local Party of Regions members from public offices and issuing other local-level claims (Zelinska, 2015b). A several thousand participant strong protest camp of an Anti-maidan countermovement emerged, centred in a park near the parliament building, supporting the president and his policy. Government-staged and composed mostly of public service employees bussed to Kyiv, this countermovement failed to attract attention and bring considerable leverage to incumbents (Zhurzhenko, 2014). The regime reached, therefore, for other repressive measures. A package of 11 "dictatorial" laws was voted with heavy procedure violations on 16 January 2014. It permitted trials *in absentia*, the abrogation of internet access by the state, and instituted a blanket amnesty to all police officers who may have committed offences against Maidan activists. In addition, its provisions outlawed participation in public unrest, travelling in groups of five cars or more, and erecting tents and stages in public spaces without official permission (Wynnyckyj, 2019). Moreover, the package introduced a notion of "foreign agents." A public organisation was to be labelled as a "foreign agent" if it received funds or property from foreign countries, NGOs, international organisations, or foreign citizens to support its activities and participated in broadly defined "political activity" (Texty, 2014). Many claimed the "foreign agents" law was borrowed from neighbouring Russia, where it was used as a successful dissent suppression tool since the early 2010s (LB, 2014; Вуєць, 2014; Медведєв, 2014; Савицький, 2014; УП, 2014a). Very similar pieces of legislation became law in other countries of the region, such as Georgia, and Hungary (see the chapters in this volume by Tsuladze [2025] for Georgia and Gerö and Kerenyi [2025] for Hungary). However, instead of the freezing effect the incumbent regime would have hoped for, the repressive measures backfired. 19 January 2014 witnessed the first violent clashes between a group of protesters and police in Kyiv as Euromaidan entered into a new stage (Kudelia, 2018). Some protesters, identified as activists of right-radical organisations, began fighting police with Molotov cocktails and bricks (DIF, 2014). Challengers innovated and announced the creation of alternative institutions—People's Councils—to replace the discredited parliament (Батьківщина, 2014). In the *oblasts,* local Maidans announced the creation of local branches of the People's Council. Several oblast and city councils joined the protests and issued statements declaring President

Yanukovych's regime illegal (Zelinska, 2015a), thus assuming the identity of a contentious actor. Mobilisation culminated on 18 February 2014, as law enforcement broke through the barricades on Maidan, prompting protesters' resistance. According to the reports, as a result of the active clashes with police, including snipers, as of February 20, 70 to 100 people were killed, most of them protesters (Лойко, 2014; Станко, 2018), and hundreds more were injured (Chernichkin & Podufalov, 2014). Shocked by the bloodshed, the parliament of Ukraine voted to prohibit the use of firearms in Kyiv and withdraw the military. The opposition leaders and President Yanukovych worked out and signed an Agreement on the settlement of the crisis in Ukraine (Guardian, 2014a)—a compromise aimed at field settlement. A partial success, the deal, however, was not accepted by the Maidan, as activists issued an ultimatum and demanded presidential resignation (УП, 2014b). Responding to Euromaidan demands, on 21 February 2014, the parliament voted to restore the 2004 Constitution, which reduced the president's role in forming the executive and foresaw the formation of the government by a parliamentary coalition of parties. It supported the president's impeachment on 22 February 2014 and set up the snap presidential elections for May 2014. Viktor Yanukovych fled the country (Guardian, 2014b). The new government was appointed, symbolically, on Kyiv's Maidan (Lyubashenko, 2014).

Field Settlement

The political regime underwent drastic changes. Following multiple defections and the escape of its leader, the Party of Regions suffered a considerable loss. A large portion of voters was left unrepresented—a power vacuum (Way, 2015) that impacted the electoral competition. The field rules were also altered, as the restored 2004 Constitution foresaw the increased role of political parties in forming the government. However, in conditions of a persistently weakly institutionalised party system (Rybiy, 2013; Yakymenko, 2017), the reform tended to aggravate existing problems such as the influence of FIGs (Fedorenko et al., 2016; Leshchenko, 2015; Whitmore, 2014). A pro-European and anti-regime social movement in Kyiv was not in the interest of Russia, which had long supported the regime of Yanukovych (Garton Ash & Snyder, 2005). Moscow launched a propaganda campaign, overstating the participation of right-radical activists and presenting the escape of President Yanukovych as a result of a "fascist coup" (УП, 2014d). In March 2014,

Russian troops occupied Crimea. Following a gunpoint referendum, the Russian Federation annexed the peninsula (УП, 2014c). Russia further spurred unrest in the east of the country by encouraging and aiding the seizure of administrative buildings in Donbas (УП, 2014e). This exogenous shock significantly altered the developments inside the strategic action field (Zelinska & Revtiuk, 2023).

Post-Maidan and into the War

The Rise of a Volunteer Movement

Under the new circumstances, the Euromaidan anti-governmental civic activism turned into pro-governmental civic activism (Lyubashenko, 2014). The need to protect the country required activists to reorient their efforts toward helping the army and taking over some responsibilities of the state during the early stages of the war (Zelinska, 2021). Many activists joined irregular armed groups, spontaneous paramilitary formations later integrated within the regular Ukrainian troops, believed to have played a key role in the spring of 2014 in saving eastern Ukraine from being overrun by Russia-supported and regular Russian forces (Fedorenko & Umland, 2022). A network of volunteer initiatives and associations took over dealing with the most acute problems, including logistical support of the military, collection of funds and food for the army, and purchase of medical equipment and medicines for the wounded. Assistance to internally displaced persons (IDPs), which were to a large extent abandoned by the Ukrainian state (Channell-Justice, 2024; Mikheieva & Kuznetsova, 2024; Romanova & Shapovalova, 2020), was among the key priorities of an emergent volunteer movement. Activists' experience of grassroots organisation during Euromaidan played a key role in their further engagement with the volunteer movement (Channell-Justice, 2024; Stepaniuk, 2022; Worschech, 2017; Zhurzhenko, 2014). Some further claim that Euromaidan inaugurated a new Ukrainian political culture or even a distinct identity of a volunteer, who focused on engaging in civic activism and contributing time, money, and ideas for public causes, particularly in response to the situation in eastern Ukraine (Boichak & McKernan, 2022; Shapovalova, 2017).

Reform Effort

Some well-known Euromaidan activists and journalists entered the political sphere, either as candidates running on party lists or independently (Zelinska & Revtiuk, 2023), or joined various initiatives to drive reforms (Huss, 2016). The government of Ukraine implemented a series of reforms, including education, law enforcement, judicial, financial, and public procurement reforms (Nizhnikau, 2022). Another was decommunisation—a highly controversial reform (Oliinyk & Kuzio, 2021) carried out amidst a wave of dismantled Lenin statues across the country (Rozenas & Vlasenko, 2022) and other complex efforts to eradicate Russian cultural influence. Guided by the demands issued by Euromaidan, the government carried out lustration, albeit with questionable success (Zabyelina, 2017). A decentralisation reform was much needed and widely supported and was one of the first, fastest, and most comprehensive reforms implemented by the post-Euromaidan government (Hanushchak et al., 2017). A success, it amounted to a deep transformation of state-society relations in Ukraine. Combined with new taxation rules that motivated small businesses to pay taxes (rather than paying "envelope" salaries) and community mergers, the new drastically larger revenues increased the institutional and financial capacity of local authorities and granted them additional competencies to direct expenditures to issues of primary importance to community residents.

Geopolitical Orientation Cleavage Transformation

Russia's aggressive policy, first and foremost the annexation of Crimea and later the brutal intervention in Donetsk and Luhansk oblasts, radically shifted public opinion in the southern and eastern regions (Bekeshkina, 2017). Overall support for Ukraine's closer ties with Russia and CIS states substantially diminished. In 2014, the eastern Donbas was the only region where a positive attitude toward Ukraine's closer ties with Russia prevailed. By 2015, significant changes had occurred in public opinion in the Donbas as well: while 74% of respondents had a positive attitude toward Ukraine moving closer to Russia in 2013 and 63% did so in 2014, only 41% selected this option in 2015 (Bekeshkina, 2017). The 2014 snap parliamentary election campaign reflected this transformation of geopolitical orientation preferences. The majority of parties that entered the parliament supported Ukraine's European and Euro-Atlantic integration

(Shevel, 2015; Партійна система України до і після Майдану, 2015). Fatherland's 2014 electoral agenda illustrates an increase in EU and West-related mentions following Euromaidan. "*Ukraine must become an integral part of a united Europe*"—stated the agenda. The party promised to further strengthen cooperation with the EU in the field of security and defence and introduce visa-free travel with the EU countries. This document also directly refers to the Russian Federation as the aggressor that waged a war against Ukraine and a state-sponsor of terrorism. Fatherland gained 5,7% of the popular vote in the multi-party constituency (a significant fall compared to 26% in 2012; see (ЦВК, 2012, 2014) and joined a pro-European coalition, together with newly created People's Front, Petro Poroshenko Block and Self-Reliance, and existing Lyashko's Radical Party (Shevel, 2015). Together, a pro-European coalition amounted to a constitutional majority. In 2019, the parliament voted on amendments to the Constitution, which enshrined Ukraine's strategic course to acquire full membership in the European Union and the North Atlantic Treaty Organization to basic law (Укрінформ, 2019). The former incumbent Party of Regions suffered a considerable defeat. Deprived of its leader, the party, for some time, enjoyed a "real internal democracy" (Хоменко, 2014) when its members competed to shape the party agenda in a (semi-)meritocratic way. Many of its members switched to the newly created Opposition Block and balanced different fractions. One group, led by Viktor Medvedchuk—a close associate of Russia's President Vladimir Putin, promoted euro-sceptic and euro-pessimist messages, unable to declare openly its pro-Russian position under the new circumstances (Хоменко, 2014; Шурхало, 2013).

The 2014 electoral agenda portrayed the Opposition Bloc as the peacemaker, calling for "*compromise, overcoming internal disputes, and starting a public dialogue about [Ukraine's] future.*" Its foreign policy section did not directly refer to the EU integration and only mentioned the EU as a mediator in Ukraine-Russia negotiations. Amidst the military conflict, the party called for neutrality and preserving non-aligned status. The 2019 electoral agenda further called the promises of quick victory against Russia "sweet fairy-tales," purposefully spread out by the "bankrupt politicians" who only deepened the crisis in the country. The agenda called immediate restoration of peace in Donbas, lifting the economic blockade of occupied Donbas and Crimea, and the restoration of passenger connection with Russia. In 2012, Opposition Block gathered 9,4% of the popular vote in a multi-party constituency (a significant fall compared to the 30%

its "predecessor" Party of Regions, enjoyed in 2012) and was additionally deprived of its traditional ally, the pro-Russian Communist party, which did not get to parliament in 2014 (ЦВК, 2012, 2014). Moreover, elections were not held in several electoral districts that remained outside the control of the Kyiv government, including in annexed Crimea and war-torn Donbas—regions that largely supported the Party of Regions in the past (Shevel, 2015).

Conclusions and Discussion

This chapter focused on two major contentious episodes in post-transition Ukraine: the 2004 Orange Revolution and the 2013–14 Euromaidan. I illustrated the dynamics between power structures and protest by focusing on increased salience and transformation of a geopolitical orientation cleavage. The 2004 Orange Revolution was often portrayed as Ukraine's choice between pro-Western and pro-Russian geopolitical orientation. This cleavage, either genuine to or instrumentalised by political actors, became one of the dominating themes in the 2012 electoral campaign. The elected government's failure to deliver on EU integration promises spurred the Euromaidan social movement in 2013, which, with an expanded agenda, gradually grew into a Revolution of Dignity as protests entered into 2014. Following the brutal Russian intervention, the geopolitical orientation preferences of Ukrainians transformed, with the eastern vector collapsing. Post-2014, Ukrainian governments had a clear pro-European agenda, with proponents of closer ties with Russia enjoying a marginal role in the Ukrainian political scene.

Equipped with a toolkit developed by the fields framework, I showed how collective incumbents, challengers, and governance units interacted to alter the power balance within the broader Ukrainian political field. The SAF framework proved useful for the analysis of contention, as it demanded accounting for various collective actors, including activist initiatives and NGOs, counter-protesters, financial-industrial groups, law enforcement agencies, local self-governments and courts. Among these, political parties deserve special attention, as they added street protests to their usual repertoire early on in independent Ukraine's history and often assumed an identity of contentious actors since. Big business interests were often fused with party politics. Together, these actors dynamically fought over the field rules, as illustrated by frequent alternations in the electoral law and changes in the Ukrainian constitution following the

Orange Revolution in 2004, its subsequent reversal in 2010, and its return in 2014.

Field framework also allowed tracing contentious politics' emergence and impact by disassembling contentious episodes into field set-up, mobilisation and settlement. I demonstrate how incumbent-challenger negotiated compromises aim to produce a new *status quo* and put an end to escalation, as both with the Orange Revolution negotiations or the short-lived agreement between political opposition and President Yanukovych following Euromaidan. In both cases, poor cohesion inside large and heterogeneous challenger coalitions contributed to quick (in the case of Euromaidan—immediate) rejection of reinstated field equilibrium.

This analysis also underlines the external actors' impact on domestic politics. One example is Russia's persistent support of anti-Western voices inside Ukraine following 2004. Further, Russian direct military intervention and occupation in 2014 was an exogenous shock that altered the developments inside the strategic action field, including the reorientation of much of the post-Euromaidan effort toward the protection of territorial integrity and addressing the IDP crisis. At the same time, the outcomes of contentious politics have the potential to feed directly into national politics and geopolitics. In an escalation of the war that started back in 2014, on 24 February 2022, Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine. It was met with fierce Ukrainian resistance. Various collective actors, some of whom had formed during Euromaidan, have organised to protect the civilian population and stop the advance of Russian troops. In the spring of 2022, spontaneous street protests against Russian forces emerged in occupied settlements in the Ukrainian south and east (Daza, 2022; Герасим & Кельм, 2022). Some consider successful decentralisation as a key factor contributing to local communities resilience and resistance during the Russian invasion and occupation in 2022: residents felt empowered and responsible for their own well-being without waiting for orders from Kyiv (Самигін, 2023). Others connect this resistance to the subtle social change through everyday acts of care and solidarity performed by volunteers across the country following Euromaidan, which fuelled collective efforts to fight off the full-scale Russian invasion (Boichak & McKernan, 2022). A closer look at the impact of social movements in the face of a war, however, remains a subject for further research.

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Conclusions

Resisting the Democratic Backlash: Social Movements in Central and Eastern Europe

Donatella della Porta

There is no doubt that most research on social movement studies has developed mainly in the West and the North of the globe, adapting to the specific socio-economic and political conditions in what have been considered long-established and stable democracies at the core of the capitalist system. In this context, social movement studies have addressed the pacification of old cleavages and the emergence of 'new' movements on issues often called post-materialist (della Porta & Diani, 2020). At the same time, however, social movement studies have been more and more often referred to in research on other geographical areas, with some concepts and assumptions proving helpful in analysing the East and the South of the hemisphere. By focusing on the impact of political opportunities on the collective framing, repertoires of action and organisational structures, the chapters collected in this volume prove the analytic value of the political process and resource mobilisation approaches in understanding contentious politics in Central and Eastern European countries. They

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also help specify concepts and hypotheses widespread in social movement studies, particularly considering the impact of various hybrid regimes and democratic backsliding on the forms and outcomes of contentious politics. They also point at the relevance of the specific interactions between the state and the market in the capitalist semi-periphery and the impact of international dynamics.

Covering in depth contentious politics in many countries in the region, the contributors to this collective volume also help to address an essential question for comparative politics and European studies: what is still typical for 'Central and Eastern European' some 35 years after the breakdown of the Soviet Union and the waves of transition to democracy in the region? In this direction, the research presented here points at some main elements I want to discuss briefly, such as the persistent low quality of democracy, with hybrid regimes often engaged in supporting pro-regime counter mobilisation directed against regime challengers; the still challenging effects of the transformation to a market economy that went together with regime transition; the 'normalisation' (including intensification) of protests with widespread anti-establishment oppositional frames.

The research results presented in this volume allow for more general reflections on contentious politics and democratisation processes. First of all, they confirm the importance of social movements in the various steps of democratisation, as well as de-democratisation processes. In research on democratic transitions, the role of civil society has been considered marginal for a long time. In their seminal work, O'Donnell and Schmitter (1986) observed that: "In some cases and at particular moments of the transition, many of these diverse layers of society may come together to form what we choose to call the popular upsurge. Trade unions, grass-roots movements, religious groups, intellectuals, artists, clergymen, defenders of human rights and professional associations all support each other's efforts toward democratisation and coalesce into a greater whole which identifies itself as the people. Although this is a moment of great expectations, 'regardless of its intensity and of the background from which it emerges, this popular upsurge is always ephemeral'" (pp. 55–56). As Ulfelder (2005) summarised, while most research focuses on elites, even though mass mobilisation is recognised as important in pushing to expand the limits of mere liberalisation and partial democratisation, it is seen as "an 'ephemeral' process vulnerable to elite co-optation, manipulation, exhaustion, and disillusionment" (p. 313).

The relevance of contention has been then stressed in social movement studies, with some attempts to look at social movements in democratisation phases (for a review, Rossi & della Porta, 2009; Schock, 2005; Tilly, 2004). As Ulfelder (2005) synthesised, "Various subsequent studies of democratic transitions have afforded collective actors a more prominent role, allowing for the possibility that mass mobilisation has a substantial impact on the transition process and is sometimes the catalyst that sets a transition in motion" (p. 313). Research on various geographical areas confirmed that democratisation is often linked to contentious dynamics, such as pro-democratic cycles of protest and waves of strikes (cf. Collier, 1999; Foweraker & Landman, 1997). They can affect different steps of the democratisation process. Protests, especially strikes, often constitute precipitating events that start liberalisation, spreading the perception among the authoritarian elites that there is no choice other than opening the regime if they want to avoid an imminent or potential civil war or violent takeover of power by democratic and/or revolutionary actors (e.g. Bermeo, 1997; Wood, 2000). During liberalisation, civil society organisations publicly (re)emerge in a much more visible fashion (O'Donnell & Schmitter, 1986): trade unions, left-wing parties and urban movements, mainly in shantytowns and industrial districts, have all often pushed for democracy (Collier, 1999; Slater, 1985), sometimes in alliance with transnational actors for example in Latin America and in Eastern Europe (Glenn, 2003; Keck & Sikkink, 1998). During the transition to democracy, old movements (labour, ethnic) and new (women's, urban) movements have often participated in large coalitions asking for democratic rights as well as social justice (della Porta et al., 2020; Tarrow, 1995). The importance of protest in transition processes has been observed in Africa (Bratton & Van de Walle, 1994), Latin America and Southern Europe (Collier & Mahoney, 1997). The mobilisation of a pro-democracy coalition of trade unions, political parties, churches and social movements has often been pivotal in supporting the movement towards democracy in the face of contending counter-movements pushing for the restoration of authoritarian/totalitarian regimes.

This involvement from below in the democratisation process was all the more visible in Central and Eastern Europe (CEE). Even within transitology, more systematic attention to civil society in democratisation processes can be found in Linz and Stepan's (1996) model of extended transition, which addresses Eastern European cases. Contrasting it with a political society composed of elites and institutionalised actors, they

suggested that "A robust civil society, with the capacity to generate political alternatives and to monitor government and state, can help transitions get started, help resist reversals, help push transitions to their completion, help consolidate, and help deepen democracy. Therefore, a lively and independent civil society is invaluable at all stages of the democratisation process" (Linz & Stepan, 1996, p. 9). The degree and forms of participation from below have proved consequential also after the episodes of democratisation (della Porta, 2016).

As confirmed for Central and Eastern Europe in this volume, research has proved that social movements are also active during consolidation, a step that is generally considered to start with the first free and open elections, the end of the uncertainty period and/or the implementation of a minimum quality of substantive democracy (Linz & Stepan, 1996; O'Donnell, 1993, 1994; Rossi & della Porta, 2009 for a review). Sometimes this is accompanied by the demobilisation of civil society as organisations as energies are channelled into party politics; in other moments, however, demobilisation does not occur. Social movement organisations mobilised during liberalisation and transition rarely totally disband; on the contrary, democratisation often facilitates the development of social movement organisations. The presence of a tradition of mobilisation, as well as the support for social movements by political parties, unions and religious institutions, can facilitate the maintenance of a high level of protest. In this stage, movements might claim the rights of those who are excluded by 'low-intensity democracies' and ask for a more inclusive democracy (i.e. peasants, employees, indigenous people and women's rights) and the end of authoritarian legacies (Eckstein, 2001; della Porta et al., 2018). Furthermore, movement networks are important in mobilising against persistent exclusionary patterns and authoritarian legacies (Yashar, 2005). Keeping elites under continuous popular pressure after transition can facilitate a successful consolidation (Karatnycky & Ackerman, 2005).

Social movement studies on CEE noted specific trends that characterised the region and related them to the experience of late democratisation and its forms. While assumptions about the weakness of civil society have proliferated, research has indicated the spread of a specific form of transactional contention (Petrova & Tarrow, 2007) based upon the pressure of moderate, professionalised and integrated associations. Given the characteristics of episodes of democratisation in CEE, the stress on civil society as an autonomous sphere beyond the state and the

market (certainly not limited to the region, see della Porta & Steinhilper, 2021) was embedded in the oppositional frames to the authoritarian regimes. Compared with previous waves of democratisation (in particular in Southern Europe in the early 1970s), the analysis of democratisation in CEE highlights in fact the role of citizens' mobilisation rather than the construction of political parties. Even more than for other waves of democratisation, research has noted the important role of participation from below, in the form of either participated pacts or eventful democratisation (della Porta, 2014, 2017). As the weakness of political parties persisted over time, research pointed at the pressure coming from social movements even in the consolidation phase. While the emergence of left-wing actors was challenging, given the legacy of the specific form of authoritarian regimes, citizens mobilised for civic, political and social rights.

However, if civil society was central in theorisation and practices, its forms and roles changed. According to empirical research, the radical view of the civil society that had developed in the opposition in Central and Eastern Europe (as in Latin America) was "tamed" after the transition, when a liberal conception of democracy prevailed. As Baker (1999) summarised, "For the opposition theorists of the 1970s and 1980s, civil society was an explicitly normative concept which held up the ideal of societal space, autonomous from the state, wherein self-management and democracy could be worked out. That is, the idea of civil society was political and prescriptive" (p. 2). Civil society theorists, such as Michnik and Kuron in Poland, Havel and Benda in Czechoslovakia, and Konrad, Kis and Bence in Hungary, "also saw civil society originally in the more positive, or socialist, terms of community and solidarity. Indeed, for many such theorists, civil society indicated a movement towards post-statism, for control of power, while not unimportant, would be insufficient for the fundamental redistribution, or even negation, of power itself. If this was to be achieved, self-management in civil society was necessary" (ibid.). Theorists like Havel considered self-organised structures from below as fundamental loci for and of democracy (Baker, 1999). With different speeds in different countries, a procedural, liberal democracy obscured the substantive claims of the radical conception of civil society, limiting citizens' participation. This happened, indeed, during the consolidation of a model of democracy based on a liberal conception, that was focused on

elected elites and excluded civil society from the true construction of politics and democracy, which had instead to be mediated through political parties.

Also in the CEE region, democratic backlash, if not backsliding, emerges as a common element, although the development paths and the quality of democracy vary greatly in the region. Late democratisation seems, in this sense, still important, even if less so in some countries than in others. As the editors of the volume correctly note, the countries analysed share many similarities but differ in various dimensions, making it difficult to build a single main typology. Certainly, most of the countries covered by the chapters presented in this volume share elements of democratic backlash, even if the degree of democratic quality varies, with democratic backsliding characterising some but not all countries.

While embedded in the very concept of democratic waves, the reflection on contentious politics in Eastern Europe points to the relevance of the different paths to democratisation, with some more advanced in the countries that started the democratisation process in 1989, even if with differences between the Velvet Revolution in then Czechoslovakia as an example of eventful protests, the participated pacts in Hungary and Poland, and the longer and more contested ones in Bulgaria and Romania; the even more arduous path in Southern Eastern Europe, such as Albania and North Macedonia, the partial failure of the Colored revolutions in Georgia and Ukraine, the reversal of liberalisation in Russia and Belarus.

The struggle for democracy and against expanding illiberalism, hence, often comes in the form of anti-establishment protests and campaigns directed against corrupt elites and against the corruption of democracy as a whole. Calls for accountability become, then, often the preferred frame to express discontent with the current state of democracy and elected officials and with autocratic leaders. The struggles for accountability and the rule of law are present in all countries but with more intensity, where civic and political rights are more repressed. According to the Civicus monitor, which assesses the opportunities for civic society going from open to narrowed, obstructed, repressed and closed, in the former Soviet Union, Russia and Belarus were assessed as closed, Georgia as narrowed and Ukraine as obstructed. Narrowed are also the two cases in South Eastern Europe (Albania and North Macedonia). In Central and Eastern Europe, only the Czech Republic (a case of eventful democratisation, see della Porta, 2014) is considered open, with Romania and Bulgaria (with more

troubled path of transition to democracy) following as narrowed and Poland and Hungary (cases of participated pacts) as instead obstructed.

The persistence or even the strengthening of illiberal tendencies explains why protest campaigns against the repression of civil liberties and for horizontal and vertical forms of accountability have been relevant in all the countries covered. The lower the quality of democracy, the higher the focus on the denunciation of corruption and populism by a coalition of oppositional actors. The fight against corruption is central in virtually all covered cases, indicating a perception of limited democratic accountability and uncertain rule of law. The definition of protests as anti-establishment captures this dimension well. Especially in the most authoritarian countries, the fights for democratisation have acquired centrality, with attempts to build very broad anti-establishment coalitions. In Belarus, non-violent resistance emerged through coalitions of civil society organisations, unions and political parties focusing on calls for democracy and resisting heavy repression of protests against electoral fraud (Nikolayenko, 2025). Similarly, protests against the Foreign Agents laws contrasted the captured state in backsliding Georgia (Tsuladze, 2025). In Hungary, since 2010, transactional action contrasted Fidesz in power, mobilising against democratic backsliding (Gerő & Kerényi, 2025). In North Macedonia, students protested against de-democratisation and competitive authoritarianism in what has been called an 'oscillating democracy', and campaigns also opposed corruption and police brutality—among others in the campaign Citizens for Macedonia in 2015 and the Colourful Revolution of 2016 (Stefanovski, 2025). Corruption and the low quality of democracy remained central concerns for protestors in Bulgaria. In Romania, protestors contested state capture by economic interests and corruption, but also the mismanagement that led to the tragic nightclub fire in 2015. The regime's corruption was also targeted by the campaigns against the governmental degrees that reduced penalties for corruption in 2017 and in the anti-corruption Diaspora campaign (Gubernat & Mărgarit, 2025). In Russia, while Putin reversed the liberalisation of the Yeltsin years, waves of protests contested the electoral frauds promoted in the electoral authoritarian regime (Buyantueva, 2025).

Especially in the more authoritarian regimes, repression triggered waves of resistance, as well as counterprotest by pro-regime supporters. In several countries in the region, progressive social movements have in fact seen not only the state-driven backlash, but also the opposition of right-wing and pro-regime protestors. This is not only true for the

post-Soviet Union countries and Russia itself but also for countries of the 1989 peaceful revolutions, especially the ones that are more clearly backsliding, like Hungary and Poland. At the same time, the narrative of a 'foreign-sponsored' civil society has been and is used to shrink the space for anti-establishment organisations in several countries and to support pro-regime groupings selectively.

A common element is also the impact of democratisation on the definition of the nation and international positioning, which has an impact on internal minorities but also on the main directions in the anti-establishment protests. In fact, pro-European Union positions have been more pronounced in the former Soviet Union countries, such as Belarus, Ukraine and Georgia. However, while being a member of the EU reduces the most extreme forms of backsliding, it certainly does not stop even powerful paths of backlash. In Poland, as in Hungary, the space for an autonomous civil society has been much reduced, while pro-regime non-governmental organisations are sponsored. International alliances also played a role in the mobilisations against the Russian war on Ukraine. In Belarus, the escalation in police repression increased since 2020, as protestors contested their government's support to Russia's invasion of Ukraine, workers, women and, especially, young people mobilised in peaceful forms. In the former Soviet Union countries, activists protested the Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2014 and anti-war protests increased with the 'special operations' in Ukraine in 2014 and then in 2022 (Franceschelli & Varese, 2024).

For many of the covered countries, the EU has been important also in terms of market reforms. While the membership or perspective to enter the European Union has opened some opportunities for democratic consolidation, the various conditionalities imposed on the process have created inequalities and discontent. In most countries, the double transformation, at the same time political and economic, has created dissatisfaction about material conditions that have erupted in anti-austerity protests, labour protests and student protests against neoliberal decommodification. According to different traditions and mobilised organisations, these protests have taken various forms, sometimes connecting with other protests on environmental issues or fundamental critiques of the corrupt establishment. In all countries, the regime changes have been accompanied by market reforms, which have produced much dissatisfaction, particularly among workers and students. In Romania, protests have multiplied since 2012 against austerity, and the increasing poverty

and precarity (Gubernat & Mărgarit, 2025). Economic problems triggered waves of contestation in North Macedonia (Stefanovski, 2025). In Albania, since 2011, miners and petro-refinery workers have contested economic politics, and students have opposed neoliberal reforms (Hoxha, 2025). In Bulgaria, protest waves have reacted to neoliberal reforms, with the unions particularly mobilising against structural reform costs; students protested state budget cuts and citizens opposing the rising energy prices (Dinev & Stoyanov, 2025). In the Czech Republic, with the party system focusing on the class dimension, the Stop the Government campaign in 2012 contested austerity policies, and the Million Movement for the Sake of Democracy in 2017–2020 have mobilised an civic ethos against the right-wing populists in power (Vráblíková, 2025). In Hungary, protestors addressed the closing and privatisation of universities (Gerő & Kerényi, 2025). In Russia, the economic reforms were contested in the streets during Yeltsin's presidency and under Putin, with significant opposition to the retrenchment of social benefits following the economic crisis of 2004 (Buyantueva, 2025).

More in general, the research shows that contentious politics is not tamed: even under heavy repression, the citizens are not apathetic. Instead, protests became more extended and mobilised on various claims. Albania, for instance, developed from top-down mobilisation linked to political parties to bottom-up forms (Hoxha, 2025). In Bulgaria, protests have strongly interacted with party politics, increasing electoral instability and opening the way to new parties (Dinev & Stoyanov, 2025). The Czech Republic has also seen growing protests since 2010, mainly on material issues. While the 1989 Velvet Revolution legitimised citizens' protests, transactional forms of contention have been accompanied by street mobilisation (Vráblíková, 2025). In Poland, protests had a huge increase, with progressive actors fighting for citizens' rights and countermovements opposing them (Kocyba, 2025). These dynamics were all the most visible on the issue of abortion, as the government endorsed a petition which claimed to abolish abortion rights altogether, triggering massive demonstrations by the All Poland women's strike in 2016 and the Deja-Vu campaign and black Friday protests in 2018. Also here, the empirical analysis indicates the importance of the democratisation paths, with CEE countries showing increasing and more autonomous protests on labour issues, environmental concerns and gender rights, and for more accountability.

At the same time, the paths towards privatisation and liberalisation have fuelled environmental conflicts against the exploitation of nature for profits. Interestingly, environmental protests are also triggered by economic transformations, and, notably in the EU member states, by extractivist activities and projects of hyper turistification. In Belarus, environmental conflicts take the form of opposition to a nuclear power station (Nikolayenko, 2025). In Georgia, the plans for exploitation of public spaces for profit have been opposed—as in the case of the campaign against the Panorama Tbilisi project (Tsuladze, 2025). In Albania, the citizens mobilised against locally unwanted land uses, including dangerous waste depositories, the hydropower station on Valbona Valley and the Vjosa River dam (Hoxha, 2025). In Bulgaria, especially since 2008, environmental protests opposed the construction of infrastructures for mass tourism on the Black Sea coast and the Vitosha mountain (Dinev & Stoyanov, 2025). In Romania, environmentalists successfully mobilised in the Save Roşia Montană protest in 2013 and against illegal logging (Gubernat & Mărgarit, 2025). In Russia, environmental protests (like the Baikal ecological wave) also spread, along with the contestation of urban planning (Buyantueva, 2025). Some of these campaigns adopt anti-imperialist and anti-colonial collective frames.

In search for common trends in the CEE region so many years after the breakdown of the Soviet Union, the analysis still points to many challenges connected to the triple transition, including regime change, neoliberal reforms and national restructuring. Research has often considered that to succeed, transitions require tactical moderation. So, O'Donnell and Schmitter (1986) warned that "If the opposition menaces the vertical command structure of the armed forces, the territorial integrity of the nation-state, the country's position in international alliances, or the property rights underlying the capitalist economy or if widespread violence recurs, then even bland regime actors will conclude that the costs of tolerance are greater than those of repression" (p. 27). Therefore, democratising actors are advised to avoid explosive redistributive issues, moderate their aims and queue requests and circumscribe the agenda. Parties—not movements—are considered pivotal in these efforts at moderation, acting as an instrument of social and political control and effective demobilisation. In CEE, the regime transitions were not gradual and, to a large extent, were steered from the outside and top-down. Democratic backsliding, as well as authoritarian turns, might be showing the limits of what has been called democratic promotion through

the domestication of civil society (Beichelt et al., 2014). As the research presented in this volume shows, contentious politics through autonomous forms of protests can represent more authentic and effective forms of mobilisation for democracy.

Studying those cases of mobilisation in Central and Eastern Europe, their relationship with power structures, along different regime types but with similar historical paths, enables future students of social movements and of the empirical study of the quality of democracy to provide answers to some of the most pressing issues of our time: How can an inclusive society be constructed in an environment that is ripe of socio-economic inequalities caused by the transition to democracy itself? How can democratic actors resist democratic backsliding or full-scale authoritarianism? What is the role of progressive social movements in these processes? Democratic backsliding, with the spreading of nativist frames by the Far Right, and increasing inequalities are general trends, by far not typical only for Central and Eastern European countries. Nevertheless, in this region, the legacy of the triple transitions is aggravating some of these trends, making reflection on how to contrast them all the more necessary. Similar to research on the Southern periphery that has shown that it is possible to resist democratic backsliding (della Porta, 2020; della Porta et al., 2022), conditions for more inclusive political participation and, ultimately, for more inclusive societies have to be created, have to be fought for, in CEE as elsewhere. Progressive social movements might prove very important for saving democracy by imagining and practising innovative forms of participation and deliberation, spreading knowledge and building solidarities and inclusive collective identities (della Porta, 2013, 2020).

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Socio-Economic Development, Class, and Protest

Maria Grasso and Ruxandra Gubernat

Across Central and Eastern Europe, the growing relevance of socio-economic issues has been leading to a resurgence of protest, as people increasingly demanded accountability and meaningful change in the face of oftentimes degrading living conditions. Tracking and analysing such protests, the current volume reflects on the broader struggle for social justice and a better quality of life in the region, where, despite the promises of the transformation processes that followed the regime changes over 30 years ago, the initial hopes of economic prosperity have remained at least partially unmet, contributing to a growing sense of disillusionment. Therefore, making sense of these dynamics requires an analysis of over time interactions between movements and political power, and those challenges emerging from the different aspects of the transition

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process. In this context, the volume editors emphasised how the "triple transition" led to diverse patterns complicating comparative research approaches (Crăciun & Rammelt, 2025). For that reason, efforts like those in this volume are important for understanding broader dynamics not limited to the region.

Throughout the volume, particular attention is paid to contextualising the problems and aspirations of different social groups, offering insights into the causes and consequences of protests in the region. The volume therefore contributes to uncovering the motivations behind protest movements' demands for social justice and understanding how social class dynamics in particular influence political activism and the formation of collective identities in Central and Eastern Europe.

The dismantling of state-owned enterprises and the introduction of market-oriented policies in all the countries of the region resulted in considerable socio-economic disparities. The emergence of new elites, often comprising former members of the nomenklatura as well as emerging entrepreneurs capitalising on privatisation processes, contrasted sharply with the plight of the majority of workers who faced job losses and declining living standards and social security. The industrial working class in particular was marginalised in the new economic order, struggling with unemployment and underemployment. This period also witnessed the rise of a new social category, the new middle class, characterised by unstable employment and social insecurity, further highlighting the growing inequalities and social fragmentation of the new set-ups emerging in post-transition societies.

A combination of modern aspirations and underlying precariousness marked the urban, young, middle class in Central and Eastern Europe. Chelcea and Druţă (2021) point out that "zombie socialism" influences middle-class protest behaviour in post-socialist societies. They argue that the lingering influence of state socialism and the rise of neoliberalism have created unique conditions for middle-class protests, which often blend demands for economic justice with critiques of the political system. Middle-class youth are particularly active in new forms of political participation, considered to be an indicator of the ever-evolving nature of middle-class protest behaviour. This demographic group, often comprising recent graduates and young professionals (the sons and daughters of the post-transition precariat), was drawn to rapidly growing urban centres where they sought better job opportunities and a higher standard of living. However, many faced short-term contracts, freelance

work, and a lack of job security, reflecting broader trends of labour market flexibilisation across the globe. This employment situation made them particularly vulnerable to economic fluctuations and downturns, undermining their financial stability and long-term planning. Despite their cosmopolitan outlook and digital fluency, the lack of robust social safety nets compounded their sense of economic insecurity, which influenced their political and social attitudes, driving them to frequently advocate for more transparent governance. As citizens were faced with the realities of the economic transition and sought to assert their rights and demands in the evolving political landscape, this resulted in waves of protests across Central and Eastern Europe spurred, mainly in the 2010s, driven by disillusionment with the promises of capitalism, which many believed had failed to deliver prosperity. Often led by this new middle class, and driven by disappointment and leveraging their resources, education, and organisational skills to challenge government policies, protests highlighted the presence of a profound crisis of legitimacy for the new democratic governments in the region (Engler et al., 2019; Gubernat & Rammelt, 2021; Onuch, 2014).

The contributions to this volume focus attention on key themes in scholarship on protest and contention relating to status, class, or socio-economic grievances. Hoxha's (2025) chapter offers a nuanced analysis of Albania's protest movements, identifying two distinct forms: top-down mobilisations led by political actors for electoral legitimacy and bottom-up movements driven by citizens advocating for socio-economic and environmental issues. This dual approach shows the flexibility and dynamism of protest movements in responding to various political and social demands. The case of Albania is characterised by the tension between political parties representing established interests, which often leads protests to consolidate power and grassroots movements, including protests led by students and environmental activists that focus on specific socio-economic grievances. The middle class is often caught between these forces, with a growing segment actively participating in grassroots mobilisations to demand more transparency and social justice.

Nikolayenko's (2025) study of Belarus examines the diverse issues driving protest movements, including election integrity, environmental concerns, national identity, and socio-economic grievances. Here, the focus is on the state's authoritarian control and civil society's resilience in the face of severe repression, with grassroots movements challenging a well-established authoritarian regime. Despite the risks associated with

state repression, middle-class actors have been at the forefront of advocating for democratic reforms and resisting the state's coercive apparatus. Their role is marked by a persistent struggle against state control and a push for civil liberties.

Dinev and Stoyanov (2025), for Bulgaria, observe that the middle class, particularly in urban areas, has been central to anti-corruption movements, reflecting broader economic disparities and the challenges of a neoliberal transition. Particularly in Sofia, it has been a significant force in protest movements, such as the green and anti-corruption protests, primarily driven by young, educated, and mobile cosmopolitans demanding greater political participation and transparency. The rise of new political parties, such as "We Continue the Change" (PP) and "Democratic Bulgaria" (DB), often reflects the aspirations and frustrations of the urban middle class. These parties emerged from protest movements and sought to address issues like corruption and the rule of law, resonating with middle-class voters.

Vráblíková's (2025) work on the Czech Republic traces the evolution of protest movements from pro-democratic mobilisations in the early 1990s to contemporary contestations against neoliberal austerity and technocratic populism. This progression demonstrates how protest movements can adapt to changing political and economic contexts, continuously influencing policy directions and governance structures. The chapter underscores the enduring impact of protest movements on shaping the trajectory of national political and economic transformations. The portrayal of protests, especially those driven by the middle class, often revolves around a civic ethos of morality and civility positioned above everyday political conflicts. This framing, rooted in the legacy of Václav Havel and the anti-communist movement, presents protest as a moral imperative against corrupt elites rather than routine political engagement. While political participation is generally low, the middle class has demonstrated the capacity for large-scale mobilisation during critical moments, as seen in the "Stop the Government" and "Million Moments" protests. These movements galvanised significant public support, although they were seen as exceptional rather than a norm in political activism in the Czech Republic.

Tsuladze's (2025) chapter on Georgia explores protests against large-scale environmental projects, anti-democratic elite decisions, and foreign policy issues. The response to these protests, including state repression and restrictions on civil society, highlights the ongoing struggle between

grassroots demands for democratic accountability and state efforts to maintain control. The contention over EU integration exemplifies how protest movements can influence a country's international alignment and democratic development, with an active, young middle class indicating a heightened political consciousness and a desire to influence policy and government accountability. The government's attempts to label NGOs as foreign agents and the introduction of laws targeting civil society organisations can be seen as direct challenges to the middle class, who are often the backbone of such civic initiatives. These actions threaten to curtail the influence and operations of organisations that advocate for the interests of the middle class.

Gerő and Kerényi (2025) analyse the post-2010 surge in protest activities in Hungary, particularly against the Orban regime's autocratisation. Their work highlights the role of social movements in fostering social integration and providing a platform for dissent in increasingly autocratic contexts. Hungary's economic model is characterised by centralisation and close ties with foreign capital, while emphasising national sovereignty. As many Hungarian citizens resisted the increasing authoritarianism and economic inequality that have accompanied Orban's policies, widespread protest movements appeared in the country. The Hungary chapter illustrates how these movements and the supporting civil society can serve as critical counterweights to authoritarian tendencies, promoting democratic norms, and mobilising opposition against autocratic governance.

Stefanovski's (2025) focus on coalition-building between social movements and political parties in North Macedonia reveals the importance of alliances in pushing for democratic reforms and the rule of law. The struggles over national identity and EU integration highlight how protests can influence domestic and international political trajectories. This chapter underscores the strategic importance of coalition-building in enhancing the effectiveness of protest movements.

Kocyba (2025) identifies the dual nature of mobilisations in Poland, with progressive movements defending the rule of law and individual liberties and regressive counter-mobilisations from the conservative right. This dichotomy illustrates the interplay between social forces and their influence on national policies and societal norms. The chapter demonstrates how protest movements can embody diverse and often opposing political agendas, reflecting the polarised nature of contemporary political landscapes. The middle class in Poland has been actively involved in various forms of protest mobilisation, often aligning with broader

civil society movements or directly with political parties. The chapter categorises mobilisations into grassroots movements like the All-Poland Women's Strike, which has seen significant middle-class participation, especially in protests against restrictive abortion laws; direct party mobilisation, involving political parties, such as the PO under Donald Tusk, organising protests and often drawing middle-class participants concerned about issues like the rule of law and European integration; and hybrid mobilisations, characterised by a mix of civil society and political party involvement, such as the March of Independence, which sees participation from both far-right groups and mainstream conservative elements.

Gubernat and Mărgarit (2025) detail the impact of anti-austerity protests in Romania, showing how initial mobilisations can trigger subsequent waves of activism that exert continuous pressure on political systems. Their analysis points to the potential for sustained protest activity to drive political change and accountability. This chapter highlights the role of protest movements in maintaining pressure on political elites and fostering ongoing political engagement and reform, with the middle class emerging as a key driver of civic engagement and protests, particularly around issues of anti-corruption and good governance.

Buyantueva (2025) discusses the increasing autocratisation of the Russian regime and its impact on protest movements. The support for opposition figures like Alexey Navalny and the response to the 2022 war against Ukraine illustrate the high stakes of political dissent and the regime's efforts to suppress it through militarisation and policing. This chapter underscores the significant challenges protest movements face in highly repressive environments and their potential to galvanise opposition despite severe repression. The state's response to protests, especially those involving the middle class, has been marked by this increasing repression. This includes legal restrictions, police crackdowns, and the use of state-controlled media to discredit protest movements. The government's efforts to curtail foreign funding for NGOs and to limit digital freedom are presented as attempts to weaken the middle class's ability to organise and sustain protest movements. The middle class's participation in protests often embodies a clash between modern, liberal values and the conservative, nationalist discourse promoted by the state. This ideological divide is a significant factor in the state's efforts to suppress protest activity, as the government seeks to maintain control over the country's cultural and ideological narrative.

Zelenska's (2025) examination of Ukraine highlights the role of protests in democratisation, nation-building, and European integration, mainly through significant events like the Orange Revolution (2004) and the Euromaidan/Revolution of Dignity (2013–2014). As political parties and financial-industrial groups (FIGs) have exploited societal cleavages, including class distinctions, for political gain, the middle class is presented as having an essential role in these movements, as they sought to challenge the status quo and advocate for a more transparent and democratic political system. This emphasises the transformative power of protest movements and the aspirations for political reform and European integration. The chapter demonstrates how large-scale mobilisations can have lasting impacts on national trajectories and international alignments.

The countries in the regions have experienced a range of political transitions, from post-communist democratisation to the challenges of competitive authoritarianism, with the middle class frequently playing a key role in advocating for democratic reforms, transparency, and accountability. In many cases, the middle class is portrayed as instrumental in organising and participating in protests and having a more substantial alignment with democratic and European values. As argued throughout the chapters, their involvement in protests can often be associated with a discourse on a broader societal push for modernisation, the rule of law, and resistance against corruption and authoritarianism. Even if many cases show that, across the region, the middle class consistently emerges as a significant actor in advocating for democratic reforms, transparency, and social justice, their specific roles and effectiveness vary based on the political context. In more authoritarian contexts like Belarus and Russia, the middle class faces severe repression but still plays a critical role in pushing back against the state.

In contrast, in relatively open systems like the Czech Republic, Romania and Poland, the middle class has more opportunities to influence political discourse and policy through sustained activism. Some countries, such as Georgia and Ukraine, are heavily focused on geopolitical orientation and governance issues, often driven by aspirations for European integration. In others, like Bulgaria, the focus is more on combating corruption and ensuring accountability within existing political structures. The involvement of professionalised NGOs and the use of digital platforms varies, with some countries relying heavily on these channels for middle-class mobilisation (like the Czech Republic). In contrast, others see more direct street protests and civic engagement (Ukraine

and Georgia, e.g.). The economic grievances of the middle class are a common mobilising factor, though the emphasis differs. Protests often address broader socio-economic issues in countries experiencing significant economic polarisation, such as Bulgaria and Romania. At the same time, in more politically repressive environments, the focus tends to be more on political rights and freedoms.

However, vulnerable groups became increasingly active in protests, mainly after the economic crisis of 2008, with many protests throughout the 2010s challenging government corruption and degrading living standards. The effects of the crisis were particularly visible among the unemployed or the pensioners. In many countries, austerity measures imposed by governments to stabilise economies further accentuated the negative effects of the neoliberal transformation in the region, leading to public discontent. In Hungary, the government introduced austerity measures that disproportionately affected the poorest segments of the population and favoured foreign capital. Romania (Gubernat & Mărgarit, 2025) experienced, in 2012, what many considered to be its first wave of significant protests (Abăseacă & Pleyers, 2019; Rammelt, 2018; Stoiciu, 2019), fuelled by discontent over austerity measures that included a reform of the healthcare system, cuts to public sector wages and social benefits. The protests were a culmination of frustration with corruption and the perceived indifference of the political elite to the hardships faced by ordinary citizens. The economic downturn led to demonstrations mainly in Bucharest, where movement participation mirrored the wide diversity of the social groups affected. In Bulgaria (Dinev & Stoyanov, 2025), public anger was directed at rising utility costs, corruption, and the oligarchic nature of the economy, which left many people struggling to make ends meet. The 2013 protests, which included pensioners and the unemployed, led to the resignation of the government, highlighting the extent of public discontent. Poland (Kocyba, 2025) managed to avoid the worst of the recession, but the crisis still led to social unrest, particularly among workers in industries hit hard by the global downturn. Protests in Poland were often led by trade unions, which organised strikes and demonstrations against job cuts and wage freezes. In Ukraine (Zelinska, 2025), the global financial crisis exacerbated existing economic challenges. The government's attempts to stabilise the economy through austerity measures were met with large-scale protests, particularly in Kyiv. The economic crisis also played a role in the broader political instability that culminated in the Euromaidan protests of 2013–2014. In North

Macedonia (Stefanovski, 2025), the crisis led to widespread dissatisfaction with the government. Protests in Skopje in 2009 and 2010 were driven by unemployment among young people, and rising poverty. These demonstrations reflected broader concerns about the economic future and the ability of the political system to deliver meaningful change for its citizens.

The chapters collectively illustrate how protest movements can arise from diverse social bases and coalitions, how emerging grievances and thwarted aspirations shape political agendas and encounter varying degrees of repression. Central and Eastern Europe has been suggested to have a weak civil society but this picture has been increasingly challenged (Baća, 2024; Bernhard, 2020; Jacobsson & Korolczuk, 2017; Jacobsson & Saxonberg, 2016) and Western dominance in the study of social movements and civil society should be revised (Ekiert & Kubik, 2017b; Foa & Ekiert, 2017; Gagyi, 2021a, 2021b;Heller & Schmidt, 2024). The volume also clearly highlights another critical area for making sense of current developments, that is, the role of major geopolitical cleavages, areas of influence and outlook in terms of whether nations look to Europe and the United States (West) or Russia (East).

In terms of future promising avenues, more research is needed on outcomes of protest and their effectiveness even beyond Eastern Europe on many key questions (Giugni & Bosi, 2012; Giugni et al., 1999; Meyer, 2021; Bosi et al., 2016). Among others, cultural impacts, interactions with institutional politics, the effectiveness of various protest strategies and outcomes in influencing policy, political discourse, and societal change, how social movements shape collective identities, public discourse, and social norms are all critical aspects deserving future work (della Porta & Zamponi, 2022; Giugni & Grasso, 2019b; Van Dyke & Taylor, 2018). Outcomes also including unintended consequences (Jasper et al., 2022; Meyer, 2021; Rucht, 2023) or long-term cultural change (Kaldor & Selchow, 2015) including the institutionalisation of social movements into movement parties or social and political organisation (della Porta et al., 2017; Fiket et al., 2024a; Giugni & Grasso, 2019c; Varvarousis et al., 2021)—all areas which deserve further scrutiny. Paying particular attention to socio-economic problems and grievances, long-term economic development and increasing inequalities, or class dynamics and class specific opportunities, can, as the volume shows, not only widen our understanding of why protests occur at one moment rather than another, in one place rather than another, but help us comprehend what

problems society faces and what potential avenues are available (Grasso & Giugni, 2016; Grasso et al., 2019).

As Norris (2022) notes, the decision to become politically active is driven by calculations on the potential benefits and risks. Compared to the West, many activists in East and Central Europe still today face many more risks. Anti-government activism may support the struggle for democracy but it can come at a high price for those who engage in it in authoritarian or repressive contexts. As such, from the early mobilisations and colour revolutions it is surprising that individuals engage at all in these more challenging contexts. Despite this, people have come to the streets to challenge what they see as corruption, injustices, and negative dynamics that could be improved or rectified through adequate political action.

Worsening socio-economic conditions particularly those leading to suddenly appearing socio-economic grievances against the backdrop of broader, long-term class dynamics strongly impact on such calculations. The volume shows that dissatisfaction, notably with long-term results of the economic and political transformations, has had an important role for leading to social conflict across diverse contexts though the forms of course vary owing to the diverse opportunities, constraints, such as the degree of autocratisation or the level of political cohesion of the urban middle classes and their patterns of alliances with other social groups affected and aggravated by deteriorating economic conditions and other relevant negative dynamics. Governments and political institutions not addressing such issues are at risk of being vehemently challenged or potentially even ousted by protest movements and replaced by new—often populist—challengers, becoming bystanders of a new political transformation. One lesson to be learned from the volume, certainly not limited to the region is that in order to protect what is left of the democratic advances and of civil liberties of the past, decision-makers, governments, and societal stakeholders need to address the long-term consequences of an economic system that centres around profits rather than people and that has not held up to the promises for widespread prosperity and opportunity. Frustrations with increasing disparities and inequalities in the region, combined with the aspirations and hopes after the regime changes, will lead to ongoing challenges to political power.

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The Facets of Mobilisation. Why Is Liberal Civil Society Losing Momentum in Central and Eastern Europe?

Cristian Pîrvulescu

All countries in Central and Eastern Europe have a fundamental connection with violence and protest. One could even argue that protest is constitutive of the new post-communist political order. However, within this protest, which connected the region to the third wave of democratisation, we find both the opportunities and the challenges related to modernisation, defined as Westernisation and democratisation.

The political and economic change processes were marked by the violence of the initial protest and the magnitude of the change, coupled with its ideological ambiguity. This is because all these states were emerging from the communist regime that had been traumatically imposed on them. Thus, the third wave of democratisation (Huntington, 1991) did not resemble the previous two. Civil society was a crucial factor in the emergence of post-communist political regimes in all former communist states, regardless of whether the system change was negotiated or revolutionary. But gradually, civil society changed both its orientation

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and dynamics. Two decades after the emergence of liberal democracy, after Central European states, the Western Balkans, and the Baltic states joined the EU between 2004 and 2013, civil society became increasingly exposed to various attacks and, at best, entered a defensive stance. In some cases, it was transformed, following the Russian model of legislation concerning foreign agents (Nimmo, 2015), into a ghost of the Past.

Political developments in Central and Eastern Europe after the fall of communism reflect the complexity of the processes of totalitarian deconstruction and democratic (re-)construction amid geopolitical reconfiguration. The political and civic opposition and protest movements, both before and after the revolution, evolved or regressed not only based on each country's history but also on regional specificities and geopolitical constraints. The fall of communism did not leave much time for the new states and their societies to consolidate democracy as a series of crises unfolded, ranging from the economic-financial crisis to the ecological crisis. The continuously changing geopolitical conditions, from the fall of the USSR to the war in Ukraine, played an essential role in facilitating or, on the contrary, blocking the process of political change so that the greater the distance from Russia—whether physical or ideological—the more significant the changes could be.

Historical Continuity

Post-communist social and political processes are part of a complex history that involves both the complicated relationships among the three empires that marked previous centuries—Tsarist, Habsburg, and later Austro-Hungarian, or Ottoman—and the relationship with the West, particularly with France and Germany in the nineteenth century, and after World War I, with the USA. Therefore, liberal democracy put down roots better where there was a specific historical tradition (Inglehart & Welzel, 2005), but even there, it had a thin social base. This is because the challenges and risks threatening democracy—from democratic regression to authoritarianism, passing through corruption and political polarisation—erode the already fragile support for democracy (Diamond, 1999). On the other hand, the abrupt transition to a market economy was difficult (Dabrowski, 2004), and even if it did not generate widespread protests, it was a significant cause of the revival of interwar vileness in Central European states and in Russia, of imperialism modelled on

pre-World War I Orthodoxy. Contrary to those who believed with optimism that in this part of the world, after 1989, history would restart, as Haraszti (1990) or Garton Ash (1990) suggested, democratic processes could not escape the influences of historical factors.

These changes in rhythm affected civic and political pro-democratic mobilisation at different paces. But what can explain this different pace? As Michael Bernhard (Bernhard, 1993) highlighted, even during the interwar period, in the case of authoritarian-military regimes like that of József Pilsudski in Poland and Miklós Horthy in Hungary, civil society managed to resist authoritarian tendencies. These survival strategies allowed for the protection of broad autonomy, which partially fuelled the reconstruction of civil society under communism. Paradoxically, Hungary and Poland, and by contagion, the other states in what became known as the Visegrád Group—initially an alliance for cooperation towards joining NATO and the EU, which after 2010 became a centre of anti-Brussels and anti-American political action, not just anti-liberal—were the promoters of illiberalism and placed civil society organisations in increasingly challenging positions. Victor Orbán's full embrace of illiberalism through his famous speech (Orbán, 2014) in July 2014 at the Tusványos Summer University in Băile Tușnad, Romania, reflects a vision contrary to democracy: it centres on national sovereignty, realised through the promotion of a model of governance modestly called 'illiberal democracy'. Essentially, Orbán criticised liberalism, considering it unsuitable for the challenges of contemporary society, especially concerning the protection of national and cultural values. In this context, Orbán presented as an alternative to liberalism not just the concept of 'illiberal democracy' but also a new governing model centred on so-called conservative values, in the name of which the role of liberal agents like civil society organisations and the rule of law could be limited, promoting so-called national interests and sovereignty instead. From this perspective, Orbán argued that Eastern democracies are not bound to conform to—indeed, they should reject—the Western liberal model and focus instead on preserving national values and Christian traditions and promoting social cohesion. Orbán's insistence on promoting Christian traditions was part of an ideological effort to find common ground with ultra-conservative movements—particularly those in North America but also in Russia—to provide broad support for his illiberal vision. In this way, Orbán's July

2014 speech became the pillar justifying the implementation of his illiberal policies, through which he consolidated his authoritarian government in the name of Christianity and sovereignty.

Although the sources of illiberalism are numerous (Laruelle, 2022), Orbán's was most likely inspired by the mirage exercised by the 'patriarch' of contemporary illiberalism, a term used by Pfeffer (2018) to describe the Prime Minister of Israel in his book *Bibi. The Turbulent Life and Times of Benjamin Netanyahu*. The term illiberalism itself was likely borrowed from Fareed Zakaria's article (Zakaria, 1997), but the known political inspiration—whether directly or indirectly for Orbán—seems to have been Benjamin Netanyahu's book *A Durable Peace* (Netanyahu, 2000) and his subsequent positions against Barack Obama's *A New Beginning* speech at Cairo University on June 4, 2009, formulated during his speeches at Bar-Ilan University on June 14, 2009, and October 6, 2013 (Netanyahu, 2013). Netanyahu's vision proposes a sort of politico-religious messianism, apparently inspired by Herzl's Zionism, to build an ideological universe that would generate a reaction against contemporary liberalism in its various forms—political, economic, cultural—in the name of national destiny and popular sovereignty, and based on a majority electoral support. In fact, through his positions and supposed historical vision, Netanyahu has positioned himself as a kind of father of illiberalism, inspiring authoritarian leaders across all continents, from Putin to Orbán, from Erdogan to Modi, from Trump to Bolsonaro.

The historical continuity between pre-communism, communism, and post-communism represents a complex topic to approach, which involves the analysis of the long-term evolution of social, cultural, and political structures in Central and Eastern Europe. In terms of social and political continuity, the power structures of communist Eastern Europe inevitably inherited administrative and power structures from the interwar period. Even though radical political regime changes have taken place, certain parts of the political and administrative elite have remained in power, influencing the continuation of policies and practices. On the other hand, many of the political institutions created during the communist period persisted even after the fall of the communist regimes, in many cases under different names or adapted to new realities. The fact that the communist regime deeply influenced national culture and identity should not be neglected, and the rediscovery of national history after the fall of communism re-created the conditions for the revival of nationalism. At the same time, even after the fall of the communist regimes, a part of

society continued to validate the values and symbols promoted during the communist era, playing a significant role in the (re)formation of national identity in the new regional and international conditions.

While the dissident movements during communism influenced political activities and civil society in the first decade of post-communism, in some countries, the interwar tradition influenced the tendency to establish some forms of authoritarian government. The historical continuity between pre-communism, communism, and post-communism highlights the complexity of social and political transition in Central and Eastern Europe. The legacy of previous regimes continues to influence institutional, economic, and cultural structures, generating challenges and opportunities. Analysing these continuities is essential to understanding the past and the future of countries that have experienced transitions from totalitarian regimes to other regime forms, sometimes democratic, sometimes authoritarian.

Cold War and Its Influence on Societal Reconstruction After 1989

Although Soviet domination after 1945 of over two-thirds of the European continent—hence Putin's nostalgia to recover the 'lost empire'—it could not erase the difference between the two Europes incorporated into the Soviet sphere of influence: Central and Eastern Europe. These regions are historically and culturally different, as indicated by Jenő Szűcs in the 1980s (Szűcs, 1983). According to Szűcs, the analysis of European historical and cultural structures reveals a Europe divided into three distinct regions, each with specific characteristics: (1) Western Europe associated with the development of parliamentary democracy, capitalism, and a political culture characterised by pluralism and diversity, where political and industrial revolutions profoundly influenced social and political structures; (2) Central Europe is characterised by a history full of conflicts, migrations, and diverse influences, lying at the intersection between East and West, where national identities are often contested in the name of the region's ethnic and cultural complexity, including countries such as Poland, Hungary, and the Czech Republic; and (3) Eastern Europe is seen as less developed economically and politically than the other two countries.

Under these conditions, societal reconstruction after 1989 was a multidimensional process involving profound reforms in almost all aspects

of social and political life. Although significant progress was made, economic, social, and political challenges continued to influence these countries. The analysis of the relationship between political processes during the Cold War and post-1989 political processes reveals significant interconnections between these periods, which had a profound impact on the political and social evolution of Central and Eastern Europe and beyond.

If the Cold War refers to a period of geopolitical tension between democratic states organised around the United States and those of the communist bloc led by the Soviet Union, then the collapse of the USSR should have also meant its end. However, the war in Ukraine testifies to the profound geopolitical instability generated by the fall of communism. Not only has Russia not abandoned the imperial and messianic idea that the USSR inherited from Tsarism, but China, which has developed economically due to state capitalism validated by its opening to Western Europe and North America, has not democratised but, on the contrary, has oriented itself towards a reconditioning of Maoism for a new geopolitical use. China's influence on Central and Eastern Europe is today a political and economic reality that facilitates the maintenance and even multiplication of divisions inherited from the Cold War era (Kaczmarski et al., 2019).

During the Cold War, Europe was divided into two spheres of influence: Eastern European countries under communist control and Western European countries following a democratic and capitalist model. Communist regimes suppressed civil liberties and political opposition, using repressive tactics to prevent any form of contestation. This did not prevent various protest movements from manifesting, which, even if repressed, as was the case with the Hungarian Revolution of 1956 or the Prague Spring of 1968, played a role in weakening the system (Mansfield & Snyder, 1995). Under these conditions, dissident and opposition movements became the nodal point around which civil society would be reconstructed. Emerging first within communist movements (Falk, 2011), dissent took the form of contestation or opposition to the political regime, associated with actions taken by individuals or groups who transgressed accepted social and political norms to express their political, cultural, social, or economic disagreement with authorities.

In this sense, dissent—which grew stronger in the two decades preceding the fall of communism—became the primary benchmark of civic resistance and mobilisation in the first phase of the post-communist

transition immediately following the fall of the Berlin Wall. Initially, with Charter 77 and then with Solidarność, these movements were seen as a social response to the collapse of the revisionist project of building socialism with a human face in Poland or Czechoslovakia after 1968 (Kundera, 1984). Gradually, they became driving forces for political change based on civic regeneration (see Vráblíková, 2025). However, dissent was also a reaction against the inability of Brezhnev-era conservatism to offer a minimal perspective for the future (Glasius, 2012). Although there were forms of dissent throughout Central and Eastern Europe, they had different social and cultural echoes depending on the specific political culture. These cultural differences contributed to the initiation of varying transition paths; some were completed, and others were altered, the consequences of which are described in the present book.

In the three stages of transition, which roughly correspond to each decade since the fall of communism, the effects of Europeanisation and globalisation were felt differently in Central and Eastern Europe, giving rise to mobilisations. The former communist states of Central Europe were the first to benefit from the effects of Europeanisation but also the first to distance themselves from it, and the analyses concerning Hungary by Gerő & Kerényi (2025) or Poland by Kocyba (2025) are illustrative.

On the other hand, states in the Western Balkans, perhaps except Slovenia and Croatia, which are historically and culturally closer to Central Europe than to the Balkans, remained stuck in an intermediate phase, which Hoxha (2025) describes well when presenting the two moments of civic and political mobilisation in Albania, or Stefanovski (2025) when analysing the tension between democratisation and competitive authoritarianism in North Macedonia.

Then, at the border between Central and Eastern Europe, Romania, and Bulgaria followed a different trajectory, with a slow and winding transition and a delayed institutional and societal adaptation (see Dinev & Stoyanov [2025] for Bulgaria and Gubernat & Mărgarit [2025] for Romania). In Bulgaria and Romania, the harsh repression of the Jivkov and Ceaușescu regimes annihilated almost all attempts at dissent, let alone opposition. Civil society had to be built in these states, which took time. On the other hand, Romania's cultural diversity, divided between a Central European-like Transylvania in the West, a Moldova geographically, culturally, and historically close to Eastern Europe, and a partially Balkan Muntenia in the South, allowed the defreeze of cleavages such as

centre-periphery and urban–rural, as well as the emergence of a cleavage between the state and civil society of the type identified by Daniel Louis Seiler (Seiler, 2003), as well as one between post-communists and post-dissidents (Grabowska, 2021).

For the states that were part of the former USSR, such as Russia (see the excellent article by Radzhana Buyantueva [2025]), Belarus (Nikolayenko, 2025), Ukraine (Zelinska, 2025), or Georgia (Tsuladze, 2025), the transition was brutally interrupted by Russia's attempts to keep them within its sphere of influence.

Consolidation of Power and the Drift of the State as a Public Space

In the new millennium, due to technological changes, especially the internet and social networks revolution, civic, and social mobilisation shifted from supporting democratisation towards an increasingly 'antisystemic' trend. Antisystem orientations created conditions for the full manifestation of populism as a 'thin-centred ideology', as Cas Mudde defined it two decades ago (Mudde, 2004). However, time has shown that populism is not a weak ideology, mainly when associated with illiberalism. As Ralph Schroeder argued, treating populism as 'thin', there is a risk of overlooking a new set of beliefs that has influenced the political direction in several countries (Schroeder, 2020). The claim of so-called illiberal democracy by Viktor Orbán and his emulators in Central and Eastern Europe has put liberal democracy on the defensive throughout the region. Against this backdrop, more or less stable authoritarian governments have been installed. But these governments have radically changed political balances and, in some cases, like in Russia or Hungary, even the political regime in these countries. Therefore, it is always helpful to return to the classic discussion on populism, which we owe to Ghiță Ionescu and Ernst Gellner, who, following a conference organised in May 1968 at the London School of Economics, edited in 1969 *Populism: Its Meaning and National Characteristics* (Ionescu & Gellner, 1969). In this book, Ionescu analysed the evolution of populism based on specific historical and cultural contexts and highlighted its destructive effects on democratic institutions. The political evolution in Central and Eastern Europe shows us that, contrary to Laclau's vision (Laclau, 2005)—who analysed populism as a simple, essentially democratic political discourse

that could be used without inhibitions by the left, right, and centre—populism is not a simple weak ideology but an ideological instrument that destroys the foundations of liberal democracy and leads to authoritarian forms of governance.

In many cases, populism was the instrument that allowed—as it did between the two world wars—the rise of illiberalism in Central and Eastern Europe, which in turn was fuelled and supported by the 'uncivil' segments of civil society. These anti-liberal groups played an important role in legitimising and consolidating illiberal regimes, offering them a base of supporters who rejected liberal values and supported authoritarian leadership. This constitutive fragility of Eastern European civil society was also discussed by Meyer, who noted, 'civil society's inherent fragility—a fragility that can result from some of its very successes, some of which foster material well-being but also encourage individualistic withdrawal, breed the illusion of independence, and hold moral and spiritual cultivation to be the optional pursuits of private citizens. These changes may not only give rise to dramatic gaps in wealth and income among classes. They also readily start a slide down the slippery slope of callous indifference to one's fellow citizen and ultimately open the space in which distrust, suspicion, incivility, and the longing for benign despots grows' (Meyer, 2022).

The 'uncivil civil society' and illiberalism represent two interconnected phenomena contributing to the weakening of liberal democracies in Central and Eastern Europe. While illiberal regimes often use populist and nationalist rhetoric to consolidate their power, they are often supported by the 'uncivil' segments of civil society that share and promote values opposed to liberal democracy. From this point of view, the evolution of protest movements in Central and Eastern Europe reveals the emergence of a new cleavage that opposes liberal to uncivil civil society, a sort of reevaluation and adaptation of the initial cleavage between pro or post-communists and anti-communists. The emergence of these movements represents a major challenge for the future of democracy in the region.

The confiscation of the state as a public space by an increasingly less competitive political elite weakens civil society, the rule of law, and press freedom. In this context, the war in Ukraine, like the COVID-19 pandemic earlier, was used to limit the freedom of movement and expression of civil society organisations. Meanwhile, the ideological fracture between East and West has deepened, and political, social, or civic

mobilisation has varied with each country's geopolitical context and experience.

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Power, Protest, and Possibilities in Central and Eastern Europe

David S. Meyer

History didn't end in 1989. In retrospect, this is hardly surprising. Although Communist governments fell in Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union came apart, creating new countries and apparent opportunities for democratic politics, all the same pressures and politics that create contention everywhere else were as ready to take off in new nominal democracies as anywhere. More surprising is that there actually was a scholarly debate about whether history had ended (Fukuyama, 1992), with an ill-defined liberal democracy and market economy as the ultimate end point. In real life, however, history doesn't end, but weighs heavily on even the most imaginative and ambitious projects, including new nominal democracies in Central and Eastern Europe. Security alliances and policies had been the overarching factor simplifying and ostensibly unifying very diverse constituencies, partly by papering over stark differences among more and less allied states. The Cold War had appeared as a stand-off of stability, even as it featured a terrifying nuclear arms race, a spillover

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of armed conflict into the Global South, and a range of repressions everywhere. Its abrupt end provided endless opportunities for scholars, particularly in the West, to opine about the threats (Mearsheimer, 1990) or pacific prospects (Van Evera, 1990) facing Europe in the future. But the shadow of the Cold War blocked outsiders from seeing the distinct aspirations, grievances, and constituencies across East and Central Europe. We learned, again, that one thing, no matter how big and overwhelming, can't describe, much less control, the world. Apocalyptic labelling aside, new openings reflected and inspired new challenges and challengers, and many different stories.

The liberal imagination is perhaps too fertile and often proceeds from the notion that democracy marks an end point to disruptive struggle and the beginning of something more akin to administration. But democracy represents various sets of processes, not an outcome, the beginning and structure of subsequent political mobilisation, which can easily be at least as ugly as what it replaced. It is also a vulnerable political form, susceptible to overthrow and backsliding. Moreover, varied social, economic, and political transitions that seemed to commence in 1990 took place in dramatically different contexts, with activists facing different states (some new) from different starting points, with more and less developed civil society, administrative states, and international constraints. All this matters. In many of the cases discussed in this volume, we see increased openness, allowing for the prospects of more diverse and intense means of making claims, but also underdeveloped state capacity, limiting the possibilities of authorities successfully delivering meaningful policy responses to movement claimants.

Scholars of contentious politics, including those appearing in this volume, are sensitive to contingencies and inevitable variations across a succession of campaigns, populist left and right, religious and secular, and nationalist and globalist. More than thirty years after the Berlin Wall came down, people continue to make history through contention, creating a politics that was largely unimaginable years earlier. The chapters in this volume go a long way toward undermining a single overarching understanding of the extended process of democratisation. It turns out that virtually every reform is difficult to achieve, vulnerable to backsliding due to pressures from within and from larger powers.

A simplified social science based on military capacity and narrowly defined interests clearly fails in explaining, much less predicting the alliances, events, and outcomes of a long and complicated democratisation process. As keen observers, the authors here provide detailed accounting of the development of a broad range of social movements and contentious politics emerging in new and old states. By itself, this is an important contribution to both academic knowledge and contemporary politics. From the trajectories of different movements, and particularly their interaction with local and distant authorities, we can begin to develop a deeper understanding of contentious politics more generally—and develop answers to persistent questions about why movements emerge when and how they do, how they exercise influence, and how states can manage dissent democratically.

As social scientists, we are also charged with doing more: developing reliable ways to make sense of events, even if unforeseen. Social theory connects the particular to the general, instructing the motivated observer about where to look for explanations, and alerting us to areas of importance and possible outcomes of efforts to remake the world. This enterprise means an engagement with established theory on social movements and contentious politics, built to address important questions, but largely developed through a relatively narrow set of cases involving social movement challenges in well-established (and relatively affluent) liberal democracies. Incorporating data, detail, and insight from less-established contexts is an important step toward broader understanding. We are grateful to the co-editors for assembling well-informed case studies that offer us a chance to conduct the meaningful comparisons they call for. On the surface, particularly from the outside, similarities in origins and development between states and their challengers abound, but underneath, there are consequential differences. Reading through all the cases presented, we can recognise connections and previously neglected variables that help us build a better understanding of mobilisation, contention, and political change. Here, I mean to suggest areas of connection with relevant questions and theories, as well as other cases, in the service of helping us all make sense of the world.

Political Opportunities and the Political Process Perspective

Most clearly, the authors here are concerned with the range of constraints that collective actors in new democracies must confront. This analytical orientation tracks most closely with the political opportunity or political process perspective. The fundamental premise of this perspective is that context is critical in making sense of the emergence, development, and outcomes of a movement. Although the basic insight has been resilient, operationalizing the concept and generating testable hypotheses has created a great deal of academic contention (Gamson & Meyer, 1996; Goodwin & Jasper, 1999; Meyer, 2004; Tarrow, 2022; Tilly, 1978).

The cases described here trace a full spectrum of political issues in contexts that were all fundamentally altered by the Cold War, and by its end and the fall of the Soviet Union, but they varied on many other key elements of political opportunity. East European states were more or less engaged or isolated economically and civically with the larger community of nations, more and less capable of delivering basic services, and had established more and less vigorous civil societies. All these factors *should* affect the origins, development, and influence of protest movements—and they did, albeit not always in ways that we might have expected. Political process approaches should help us understand both the similarities and differences.

Making sense of the theory and applying it to contemporary cases is best served by returning to basic premises. The term, "political opportunity structure", was first used by Peter Eisinger (Eisinger, 1973), who borrowed "opportunity structure" from research on career ladders. Looking at the openness of city governments in the United States, Eisinger found that protests were most likely to occur in cities which offered some limited openings for making institutional claims. Riots and protests were less likely in cities that were very open or completely closed to political input from below. An administration's openness to expressions of political grievance could preempt protest while a closed opportunity structure effectively discouraged or repressed them at the outset.

Tilly (1978) refined the finding into a larger theory and applied it to nations, emphasising the curvilinear relationship between state openness and protest. The analytical action was about the ways in which political organisers make strategic choices in an environment they did not do much

to set up and generally can only influence in limited ways. Many subsequent studies followed, and analysts conceptualised and operationalised political opportunities with dramatically varied models (Meyer & Minkoff, 2004), sometimes offering spare models that would apply to virtually all movements (Kitschelt, 1986) and sometimes using models that emphasised more issue-specific variables traced over time to make sense of a particular movement or set of claims (McAdam, 1999; Meyer, 1990). The basic approach, however, has proven useful in analysing both particular movements over time or across contexts, and a more general sense of a social movement sector in a single or comparative setting (Tarrow, 1989).

The political opportunity perspective pushes analysts to look not only at the challengers, but also the policies and authorities they challenge. The premise is that political organisers make choices about the issues and approaches they use in response to the world around them, and for most of the movements described in this book, that starts with the state, its structure and its policies. The structure of political opportunities advantages some strategies for influence while marginalising others. But all is not explained by structure. The signals sent about issues ripe for challenges and approaches that might be available must be received and interpreted by collective actors who can organise effectively. Opportunities need to be recognised by people who have the capacity to take advantage of them to matter. Thus, the perception and interpretation of opportunities is critical (Gamson & Meyer, 1996), as are the material and ideational resources needed to launch and sustain a challenge (McCarthy & Zald, 1977).

History and Memory

For large-scale protest movements to emerge, it's necessary for people to believe that their efforts might matter. Of course, the formal governmental structure matters, but not independently of the recalled history of governance and resistance of the past. The memory of a protest culture in Poland (see Kocyba's [2025] chapter), for example, provides a sharp counterpoint to the absence of such a culture in Albania (see Hoxha's [2025] chapter)—or the frustrated efforts at resistance to the Soviet Union in Hungary and Czechoslovakia. Recognition of memory and culture doesn't by itself explain subsequent trajectories of resistance,

but it is surely important in making sense of how people understand the prospects for effective organised resistance.

Understanding the social history of resistance emphasises some distinct resources and alliances. The perceived successes of the past shape the strategies and coalitions that organisers choose later. Here again, the transitions of 1989 continue to resonate, and not always helpfully. As example, the space and support provided by the Roman Catholic Church in Poland's 1989 campaign underscored the Church as a powerful actor in both governance and movement politics in the ensuing years; it continued as an inescapable and powerful actor in Polish politics. In Bulgaria, however, the resistance to autocracy at the end of the Cold War was dependent upon an extremely broad and much flatter coalition, which activists continue trying to recreate to bring about real reform (see Dinev & Stoyanov's [2025] chapter in this volume). History, recorded and understood, provides additional leverage in understanding perceptions of opportunity.

State Capacity

Second, sustained protest campaigns are more likely to emerge in contexts where people believe that their targets can deliver responses to their grievances. This is a function of real and recognised state capacity. Kitschelt (1986) deployed state capacity as one of two key variables (along with openness to political input from below) in explaining the different ways resistance to nuclear power emerged in four West European states, but few scholars have followed his lead.

The relative lack of attention to state capacity is a missed opportunity for analysts and seems particularly relevant to the cases here. From the origins of the theory, scholars have noted that the modern state makes a more *indirect* repertoire of contention possible, in which people have an incentive to organise collective action to petition the state, rather than steal or seize grain in an event (Tilly, 1978). The modern social movement, defined as sustained interaction between challengers and authorities, is predicated on the existence of a state strong and extended enough to redress claims, the target and fulcrum of much movement politics (Tarrow, 2022). Social movement politics are only attractive, even possible, when there is a functional state that can respond to grievances and can operate in some sort of systematic way, with an articulated set of rules, laws, and procedures. Indeed, protesters often press for adherence

to rules and processes at least partly so they can see the results of their political efforts, as Tsuladze (2025) shows in her treatment of informal governance in Georgia.

There are at least two critical dimensions to state capacity that help explain the character of contentious politics in Central and East Europe: *policy capacity* and *policing capacity*. The first, policy capacity, as Kitschelt (1986) explains it, is the actual ability of the state to make and implement policy. All things equal, policies can be implemented more effectively with a centralised, well-resourced state, which enjoys strong influence on market conditions, and is mostly unencumbered by an independent judiciary.

Many of the governments founded in the wake of the Cold War, often in newly established countries, were so challenged economically and politically, that they were unable to develop the strength to respond to the claims, or even the needs, of their citizenries—too small, too corrupt, too poor. To the extent that organisers were able to stage something approaching social movement politics, they were often organised around nationalist identities, whose resolution was imagined, rather than material claims, which were constantly frustrated (cf. Migdal, 1988). And political leaders unable to deliver on material claims were ready to build political capital by pandering to identity claims.

New governments mostly had difficulty in developing policy capacity comparable to the autocratic governments that ruled during the Cold War, where their leaders also enjoyed the power to crush popular expectations. Additionally, they were beleaguered by rampant corruption, which reinforced a cynicism about governance both within European states and a comparable cynicism among those who would challenge them (see chapters by Nikolayenko [2025] and Buyantueva [2025]). To be sure, corruption is hardly peculiar to Central and Eastern Europe, but in better functioning states, it provides a manageable friction to politics and policy, or even an anomaly to be addressed by the bureaucracy and the criminal justice system. Absent such a functioning state, people have less incentive to organise collective action to make claims and are more likely to figure out independent workarounds to respond to personal troubles—appealing to patronage rather than politics (Dhananka, 2021). Movements can challenge corruption, of course, but the challenges appear small-bore and endless. Social movements face an unending stream of targets, and even when activists are able to win governmental reforms, they receive little of the material benefits needed to sustain activism and build democratic

culture. In effect, necessary battles against corruption consume effort and attention that organisers might well prefer to spend on substantive issues including social welfare, housing, and the environment.

Resources

Incipient social movement organisations were similarly short on resources, often dependent upon international support to sustain themselves and their work. But outside funders can be fickle, and funding streams erratic. The lack of sustained support limited the growth and reach of social movement organisations. Gerő and Kerényi (2025) persuasively argue that the absence of funding stalled the development of civil society in Hungary, allowing the emergence of a government that displayed no interest in helping an autonomous social sector to develop. If the absence of funding is a challenge, outside funding also creates its own problems. As Vráblíková (2025) notes in her chapter on the Czech Republic, cultivated dependence upon outside funders can preempt and undermine the development of more authentic grassroots campaigns. Activists faced difficulties in maintaining the psychological and material resources needed to sustain campaigns that could rarely see meaningful progress through successive elections and mobilisations in the streets. Exasperation or resignation with limited results produced an understandable—and frustrating, electoral and civic fatigue across new nominal democracies.

Repression

In addition to capacity on matters of policy, we must also recognise policing capacity, that is, the strength to impose order through forceful *repression*, including policing the streets and prosecuting and punishing dissenters. Protesters in Central and Eastern Europe routinely faced harsh repression, as states experimented with new means of establishing public order. Repression raises the risks and costs of collective action, providing a potentially powerful deterrent to collective action of all sorts. Harsh punishment of dissident leaders serves not only as a deterrent to social action, but also a decapitation of the most talented and committed leaders, doubly crippling movements. But repression also serves as a provocation, and an incentive for building coalitions to challenge authorities and public order policies.

Of course, repression is hardly unique to Central and Eastern Europe. There is a long and complicated literature on repression in an extremely wide variety of settings, from which we learn that repression can crush dissent or, sometimes, provoke a backlash and enhance protest mobilisation—an apparent paradox (Davenport, 2007). One answer to this apparent paradox is the comprehensiveness and efficacy of state repression. It is striking that repression appears to work by decapitating and deterring protest movements, but only if it is sufficiently severe and extended (Zhukov, 2023). To make repression work, states need the resources to impose order, but also the political will to impose harsh consequences on dissident citizens. In all cases, the alignment of resources and resolution is substantially less consistent than during the Cold War; this does not mean, however, that they are insignificant. Russia and its closest allies were most effective at stilling protest movements (Mamaev, 2024), whereas episodic efforts at repression—say in Ukraine—spurred domestic backlash, international attention, and sometimes material support for the protesters.

Importantly, although the choices that organisers made could be consequential, they could not, by themselves, determine outcomes. There is a romance about largescale dramatic civil resistance. We want to believe that choreographed and extended nonviolent resistance can topple repressive governments—and sometimes it can (Chenoweth & Stephan, 2011). But it is a tragic mistake to look only at the confrontations in the street and not the larger political context in which they exist. Authoritarian states during the Cold War had a long period of successful marginalisation, repression, and deterrence of organised dissent, and the strategy didn't disappear when the Cold War ended. As Nikolayenko (2025) shows in her chapter on Belarus, pro-democracy forces have repeatedly tried to organise large-scale protests, but they failed to take down the government. Analytically, it's important to distinguish between the protest outcome of successful mobilisation—getting into the streets and making a strong statement—and political success—winning policy reforms or political gains.

The Global Intrudes

Although the politics of political blocs during the Cold War often obscured variance within states inside each bloc, the end of the Cold War didn't end outside pressures and influence. It's important to recognise the

important power of extranational forces in encouraging or constraining state responses to protest movements. The classic works on political opportunity often compared different cities, states, or countries, effectively treating them as roughly equivalent independent units, equally susceptible to pressure from below. But social movements can be enabled, protected, or ignored by international forces. In looking at the civil rights movement in America, for example, we see that American politicians' commitment to the public diplomacy for the Cold War sought to offer protection and some support to activists (Dudziak, 2000). More generally, activists' success in generating extranational attention and support is often critical to their ability to sustain their efforts and, ultimately, win reforms (Keck & Sikkink, 1998). But some activist constituencies are better at winning international support than others, and some states are more susceptible to outside pressure than others.

Here, it is useful to think about states as being *nested* in a larger political world, constrained by relations with more powerful states and supranational and transnational forces, including alliances and other social movements (Meyer, 2003). The influence of the nesting institution depends upon two distinct but related factors: how extensive its claims are on the nested state (e.g. military and security policy; economics; domestic alliances); and how exclusive its influence is. When we look at these cases, we see variable influence of a range of exogenous actors on the dynamics of contention within each state. The new nominal democracies were all more open and exposed to social movements around the world—partly a function of the end of the Cold War, and partly a result of vastly increased communications media around the world. Each country had to navigate a web of new international relations which brought distinct pressures and opportunities. Some states were far more heavily influenced by Russia (e.g. Belarus and Georgia), whereas others were more visibly committed to working with the West (e.g. Czech Republic); most worked to navigate a more or less independent course by dealing with both. Because the West and Russia offered radically different prescriptions for contemporary politics, negotiating a balance is no easy matter.

In the transitional democracies in Central and Eastern Europe, leaders received strong signals from larger powers about how to deal with their own dissenters. Western democracies encouraged tolerance and inclusion for protesters, while Russia pushed for stricter control. Forces inside each country fought to influence which outside factors would matter. The balance of power within each country changed over time, and the

search for outside support created domestic political issues. The pressure to rename North Macedonia, for example, came from domestic interests in joining an integrated Europe, leaning toward the West, and unleashing nationalist movements, as Ivan Stefanovski shows in his chapter.

The wave of democracy and anti-austerity movements around the world, including the Arab Spring (Alimi & Meyer, 2011), the 15-M movement in Spain (Shoshan, 2018), and Occupy movements in the United States and elsewhere (Gould-Wartofsky, 2015) were echoed with varied amplitude across Central and Eastern Europe, a statement against neoliberal governance. Essentially, activists saw putative allies in other countries successfully making claims that resonated with them and tried to emulate their efforts, albeit in states less able to redress those complaints. In Romania, as Gubernat and Mărgarit (2025) show, the global wave of anti-austerity protests reinvigorated, at least temporarily, political participation in both protest and voting. The point is that domestic grievances can be identified and crystallised exogenously.

Russia successfully pressured Georgia and Belarus to limit contact with the West and maintain a de facto security alliance. The threat, sometimes executed, of Russian military intervention encouraged governments to comply with Russia's definition of its own security interests, effectively turning nominal democracies into severely constrained buffer states. The most destructive example continues to play out in Ukraine (see Zelinska's [2025] chapter in this volume), beginning with the Russian invasion and eventual annexation of Crimea, followed by a larger and more ambitious invasion intended to prevent Ukraine from turning to the West. The Russian invasion engaged Western allies, as NATO nations sent weapons to Ukraine and shared intelligence. Ukraine has repeatedly expressed its intent to follow other Central and Eastern European states and join NATO, which is newly responsive to the appeal (Garamone, 2023). Of course, participation in NATO requires domestic commitments of member states to build their military capacity as well as foreign policy commitments to the alliance. New international commitments create distinct issues and constituencies domestically.

Alliance with Western institutions and states also brings domestic commitments and new issues. Membership in the European Union, for example, calls for ceding some national autonomy on taxation and immigration, and a demonstrated commitment to opening markets. It also brings an additional level of international scrutiny on matters of domestic politics and human rights. Importantly, European Union membership

requires a functioning bureaucracy and economy, and seeking such membership makes for a clear sense of priorities for governance domestically (see Hoxha's [2025] chapter). It is important to recognise, however, that such commitments are not absolute or irreversible. The larger point here is that the contentious politics within Central and Eastern European states are heavily influenced by the larger world, including social, economic, and security initiatives from outside the nation.

Conclusion

History didn't end in 1989 or any time since, but it did turn in new directions with the end of the Soviet Union and communism. In the nominal new democracies of Central and Eastern Europe, we see states and challengers continue to grapple with what appear to be unlimited possibilities and unimaginable constraints. There is no single solution or unitary pathway out of the Cold War bloc system, and the variation of policy decisions and political protests across the region present both analytical challenges for scholars and both inspiration and threats to citizens.

I've tried to show that the political opportunity or political process paradigm offers analysts the best available tool kit for making sense of what's happened over the past few decades—and the best set of tools for making sense of what's likely to happen in the future. I've also argued that the academic paradigm can be strengthened by the reports and insights of the chapters here.

The struggles for (and against) variants of democracy and independence suggest factors that have been given short shrift in academic writing and analysis. I urge observers to attend to state capacity far more closely in explaining the trajectory of challenging movements. Remember, large numbers of people protest only when they think something is wrong, that it could be otherwise, and that their efforts could make a difference (Gamson, 1992). Here, the social psychology of collective action is highly responsive to observable structural and material conditions. If repeated participation in protest or even mainstream politics doesn't suggest a route to influence, most people are going to stop participating. Developing a state structure that can begin to deliver responses to frequent demands is the obvious struggle for most of the states covered in this volume. The successful establishment of effective governance (or not) will condition the contentious politics that follows.

I've also urged analysts to pay attention to the exogenous pressures and constraints that can affect the development of movements and states. Extranational and transnational social movements suggest ideas and approaches for pursuing them; their examples can diffuse across national borders and inspire allied efforts. States, alliances, and supranational institutions provide incentives and strictures that affect the development of political and economic structures as well as contentious movements. How powerful these exogenous factors are is a function of state capacity, size and strength, and autonomy.

But the cases presented here are also important for readers as citizens. When democracy around the world is under duress, even in ostensibly stable polities, and challenging movements on the left and right can exercise visible institutional power, the experiments in progress in Central and Eastern Europe provide both warnings and inspiration.

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Index

A

Accumulation of resources, 197
Akrestsina detention centre, 58
All-Poland Women's Strike, 231
ANO, 114, 121, 123, 125, 126, 128, 129
Anti-austerity, 14, 109, 121–125, 129, 249, 254, 336, 348, 381
Anti-corporate, 255, 256
Anti-corruption, 82, 92, 114, 249–251, 255–257, 259, 260, 263, 264, 267, 284, 289, 335, 346, 348
Anti-establishment, 82, 91, 95, 102, 126, 212, 254, 261, 263, 264, 330, 334–336
Anti-globalisation, 256
Anti-governmental, 249
Anti-homophobia, 138, 146
Anti-monopolies, 90, 93–95, 99, 101
Anti-systemic movements, 91
Arrests, 40, 57–60, 68, 143, 144, 147, 233, 279, 289, 290
Authoritarian drift, 5
Authoritarianism, 5, 6, 9, 13, 53, 62, 66, 68, 70, 103, 162, 164, 193, 202, 275, 276, 277–279, 292–294, 308, 331–333, 335, 338, 339, 345, 347, 349, 352, 360, 361–363, 365, 366, 367, 379

B

Babiš, Andrej, 121, 123, 125–127, 129
Backstage decisions, 153
Belarus, 6, 8, 11, 13, 51–60, 62, 65–71, 334–336, 338, 345, 349, 366, 379–381
Belarusian Popular Front, 62
Berkut, 303, 306, 310
Berlin Wall, 365, 372
Bloc of Yuliya Tymoshenko, 303, 305
Borissov, Boyko, 82, 86, 90, 93, 98, 100, 101

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Bulgarian Socialist Party (BSP), 82, 85, 87, 90, 92, 94–97, 102, 104

C

Capitalist transformation, 2, 86, 87
Captured state, 139–141, 148, 191, 335
Car drivers' movement, 276, 282, 283, 285
Centre-periphery cleavage, 99, 104
Charnobyl Way, 65, 66
Charter 77, 110, 365
CIS countries, 309
Citizens for Macedonia, 191, 195, 335
Citizens for the European Development of Bulgaria (GERB), 82, 86, 87, 92–95, 97, 98, 100–102, 104
Civic Democratic Party (ODS), 111, 115, 125
Civic Democrats, 113, 114, 118–121, 128, 129
Civic ethos, 110–112, 127, 130, 131, 337, 346
Civic ethos protest, 110, 111, 120, 127
Civic Platform (PO), 219, 220, 229, 236–238
Civil society, 1, 4–9, 12, 13, 29, 42, 90, 103, 109, 111, 112, 114, 117, 118, 132, 147, 148, 152–154, 161–171, 173, 174, 176, 183, 184, 196, 198–200, 204, 208, 211, 217, 219, 221, 222, 226, 229, 232, 233, 236, 239, 248, 252, 253, 256–258, 264, 275–278, 292, 305, 307, 330–336, 339, 345–348, 351, 359–361, 363, 364, 366, 367, 372, 378
Civil society-state relationship, 167
Cleavage(s), 12, 13, 27, 30, 83, 84, 89, 99–102, 203, 209, 211, 302, 303, 314, 316, 329, 349, 366, 367
Cold War, 363, 364, 371, 372, 374, 376, 377, 379, 380, 382
Colourful Revolution, 192, 197, 199, 200, 335
Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS), 302, 303, 314
Competitive authoritarianism, 193–195, 202, 335, 349, 365
Concentration of power, 145
Confederation, 225
Conservative nationalist discourse, 280, 292
COVID-19, 7, 38, 40, 55, 102, 125, 128, 207, 224, 284, 290, 367
Crimea, 55, 280, 284, 313–316, 381
Czech Social-Democratic Party, 115

D

Decision-making, 28, 33, 38, 41–45, 142, 144, 165, 169, 176, 183, 251, 278, 279
De-democratisation, 8, 330, 335
Democracy, 4, 10, 14, 15, 27, 29, 30, 33, 36, 39, 52, 56, 71, 88, 91, 96, 99, 103, 105, 111, 112, 114, 117, 120, 124, 127, 138, 152, 162, 165, 170, 176–178, 183, 193, 194, 196, 198, 211, 220, 260, 266, 277, 305, 330–335, 337, 339, 352, 360, 361, 363, 367, 372, 381–383
Democracy deficit, 177
Democratic backlash, 6, 334
Democratic backsliding, 1, 5, 6, 144, 147, 220, 238, 330, 334, 335, 338, 339
"Democratic Bulgaria", 82, 95, 98, 346

Democratic resilience, 6, 8
Democratisation, 6, 9, 10, 14, 28, 91, 168, 192, 193, 212, 253, 261, 330–337, 349, 359, 365, 366, 372, 373
Digital media, 287, 291
Discursive opportunity, 120
Discursive political opportunity, 122
Disinformation campaigns, 61, 152
DPS, 82, 85, 90, 92, 94, 95, 98, 101

E
Education, 34, 37, 58, 86, 90, 99, 123, 138, 171, 172, 176–181, 293, 314, 345
Electoral fraud, 57, 60, 61, 276, 306, 335
Electoral instability, 93, 103, 337
Environment, 7, 12, 13, 28, 33, 34, 41–43, 53, 65, 111, 112, 115, 117, 121, 131, 138, 144, 162, 166, 167, 173, 252, 276, 277, 293, 294, 339, 348, 350, 374, 378
Environmental activism, 66, 140, 142, 255
Ethnocentrism, 209
EU-Georgia Association Agreement, 144
Euromaidan, 291, 301, 303, 308, 310–317, 349, 350
European Union (EU), 2, 8, 9, 13, 32–34, 36, 43, 53–55, 63, 82, 83, 85, 88, 97, 101, 102, 104, 115, 117, 118, 121, 122, 126, 131, 144–148, 150, 152, 153, 167, 168, 191, 193, 196, 198, 207, 208, 220, 234, 236, 248, 249, 254, 260, 264, 280, 302, 303, 308–310, 315, 316, 336, 338, 347, 360, 361, 381
Extremism, 290, 291

F
Fair elections, 111, 281, 283–287, 289
Fake news, 290, 291
Fatherland, 303, 308, 309, 315
Fidesz, 161, 168, 175, 176, 178, 180, 182–184, 335
Field, 3–5, 11, 39, 83, 117, 162–164, 169–171, 173–175, 178, 184, 248, 252, 293, 302–305, 307, 308, 312, 316, 317
Field framework, 304, 316, 317
Foreign agents, 178, 287, 288, 292, 293, 311, 347, 360
"Foreign agents" law, 141, 147–149, 151–154, 287, 311
Foreign patronage, 117
Foreign policy, 13, 54, 56, 85, 115, 144, 152, 153, 309, 310, 315, 346, 381
Foreign-supported organisations, 169
Freedom Day, 62, 63, 65
French Proposal, 191, 192, 207–210

G
Gazeta Polska Clubs, 226, 229
Geopolitical cleavages, 8, 9, 302, 310, 351
Georgian Dream (GD), 137
Government-sponsored NGOs, 103, 169
Grassroots, 42, 52, 109, 110, 116, 128, 161, 175, 177, 234, 256, 264, 285, 286, 306, 313, 345, 347, 348, 378
Green Movement, 89, 92, 98
Grievances, 3, 5, 29, 30, 32, 36, 38, 44, 45, 66, 84, 87, 110, 122, 191, 196, 197, 199, 200, 204, 205, 207, 209, 211, 252, 263, 282–285, 350, 351, 372, 376, 381

Gyurcsány, Ferenc, 168
Gyurcsány's speech, 174

H
Harassment of civil society, 168, 169, 183
Havel, Václav, 110, 111, 333, 346
Human rights, 28, 33, 61, 63, 64, 111, 112, 115, 117, 118, 121, 138, 166, 171, 173, 184, 194, 197, 211, 283, 291, 310, 330, 381

I
Illiberal democracy, 361, 366
Illiberalism, 6, 334, 361, 362, 366, 367
Independence March, 221, 223–227, 233, 236
Inequality, 4, 5, 88, 283, 347
Informal governance, 138, 139, 142, 153, 377
International influence, 117, 195, 201
International intervention, 194, 198, 210, 211
Internationalisation, 8, 117
International politics, 116, 118
Internet activism, 204
Issue-spatial opportunities, 131

J
Jobbik, 176, 183, 184

K
Klaus, Václav, 111, 112, 118, 120, 124, 127, 131
Kremlin, 277–280, 283, 284, 290–292, 307
Kuchma, Leonid, 305

L
Labour, 61, 86, 88, 89, 171, 176, 181, 184, 303, 331, 336, 337, 345
Law and Justice (PiS), 219, 220, 223–230, 232–234, 236–239
Liberal democracy, 10, 266, 333, 360, 366, 367, 371

M
March of a Million Hearts, 237
Mechanism of party engagement, 205, 206
Mechanism of political party engagement, 199, 200, 202, 204, 208, 211
Medvedev, Dmitry, 279, 282, 284
Million Moments, 110, 125–130, 132, 346
Million Moments for the Sake of Democracy, 109, 121, 125
Million moments of Democracy, 129
Multi-purpose organisations, 164

N
Nashi, 292
Nationalist demonstrations, 101
Nationally regulated capitalism, 119
National Movement, 82, 85, 225
Navalny, Alexey, 14, 284, 287–290, 348
Netanyahu, Benjamin, 362
New post-communist political order, 359

O
Oligarch, 87, 92, 113, 141, 148, 149, 153, 278
One Million for the Freedom of Speech, 177

Opportunity(ies), 3, 4, 6, 32, 45, 62, 83, 84, 95, 99, 112, 117, 121, 123, 125, 129, 131, 166, 167, 173, 191, 222, 225, 228, 248, 250, 276, 280, 334, 336, 344, 349, 351, 352, 359, 363, 371, 372, 375, 376, 380
Opposition Agreement, 113–115
Opposition Bloc, 303, 315
Orange Revolution, 54, 301, 303, 305, 307, 308, 316, 317, 349
Orbán, Viktor, 167, 175, 181–183, 361, 362, 366
Oscillating democracy, 193, 335
Outcomes of social movements, 2, 4, 11, 12, 28, 36, 38, 45, 92, 93, 103, 192, 194, 197, 198, 199, 202, 203, 206, 210, 211, 222, 250, 252, 260–266, 301, 303, 304, 307, 317, 330, 351, 373, 374, 379

P

Panorama Tbilisi, 140, 142, 143, 338
Parties, 3, 8–14, 28, 29, 31–35, 38, 40–42, 44, 45, 51, 53, 62, 64, 65, 67, 68, 70, 81–83, 87–95, 97, 100–105, 113–116, 119, 121, 122, 125, 128, 129, 131, 141, 145, 146, 149, 151–153, 162, 164, 177, 178, 182–184, 192, 194, 196, 198–200, 202, 204, 206, 208–212, 218–222, 225–227, 230, 233–238, 248, 253, 254, 257, 260–263, 265, 266, 278, 279, 282, 283, 286, 302, 303, 305–310, 312, 314, 316, 331–335, 337, 345–349, 351
Party engagement
  mechanism of, 205, 206
Party mobilisation, 221, 236, 237, 348
Party of Regions, 303, 308, 309, 311, 312, 315, 316
Party politics, 9, 10, 29, 116, 120, 128, 129, 225, 302, 316, 332, 337
Party system dynamics, 84, 85
Pensioners' movement, 282, 285
Ploshcha-2006, 57
Political backstage, 148, 153
Political cleavages, 9, 10, 82, 83, 104, 182
Political culture, 12, 42, 44, 45, 110, 112, 113, 163, 265, 266, 313, 363, 365
Political freedom, 276, 277, 280, 281
Political opportunity structures, 3, 5, 14, 27, 33, 45, 53, 63, 70, 103, 110, 114, 118, 121, 122, 126, 129–132, 192, 194, 202, 211, 221–223, 237, 250, 275–277, 279, 281, 282, 287, 292–294, 305, 308, 329, 374, 375, 380, 382
Political outcomes, 110, 125, 197–199, 202, 203, 210, 212, 251
Political party engagement
  mechanism of, 199, 200, 202, 204, 208, 211
Political process, 93, 99, 194, 195, 197, 198, 202, 211, 277, 301, 308, 329, 360, 364, 374, 382
Political process theory, 3, 81, 276
Political regime, 28, 52, 66, 70, 168, 248, 277, 312, 359, 362, 364, 366
Political rights, 52, 144, 204, 280, 281, 334, 350
Populism, 1, 7, 126, 127, 129, 266, 335, 366, 367

Post-election protests, 54, 56–58, 61
Pro-democracy, 85, 200, 249, 253, 331, 379
Pro-Europe, 147
Pro-European, 54, 101, 144, 145, 147, 154, 199, 249, 250, 260, 263, 309, 312, 315, 316, 336
Pro-government, 94, 182, 184
Protest culture, 28, 29, 38, 88, 261, 375
Protest cycle, 81, 82, 84, 88, 91, 92, 94, 95, 99, 100, 103, 104
Protest parties, 13, 93, 95, 97, 100, 101, 103–105
Public space, 40, 174, 249, 311, 338, 366, 367
Pussy Riot, 289
Putin, Vladimir, 56, 275–280, 283, 285, 287, 289, 315, 335, 337, 362, 363

R
Railway partisan movement, 68
Repertoires of contention, 196, 199–201, 256, 376
Repression, 7, 8, 13, 33, 39, 45, 52, 65, 222, 227, 228, 231, 275–277, 280, 281, 285, 287, 289, 290, 294, 307, 309, 335–338, 345, 349, 351, 365, 372, 378, 379
Resources, 11, 12, 29, 44, 54, 70, 71, 99, 110, 116, 117, 121, 130, 163, 167, 170–173, 178, 179, 184, 195, 203, 207, 210, 221, 227, 231, 248, 251, 253, 275–277, 282, 285, 286, 288, 291, 293, 294, 304, 305, 318, 345, 375, 376, 378, 379
Restrictive regulations, 163
Revival, 90, 95, 96, 102, 360, 362
Russian imperialism, 67, 71
Russia-Ukraine war, 55, 68, 69, 71

S
Saakashvili, Mikheil, 54, 138
Securitisation, 280
Shock Therapy, 218
Shrinking space, 8, 173, 177
Social change, 4, 38, 162, 164, 317
Social Democrats, 111–113, 118–123, 125, 126, 129
Social dialogue, 167, 169, 248
Social justice, 36, 249, 256, 266, 331, 343–345, 349
Social media, 38, 44–46, 67, 69, 90–92, 150, 151, 249, 250, 256, 283, 286, 287, 290, 291, 293
Socio-economic grievances, 5, 13, 29, 345, 352
Socio-economic underpinnings, 4
Solidarity, 12, 36, 65, 67, 68, 124, 217–219, 229, 234–236, 238, 239, 259, 266, 317, 333
Solidarność, 365
Sovereign internet, 280
Soviet Union, 62, 66, 70, 144, 217, 275, 277, 330, 334, 336, 338, 364, 371, 374, 375, 382
Spatial opportunities, 110, 115, 116, 121
State capacity, 14, 372, 376, 377, 382, 383
State capture, 113, 248, 335
State-mobilised movements, 7
State repression, 6, 7, 52, 58, 59, 62–65, 67, 70, 209, 235, 277, 287, 294, 346, 379
Stop the Government, 109, 110, 121, 123–125, 129, 130, 132, 337, 346
Strategic action field (SAF), 304, 313, 317

Student movements, 27, 38, 88, 92, 178, 179, 197
Students, 29, 30, 37, 38, 42, 57, 58, 60–62, 89, 90, 92, 123, 130, 147, 150, 151, 178–182, 196, 286, 310, 335–337, 339, 345

T
Technocratic populism, 13, 121, 123, 126, 346
Theory of fields, 304
"There is Such a People", 82, 95, 96
Trade unions, 8, 36, 51, 61, 88, 89, 91, 112, 115, 118–120, 122, 123, 130, 131, 162, 180, 194, 217–219, 238, 239, 247, 248, 330, 331, 350
Traditional values, 149, 266, 292
Transactional activism, 115, 116, 121, 131, 163, 184
Transactional new social movements, 115–118, 127, 131
Transfer of power, 137, 138
Transformation, 2, 4, 13, 30, 36, 40, 84, 86, 89, 98, 104, 119, 162, 168–170, 175, 178, 179, 184, 218–220, 223, 238, 248, 252, 254, 301, 314, 316, 330, 336, 338, 343, 346, 350, 352
Transition, 3–8, 13, 14, 29, 30, 43, 82, 84, 86–88, 92, 99, 101, 109, 114, 195, 197, 220, 247, 277, 301, 316, 330–333, 335, 338, 339, 343–345, 349, 360, 365, 376
Tripartite, 119, 120, 124, 131
Tsikhanouskaya, Sviatlana, 57, 59

U
Ukraine without Kuchma, 305
Uncivil civil society, 367
Unintended consequences, 11, 45, 252, 351
Union of Democratic Forces (SDS), 82, 84–89
United National Movement (UNM), 138, 145, 146, 151, 152
United Russia, 279
Urbanism, 39

V
Visegrád Group, 361

W
War on Ukraine, 280, 292, 336
"We Continue the Change", 82, 95, 97, 99, 346
Westernisation, 359
Women's marches, 60
Workers' movements, 181

Y
Yanukovych, Viktor, 305, 306, 308–310, 312, 317
Yeltsin, Boris, 275, 277–279, 282, 335, 337
Youth Front, 58
Yushchenko, Viktor, 54, 305–308

Z
Zhivkov, Todor, 88, 101